

Surely, this was ...

A Fictional Book of Truth
by
Trey Allen King

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Act 1

Act 1 - 01

Jerusalem burned with tension, her golden gates flung wide to swallow the sea of pilgrims that surged like floodwaters through her ancient streets. Above it all, the Temple gleamed—a shard of heaven—but its light was smothered by the blood-red banners of Rome that snapped and cracked in the wind, a brutal reminder of whose iron fist held this land. This was the city of prophecy and kings, now a jewel bound in chains.

The air itself seemed alive, thrumming with the echoes of history, the clash of swords and prayers. It was Passover, the season of remembrance, when Israel's God had torn apart the sea and broken the backs of pharaohs. But now, beneath the shadow of Caesar, those same people shuffled under the eyes of watchful soldiers, their steps burdened by an unspoken question: had the God of deliverance turned His face away?

Rome's power was everywhere: soldiers prowled the gates, their swords gleaming like fangs; tax collectors perched in their stalls, their eyes sharp as blades, ready to strip the faithful of what little remained. Jerusalem was a city at war with herself—a fortress of faith with rebellion smoldering in her veins, waiting for a spark.

For three years, that spark had flickered in whispers—a man from Galilee, a shadow that had grown into a flame. First a carpenter, then a teacher, now a mystery. They said he healed the broken, fed the hungry, stilled the wind, even called the dead to rise. The crowds clung to his words, parched souls drinking from a deep and endless well. And now, as if summoned by their cries, this man had come to Jerusalem.

The gates of the city groaned as they closed behind him, and all of Jerusalem seemed to shudder, caught between hope and ruin.

The Procession

The man did not come on a warhorse, nor clad in gleaming armor, but astride a humble donkey, his figure silhouetted against the yawning gates of Jerusalem. Around him, the crowd surged and roared, their voices a tempest of hope and desperation: *“Hosanna! Hosanna to the Son of David!”* Cloaks fell like offerings before him; palm branches swayed like banners of defiance and prayer, caught between cries for peace and the embers of rebellion.

Yet his eyes bore no triumph. They held a sorrow both profound and unyielding, a quiet grief that seemed untouched by the crowd's jubilation. He rode onward with a calm that neither welcomed nor resisted the moment, a stillness stark against the fervent energy surging around him—like a solitary stone unmoved in the heart of a storm.

Above the tumult, a Roman soldier sneered, breaking the reverie. *“This is their king?”* His words dripped with scorn, but there was a flicker of unease in his gaze. He turned to his officer, Lucius, whose face betrayed nothing.

“They call him a healer,” the soldier pressed, as though his own words might banish the discomfort. “A prophet. Some even whisper he raised the dead.”

Lucius, a commander forged in the fires of Rome's conquests, tightened his grip on the hilt of his blade. He had seen prophets rise, only to fall beneath the crushing weight of Roman order. Their zeal always burned too bright, too briefly, before being extinguished by steel. Yet something about this man gnawed at the edges of Lucius' certainty. He said nothing, though his teeth clenched.

Simon

On the edges of the gathering stood Simon of Cyrene, a pilgrim far from his homeland, clutching his satchel like a lifeline. The cries of “Hosanna!” crashed around him in waves, a flood of devotion that unsettled more than it inspired. He had heard whispers of this man—who hadn’t? —but Simon had come to Jerusalem for the holy days, not for signs and wonders.

Eli, his traveling companion, elbowed him with boyish excitement. “Do you see him, Simon? They are calling him the Messiah.”

Simon frowned, his eyes scanning the throng, landing on the figure astride the donkey. His lips tightened. “A Messiah should come with armies, not riding on a donkey,” he murmured.

Simon’s heart churned, a quiet storm of doubt. The man didn’t look like a king. No crown. No sword. He looked like a lamb being led to the slaughter.

Barabbas

In the shadow of a crumbling wall, Barabbas stood with arms crossed, his eyes narrowed to slits of scorn. To him, this was no king—just a fool marching toward his own demise. His lip twisted in a sneer as he turned to Gestas, his brutal and unwavering ally. “Look at them,” he spat, nodding toward the cheering throng. “Groveling for miracles. They’d crown a fishmonger if he promised freedom.”

Leaning against the rough stone, Dismas watched the man in the procession with an unspoken weight in his gaze. His voice, when it broke the tension, was soft and wistful, carrying an edge of sorrow. “Maybe it isn’t freedom they’re looking for,” he murmured. “Maybe it’s hope.”

Barabbas scoffed, waving him off with a dismissive snarl. *“Hope won’t drive Rome from our streets. Only steel will.”*

But as the man on the donkey disappeared into the crowd's embrace, even Barabbas felt the shadow of something deeper—something he refused to name—settling over the city.

The crowd surged like a living tide, their voices crashing against the walls of Jerusalem. Snatches of conversation rose and fell, carried on the air like fragments of prophecy.

“This is the one who healed the blind man in Jericho,” a woman whispered to the child at her side, her voice trembling with reverence.

“He fed thousands with nothing but bread and fish,” murmured an old man, his words heavy with memory.

Others spoke of wonders that defied reason: water turned to wine, storms stilled by a single word, and even the dead brought back as though death itself bowed to his command.

But not every voice carried awe.

“He eats with sinners,” a merchant scoffed, his sneer slicing through the reverence like a knife. “A true prophet wouldn’t disgrace himself like that.”

Another voice chimed in, edged with derision: “He called the Pharisees blind guides. It’s no wonder they want him silenced.”

And beneath it all, like a dark undercurrent flowing through the crowd’s wonder and disdain, came the faint, uneasy whispers of fear.

“The Romans will crush this,” a tax collector warned, his voice low and firm, as though issuing a decree. “A man like that—a man who stirs the people—is a danger to their order.”

Through the rising swell of voices, Simon’s gaze settled on the man at the center of it all. He rode quietly, humbly, through the gates of Jerusalem, a figure at once unassuming and unfathomable. Around him, the crowd’s cries swelled into a storm of *“Hosanna!”*—a wave that rose to meet the heavens and broke against the city like a force of nature.

Yet for Simon, those cries were not a victory. They felt more like a question, echoing in his chest and leaving him unsettled. He cast a glance at Eli, whose face glowed with the unrestrained wonder of a man who thought he was witnessing destiny. Then Simon looked to the Roman soldiers, their hands resting uneasily on their swords, their eyes scanning the crowd like predators in a restless forest.

Simon did not know it yet, but this moment—this man—would upend everything he thought he understood. The gates of Jerusalem would close behind him, but the gates of history had just begun to open.

He did not know it yet, but this moment—this man—would change everything.

Act 1 - 02

Simon

The gates of Jerusalem were not just stone and mortar—they were a threshold, a thing alive with the history of kings, prophets, and conquerors. Now they yawned wide to swallow Simon and Eli, who stepped through into a world that roared and clattered like a forge on festival day.

Smoke curled lazily from cooking fires, blending with the sting of dust kicked up by countless sandaled feet. The air seemed heavy with smells—roasted lamb, sweat, the sharp metallic tang of blood from the animals destined for sacrifice. The noise of the multitude rose like the hum of an angry hive, underscored by the low growl of commerce and prayer.

“Jerusalem,” Eli breathed, his voice heavy with wonder. “The city of kings.”

Simon adjusted the strap of his satchel, the weight of it biting into his shoulder. “If this is a city of kings, where’s the throne? All I see are tax collectors and Romans.”

Eli shot him a look, half-amused, half-reproachful. “You might at least try to feel the reverence, Simon. After all, isn’t this what you came for?”

Simon didn’t answer. His eyes swept over the crowd instead, noting the restlessness that rippled beneath the surface. It wasn’t just the noise, the jostling bodies, or the shouts of

traders hawking everything from spices to sacrificial lambs. It was something else—something he couldn't name.

Simon frowned but kept walking. He didn't need to ask who they were talking about. The echoes of the morning's procession still lingered in his mind—those shouts of “Hosanna!” rising like waves and breaking against the man on the donkey. He had kept his distance then, uncertain what to make of it all.

Eli, of course, was brimming with enthusiasm. “It was something, wasn't it?” he said suddenly.

Simon grunted.

“The way the people cried out,” Eli pressed, undeterred. “You could feel it, couldn't you? Hope. Real hope.”

Simon stopped short, forcing Eli to halt beside him. “You call that hope? A man riding a donkey while the Romans stand by with their swords? That's not hope, Eli. That's asking for trouble.”

Eli smiled faintly, a flicker of mischief in his eyes. “Not every battle is fought with swords, Simon.”

Simon shook his head and started walking again. “If it isn't, then it's lost before it's begun.”

The merchants' voices rang out above the din, desperate to out-shout their competition. The air hung heavy, laden with the mingled aromas of roasted meat, unwashed bodies, and the sharp, bitter edge of fear.

Simon's gaze darted to the Roman soldiers stationed at the edges of the square. They stood like statues in the midday sun, their armor polished to a cruel brightness. One group huddled together, speaking in low, clipped tones.

“Triple patrols this week,” one grumbled. “Too many whispers in this city.”

Another sneered. “And that Nazarene only stirs the pot. I saw the Pharisees watching him this morning. They looked ready to spit nails.”

Simon turned his head quickly, not wanting to be caught listening. The Romans had an uncanny ability to sniff out trouble, and he wasn't interested in becoming their next curiosity.

Eli pulled Simon toward a quieter corner of the marketplace, where the press of bodies wasn't quite so suffocating. "What did I tell you? You can feel it, can't you? There's something in the air, something... bigger than us."

"Bigger than us?" Simon dropped his satchel onto the ground with a sigh. "I'll tell you what's bigger than us—the Temple, the Romans, and every tax collector between here and Cyrene. That's what's in the air."

Eli laughed softly, shaking his head. "You're blind, Simon. You think faith is just in the stones and the rituals. You don't see the fire in people's eyes."

Simon's eyes flicked toward a dark alley, where a group of men stood cloaked in shadow, their faces half-hidden beneath hoods. Their conversation was low and urgent, words lost in the clamor of the square. There was a sharpness to their movements, a kind of coiled energy that made Simon uneasy.

He didn't linger. Trouble like that didn't need a name. It found you easily enough if you weren't careful.

The tension in the square was palpable, like the moments before a storm. Simon tried to shake off the unease as he sat down on a low stone ledge. Nearby, a boy darted through the crowd, his voice high and shrill with excitement.

"The Messiah has come!" the boy cried. "Did you see him? The Messiah has come!"

Simon watched the boy vanish into the throng, his words lingering, like smoke within the ether. He leaned back against the wall, his face shadowed by doubt.

"Do you think we'll see him again?" Eli asked, breaking the silence.

Simon didn't look at him. "I hope not."

"Why?"

"Because this city chews up men like him and spits them out."

Eli said nothing, his smile fading as Simon pushed himself to his feet.

I'll catch up with you later at the Inn, Simon said. "I've got some things to do."

And with that, he slung his satchel over his shoulder and disappeared into the crowd.

The marketplace stretched before Simon like a living tapestry, a blur of color and motion that swirled and shouted and sang. Stalls teemed with goods from distant lands, their bounty piled high in tribute to the season. Bolts of fabric draped over wooden frames, their purples rich as wine, their blues deep as twilight. Silks caught the sunlight in molten waves, shimmering like the rivers of paradise. The air itself seemed painted with color, every hue dazzling against the weathered stone of Jerusalem's ancient walls.

Nearby, earthen jars brimmed with saffron, cinnamon, and cumin, their pungent aromas wafting upward to mingle with the savory smoke of some animal roasting over open flames. Simon's nose twitched, caught between the tantalizing pull of the spices and the primal sweetness of charred meat.

A merchant hoisted a bleating lamb high, its soft wool glowing pale in the torchlight. "Lambs for sacrifice! Unblemished and pure—worthy of the altar!" he called, his voice rising above the clamor, sharp and commanding. From the next row, another vendor's rough, hearty shout followed. "Figs and dates! Fresh from the hills of Judea!" His basket overflowed with fruit, their dark sweetness gleaming like hidden treasure.

Everywhere Simon turned, the world seemed to brim with life. Faces—so many faces—each etched with a story. Men with skin weathered by sun and wind, their eyes fierce from long journeys across distant lands. Pale northerners, their hair like

straw, their voices grating like iron. Women adorned in shawls embroidered with gold and pearl, their steps light as they wove gracefully through the bustling chaos.

Children darted through the crowd like swallows, ducking under the arms of vendors and the legs of lumbering oxen. Old men leaned over their canes, arguing with traders in thick, spiced tongues Simon didn't recognize, their hands gnarled with age but quick to point in protest. Mothers clutched their children close, pointing to the sights with wonder that glowed even in the weariness of their eyes.

Simon marveled at it all—the noise, the life, the sheer humanity of it. A great ocean of people surged through the streets, each face moving with its own purpose, yet somehow all bound together in the same ceaseless current. He felt like a small, single drop in this vast tide of humanity.

The city overwhelmed his senses. Every sound, every scent, every shifting light caught him off guard. It was dizzying, almost unreal, as though he'd stepped into a dream where everything pulsed with meaning and purpose.

Yet beneath the joy and noise, Simon felt it: a tautness, a wariness. The air itself seemed wound tight, as though waiting for something to break. Faces in the crowd, jubilant one moment, seemed guarded the next. Conversations dropped in volume when strangers passed too close. It was as though the city held its breath, unsure whether to cheer or flee.

Jerusalem was alive, but it was also a city under watch, under rule. It was a holy celebration in a cage, the noise of faith mingled with the silence of oppression.

Simon slowed his steps, grounding himself with a deep breath. He had not come to this holy city to marvel at its sights or be swept away by its chaos. This was Passover, the holiest time of the year—a time to remember, to honor the God who had once delivered His people from bondage.

He thought of the story that had bound his people together for generations. The Exodus was no mere tale; it was their bloodline, their covenant, their inheritance. As a child, he had

sat at his father's knee, wide-eyed as the story unfolded. He could still hear the cadence of his father's voice, describing the night when their forefathers had marked their doorposts with the blood of a lamb. The angel of death passed over them, sparing their firstborn, while Egypt wept.

Now, as a man, Simon carried that story within him like a shield. He had come to Jerusalem to honor it, to walk where his ancestors had walked, to take part in rituals that shaped not just memory, but identity. Every step he took toward the Temple felt like a link in an unbroken chain, binding him to the faith of his fathers.

But even as he walked, purpose burning in his chest, Simon couldn't escape the shadows cast by the present. Roman soldiers watched from the edges of the city, their presence as cold and impersonal as their iron. They leaned against walls, stood at corners, their armor glinting like wolves' teeth in the sunlight.

Simon felt their eyes sweep the crowd with detached precision, weighing every pilgrim, every merchant, every child as if they were threats to be cataloged. The soldiers moved without urgency, yet their every step carried menace. Their hands lingered near the hilts of their swords, as though the simple act of breathing might provoke an answer in steel.

Simon's heart burned with a quiet anger as he watched. He had come to Jerusalem to celebrate freedom, but here, in the city of God, that freedom felt like a distant memory.

The burden bore down on him. This was Passover—the season of deliverance. And yet, Jerusalem itself seemed shackled, its people bound not by chains but by the suffocating presence of empire.

As Simon walked deeper into the city, he felt the tension of two worlds pressing against him: the sacred and the profane, the promise of God and the shadow of Rome. Could God's covenant still hold, even in this place? Could the story of the Exodus, so full of triumph and liberation, still shine against the harsh realities of the present?

He glanced around at the faces moving past him, some bright with hope, others worn by doubt. Jerusalem, sacred and scarred, felt like both a sanctuary and a prison. His heart ached with reverence and sorrow, the two emotions intertwining with each step he took.

And yet, despite the doubts gnawing at him, Simon pressed on. This city was a crucible, its stones etched with struggle, its air heavy with history. But it was also a place of faith—a place where his people had endured, where they had found their God even in the darkest of times.

Simon's steps grew firmer as he walked, his chest tightening with a strange mixture of anger and resolve. Perhaps that was the nature of faith—to walk forward even when the path seemed lost, to carry the light of God even in a world cloaked in shadow.

The soldiers' eyes scanned the crowd with a detached vigilance, surveying each pilgrim, merchant, and family as if every person was a potential threat. Simon noticed how people moved differently around the soldiers. Conversations grew softer, and laughter vanished entirely when the guards came near. Parents pulled their children close, eyes lowered to avoid catching a soldier's gaze. Even the vendors who had been calling out moments before seemed to lose their voices when the soldiers paused nearby.

Simon felt his own pulse quicken as he observed the soldiers. It was one thing to know of Rome's power from afar, but here, in the city of his faith, under the gaze of men who neither knew nor cared for his people's God, that power felt stifling. The soldiers didn't move to greet the people, to interact, or to understand. They were here as a reminder, each one a living symbol of Roman dominance, standing like statues in iron and leather. Their duty was simple: to remind everyone that Rome held the leash, that Jerusalem's streets were not truly free.

The power of Rome lurked in every shadow, a reminder that the freedom his people celebrated at Passover was granted only at Rome's discretion. He felt a cold anger rise within him, a quiet indignation that he pushed down, knowing it was not the time or place. *Let the Romans stand watch*, he thought,

forcing himself to look away. *They may hold these stones, but they will never hold our faith.*

As Simon continued through the crowded streets, his wife's parting words echoed in his mind, quiet but firm. *"Jerusalem is no place for idle curiosity, Simon. Keep your head down. Go, do what you came for, and come home safely."* She had spoken with a calm strength, their newborn daughter cradled in her arms, her eyes steady but shadowed with worry. He could still see her standing in the doorway of their home, her expression a mixture of pride and fear, her fingers clutching their child close.

He imagined her now, back home, waiting for his safe return, managing the household with the same resilience that had carried them through years of hardship. She had never once tried to dissuade him from this journey, understanding its importance, but he could sense her unspoken concerns. She was his anchor, the quiet strength that allowed him to face the challenges of each day, and he knew she would be waiting for him, her steady presence, a promise he carried with him on this journey.

His thoughts shifted to his two sons, Alexander and Rufus, both still too young to understand the fullness of the faith he had come to honor. But they had watched with excitement as he prepared for his journey, eyes wide with wonder at the thought of Jerusalem, the holy city they had heard of only in stories. In his mind's eye, he could see them leaning in, eager for every detail, their faces alight as he described the massive gates, the towering walls, the colors and noise of the marketplace.

They would want to know everything—the sights, the people, the smell of the spices, the taste of the bread. He imagined them asking about every little thing he saw, wanting to know every sound, every color. The thought brought a small smile to his face. He had come not only to fulfill his duty to God but to bring back a piece of this city for his family, to share with them the beauty and holiness he felt in every step he took.

He clutched the strap of his satchel, feeling the few coins he had saved. Each coin represented a small sacrifice, months of

work put aside so he could afford this journey. It was enough to buy provisions for Passover, and perhaps even a small trinket or two to bring back for his family. His sons would treasure a keepsake from the holy city, something they could hold in their hands, a reminder of their father's journey.

As he walked, he carried the emotional strain of that promise—the commitment to return home safely. He was here to honor God but also to honor his family, to bring a piece of Jerusalem back to them. His heart wrestled between the reverence that filled him and the ache of longing, knowing they were far away yet ever present in his thoughts.

As he moved further into the bustling crowd, Simon's ears caught the sound of tense, low voices. A small group of men and women stood huddled close, their heads bent together as they spoke in urgent whispers. The crowd flowed around them, but their circle remained tight, isolated, an island of unease in a sea of movement.

He slowed his pace, his curiosity piqued. Their voices were muffled, and he had to strain to make out their words over the noise of the marketplace.

"They're everywhere," one man grumbled, his voice thick with bitterness.

"They've tripled the patrols for Passover.

Just a whisper—that's all it would take to bring their wrath down on us."

Simon felt his stomach tighten. He had come to Jerusalem to celebrate, to take part in the joy of Passover, but the city felt anything but joyful. There was a heaviness within the mist, a sense of something dark and volatile, ready to ignite with the smallest provocation. As he listened to the group, he glanced around, taking in the expressions of those passing by. Faces that should have been filled with reverence and anticipation were instead marked by caution, by an unspoken fear that seemed to follow them through the crowded streets.

The others nodded in agreement, their faces etched with quiet anger and frustration. Simon could see the strain in their eyes, the burden of years spent living with foreign occupiers, their

lives perpetually overshadowed by an authority that neither understood nor respected their traditions. These were people who, like him, had come to honor their faith and remember their liberation. Yet here they stood, glancing over their shoulders, speaking in hushed tones, too afraid to celebrate with abandon.

Simon turned away, trying to dispel the unease that clung to him. He had always been aware of Rome's presence, had seen the soldiers with his own eyes, but hearing the fear woven into the pilgrims' voices made it feel oppressively real. His heart sank, the joy of his journey fading as the fragile nature of their freedom became starkly clear. The festival they had come to honor—a celebration of liberation—felt hollow under the unyielding gaze of Roman authority. Here in Jerusalem, freedom was nothing more than a carefully controlled illusion.

A sudden cry tore through the marketplace, raw and jagged, shattering the hum of voices and the rhythm of trade. Simon froze, his heart leaping at the sound. Ahead, the crowd swelled, bodies pressing together as a grim circle formed. Whatever lay at its center held them spellbound, their curiosity tinged with an unspoken fear.

Simon pushed forward, slipping between the gathered onlookers, his pulse pounding in his ears. When he reached the front of the circle, the scene before him struck with the force of a blow.

A Roman soldier stood tall and unfeeling, his hand gripping the leather handle of a whip that hung limp at his side. At his feet knelt a man, his robes torn and dirt-streaked, his body rigid with the effort of holding himself upright. One hand hovered feebly before him, a pitiful defense against the next strike.

The whip snapped, a vicious crack that gave the impression of splitting the air itself. The man flinched, his back arching as the leather bit into his flesh, leaving a fresh welt across skin already flayed and bleeding. He grunted in pain, his teeth pressing firmly together, but he did not scream.

Simon winced, his stomach churning at the sight. Another lash fell, then another, each delivered with mechanical precision. The soldier's face betrayed no emotion, his movements detached, almost methodical. Blood darkened the dirt at the man's knees, but he refused to collapse entirely, his silence a small act of rebellion.

Around Simon, the crowd stood mute, their collective silence as heavy as the whip's blow. A few looked away, their faces pale and stricken. Others whispered quiet prayers, their voices too faint to carry. Some spoke in hushed tones, though none dared raise them loud enough to be heard.

Simon's hands clenched into fists at his sides. He felt the tension coiling in him, a raw, restless anger that begged for release. Yet he knew better than to act. The cost of defiance was plain to see, etched into the bloody stripes on the man's back.

This was a time to celebrate God's deliverance, to remember the mighty hand that had shattered Egypt's yoke. But here, in the city of holiness, Simon saw only chains—Rome's power wielded without mercy, without restraint. Justice and mercy were stories told in the synagogues, but in the streets, cruelty reigned.

The whip cracked again, and Simon flinched once more. He hated himself for it, for the helplessness that kept him rooted to the spot, for the fear that bound his voice to silence.

The punishment dragged on until even the crowd's subdued murmurs faded. When the soldier at last lowered his whip, Simon's attention shifted to a figure standing just beyond the ring of onlookers. A Roman officer, clearly the man in command, observed the scene with a dispassionate calm.

His face was smooth, composed, as if he were watching a craftsman ply his trade rather than witnessing an act of brutality. His hands rested lightly at his sides, his posture loose and untroubled, a man utterly at ease with his authority.

The officer's gaze swept over the crowd, and for a brief moment, his eyes locked with Simon's. Something cold moved

between them, an unspoken understanding that set Simon's teeth on edge. This man bore no hatred, no cruelty in his expression. Instead, there was a quiet certainty, the confidence of one who knew his power was absolute.

Simon held the gaze longer than he intended, his chest tight, his heart pounding. He wanted to look away, to sever the connection, but something held him there, some primal need to meet the officer's indifference with defiance.

The officer's lips curled into a faint, unreadable smile. Then, with a small wave, he signaled to the soldiers. The whip was lowered, and the man crumpled to the dirt, his strength finally spent. The officer turned away without a word, his stride unhurried, as if the entire affair had already slipped from his mind.

Simon watched him go, a chill running down his spine. There was no malice in the officer's gaze, no anger or hatred—only a quiet certainty, a sense of power so complete it required no emotion. In that moment, Simon understood to this man, they were not people. They were subjects, a mass to be governed, to be ruled without question. The officer's calm was the calm of indifference, a disinterest that was somehow more terrifying than hatred.

As the officer disappeared into the crowd, Simon felt a pang of dread settle over him. He had known Rome's power in the abstract, but here, in the holy city, that power felt suffocating, an iron hand that squeezed the life from everything it touched.

Around him, some moved away quickly, their heads bowed, eager to leave the scene behind. Others lingered, their faces tight with anger or blank with resignation. Simon caught sight of a mother whispering to her child, their hands entwined as she hurried them along. An old man paused near the blood-stained dirt, his shoulders heavy with the weariness of having seen too much.

The thought filled him with a hollow anger. He had known of Rome's power, had heard stories of their ruthless control, but seeing it here, in the very heart of his faith, was different. Here, in Jerusalem, the city that had always represented holiness

and freedom, Rome's power felt like a violation. The Passover season was meant to honor liberation, yet here they were, held captive by an empire that showed neither mercy nor understanding.

Simon forced himself to keep walking, though his thoughts were dark. A part of him felt betrayed, as though the city he had longed to visit had somehow deceived him. He had come expecting reverence and peace, but what he found was a city under siege, a place where the sacred was overshadowed by cruelty. The joy he had felt upon arriving seemed distant now, replaced by a gnawing doubt, a fear that his pilgrimage would be marked not by the sacred, but by sorrow.

And yet, beneath his disillusionment, he felt something else—a strange resolve, a quiet determination. He had come to Jerusalem to honor his God, to remember his people's deliverance, and he would not let the darkness he saw here steal that from him. Perhaps it was all the more reason to pray, all the more reason to remember the Exodus and the promise of freedom. He walked on, his steps steady, his heart heavy, but his faith somehow sharper, as if the cruelty he had seen had only made his purpose clearer.

Jerusalem, he realized, was not just a city of reverence. It was a place of struggle, a place where faith was not a luxury but a necessity, something to hold onto in the midst of suffering. And though the fear and anger still lingered, he felt his purpose renewed, a reminder that his faith was a light in dark places, a strength that could not be taken from him.

As Simon moved deeper into the crowd, low, urgent voices reached his ears. He turned slightly, curiosity pulling at him, and caught sight of a small group of men and women huddled together, their heads bent in whispered conversation.

"The soldiers are everywhere," a man stated almost inaudibly, his voice bitter and sharp. Simon's stomach tightened. The man's tone carried a warning—not panicked, but cold and certain, like a storm rolling in from the horizon.

A woman leaned in, her voice barely above a breath. "They don't care for us, for our ways. To them, we're a nuisance."

Even our worship comes with their permission.”

An older man standing nearby remarked under his breath, his voice roughened by years of hardship

“This is how it is. Life means nothing to them. We are nothing to them.”

The group nodded in solemn agreement, their faces taut with anger and frustration. Simon could see the invisible strain of their words reflected in their features—the years of indignity, of living with foreign rule, of worshiping beneath the shadow of men who neither understood nor honored their faith.

Simon turned away, attempting to shake the unease that had taken hold of him. He had known of Rome’s presence, of course. He had seen their soldiers from a distance and heard the stories of their brutality. But now, standing in their shadow, the reality pressed against him in a way he had never experienced before.

The joy he had carried into the city felt dimmer now, dulled by the stark harshness of the present. The festival, meant to be a celebration of freedom, felt hollow beneath Rome’s watchful gaze, where freedom seemed little more than a fading memory.

Adjusting his satchel, Simon pressed forward, though his steps felt heavier. The celebration that should have lifted his spirit now seemed fragile, brittle, as though it might shatter beneath the weight of the tension surrounding him. Yet even as doubt began to creep in, he refused to let it settle.

Act 1 - 03

Lucius

Lucius stood at the marketplace, the sun carving sharp lines across his polished armor. The air was heavy with dust and heat, thick as the tension that gripped the gathered crowd. Voices murmured low and uncertain, their cadence like the growl of a distant storm. People pressed forward in the square; their faces drawn toward the grim spectacle at its center.

His soldiers flanked him in precise formation, their faces as unyielding as the stone beneath their boots. Their eyes scanned the crowd, a silent challenge, daring anyone to stir, to speak, to even breathe a hint of rebellion. At their feet knelt a man in the dirt, his head bowed but not broken. Defiance smoldered in his expression—a flickering ember that refused to be extinguished, even with the crushing weight of pain and humiliation.

Lucius watched it all with practiced detachment. This was no new sight—he had seen men broken in arenas, on streets, and in the back alleys of cities far more treacherous than Jerusalem. Punishment was the language of empire, and Lucius had become fluent.

These moments were not merely spectacles; they were Rome's handprint, pressed deep into the heart of every province.

Fear was a blade; one he had learned to wield with precision. Too much and the blade dulled, rebellion sparking from the ashes of brutality. Too little, and the people forgot why they

should kneel. Lucius walked the balance like a seasoned soldier navigating a narrow mountain pass. And though he carried himself with the ease of one accustomed to such heights, he never forgot the danger that lurked below.

The onlookers shifted like reeds caught in an uncertain wind. Some turned their faces away, shoulders hunched as if to shield themselves from the scene. Others stood rigid, their mouths set in grim lines, their eyes hard with barely concealed rage. Lucius studied their faces, the way resentment twisted their features. Hatred always burned brighter in Jerusalem; the zeal of their faith fed it like dry tinder to a fire.

This city was a crucible, hotter than most, its people sharp-edged and prone to sparks. Lucius had seen it before: the crackling energy of a crowd poised to ignite. He could feel it now, an almost electric tension threading through the air, coiling and waiting for release.

But he knew how to read them, these gatherings of the oppressed. He could tell when the tide might rise and when it would merely lap against the shore. He had learned to see it in the way hands clenched at sides, in the way mothers clutched their children's hands tighter, in the subtle shift of feet edging forward or back. Today, the storm would hold—for now.

Lucius' stance was a message, his posture a command. His presence alone spoke Rome's language: *You are seen. You are known. You are ruled.* The crowd understood it, even if they hated it. Their hatred didn't concern him. It was an expected thing, like the heat of the sun or the sting of dust in his eyes.

Fear, though—fear was useful. It could be sharpened, honed into a weapon of control. Fear tempered rebellion, kept order in lands where the soil reeked of blood and the air stank of prophecy. Fear could be shaped into respect, and respect was the closest Rome would ever come to loyalty in these provinces.

He had spent years perfecting this art, understanding the psychology of dominance. There was no cruelty in it—at least, not for cruelty's sake. Lucius did not revel in the whip or the

lash; he simply understood their necessity. Power demanded symbols, and men like the one kneeling before him served as those symbols.

Still, he kept his own face unreadable, a mask of calm authority. Let the people see it, let them hate it if they must. Their hatred was proof of Rome's strength, a strength they could not touch.

The whip cracked through the air, sharp and brutal, and Lucius watched as the man on the ground flinched, his body jerking with each strike. He didn't cry out, didn't beg for mercy. There was a defiance in him, a stubbornness that Lucius almost respected, though he knew it would do the man no good. Mercy was not Rome's way, and here, in the heart of Jerusalem, mercy was a luxury he could not afford.

The crowd held its collective breath, each lash of the whip drawing gasps, murmurs, and glances of shared anguish. Lucius kept his gaze steady, unmoved. He knew the message was being delivered—that in this city, beneath Rome's watchful eye, defiance would be met with swift and merciless punishment. As long as he stood here, as long as they saw the strength of Rome in his stance and the iron in his gaze, they would remember their place. They would remember that their city was not theirs alone.

Lucius gave a small, deliberate nod to Antonius, a gesture as sharp and final as a command. It was enough to halt the younger soldier mid-motion, the whip in his hand falling slack as the energy coiling through his body met an immovable wall. Antonius' face, lit moments ago with unrestrained eagerness, now tightened with disappointment, though he masked it with a quick, stiff nod of his own.

Lucius' gaze lingered, cold and unyielding, a silent warning against indulgence. He had seen men like Antonius before—soldiers who thrived on cruelty, who found pleasure in breaking others. Such tendencies could be useful in the right measure, but unchecked, they were a fire that threatened to burn everything, and fires were a dangerous luxury in a city like Jerusalem.

"Permission to continue, sir?" Antonius' voice held a note of impatience, as if he could barely contain himself. He looked up at Lucius, eager for his signal, the whip in his hand ready to strike. Lucius studied the younger man, noting the way his fingers flexed against the leather, the barely concealed hunger in his expression. This wasn't control; it was indulgence, and indulgence was weakness.

"Control yourself, Antonius," Lucius said, his tone cold and even. "You're here to enforce order, not to entertain yourself."

Antonius' face fell slightly, though he tried to mask it with a stiff nod. "Understood, sir."

Lucius held Antonius' gaze, a silent warning in his eyes. He had little patience for men who could not separate duty from pleasure. A soldier's loyalty was to Rome, and Rome demanded discipline above all else. The satisfaction of personal vendettas had no place here, especially not in a city already simmering with unrest. Lucius knew well that a single act of brutality could spark the fire he spent every day trying to contain.

He turned his attention toward the crowd, ignoring Antonius' disgruntled expression. Lucius felt the intensity of the people's eyes on him, the seething resentment, the barely concealed hatred. They looked at him and his soldiers as intruders, as violators of their sacred space, and he could almost feel their loathing pressing down on him like the heat within the atmosphere. But unlike Antonius, he didn't revel in it. To Lucius, this wasn't a power trip. It was a duty, an obligation to maintain the Empire's rule. He took no pleasure in their suffering; his satisfaction came only from the assurance that he had done his job well, that he had upheld the order Rome required.

Antonius struck the man again, a blow that sent a fresh wave of shock through the crowd. Lucius watched, noting every reaction, every flinch, every tightened fist. This was how you controlled people—not through constant bloodshed, but through carefully measured fear. It was a lesson Antonius had yet to learn, and one Lucius feared the younger man might never understand. But as long as he was under Lucius'

command, Antonius would follow orders. He would learn restraint, or he would learn the price of failing to heed it.

For now, Lucius would allow the punishment to continue. It was a show of power, yes, but more than that, it was a reminder to the people of who ruled here, who held the power to take their lives in hand as if they were little more than dust beneath Rome's feet.

The whip cut the air again, its sharp crack a merciless punctuation to the scene. Each lash sent a jolt through the kneeling man's body, his shoulders jerking as the leather tore at his flesh. But he did not cry out. He did not beg. The defiance etched in his taut expression and unwavering glare made Lucius pause. It was rare, this kind of resistance, a stubborn refusal to break even in the face of overwhelming force.

Lucius could almost respect it. But respect did not alter the reality of the man's position. Rome did not grant mercy, especially not in Jerusalem, where mercy was as dangerous as rebellion itself. Here, the Empire's control rested on precision and power—on displays like this, where punishment was not just retribution but a lesson writ large for every eye to see.

The crowd shuddered with each crack of the whip. Gasps and whispered prayers flowed through them like ripples, blending with the oppressive tension in the air. Faces either paled or flushed with restrained fury; hands tensed at their sides or disappeared beneath robes. Yet no one moved, and no one spoke.

Lucius stood unmoving, his gaze steady, his bearing a wall of command. He felt their eyes on him, burning with resentment, and he let them look. Let them seethe. It was enough that they watched, enough that they saw in his stance the unyielding power of Rome. They could hate him if they wished. Hate was harmless so long as it remained silent.

The punishment dragged on, the crack of the whip punctuating the oppressive silence that had fallen over the gathering. Lucius stood just beyond the ring of onlookers; his gaze fixed

on the kneeling man. The soldier's strikes landed with the practiced efficiency of a craftsman—a display of Rome's discipline, its power made manifest.

Lucius felt none of the distaste or satisfaction that often marked such moments. To him, this was a necessary task, no more and no less. The punishment wasn't cruelty; it was instruction. And while the people whispered their prayers or clenched their fists in silent rage, he remained untroubled. This was his role, his duty—to uphold order in a city that teetered on rebellion.

As the murmurs of the crowd began to fade, his gaze swept over the gathering, reading the tension in their postures and the barely concealed defiance in their eyes. But then his attention caught on a single figure, standing still amidst the shifting bodies.

A man, plainly dressed, weathered from travel.

Their eyes met, and something passed between them—sharp, unspoken, and unfamiliar.

The man didn't look away. His expression was calm, but there was a weight to it, a quiet defiance that lingered beneath the surface. It wasn't the raw hatred Lucius had seen in other provinces, the kind he could easily dismiss. This was different, quieter, harder to categorize. It unsettled him.

Lucius narrowed his gaze slightly, trying to read the man, but the defiance remained, steady and unyielding. For the first time in the long procession of punishments he had overseen, he felt himself being watched, not by the masses, but by this one man.

The soldier raised the whip again, the gesture too eager, too thoughtless. Lucius lifted his hand in a subtle signal, halting the strike before it fell. His command was met with immediate compliance, the soldier lowering his weapon with a grudging stiffness. The kneeling man sagged to the dirt; his strength spent.

But Lucius' focus remained on the figure in the crowd. The man was still watching, his gaze holding fast, though Lucius could see the tension in his jaw, the tightness in his chest.

For reasons he could not name, Lucius felt compelled to acknowledge him. A faint, unreadable smile tugged at his lips—not out of amusement, but as a silent assertion of control. With a wave, he dismissed the soldiers, the moment passing as swiftly as it had begun.

Turning on his heel, Lucius strode away without another glance at the kneeling man or the onlookers. He carried himself with the calm certainty he knew the assembly would read as strength, but inwardly, he wrestled with the strange sensation that lingered after the encounter.

What had he seen in that man's gaze? It wasn't hatred, nor submission. It was something harder, something that refused to fit within the comfortable patterns of fear and rebellion he had come to understand.

Lucius forced the thought from his mind as he walked, the familiar weight of duty settling over him once more. This was Jerusalem, and such moments could not be allowed to distract him. Yet even as the square faded into the hum of the city, the memory of that steady gaze stayed with him, like a shadow he could not quite escape.

Lucius walked the square, his measured stride kicking up small clouds of dust as the dispersing throng ebbed behind him. The murmurs of the onlookers faded into the hum of the city, yet the grip of their silent defiance lingered, heavy as the heat in the air. His face remained a mask of calm authority, but beneath it, his thoughts churned.

This city was unlike any he had encountered in his years of service. Its resistance wasn't loud or violent—not yet—but it was there, as present and immovable as the walls of its Temple. Fear could bend men's wills, but here, in Jerusalem, faith stood taller than any monument, unmoved and unmovable.

He reflected on the earlier years of his career, on the campaigns in Gaul and Hispania. There, Rome had crushed defiance with ruthless efficiency. Fear and force had subdued cities and tribes, their loyalty bought with the promise of survival. Over time, their gods had withered beneath Rome's banners, replaced by the cold, pragmatic understanding that resistance was futile.

But Jerusalem was different. Here, the people's loyalty was not to some scattered pantheon or forgotten king. Their devotion was bound to a single, unseen God, a deity whose influence was woven into the very fabric of their lives. It gave them a resilience Lucius could neither measure nor understand.

He continued along the square's edge, his gaze drifting toward the Temple rising against the skyline. The late sun glinted off its golden accents, a defiant brilliance that appeared to stand as a beacon of their faith.

What would it take to rule a place like this? Lucius had asked himself the question before, but now it lingered with a new weight. Could fear alone keep these people subdued? Could displays of Roman power silence voices lifted in prayer to a God who, by all accounts, demanded unwavering devotion? He doubted it.

This city's spirit slipped through the Empire's grasp like smoke, intangible yet pervasive. Rome could control their bodies, chain their hands, and spill their blood. But their hearts? Their faith? Those were beyond the reach of any blade.

The thought unsettled him. Lucius was a man of discipline and strategy, a soldier who lived by the certainty of tactics and the strength of steel. Yet here, he felt those tools blunted against something he could not define.

As the last of the multitude thinned, Lucius found his mind returning to the face of a man he had seen earlier—a pilgrim, calm amid the chaos, his gaze meeting Lucius' own without flinching. There had been no fear in that gaze, no anger, only a quiet defiance that lingered in Lucius' thoughts like a thorn.

It wasn't the kind of rebellion that broke into open violence. It was worse: a strength that seemed to root itself deep, unyielding and impervious to force. Lucius had seen men break beneath the lash, their spirits crumbling long before their bodies gave out. But here, in Jerusalem, there was something else—something that refused to bend.

What gave these people their strength? What allowed them to endure the oppression of Rome's might? Lucius was a man who understood the mechanics of power, yet here, he could find no flaw, no crack in their armor of faith. It frustrated him, but it also intrigued him.

He turned his gaze back to the Temple, the gilded edges glowing in the fading light like embers of a fire. For all its legions, for all its governors and tributes, Rome felt precarious here. The Empire's control was a heavy hand resting on something alive and restless, something that could not be crushed.

Lucius straightened, pushing the doubt aside with the practiced ease of a man who had spent decades suppressing weakness. He was a soldier, an instrument of the Empire's will. His duty was not to question but to enforce. Yet, as he turned back to his post, a shadow of unease lingered in his thoughts.

The people's hearts, he realized, were free in a way their bodies were not. And that freedom, invisible and untouchable, was a threat no soldier could ever fully subdue.

For now, Lucius would do what he had always done: follow orders, maintain control, and ensure the people of Jerusalem knew the cost of defiance. Yet, as he turned away from the square, a shadow of doubt trailed him, lingering like the dust clinging to his cloak. This city held secrets, a strength rooted deep in its stones and its people. He could feel it, elusive yet undeniable—a force that might one day rise to challenge even the might of Rome. The thought stirred something in him, a strange blend of fear and respect that he knew must be buried if he were to carry out his duty.

Ahead, Jerusalem unfolded—a maze of winding streets and shadowed alleys, the colors of the marketplace still vivid in the fading light. Yet beneath the vibrancy lay a tension that pressed against him as surely as the city's heat. This was his post, his territory, and every crooked path and corner fell under his watchful eye. His orders were clear: maintain order, extinguish rebellion, and remind these people, by force, if necessary, that they lived controlled by the iron hand of the Empire.

Lucius took pride in his role. Rome had entrusted him with its authority, a mantle he had worn through years of discipline and service. Yet tonight, standing in the heart of this restless city, unease settled over him like a heavy cloak—a feeling he could neither name nor shake.

He had seen Rome's power sweep across the known world, conquering nations, subduing kings, and binding disparate peoples under one rule. It was a force unmatched, a juggernaut of discipline and ambition that brought civilization to the wild and order to the chaotic. Yet here, in Jerusalem, Lucius felt as though he were grasping at sand.

These people were bound not by the kind of gods that could be absorbed into Rome's pantheon, but by something far more elusive. Their faith was a deep-rooted fire, unseen yet unyielding, and no lash or decree seemed capable of quenching it. Rome could command their actions, chain their bodies, even spill their blood, but their spirit lay beyond reach, untouchable and unbroken.

His thoughts circled to the punishment he had ordered. He could still hear the whip's crack echoing across the square, the gasps and murmurs amid the multitude mingling with the defiant silence of the man who had endured it. In other cities, this display of power would have been enough to cow the people, to send them home with lowered heads and silence on their tongues. But here, among a people whose loyalty lay with an unseen God, Lucius doubted the lesson would hold.

Would they return to their homes subdued, or would the cruelty they had witnessed harden their resolve? He could almost feel

the resistance simmering in the aura, a quiet determination that no whip could extinguish.

Lucius allowed himself to entertain the unsettling thought that there was something in this city—a force within its stones, its air, its people—that defied comprehension. This place carried an ancient weight, as if time itself moved differently here, its currents slow but unrelenting. The people of Jerusalem were bound to something larger than themselves, something that neither sword nor fear could sever.

He dismissed the thought with effort, reminding himself that he was a man of discipline, a servant of Rome's logic and power. To entertain such notions was to stray into dangerous territory, the kind of thinking that weakened resolve. Yet even as he tried to silence the whispering unease, it persisted, soft and insidious, murmuring of Rome's limitations.

The Temple loomed ahead, its golden edges catching the last light of the sun, a monument to the faith that fueled this city's defiance. It struck Lucius that for all of Rome's might, it could never command the devotion these people gave freely to their unseen God. They obeyed Rome because they must, but their hearts were bound elsewhere, and no decree or legion could change that.

As the sun dipped lower, the city began to change. Shadows stretched long and sharp across the streets, and the bustling energy of the day gave way to the quiet hum of evening. The remnants among the crowd faded into the alleys, their whispered voices merging with the soft rustle of the breeze. Yet even in the growing stillness, Lucius felt the city's tension, its quiet resistance humming just beneath the surface.

He straightened, forcing the unease from his thoughts. He was a commander in the greatest army the world had ever known. He was here to bring order, to enforce Rome's will, and to ensure that Jerusalem remembered its place beneath the Empire's rule. His purpose was clear, and he would see it fulfilled, no matter the challenges this city presented.

And yet, as he turned to leave, a chill crept through him—not from the coolness of the evening, but from the sense that this

city was not like the others he had subdued. Jerusalem was not simply a place; it was a force, alive and untamed, bound to something eternal.

For the first time in years, Lucius felt the burden of uncertainty pressing against him. No matter how many soldiers he commanded, no matter how tightly he held the reins of power, he could not shake the feeling that here, in this ancient city, Rome's reach would always fall just short of true control.

As the fading light cast his figure into silhouette, Lucius moved on, a soldier bound by duty but haunted by the unyielding spirit of a city that would not bow.

Act 1 - 04

Dismas

The cave swallowed the light, its depths untouched by the sun, the jagged walls alive with shifting shadows cast by the flickering torches. The air was dense and heavy, carrying the scent of damp earth, sweat, and smoke, underscored by the faint, metallic tang of old blood—a ghostly reminder of past violence etched into the very stone. It was a crude sanctuary, this place, serving as both a haven and a cage for the men who now called it their stronghold.

The rough, uneven walls loomed around them, imposing and heavy, like the unspoken burden they all shared. Shadows twisted along the stone, their shapes stretching and collapsing with every movement of the torches, like dark figures lurking at sight, restless and waiting. Each man held his torch aloft, the flames sputtering as if reluctant to cast light on faces marked by years of suffering and rage.

In the center of the cave, a single wooden crate had been dragged in and set down with purpose, its surface scratched and worn from use. On it lay a parchment map, crinkled and torn at the edges, bearing marks of smudged ink and deep creases. This makeshift table, barely more than a slab of wood, was both altar and battleground. It was where dreams of freedom took form, where plans of vengeance were sharpened, and where fear was swallowed whole in the name of a cause that demanded every ounce of loyalty.

Barabbas knelt by the crate, his eyes fierce and focused, his face cast in flickering shadow. The play of light and dark over his scarred features gave him a look of grim determination, and in the deep lines around his mouth and brow lay the evidence of a life lived in defiance. He was a man forged in the fires of rebellion, his strength tempered by loss, his conviction as unyielding as the stone that surrounded him.

He carried himself with a quiet authority, every movement deliberate and restrained. His calloused hands, shaped by years of gripping weapons against foes who often outnumbered and outmatched him, spoke of resilience and endurance. Yet, he bore the weight of his mission with a calm that blended confidence and an undertone of fatalism. Leaning over the map, his finger traced a jagged line with practiced precision, his gaze locked on the marks before him, as though deciphering something only he could fully grasp.

"Here," he murmured, his voice low but resonant, carrying through the silence with a weight that made every man listen. His finger stopped on a narrow passage sketched along the road leading to Jerusalem. He glanced up, his eyes meeting those of each man in turn, as if silently binding them to the place he'd chosen. This was the spot where the road constricted, where the rocks loomed like walls on either side. It was where they would make their stand, and where Rome would feel the sting of their defiance.

Around him, the men leaned closer, their faces illuminated in the unsteady light. Gestas, a wiry figure with scars slashed across his face like grim medals of survival, stood close to Barabbas' right. A smirk twisted his mouth, his eyes glinting with anticipation. Yosef, barely more than a boy, clutched his dagger with white-knuckled determination, his gaze fixed on Barabbas with a mix of awe and fear. And Dismas, standing slightly apart from the others, looked on with a distant, thoughtful gaze, shadows deepening under his eyes.

In the silence that followed, the cave seemed to close in around them, its walls echoing with unspoken doubts and silent resolve. They were a ragtag band, bound not by blood but by the shared weight of suffering and loss. Their hands were rough, their faces marked by hardship, and in each of

their eyes was the flicker of something raw—something born of hatred, desperation, and the hunger for justice.

Barabbas' finger lingered on the map, pressing down as if trying to leave a mark. "We strike here," his voice sharpened, carrying a hint of something darker, more dangerous. "They'll pass through this narrow stretch, and we'll be waiting. They won't be expecting an attack so close to Jerusalem. This is our chance—our chance to remind them that this land, these roads, are not theirs to take."

His words hung in the environment, and for a moment, no one spoke. It was a vow, an oath made in blood and silence, and it needed no response. The men around him felt it as keenly as he did, each of them bearing scars—both visible and hidden—that marked them as outcasts, as fighters with nothing left to lose. And so, they listened, their breaths shallow, their bodies tense, each of them bound to the plan that had taken shape within these walls.

Barabbas looked up, his gaze sweeping over the faces of his comrades. In each of their eyes, he saw the reflection of his own resolve, the same fire that had driven him to defy Rome time and again, even when the odds seemed insurmountable. "Tomorrow," he spoke, his voice hard and unyielding, "we scout the road. And when they come through the next day, we'll be ready."

He rose, his eyes never leaving the map, as if he could see the ambush playing out before him. Around him, the men nodded, their faces grim and resolute. This was the path they had chosen, each of them bound to it as surely as the sun rose each day. There was no turning back, no room for doubt. In a few days, they would lay their claim, and by the time the Romans realized their mistake, it would be too late.

And at the light, Dismas watched, his thoughts unreadable, his thoughts already winding down darker paths, where questions he dared not voice took root and grew like weeds in the shadows.

Barabbas leaned over the map, his eyes narrowing as he traced the route with one finger, moving along the path with

the slow precision of a craftsman drawing the last line of a design. He stopped at the narrow stretch where he'd chosen to set the trap, his finger tapping on the spot to drive his point home.

"The road cuts between the rocks, narrow and treacherous. They'll have no room to maneuver, no chance to turn back." His gaze lingered on the sketched line as if seeing the Romans already in his grasp. "Five soldiers," he continued, "guarding a convoy with enough supplies to feed our group for months. Wine, grain, gold, silver. Rome's riches, bound for their tables. It's a reminder of the luxury they drain from us, while we scrape by on the crumbs they leave."

The men leaned in closer, drawn by his words as though he'd woven a spell. There was something in Barabbas' voice, a steeliness sharpened by years of watching his people suffer. Each raid, each act of defiance, felt like a small step toward reclaiming the pride Rome had stripped from them. Around him, their eyes glinted, some with the fierce light of loyalty, others with the thrill of battle.

Gestas snorted, a dark grin spreading across his scarred face. His teeth flashed in the torchlight as he let out a low chuckle. "Five soldiers?" he sneered. "Is that all?" He spat to one side, shaking his head in mock disappointment. "I thought we were preparing for a fight, not a slaughter. Five's hardly worth the trouble—we'll carve through them like warm butter."

He looked around, inviting laughter, and a few of the men grinned in agreement, sharing in his disdain. Gestas thrived in these moments, the unrestrained freedom to indulge in the violence he had always craved. He saw the raid not as a rebellion but as a high-stakes thrill in a world that had shown him nothing but harshness. A former street thief, he had learned young that survival was earned through brutality. In Barabbas' rebellion, he'd found a place to turn that skill to purpose, even if the purpose itself meant little to him.

Barabbas cast him a withering look, one that silenced the men's quiet laughter. "Five soldiers," he repeated, his voice cold. "Enough for Rome to feel confident, but not enough to suspect anyone would dare challenge them. They'll assume

they're safe on these roads—so close to Jerusalem, they believe they're untouchable." His mouth twisted into a grim line. "But they don't know what we're capable of. We will scout every inch of this road, and the day after, we remind them that they are not invincible. Not in our land."

He straightened, looking over the gathered men, his face hardening as he took in the fire in their eyes. This wasn't his first raid, nor would it be his last, but there was a fierceness in him that gave the impression of rippling outward, stirring his comrades like a wave. These men, each one scarred by loss and hardened by anger, were bound to him by a shared desire to strike back against a world that had broken them. It wasn't the thrill of battle that drove them—it was the bitter thirst for justice.

Gestas rolled his eyes but held his tongue, his grin lingering as he shifted his weight. His fingers played idly over the hilt of his dagger, a habit from years spent surviving by blade and bluster. "You think five soldiers will give us any trouble, Barabbas?" he said, his tone lighter but still mocking. "Seems like a waste of our skills, if you ask me. They'll barely have time to draw their swords before we're on them."

Barabbas' gaze hardened. "Underestimate them if you like, Gestas. But know this: Rome's arrogance is only half of their weapon. Their armor, their training—they're more than capable of holding their ground, even when they're outnumbered. One misstep, one flaw in our plan, and it's us who'll be lying in the dirt."

A tense silence enveloped the group. Gestas averted his gaze, speaking in muffled words, though the mocking smirk lingered on his face. Yet, the force of Barabbas' words stifled any further objections. They all understood the gravity of the moment, even if some masked their fear with a veneer of bravado.

Barabbas turned his gaze from Gestas and swept it across the others, letting his voice rise, filling the space with a quiet intensity. "They believe they have stripped us of everything—our homes, our dignity, our very lives. They think they can take and take until there's nothing left of us but shadows. But soon,

we remind them that they cannot claim what is not theirs. We remind them that this land, these roads, belong to us.”

The murmurs of agreement grew louder, the men nodding, their hands tightening around their weapons. They felt the truth of his words, the rage that burned in his voice resonating with the anger and loss each of them carried. For most, this wasn’t just about revenge—it was about reclaiming the humanity that Rome had tried to strip away.

A short silence followed, laden with the gravity of the plan, as each man turned inward, grappling with his own reasons for being here, for preparing to shed blood on a road none of them owned but all believed in. On the gathering, standing a step behind, Dismas felt the tension tug at him. He looked down, the torchlight’s flickering shadows deepening the lines of his face, casting his features in a blend of doubt and resolve.

He had once traveled these roads as an innocent, a merchant, walking with his head low, eyes wary, selling goods that barely filled his family’s table. That life had slipped from his grasp, ground away by taxes, starvation, and the daily indignities of Roman rule. And now, the path he’d chosen seemed to twist before him, the hope of escape replaced by an uncertain loyalty, a reluctant allegiance to a cause he wasn’t sure he believed in.

Barabbas’ gaze shifted to him, and for a brief moment, their eyes locked. A silent question lingered there, an unspoken demand for allegiance. In that instant, Dismas felt the pull of the group, the gravity of their shared purpose pressing down on him like a stone.

But his hesitation lingered, a shadow he couldn’t shake. He looked away, tension tightening his features, yet something unspoken in him still rebelled, a quiet voice drowned by the fervor of the men around him. He could feel the cost of each raid weighing on him, a toll that no one else seemed to notice.

Dismas lingered at the group, watching the torchlight play over the hardened faces around him. The others listened to Barabbas’ words like men starving for bread, their eyes alight with the grim fire of vengeance. For them, every road Rome

claimed, every crop they took, and every coin they bled from the people was an unforgivable theft. To strike back—to claw back some small piece of what they'd lost—was more than their right; it was their duty.

But for Dismas, the cost weighed heavier tonight than ever before. He felt a tightness in his chest as he looked over the map, the narrow road they would use to trap the convoy. In his mind, the ambush unfolded in brutal clarity: the soldiers caught unaware, scrambling as the first wave of men leaped from the rocks; the shouts, the clash of metal on metal; the blood staining the dust. It was the same scene he'd pictured for every raid, and yet tonight, something twisted in him as he thought of the other lives that might cross that road.

A scene came unbidden to his mind—one he had buried long ago. He saw a younger version of himself, walking that same road with a merchant's bag slung across his shoulder, its weight pulling at him with every step. He was no fighter then, just a trader with a few rolls of linen and handfuls of olives to sell. He had traveled these same paths with nothing but his goods and his hopes, moving cautiously between towns, wary of the Roman patrols. He'd kept his head down, his voice quiet, his eyes averted.

But those days had been taken from him, ground away by the unrelenting crush of Roman taxes, the price of survival climbing higher until he had nothing left to give. By the time he turned to Barabbas, desperation had already eaten away any chance of a peaceful life. He had told himself it was temporary—that one day, when the time was right, he would leave this band of rebels, return to the roads with a merchant's satchel instead of a sword. But now, as he looked around at the faces of his comrades, he saw that this life was his only life. And the price of his loyalty felt heavier each day.

He looked down at the map, at the narrow road they would soon turn into a trap and felt a chill crawl up his spine. He took a slow breath, his voice quiet as he spoke, "And what of the others?" His question slipped into the silence like a thread through a needle, pulling at the fabric of the men's focus. "Travelers. Merchants. Families with children. They walk these roads, too."

Barabbas' head tilted slightly, his expression sharpening as he turned to look at Dismas. The men shifted, some glancing at Dismas with faint surprise, as though he had broken an unspoken rule by bringing up concerns none of them dared to voice. Yosef, the youngest among them, looked away, biting his lip. His hand tightened on his dagger, as though it might give him the strength to brush aside any doubts.

Dismas' gaze didn't waver. The faces he saw in his memory crowded in, each one demanding to be acknowledged. He could still picture them—the merchants he'd once traded with, the mothers leading children by the hand, the travelers who carried their lives on their backs. They were innocents, caught in the crossfire of a war that didn't care whether they lived or died. He remembered the way he had looked at men like Barabbas once, seeing them as reckless fools bent on destruction, unable to recognize that he himself would one day join their ranks.

Gestas let out a derisive snort, his mouth twisting into a mocking sneer. "What of them?" he retorted, his tone thick with disdain. "They'll step aside or run, same as everyone else. If they get in the way... well, that's the price of war, isn't it?"

He looked around, inviting the others to agree with him, a dark satisfaction glinting in his eyes as he dared anyone to challenge his words. Gestas' scars caught the torchlight, giving him an almost feral look as he leaned forward, relishing the chance to taunt Dismas.

"You think the Romans care about anyone outside their own ranks?" Gestas continued, his voice a sneer laced with bitterness. "They've trampled over our lives without a second thought, like we're less than dust. Don't waste your pity on those who can't see what's at stake. If they can't move fast enough, then they pay the same price we have." He leaned back, crossing his arms with a look of cruel satisfaction.

Dismas clenched his jaw, forcing himself to stay calm under Gestas' mocking gaze. The words struck him deeply, not because they were wrong, but because he could feel the truth in them gnawing at his resolve. Gestas was right—Rome cared nothing for the lives it trampled. Every coin taken, every

tax raised, every lash struck was a reminder of their indifference, their cruelty. But he had once been one of those people, one of the faceless masses struggling to survive, and he couldn't ignore the cost this raid would extract from them.

For Gestas, the idea of sparing innocents was laughable, a sign of weakness. To him, this rebellion was the largest game he'd ever played, a chance to see how far he could push his craft of violence, a twisted form of survival he had mastered young. Gestas' allegiance was not to freedom or loyalty—it was to the thrill of the fight, the satisfaction of seeing blood on his blade and knowing it had fed him. His scars were his only testament to a life where survival was earned, not given, and he would sooner die than starve subjugated under Rome's heel.

Dismas shifted, holding Gestas' gaze. "Survival doesn't make us the same as them, Gestas," he said quietly, his tone steady but edged with frustration. "We fight to reclaim what's ours, but that doesn't mean we forget what it feels like to be trampled." The words hung in the atmosphere, a calm but firm challenge.

Gestas snorted again, dismissing Dismas' words with a wave of his hand. "Oh, please. Don't act like you haven't chosen this path as much as the rest of us. Or are you here out of pity for those who don't even know what's coming?"

He let the question linger, his smirk widening as he leaned back, clearly enjoying the tension he'd stirred. For him, Dismas' reluctance was nothing more than an invitation to mock, a weakness to exploit.

Barabbas' gaze, sharp and unrelenting, locked onto Dismas, his eyes hardening as he read the turmoil etched on his friend's face. "Dismas, you're not here to pity travelers. You're here to take back what's ours. Rome has stolen everything—our land, our dignity, our freedom. Do you think a handful of frightened civilians will stop them?" His tone was resolute, breaking through the tension with a finality that brooked no argument.

Dismas held his gaze, his eyes shadowed by a weight that seemed to rest solely on him. "I know what Rome has taken,"

he said softly, his voice heavy with a sorrow the others didn't share. "I've seen it... felt it." His words carried a quiet resignation. "But every blow we land scars more than just our enemies. There's always a cost, even if we pretend not to see it."

Barabbas' expression tightened, and his gaze grew colder. "Then let them pay it," he replied, his voice echoing against the stone walls. "Let them taste what we've tasted. Fear, loss, bloodshed—these things are nothing new to us. But to them? They need a reminder, and we will be the ones to give it."

A murmur of agreement rippled through the men, each nodding in silent consent. Their faces, hardened with anger and defiance, took on a fierceness that left no room for mercy. They were ready to strike, to remind Rome that even the smallest uprising bore the scars of lives fractured by years of oppression.

Gestas leaned forward, his grin broadening as he sensed Dismas' discomfort, a glint of dark pleasure in his eyes. There was something hungry in his eyes, something that savored the chance to taunt, to belittle any hint of hesitation.

"What's wrong, Dismas?" Gestas sneered, his tone dripping with mockery. "Are you going soft on us? All this talk of sparing travelers... seems to me you're dreaming of a quiet life." His words were knives wrapped in laughter, and he relished each jab as he leaned closer, like a predator toying with prey. "Or maybe," he added, his voice lowering as his gaze sharpened, "you've just forgotten what we're here to do."

Dismas didn't look away, though his jaw tightened. Gestas' voice was a harsh reminder of what he had turned away from, of the life he'd once lived as a merchant—simple, peaceful, filled with dreams he hadn't thought he would ever lose. But this path, the one he walked now, was paved with something else entirely: sacrifice, violence, a bitterness that stained his soul with each ambush, each clash with Rome.

Gestas watched him with a smug satisfaction, crossing his arms over his chest as he leaned back. "Survival, Dismas. That's the only truth we've ever had. That's the only truth that

matters. You think you're different? Think again." He laughed, a dark, hollow sound that echoed in the cave. "We're all here because we've lost everything else. We don't have the luxury of pity. Rome doesn't care if we live or die, and I sure as hell don't care about the fools who can't keep out of our way."

For Gestas, this rebellion was nothing more than a game—a grand, bloody game where he could test the limits of his cruelty, feed the thrill that pulsed through his veins whenever he saw fear in another's eyes. Gestas had learned violence young, in the alleys of a city that had shown him only the bare edge of survival. For him, Rome was just another adversary, another challenge to face. And if it meant he could indulge in bloodshed along the way, so much the better. Loyalty was a laughable notion, freedom, a distant dream. The only thing he believed in was his own knife and the satisfaction it brought when it found its mark.

Dismas met Gestas' gaze, his own eyes dark with frustration. "Is that all this is to you, Gestas?" he asked quietly. "A thrill? A game made just for you?" He searched Gestas' face for any flicker of empathy, of understanding, but saw nothing but the familiar sneer.

Gestas laughed again, shrugging, his smirk unwavering. "Call it what you want. But don't try to fool yourself, Dismas. You're here because you chose this path, same as the rest of us. Don't act like you're different." He looked around, as if daring the others to disagree, his grin widening as he leaned back, arms crossed over his chest.

Dismas felt the chill of Gestas' words settle over him like a weight. He clenched his fists, holding back the retort that burned in his throat, knowing it would only feed Gestas' mockery. And yet, as he looked away, he couldn't shake the feeling that Gestas was right. He had chosen this path, as much as any of them. And every step he took down it brought him further from the life he had once known, from the man he had once been.

A silence settled over the group, broken only by the soft crackle of torchlight. Gestas' words lingered within the haze, cold and unyielding, a reminder of the brutal reality they all

faced. The others shifted uncomfortably, glancing between Dismas and Gestas, but no one spoke. They were bound by a shared rage, a shared hatred, and there was no room for doubt. Not here, not now.

“Enough!” Barabbas’ gaze swept across the group, his face set in a mask of steely resolve. He had watched the exchange between Dismas and Gestas in silence, his face unreadable, but now he spoke, his voice calm yet powerful, slicing through the tension like a blade.

The single word silenced Gestas’ smirk and drew every eye to Barabbas, who stood taller now, his presence dominating the cave. His gaze swept over them, steady and sharp as flint, each man feeling the intensity of his scrutiny, as though Barabbas could peer into their very souls, weighing their loyalty and testing their resolve.

“We are not here to question the price of this fight,” he spoke, his voice ringing with conviction. “We are here to reclaim what is ours. Rome has taken everything—our land, our families, our dignity. They’ve stripped us to the bone and left us with nothing but dust.” His words fell like a hammer on an anvil, solid and unyielding, and the men listened in tense silence, their breaths held as if afraid to break the moment.

He looked at Dismas, his gaze unflinching, a challenge written in his eyes. “You think this path is easy, Dismas? You think this is a choice we take lightly?” His voice was fierce, a blade cutting through any illusion of mercy. “No. We fight because we must. Because if we don’t, then Rome wins. If we don’t, then we are nothing. And I, for one, refuse to be nothing.”

He turned his gaze to the others, letting the fire in his eyes meet each of theirs in turn. “They take what they want. Walk our roads, claim our land, and leave us to rot in their shadow. But we will remind them that this land does not belong to Rome. We remind them that we are still here—that we will not fade quietly into the night.”

The men nodded, murmuring in agreement, their faces hardening with the same fire that burned in Barabbas’ eyes. For each of them, his words resonated like a drumbeat,

echoing through the depths of their minds, stirring the rage and defiance that lived in their hearts.

They knew what Rome had taken from them, and Barabbas' vow pressed on them like an unspoken oath, binding them to the cause with an intensity that allowed no room for doubt.

Yosef, the youngest among them, leaned forward, his face a blend of awe and fear. He clutched his dagger with trembling, white-knuckled hands, his wide eyes fixed on Barabbas. To Yosef, Barabbas was more than a leader—he was a legend, a man who had defied Rome time and again with a fierceness Yosef could only dream of. Now, standing in the same room, hearing the same words, Yosef felt that fire ignite within him, a flame he would carry into battle with pride.

"They'll know our names, won't they?" Yosef asked, his voice unsteady with excitement and fear. "The Romans... they'll know we're here to fight."

Barabbas' gaze softened briefly as he looked at the young man, seeing in him a reflection of the person he had once been—a man driven by dreams of freedom and the hope of a life unchained from Rome's rule. But Barabbas understood now what Yosef could not yet grasp: rebellion came with a cost; one measured in sacrifice. His back bore the scars of countless beatings, and his heart carried the ache of comrades lost to the Empire's blade. And yet, the fire within him remained, undimmed by pain or loss.

"Yes, Yosef," he said quietly, his voice edged with a somber resolve. "They will know us. And they will fear us." He turned his focus to the map, his fingers tracing the path they would take, as though sealing a pact in blood. "The road to Jerusalem will be stained with their pride."

The men murmured their agreement, hands coiled tightly and faces set with determination. Around him, Barabbas felt their resolve solidify, each man bound to the plan not only by loyalty but by anger, suffering, and the shared belief that this fight was their only path forward. Freedom, Barabbas knew, demanded sacrifice. And he was ready to lead them into the fire, even if it meant paying the ultimate price.

Dismas' gaze dropped, tension rippling through his face as he absorbed Barabbas' words. The truth in them struck him, sharp and bitter, cutting through his doubts with a clarity that left him both inspired and hollow. Barabbas wasn't just speaking of the raid; he was describing a freedom Dismas had only imagined, a freedom paid for in blood and agony. And though his heart ached with uncertainty, Dismas felt himself drawn into that vision, bound to it by the scars he carried.

Barabbas pivoted to the men, his voice rising, filled with a fierce determination. "Tomorrow, we scout every inch of that road. Every rock, every shadow, every stone. When the convoy comes, they will not see us until it's too late. And when they do..." His voice trailed off, leaving the promise hanging in the air.

The men nodded, murmuring their agreement, each one prepared to pay whatever price was asked of them. They were ready, bound by Barabbas' words, by the oath they shared. For now, for this moment, their doubts were silenced, replaced by the steady drumbeat of vengeance.

As the tension settled, the men redirected their attention to the map, their grim resolve solidified by Barabbas' speech. Yet Dismas felt a hollowness in his chest, a weight that appeared to press down harder with each word spoken, each promise of blood. The others had found purpose in this rebellion, a kind of strength he both admired and envied. But Dismas felt himself standing on something darker, as though one more step would plunge him into a depth he could never escape.

In the quiet that followed, his thoughts drifted to rumors he had heard in Jerusalem—whispers of a man from Nazareth, a prophet who spoke of peace instead of war, a kingdom that did not demand the blood of innocents. It was a foolish notion, he told himself, yet he couldn't shake it. He had heard it from a merchant's wife, a woman who claimed that this prophet could heal with a touch, that he fed thousands with mere scraps. The memory stirred something within him, a question he dared not speak.

Gestas leaned closer, his voice dropping low, almost conspiratorial. "You're awfully quiet, Dismas," he spoke, his

words curling like smoke. "What's in that head of yours? Second thoughts?" His grin was crooked, laced with amusement. "Or maybe you're scheming your own way out, looking for a crack to slip through before the real trouble starts." He chuckled darkly, his eyes narrowing as though he could read every unspoken thought. "Don't worry. Whatever you're planning, you won't get far without us. You need this as much as we do."

Dismas' eyes flashed with irritation, and he met Gestas' gaze, a hard edge in his voice. "I've fought beside you and bled beside you. Don't mistake caution for weakness." His words were calm, but there was a tension in his voice, a note that betrayed the struggle within him.

Gestas chuckled, his mocking grin widening as he leaned back, crossing his arms over his chest. "As long as you're still with us when it counts, that's all that matters." His voice was laced with dark amusement, his eyes dancing with the thrill of having found a weak spot in Dismas' armor. "But don't go hoping for miracles. Rome won't fall to pretty words and wishes."

Dismas forced himself to look away, to let the comment slide, but Gestas' words echoed in his mind, sharper than any blade. He had joined this fight out of necessity, driven by a desire to reclaim what he had lost, but now he couldn't ignore the nagging doubts that gnawed at him. What if there was another way? What if this path, paved with blood and vengeance, wasn't the only path to freedom?

But as he looked at the hardened faces around him, he knew that such questions had no place here. These men were bound to Barabbas' cause, to the promise of a rebellion that would shake the very foundations of Roman rule. To speak of doubt, of peace, was to betray that bond. And so Dismas swallowed his questions, burying them deep within, even as they continued to fester, like a wound that refused to heal.

Barabbas raised his hand, silencing the murmurs and ending the simmering tension with a single, decisive gesture. His face was set in stone, his eyes hard as he addressed the men with

the quiet authority that came from years of leading raids, of facing death and emerging stronger.

He looked around the room, his gaze settling on each man in turn, as if branding this command into their very souls. “No mistakes. No mercy. The Romans believe they are untouchable here, but we will show them they are wrong. We will make them feel the pain of every life they’ve taken, every coin they’ve stolen, every scar they’ve carved into our land.”

The men nodded, murmuring their agreement, the grim resolve in their eyes hardening. This was their mission, their oath. Rome’s oppression had ground them down to the brink of despair, but here, under Barabbas’ command, they had found a purpose that reignited their strength.

Barabbas’ gaze lingered on Dismas for a moment, a silent question in his eyes, as though he could sense the conflict stirring within his comrade. But he said nothing, letting the silence speak for him, a reminder that there was no room for doubt, no room for hesitation.

“Remember,” Barabbas continued, “every blow against Rome brings us closer to freedom. Soon, we take back what’s ours. Very soon, we remind them that we are not their slaves, that we are not theirs to break.”

The men’s voices rose in agreement, a low, rumbling sound that echoed through the cave like the growl of a beast preparing to strike. They clasped hands, exchanged nods, their faces set with grim determination. For them, this was more than just a raid—it was a reckoning, a chance to reclaim the humanity that Rome had tried to strip from them.

Dismas nodded along with the others, his face calm but his heart burdened. Barabbas’ words pressed on him, not just as a shared conviction but as a force that bound him to the group even as it set him apart. He had made his choice; he would follow the plan. Yet, as he glanced at the hardened faces, the eager spark in Yosef’s eyes, and the unyielding resolve in Barabbas’ stance, he couldn’t escape the sense that he stood on the brink of a precipice, one step away from losing himself entirely.

As the meeting concluded, the men began to disperse. Some clapped each other on the back, others inspected their weapons, murmuring quiet affirmations of readiness. The torchlight flickered against the walls, casting jagged shadows as they moved to leave the cave, each man carrying the looming weight of the ambush ahead like an unseen burden.

Dismas lingered behind, his gaze fixed on the flickering flames that danced along the rough stone walls. The shadows twisted and swayed, forming dark shapes that seemed to reach out, pulling at him, reminding him of the life he'd once known, a life that felt distant and foreign now. He let out a slow breath, feeling the chill of the cave settle over him like a shroud.

Outside, the stars blinked coldly, indifferent to the plans of men, to the wars they waged, the blood they spilled. Dismas stared up at them, his mind filled with the faces he could never forget—the faces of his family, his friends, the people he had left behind in the name of survival. He carried the load of their memory pressing down on him, filling him with a longing he couldn't name.

Somewhere in the distance, there was a whisper—a faint, unspoken promise of a different life, a life free of violence and bitterness. But it was a fleeting thought, a shadow that vanished as quickly as it had come. Here, seized by the weight of Barabbas' gaze, the silent call of duty, that whisper was nothing more than a distant echo, a ghost of a dream he had long since buried.

He reached down, his fingers brushing the hilt of his dagger, feeling the familiar weight of the blade. It was a comfort, a reminder of the path he had chosen, of the promises he had made to himself. He had chosen this life, he reminded himself. He had chosen to fight, to stand beside Barabbas, to strike back against the force that had taken everything from him. And yet... he couldn't ignore the small, gnawing doubt that lingered at his mind, the voice that whispered that there might be another way.

The men were waiting for him, watching with expectant eyes, their faces hardened by years of suffering and loss. He nodded to them, forcing a calm he didn't feel, and followed them out of

the cave, his footsteps echoing softly in the darkness. He would fight, as he always had. But in the quiet spaces of his mind, in the moments between breaths, he would hold on to the faint hope that there was something beyond this path—a hope that, though small, refused to die.

The chill night air met him as he stepped out of the cave, filling his lungs with the sharp scent of earth and pine. He took a deep breath, letting the coldness settle over him, steeling himself for the task that lay ahead. Somewhere along that dark road, beneath the same indifferent stars, the Romans were waiting. And very soon, they would meet.

Dismas cast one last glance at the cave, then turned his gaze to the horizon, to the path that stretched before him, dark and uncertain. He knew that whatever lay at its end, he would not escape unscathed. And in the silence that followed, with the stars as his only witness, he made his choice.

Act 1 - 05

Simon

The stranger's words clung to Simon like an iron brand, searing his thoughts as he moved away from the brutal scene.

"This is how it is. Life means nothing to them. We are nothing to them."

The bitter truth of those words gnawed at his mind, leaving an invisible scar that felt as if it deepened with every step. The injustice of it churned within him, a cold fury coiled beneath layers of discipline and faith, unfamiliar and unrelenting.

He exhaled sharply, shaking his head as if the motion might banish the memory. He hadn't come to Jerusalem to dwell on Rome's cruelty or entangle himself in its turmoil. His purpose was a pilgrimage—a sacred vow bound to his ancestors and his God. Yet no matter how he tried to shake off the burden of what he had witnessed, it clung to him, an unrelenting shadow. Something fundamental had changed, an invisible thread pulling at the fabric of his journey.

The city stretched out before him in a labyrinth of life and chaos. Merchants barked from their stalls, their cries rising above the din as they hawked fruits, spices, and linens. The air swirled with the pungent tang of unfamiliar herbs, mingling with the heady scent of incense that drifted from shrines and street altars. People paused in the flow within the masses to murmur prayers or leave offerings, but Simon felt no comfort in their

piety. Instead, Jerusalem throbbed with a pulse of foreboding, its energy unsettling and raw.

Roman soldiers stood like sentinels at every corner, their armor glinting in the unrelenting sun. Their eyes tracked the crowd with quiet control, less like beasts chasing prey and more like predators certain of the outcome. Simon watched as people skirted them with wary glances and hurried steps, their reverence for the city tempered by fear. The soldiers seemed to bask in the unease they inspired, their hands resting lightly on their swords, exuding an authority that weighed on the crowd like an unseen yoke. Even the vibrant noise of the marketplace seemed dulled beneath the oppressive tension, as if the city itself were holding its breath.

In the marketplace, Simon sought solace in its vivid spectacle: bolts of brightly colored fabric draped across tables, clay jars overflowing with olives that gleamed like onyx in the sunlight, and the sharp tang of vinegar and spices weaving through the heavy air. The city pulsed with life, vibrant and teeming with pilgrims from every corner of the land, each carrying their own stories, their own hopes, their own sorrows. Yet Simon drifted through the throng like a shadow, detached and unmoored, an outsider in the heart of a bustling sea of humanity.

The Temple rose above the cacophony, its white stones shimmering like a promise etched into the sky. It was for this sacred place that Simon had come, for this reason he had walked so many miles. He thought of the prayers he had prepared, words of devotion and gratitude, of protection for his family and strength for the days ahead. Those prayers had seemed so certain, so whole, before he arrived. Now, with the force of Rome's brutality bearing down on his mind, they felt thin, fragile—a whisper against a storm.

Around him, life surged: a woman haggling fiercely over grain, a child tugging on his mother's sleeve, an old man speaking softly to a merchant about spices from distant lands. It was a beautiful, chaotic tapestry of resilience, a testament to the strength of his people. And yet, beneath it all, Simon sensed an unease as heavy as his own, an unspoken tension rippling through the horde like the low growl of thunder before a storm.

He forced himself to breathe deeply, lifting his head as though the simple act might steady his resolve. He had come to Jerusalem for more than his own struggles, more than the fleeting troubles of this world. This city, holy and burdened, had always been a place of contrasts—faith and fear, devotion and danger intertwined like threads in a loom. Simon thought of the countless pilgrims who had walked these same streets, their prayers rising like incense to the heavens despite the shadows cast by Rome. He was not the first to carry such doubts, such burdens. He would not be the last.

Ahead, the Temple beckoned, its towering walls standing as a sanctuary against the chaos. It was there Simon knew, that he would find strength. Whatever storm brewed around him, this was his anchor, his refuge. With one final glance at the marketplace—at the restless crowd, the indifferent soldiers—Simon turned and his steps grew surer with each stride.

He had come to this city for something unshakable, something eternal. For his family, for his faith, he would carry on. And though the shadow of Rome loomed over every corner of Jerusalem, Simon clung to the certainty that his journey still held meaning. He would not let it be in vain.

The massive courts stood above Jerusalem, their scale unbroken even under the weight of occupation. Its stones gleamed in the warm light of the sinking sun, white and solid as the faith that had endured within these walls for centuries. Simon felt a tremor of reverence as he approached, his heart stirring with the quiet awe of one who had traveled far to lay his burdens at the feet of the divine. This sacred place stood as more than just a building—it was a testament to survival, a monument to the resilience of a people who had endured the crushing weight of empires and emerged, again and again, unbroken.

But reverence was not the only emotion Simon carried. Beneath it flickered doubt, a question that refused to be silenced. Was this sanctuary still the refuge it had always been? Could these walls, no matter how solid, truly shield them from the forces gathering just beyond their gates? The image of the soldier's whip flashed through his mind, vivid and

sharp—a brutal reminder of how easily power could breach even the most sacred spaces.

Simon couldn't shake the feeling that this city, with all its holiness, was bracing for something monumental. It felt as though Jerusalem herself were waiting for a reckoning, a moment that would either strengthen the bonds of faith or reveal their fragility. He had come seeking solace, guidance, a sense of renewal, but now he feared the answers he sought might not lie within these walls. The structure was beautiful, enduring, yet it seemed to tremble under the strain of all it carried.

Simon inhaled deeply, drawing strength from the cool evening air as he continued forward. The doubts and shadows in his mind could not be allowed to take root; his faith demanded more. Whatever flaws the Temple might hold, whatever forces sought to undermine its sanctity, it remained a symbol of everything his people had endured. It was imperfect, vulnerable, and yet it stood firm, a testament to defiance against despair. For that alone, Simon resolved to press on.

Ahead, the Temple roof absorbed the last rays of sunlight, its high walls bathed in golden light, glowing faintly against the encroaching dusk. It seemed to rise above the chaos, a reminder of all that had been promised and of the covenant that bound his people to something greater than themselves. Simon tightened his grip on his satchel and steadied his breath, his steps purposeful now.

As another group of pilgrims passed, their voices low and reverent, Simon caught fragments of their stories. Among them were the old, their faces marked with lines of struggle and resilience, their steps deliberate as they leaned on weathered walking sticks for balance and comfort. The young moved with a different rhythm, their eager strides and bright eyes brimming with unguarded energy, a stark contrast to the heavy atmosphere over the city. Watching them, Simon felt a bittersweet ache—a reminder of the faith they shared and the isolation he could not shake. Here, among his people, he should have felt grounded, yet he was untethered, his solitude a weight that even their presence could not lighten.

The sacred halls rising before him promised unity, a connection that spanned generations and carried his people through exile, conquest, and endless trials. Yet Jerusalem itself felt strained, as if holding its breath for an event that would fracture every bond, test every prayer. Simon had come seeking peace and clarity, but he feared that the answers he sought might not lie within these walls. Something unspoken, unyielding, seemed to linger beyond the Temple's gates, waiting to be revealed.

Ahead, the sun dipped lower, casting amber shadows across the faces amid the gathering as Simon approached the Temple's entrance. A small group of men stood apart, huddled in whispered conversation. Their robes, stained with the dust of the road, could not conceal the intensity in their expressions—a light of hope, tempered by fear. Simon slowed his steps, pretending to adjust his satchel, and lingered just close enough to catch their words.

"Have you heard?" one man said, his voice tight with a mix of caution and awe. "They say there is a prophet among us—a man who speaks of a kingdom, unlike any we've known."

Another nodded, his movements swift and furtive as he glanced over his shoulder. "A Messiah," he murmured, his tone barely audible. "They say he heals the sick with a touch, that his works defy the laws of this world."

Simon's pulse quickened as their words wrapped around him, familiar and dangerous, like the flicker of flames too close to dry grass. He had heard rumors of such a man—stories carried by travelers and merchants, whispered in hushed tones. A carpenter from Nazareth, they said, who calmed storms with a word, fed thousands with a handful of bread and fish, and spoke with a wisdom that silenced even the most learned. A healer, a miracle-worker—perhaps more.

But the word Messiah struck deeper, carrying a weight that could not be ignored. To believe it was to risk everything.

"What does he say?" Simon asked softly, his voice carefully measured as he met the eyes of one of the men. "Is he truly what we've been waiting for?"

The man hesitated, his expression a fragile balance of skepticism and longing. “He speaks of a kingdom not of this world—a kingdom of justice and peace. Some believe he is the one, sent to deliver us from Rome.” His voice fell to a near whisper. “But others say it’s a fool’s hope, that his words will bring Rome’s wrath upon us all.”

Simon felt those words settle over him like a shroud. To hope for deliverance, to believe in the promise of a Messiah, was to walk a blade. Rome tolerated no challenges to its authority, and even whispers of a new kingdom could bring swift and ruthless retaliation. Yet wasn’t that hope part of why Simon had come to Jerusalem. Wasn’t it the faith he sought to rekindle, even under the oppressive shadow of empire?

The group fell silent as a patrol of soldiers marched past, their footsteps pounding the ground in an unyielding rhythm. Their presence stifled the air, replacing the crowd’s murmurs with an uneasy stillness. Simon’s gaze flicked to the men around him, their faces hard and guarded, their hope momentarily obscured by fear. Yet in their eyes, he saw it—a quiet, stubborn light that refused to be extinguished.

Hope was fragile, easily shattered beneath the iron grip of empire. But as Simon studied the men, he saw its strength as well—resilient and defiant, unyielding even in the face of danger.

Doubt and fear lingered in Simon’s thoughts, but he pressed forward, his steps steadier with each passing moment. He had come to fulfill his vow, to lay his prayers before the divine. And though the shadow of Rome loomed heavy over the city, Simon held fast to the belief that his journey was not in vain.

Simon continued weaving his way through the crowd, his mind still heavy with the rumors he’d overheard about the prophet. Suddenly, a hand gripped his shoulder firmly, halting his steps. He turned, his eyes meeting a familiar face from years past—a friend from his youth, with whom he had once toiled under the same sun and shared countless stories and laughter.

“Simon!” Mathias exclaimed, a mixture of surprise and warmth in his voice. “I almost didn’t recognize you! It’s been far too long.”

Simon couldn’t help but smile, a brief, welcome relief from the unease he felt in the bustling city. “It has,” he replied, grasping Mathias’ arm in greeting. “I’d hoped to see you here, though I wasn’t sure I’d find you in this chaos.”

Mathias chuckled, though his laughter was tinged with an edge of weariness. “Chaos is right. You’ve arrived in Jerusalem just in time for the thick of it.” He cast a wary glance around, his face growing serious. “These are troubled times, my friend. It seems the whole city is on edge, as though we’re all holding our breath, waiting for something to tip the scales.”

Simon’s smile faded as he listened, a creeping sense of dread beginning to stir within him. He had seen evidence of this tension everywhere—the watchful eyes of the soldiers, the hushed conversations among the pilgrims, the fear lurking beneath the reverent excitement. And now, here was Mathias, echoing the same sentiment he’d sensed but hadn’t yet spoken aloud.

“What’s this I hear about a prophet?” Simon asked quietly, his voice barely above a murmur. “They say there is talk of a Messiah—someone who claims to be the deliverer we’ve waited for.”

Mathias’ expression darkened, worry shadowing his face. He cast another glance around before leaning in close, his voice low and serious. “Yes, the rumors are true. They say he’s been performing miracles—healing the sick, feeding the hungry with nothing but a few scraps. Some are calling him a prophet; others say he’s the Messiah.” He paused, the hesitation clear in his voice. “But I fear what Rome will do if his following grows much larger. They’re watching him closely, Simon. One misstep, one moment of chaos, and everything could erupt.”

Simon’s chest tightened as he considered Mathias’ words. The very mention of a Messiah, a new kingdom, carried a dangerous weight. To Rome, such claims were nothing less than a threat, a call to rebellion. And yet... wasn’t that hope the

very reason so many pilgrims had gathered in Jerusalem? Wasn't it that promise of deliverance, of freedom, that his people had clung to for generations?

"What do you think?" Simon asked quietly, his gaze fixed on Mathias' face. "Do you believe he could be the one?"

Mathias' eyes softened; the lines of worry etched deep into his face. "I want to believe, Simon. Truly, I do. But I've seen too many dreams shattered, too many people pay the price for daring to hope." He paused, his words heavy in the space between them. "Hope is a dangerous thing. It can lift you up, but when it fails... it can break you."

Simon nodded slowly, the truth of Mathias' words settling over him like a shadow. They were words born of caution, shaped by hard-earned experience. To hope was to risk everything—to open one's heart to a dream that might never come to pass. Yet, without hope, what did they have? Simon had come to Jerusalem seeking strength, seeking to renew his faith. But now, he felt its fragility, the precarious ground on which it stood, shaken by forces beyond his control.

They stood in silence, their shared understanding forming an unspoken bond between them. In their clasped hands, Simon sensed the tension of fear and expectation, hope and doubt mingling inseparably. Mathias' gaze met his, carrying the quiet anguish of a man who yearned to believe but feared the price it might demand.

"Stay safe, Simon," Mathias said softly, his voice a quiet plea. "Jerusalem is no place for idle dreams—not anymore."

With that, Mathias released Simon's hand, his form disappearing into the crowd, swallowed by the press of pilgrims and merchants. Simon watched him go, a sense of loss stirring within him, as if he had just seen a flame extinguished, a glimmer of faith dimmed beneath the weight of the world.

Turning back toward the Temple, Simon's heart felt heavier than before. The promise of a Messiah, of deliverance, loomed both as a beacon and a warning—a vision of freedom

intertwined with the inevitability of suffering. The city seemed to hold its breath, caught in the tension between hope and fear, waiting for the moment when the balance would tip. Simon wondered which force would ultimately prevail.

The masses pressed in tighter as Simon approached the Temple steps, a sea of humanity teeming with reverence and unease. Pilgrims surged forward, murmuring prayers as they ascended the wide stone stairs that led to the sacred structure. Others lingered in clusters, speaking in hushed tones, their wary glances fixed on the Roman guards stationed strategically around the square.

Keeping his head low, Simon wove through the throng, his thoughts weighed down by Mathias' parting words. Each step felt heavier, as though the shroud of responsibility intensified the closer he came to the Temple. Fragments of conversation drifted past him, hopes and fears mingling in the breeze alongside the scent of incense wafting from the altars. The tension was palpable, an undercurrent humming beneath the prayers and chants, a stark reminder that even here, in the shadow of the sacred, danger was never far away.

A mother brushed past him, pulling her two children close, her face set in a mask of determination. Simon watched her, feeling a pang of empathy for the worry etched into her expression. She moved forward with a fierce protectiveness, her grip on her children tight as though her love alone could shield them from the dangers that surrounded them. Simon thought of his own family waiting eagerly for his return. He understood her fear, her need to seek out a place of safety in a world that seemed intent on stripping away every comfort, every certainty.

The Temple was more than just a building; it was a fortress of faith, a reminder of who they were and where they came from. For generations, his people had come to this place to seek guidance, to lift their struggles to something greater. Simon knew he was just one among many, a single soul in the vast story of his people. Yet the weight of that story settled heavily upon him now, urging him to move forward, to draw strength from these walls, however fragile that strength might feel.

As he reached the top of the steps, he paused, allowing himself a moment to take in the sight of the Temple rising above him, majestic and unyielding. It was a place of hope, a refuge from the harshness of the world, a reminder that even under the watchful eyes of Rome, their faith endured. And for the first time since he entered Jerusalem, he felt a flicker of calm, a brief moment of peace amidst the chaos.

Crossing the threshold of the Temple, Simon felt the world outside fade away. The air inside was cool, carrying the faint scent of incense and olive oil, a soothing contrast to the heat and dust beyond these walls. He moved slowly, his footsteps hushed on the smooth stone floor, his eyes drawn to the flickering oil lamps that cast a warm, gentle glow across the intricate carvings and gold accents that adorned the interior. Here, in this sacred space, he could feel the centuries of devotion that had shaped it, the prayers of his ancestors echoing within these walls.

Simon approached a small altar, a modest wooden structure worn smooth by the hands of countless pilgrims who had knelt here before him. He took a deep breath, letting the silence settle over him, quieting the turmoil in his mind. Kneeling on the cool stone floor, he closed his eyes, his thoughts drifting to his family, to the loved ones he had left behind in Cyrene. He pictured his wife, her calm strength, her gentle smile; his sons, wide-eyed with wonder, eager to hear of his journey; his newborn daughter, her tiny hand curling around his finger as he whispered promises of protection and love.

He bowed his head, his voice a soft murmur as he began his prayer. "Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the Universe," he whispered, the words carrying a quiet power, ancient and unbroken. "You have sanctified us with Your commandments and commanded us to light the festival candles."

The words were familiar, anchoring him in the lineage of his faith and the enduring resilience of his people. As he continued, his doubts began to ebb, replaced by a quiet determination. Here, in the presence of the sacred, he felt the strength he had been searching for—a strength that bound him to his family, his ancestors, and the countless souls who had sought refuge within these walls.

For a moment, he was no longer just Simon of Cyrene, a humble merchant seeking meaning in a world fraught with danger. He was a part of something greater, bound to a faith that had withstood the rise and fall of empires. He felt his resolve harden, a flicker of light against the shadows that threatened to consume him. He would return to his family not just with stories, but with the promise of resilience, of a faith that could endure even the darkest of times.

As Simon rose from his prayer, a sense of calm lingering in his chest, he noticed movement nearby. A young child, no older than six or seven, was tugging at her mother's robe, her eyes wide with wonder as she pointed toward the intricate carvings on the Temple's columns. Her expression was one of pure awe, a simple joy that appeared to shine through the tension that surrounded them. "Look, Mama! It's beautiful!" the child whispered; her voice soft but filled with delight.

The mother managed a gentle smile, though Simon could see the worry etched into her brow, the shadow of concern that lingered even in this sacred space. "Yes, my dear. It is beautiful," she replied, her tone both tender and weary. She wrapped an arm around her daughter's shoulders, pulling her close, as though hoping to shield her from the harshness of the world beyond these walls.

Simon watched them, a pang of empathy stirring within him. The child's innocent wonder was a reminder of the world he had hoped to build for his own children, a world free from fear and oppression, a world where beauty and faith could flourish un-shadowed by violence. He felt his resolve strengthen, a quiet determination settling over him. He would not let the darkness of this world overshadow his family's light; he would carry this moment, this peace, back with him, a shield against the trials that awaited them.

The mother glanced up, catching Simon's eye, her expression one of weary understanding. In that brief exchange, they shared a silent acknowledgment of the burdens they carried, the unspoken promise to protect their children, no matter the cost. Simon offered a small nod, a gesture of solidarity, of shared purpose. They were strangers, bound only by a fleeting

encounter in this sacred space, but in that moment, he felt a kinship with her, a connection that went beyond words.

Here, amidst the beauty and solemnity of the Temple, he found a strength he hadn't expected, a determination that would carry him through whatever lay ahead. He thought of his family, of the promises he had made, and he knew that he would not leave Jerusalem empty-handed. He would bring back more than mere stories or trinkets; he would bring back the resilience of his faith, a promise of hope in the face of darkness.

The mother and child moved on, their figures blending into the crowd, but their presence lingered with him, a reminder of what he fought for, of the future he wished to protect. He took a deep breath, letting the peace of the Temple settle over him one last time, a calm before the storm that awaited outside.

Simon took a final breath within the Temple's walls, feeling the coolness of the stone and the quiet strength of this sacred place settle over him. It was as if, for these few moments, he had found a refuge where his worries could not reach him, where the burden he carried had lightened, if only slightly. Here, amidst the quiet murmurs of prayer and the flickering oil lamps, he had found a sense of purpose, a reminder of why he had made this journey.

But outside, the faint roar amid the multitude was already reaching his ears, the relentless pulse of life in Jerusalem pressing against the Temple like an unyielding tide. He knew that once he stepped back into the city, the burdens of reality would descend upon him again—the watchful gaze of Roman soldiers, the strained faces of fellow pilgrims, the hushed whispers of rebellion and looming danger. Yet, he felt ready. He had come too far, given too much, to leave this city without something to take back home.

Slowly, he turned and began making his way back toward the entrance. He moved with a new steadiness, his steps no longer hesitant but sure, guided by the quiet strength he had found within these walls. He was not just a man passing through Jerusalem; he was a father, a husband, a son bound by faith and duty, carrying with him the resilience of his people.

He would bring back more than stories or mementos; he would bring back a piece of the endurance he had found here, a promise of hope and strength for his family.

As he neared the Temple's grand doors, he paused, casting one last look at the space around him, the high stone walls that had borne witness to countless generations.

He adjusted the strap of his satchel, his hand brushing against the small pouch of coins he had saved for this pilgrimage. It wasn't much, barely enough to buy the supplies he needed for his family back home. Yet now, with his purpose rekindled, he knew he would find a way. He would gather what he could, humble though it might be, and bring it back to them as a symbol of this journey—a symbol of the love and resilience that bound them together, no matter the trials they faced.

Steeling himself, Simon stepped forward, passing through the Temple's doors and into the evening. The noise of the city surged toward him like a wave, harsh and unrelenting, but this time he met it with calm resolve. The legion of bodies thrummed around him, a ceaseless flow of pilgrims and merchants, guards and children. It was a world brimming with tension, the threads of countless lives intertwining, each person carrying their own hopes and fears. Yet amidst the clamor and chaos, Simon clung to his purpose, holding it close like a flame carefully shielded from the wind.

Act 1 - 06

Dismas

The dawn was gray and uncertain, its light struggling to penetrate the heavy clouds that clung to the rugged hillsides. Barabbas, Dismas, and Gestas made their way up the steep path, their footsteps muted by the loose gravel beneath them. The air was cool, sharp, tinged with the scent of earth and stone, as if the ground itself held its breath, waiting.

Barabbas took the lead, moving with the confidence of a man who knew these paths intimately. His broad shoulders cut a determined line through the mist, every step deliberate, his gaze fixed ahead. Gestas followed close behind, his eyes gleaming with an excitement he couldn't quite hide, as if the anticipation of violence gave him energy. Dismas lingered at the back, his steps slower, burdened by a sense of unease that had followed him like a shadow since they'd set out that morning. The previous night's conversation had unsettled him, gnawing at his thoughts like a persistent ache.

The path wound upward, treacherous and narrow, hemmed in by jagged rocks that jutted out from the hillside like ancient teeth. Around them, the land was barren and unforgiving, dotted only by patches of scrub and the occasional twisted tree clinging to the rocks. Dismas glanced over his shoulder, the valley below obscured by the morning mist, and felt a pang of something he couldn't name—regret, perhaps, or a memory of a life he had nearly forgotten.

They moved in silence, each man lost in his own thoughts. Barabbas' expression was set in a grim line, his mind already on the ambush, on the sharp flash of blades and the thrill of striking a blow against Rome's oppressive grip. Gestas, by contrast, seemed almost relaxed, his lips curving in a smirk as he glanced around, as though savoring the quiet before the storm. Dismas, however, felt a growing weight pressing down on him with each step, an unease that wound itself tighter and tighter around his heart.

He couldn't shake the feeling that he was out of place, that this life of violence and rebellion was swallowing him whole, turning him into something he hadn't intended to become. He had once thought that joining Barabbas' cause would give him purpose, a way to fight back against the injustice he had suffered. But now, as they climbed through the silence of the hills, he wondered if he had made a terrible mistake. The thrill that animated Barabbas and Gestas felt foreign to him, like a language he could no longer understand.

Ahead of him, Barabbas picked up his pace, his eyes narrowed in determination as he focused on the path. Dismas watched him, a strange mixture of admiration and dread tightening in his chest. Barabbas was a man of conviction, unwavering and relentless, and for a long time, Dismas had found strength in that. But now, he wondered if conviction alone was enough to sustain a man—or if it would only lead him to ruin.

Finally, they ascended to the ridge, a jagged outcrop jutting over the winding road below. Barabbas halted abruptly, extending his arm in a deliberate motion. "Here," he declared, his tone carrying a grim authority laced with satisfaction. His eyes locked onto the narrow pass between the cliffs, the treacherous path below resembling a trap waiting to be sprung. "This is where we'll strike," he continued, his gaze alight with a predatory focus. "They'll file through here, unaware, as helpless as prey walking into the jaws of the hunter."

Gestas stepped up beside him, squinting down at the road with a smirk. "Try sheep headed to the butcher." He let out a soft chuckle, his hand idly resting on the hilt of his blade. "They'll

be stumbling over themselves before they even realize what's happening."

Dismas stepped forward, his eyes following the line of the road below. From this height, he could see the way it narrowed, pinched between steep cliffs, forming a natural funnel that would trap anyone traveling along it. It was a clever spot, ideal for an ambush, hidden from view and far from any patrol that might intervene. Still, a nagging sense of doubt gnawed at him.

"It's a good place," he admitted, his tone quiet and thoughtful. "But are we sure it will only be a handful of soldiers? If they're expecting trouble, they'll send more guards. It wouldn't take much to turn this into a death trap—for us." Barabbas shot him a hard look, a flash of irritation crossing his face. "Always the cautious one, aren't you, Dismas? You think too much. If they bring more, we fight harder. That's the way of it."

Dismas met his gaze, his jaw set, a faint smirk tugging at his lips. "Maybe I just prefer keeping my head attached to my shoulders. Someone here has to think things through."

Gestas chuckled darkly, his grin sharp as a blade. "Thinking doesn't win wars, Dismas. Steel does. And last I checked; Rome wasn't trembling at the sound of your clever little quips." He tilted his head, his eyes gleaming with mockery. "But by all means, keep philosophizing. Maybe they'll spare you for being insightful."

"We're here to act, not bicker". Barabbas' eyes darkened, but he kept his voice steady. "Tomorrow, we strike without a second thought. We hit them fast and hard, and by the time they understand what's happening, we'll be gone."

Dismas glanced down at the road once more, his unease growing. The logic of the ambush was sound, but he couldn't shake the feeling that they were tempting fate, that something unforeseen would come to pass. Yet here, surrounded by men who saw caution as weakness, he knew better than to voice his doubts any further. He nodded, saying nothing more.

Barabbas' gaze returned to the road below. "We will make sure Rome learns that this land isn't theirs to take. We remind

them who owns these roads, who this land belongs to.” His voice was fierce, filled with a cold conviction that left no room for doubt or hesitation.

Gestas let out a quiet laugh, clearly savoring the promise of violence. “Tomorrow, then. It’ll be a fine sight, watching those Roman dogs realize they’re not invincible.”

Dismas forced himself to nod, swallowing the unease that simmered beneath his calm expression. He looked out over the ridge, the narrow path below, and wondered how many more such missions he would endure before his doubts overtook him completely.

Just as the three men prepared to descend, a faint murmur drifted up from the valley below, carried on the morning air. Barabbas stiffened, raising a hand to silence Gestas and Dismas. They froze, straining to hear, their eyes scanning the slopes. The sound grew clearer—a rhythmic rise and fall of voices, unmistakably a gathering of people.

Barabbas motioned for them to follow him around the hillside, moving with practiced stealth. They rounded a sharp curve and halted at the sight below: a crowd, scattered across the grassy slope of a hillside, its size beyond anything they had anticipated. Hundreds—no, thousands—of people had gathered, their faces turned toward a lone figure who stood atop a small rise, speaking with calm authority.

Dismas squinted, his heartbeat quickening as he took in the scene. The crowd stretched out over the hillside like a vast human tapestry, a wave of worn, ragged faces that seemed to lean forward, drinking in the words of the speaker with a fervor he could feel even from this distance. He couldn’t make out the man’s words, but he sensed something in his voice—a warmth, a gravity that was unlike anything he’d heard before.

Barabbas’ lip curled in disgust as he observed the crowd. “Look at them—flocks of fools waiting for a miracle,” he grumbled, his voice laced with scorn. “Does this city have no end of desperate souls?”

Gestas chuckled, crossing his arms as he leaned back against a rock, his gaze fixed on the assembly with mild amusement. "Can you blame them? The man's probably a better speaker than their priests. At least he's quieted them down."

Dismas, however, found his gaze fixed on the lone figure, a sense of curiosity stirring within him. The voice had a quality he couldn't place, something that reached him even from afar. Before he realized what he was doing, he took a step forward, wanting to draw closer, to hear the words for himself. For reasons he couldn't explain, he felt the urge to listen, to see the man up close.

Barabbas threw him a sharp look. "Where do you think you're going?"

Dismas shrugged, trying to mask his curiosity with a grin. "We're hungry, aren't we? Even prophets have to eat. Maybe there's food." He managed a wry grin, but the feeling tugging at him was deeper, a pull he couldn't quite shake.

They descended the slope, moving cautiously along the crowd. As they neared, the soft murmur of the man's voice grew clearer. The speaker's words, calm and steady, seemed to carry far beyond the natural reach of a single voice, filling the hillside with a quiet authority that stilled the crowd. Dismas couldn't quite make out everything he said, but each phrase felt like a balm, resonating with something deep within him. He felt a strange peace wash over him, a feeling so foreign it unsettled him.

Suddenly, the man raised a few small loaves of bread into the air, speaking words that Dismas couldn't hear. As the bread was broken and passed, something remarkable began to unfold. As if by some miracle, the small portion multiplied, spreading through the crowd, filling each person's hands. Gasps of astonishment rippled through the people, murmurs of awe filling the air as bread continued to pass down the rows, seemingly without end.

Gestas' usual smirk faded as he watched, his face shifting to one of disbelief. "Did you see that?" he whispered under his breath, his voice tinged with something close to fear. "How...?"

Dismas felt his heart pound. He'd seen the man break only a few loaves, yet the food continued to pass through the crowd, filling the hands and mouths of those who had come. It defied every law he knew, every reality he trusted. This wasn't just a trick or illusion—this was something he couldn't explain, a moment that defied the brutality of his world.

Beside him, Barabbas' expression darkened, his face hardening. "It's nothing but a show," he said in a low tone, his voice dismissive. "Cheap magic for those who are weak enough to believe in it. Peace and miracles—what good are they when you're living under the rule of a sword?"

Dismas ignored him, transfixed by the sight. For the first time in years, he felt a stirring in his chest, a whisper of something he'd nearly forgotten. It was the feeling of hope—a fragile, dangerous thing, but something he couldn't deny. He kept his eyes fixed on the man, watching the way he moved, the way he spoke, and wondered if there was something more to him than he had first thought.

Amidst the crowd, a familiar voice called out. "Barabbas!" The voice held a strange blend of warmth and rebuke, a tone only an old friend could manage.

Barabbas turned toward the voice, his instincts sharpening as he recognized the speaker. His lips curled into a crooked smirk, though his eyes gleamed with suspicion. "Well, look who it is," his voice steeped in mockery. "Judas Iscariot. From zealot to prophet's disciple. I didn't think I'd see you praying at the feet of a preacher."

Judas stepped closer; his posture steady but his eyes heavy with conviction. "I chose to follow him, Barabbas," he said evenly. "I believe he's the one—the Messiah we've waited for. You and I bled for the same cause once. But this—this is something greater than rebellion."

Barabbas' laugh was sharp and bitter. "The Messiah? You think your teacher is the one to free us? For three years, Judas, he's wandered around, preaching to peasants, healing beggars, talking about love and forgiveness. Rome doesn't fear that. Rome fears blood. It fears rebellion." He leaned in,

his grin sharpening. "What has he done to strike fear into them? Nothing."

Judas' jaw tightened, but his voice remained calm, though tinged with frustration. "He doesn't need to spill blood to change the world, Barabbas. I've seen what he can do—miracles that defy understanding. He could rally thousands without raising a sword. He could call down heaven itself if he chose to."

Barabbas sneered, his contempt plain. "Then why hasn't he? He's had three years, Judas. Three years of gathering followers, walking the hillsides, and telling stories. If he's the deliverer, why hasn't he struck? What's he waiting for?"

Judas hesitated, the question hitting him like a blow. "He has his reasons," he said, though the words came slower, as if even he needed convincing. "I don't know his timing, but that doesn't mean he won't act. With Jerusalem filled for Passover, the city is ready. The people are ready. He could lead us now, Barabbas."

Barabbas scoffed, stepping closer until their faces were inches apart. His voice dropped to a low, venomous snarl. "You're clinging to a dream, Judas. You think Rome will tremble at miracles? You think sermons will drive soldiers from our streets? No. Freedom is bought with blood. And while you're waiting for your dreamer to make up his mind, more of our people die."

Judas' frustration flared, his voice rising with intensity. "And how far has that gotten us? Every rebellion crushed, every leader dead, and Rome's grip tighter than ever! Do you think I don't question, don't wonder why he waits? But I've seen his power, Barabbas. He doesn't need swords to win. He could summon armies with a word."

Barabbas' contempt hardened into icy resolve. "If he could, Judas, then he would have by now. He hasn't because he can't. Your Messiah isn't waiting for the right moment. He's not going to fight at all."

The words hit Judas like a slap, but he swallowed the rising bitterness, forcing himself to hold Barabbas' gaze. "You don't understand, Barabbas. You've always trusted in steel and fire. But this is something deeper—something stronger than rebellion. He's building a kingdom that Rome can't destroy."

Barabbas shook his head, his smirk returning, though it was colder now, filled with pity. "Go back to your preacher, Judas. Let him lead the meek and the hopeful. I'll lead the men who know what freedom costs."

The tension between them hung heavy, like a blade poised to strike. Judas exhaled sharply, his voice softening but retaining its edge. "You call it weakness, Barabbas. But it isn't. It's hope—the kind that can outlast Rome and every empire that comes after." He paused, searching Barabbas' eyes for a flicker of understanding but finding only defiance. "I don't expect you to see it. Not yet."

Barabbas stepped back, crossing his arms, his posture unyielding. "Then leave me to my fight, Judas. Let me do what your Messiah won't."

Judas hesitated, then turned away, his steps brisk, though his mind churned. The question Barabbas had asked—*why hasn't he acted?*—echoed like a drumbeat in his thoughts. He had followed Jesus for three years, watched him perform miracles that could rally a nation. Yet still, Jesus remained silent, refusing to take the fight to Rome.

As Judas walked away a seed of doubt planted by Barabbas began to take root, a dark whisper in the back of his mind. Perhaps it was time to force the Messiah's hand. Perhaps the path to freedom lay not in waiting, but in pushing him to reveal his power.

Behind him, Barabbas turned away, his contempt lingering as he melded back into the crowd, his focus fixed on his own plans. Both men walked different paths, yet each step carried them closer to the same storm.

Barabbas watched Judas disappear back into the crowd, a bitter sneer curling his lips. He stared at the retreating figure,

his teeth pressing together as if holding back words left unsaid. Then he scoffed, shaking his head with a look of pure disdain. "There goes the fool, off to chase fairy tales and empty promises."

Gestas let out a low chuckle, nudging Dismas with his elbow. "Look at him, all full of hope and dreams. Doesn't know what it takes to survive."

But Dismas wasn't listening to Gestas. His gaze was fixed on the mob below, the murmurs of reverence still carrying up the hill. He could see the way the people looked at Jesus, with something akin to awe. Even Judas, whose fervor Dismas had found unsettling, looked at Jesus as if he truly believed this man could change everything. And somehow, this strange belief held its own power, a force that appeared to defy the brutal reality Dismas had come to know.

Barabbas turned to Dismas, a sharp edge in his eyes. "You're not buying into his nonsense, are you? This so-called 'Messiah' will do nothing but leave a trail of crushed hope in his wake. He's no more a savior than the next fool."

Dismas shrugged, forcing himself to adopt a casual tone. "I know what I see, Barabbas. And what I see is that these people—" he gestured toward the spectators—"believe in him. Whether he's truly the Messiah or not, he's giving them something they've never had before."

Barabbas' expression twisted with contempt. "And you think that matters? You think Rome cares about hope? They crush it beneath their heel every day. This Messiah will crumble the moment he tries to stand against them."

Dismas said nothing, choosing instead to hold Barabbas' gaze, his face betraying no emotion. But inside, he felt a flicker of something he hadn't felt in years—doubt. As much as he respected Barabbas, he couldn't shake the feeling that there was something different about Jesus, something powerful enough to make even men like Judas abandon their weapons.

"Let him have his miracles," Barabbas continued, his tone laced with disdain. "We're here to deal in reality, not illusions."

When the time comes, this prophet and his dreamers will see that blood, not words, is what drives Rome to its knees.” The words echoed in Dismas’ mind as he watched Judas disappear into the crowd, a lingering unease settling in his chest.

As Barabbas and Gestas turned to leave, Dismas cast one last glance at the crowd below, his gaze lingering on the lone figure of Jesus at the center. Even from a distance, he could feel the quiet power radiating from the man, a strength that appeared to come not from force or intimidation, but from something deeper—a calm resolve that defied all logic.

He felt a strange longing to stay, to move closer and hear Jesus’ words for himself. It was a dangerous impulse, one that he knew could make him a target of both Rome and Barabbas. Yet, something about this man, this so-called prophet, called to a part of him he’d thought long dead.

He imagined the world Jesus seemed to offer—a world free from bloodshed and vengeance, a world where strength didn’t mean violence. It was a vision that felt as foreign to him as it was appealing, a dream he’d once believed in but had buried beneath years of bitterness and survival.

But then Gestas’ mocking voice cut through his thoughts, a reminder of the path he had chosen. “Come on, Dismas. Leave the ‘Messiah’ to his followers. We’ve got real work to do.”

Dismas tightened his expression, forcing himself to turn away from the crowd. The reality of their mission loomed before him—a brutal ambush, a chance to strike back at Rome in the only way he knew. And yet, as he followed Barabbas and Gestas down the hill, he couldn’t shake the feeling that he was leaving something behind—a chance, perhaps, to be something more than a weapon in another man’s war.

With each step, the murmurs among the gathered populace faded, swallowed by the silence of the hills. But the memory of Jesus’ calm gaze lingered in his mind, a quiet reminder of a world he might never know.

By the time they reached the base of the hill, the atmosphere had shifted. Barabbas' expression was hard, his eyes filled with a renewed determination. The brief detour through the pack had only deepened his resolve, reinforcing his belief that strength was the only path to victory. He turned to Dismas and Gestas, his voice cold and steady.

"We strike as planned. We hit them hard and fast, and we don't stop until every last Roman soldier is lying in his own blood." His gaze swept over them, his eyes fierce and unyielding. "Rome will not fall to prophets or messiahs. It will fall to men like us, men who understand what it takes to win."

Gestas nodded eagerly, his face twisted in a grin of excitement. "Finally, something real. Let the dreamers have their miracles—we'll take the victory ourselves."

Dismas forced himself to nod, though his heart remained burdened. The faces amidst the multitude lingered in his mind, their expressions alight with hope, their faith a quiet force that had etched itself deeply into him.

Dismas tightened his grip, feeling the familiar surge of anger rise within him. The dream of a peaceful world was just that—a dream, a vision that held no place in the brutal reality of his life. And yet, even as he steeled himself for the violence to come, he couldn't help but feel a pang of regret, a lingering sense that he was turning his back on something precious.

But there was no room for doubt here. Not under Barabbas' unyielding gaze, not with the ambush looming ahead. He took a deep breath, forcing himself to focus on the task at hand, to set aside the strange, haunting memory of the prophet's face.

"Tomorrow, then," he murmured, his voice barely more than a whisper.

Barabbas nodded, a cold smile crossing his face. "Tomorrow, we show Rome what it means to fear."

And with that, they turned away, leaving the hillside behind as they descended into the shadowed valley below, their minds fixed on the bloodshed to come.

Act 1 - 07

Lucius

The barracks lay steeped in shadow, illuminated only by the dim, sputtering light of torches affixed to the stone walls. The torches cast an amber glow across the rough surfaces, casting long, undulating shadows that twisted over every crack and corner. Lucius stood just inside the doorway, back straight, hands clasped tightly behind him, every inch of him a soldier. Though he kept his gaze firmly forward, his sharp eyes caught every flicker, every breath of movement. A disciplined stillness held him, a composure he wore like armor, though his mind simmered with irritation. He waited, unwilling to break the silence that hung between him and his commander.

Outside, the city buzzed with a faint, muffled hum—Jerusalem, crowded beyond capacity as Passover approached. The faint clamor of the city filtered through the walls, the murmur of crowds, the distant clang of metal, and the occasional bleating of livestock blending together like a single, droning heartbeat. Lucius felt that Jerusalem was practically pulsing, teetering on an invisible edge as its narrow streets filled with pilgrims and outsiders. The tension was tangible, the kind that seeped into every breath and held itself just beneath the surface of every casual glance and murmured prayer. Lucius had seen it before, this restlessness, in other occupied lands and other times, when hope and defiance swirled too close together.

Yet here, within the barracks, silence held dominion, commanded by Marius the Centurion's presence at the center of the room. Marius sat at a rough-hewn table strewn with

curled parchments and maps. His face was composed, though lined with years of hard-won authority. His gaze was fixed on a point beyond the cluttered table, seeing beyond it, his focus and stillness demanding attention. Marius' gaze, sharp as a whetted blade, had seen men break under far less than the silence he now held over Lucius, and Lucius felt both respect and frustration simmering beneath his still exterior.

As Lucius waited, watching the older man's stillness, he could not help but notice something unusual in Marius' expression. There was a certain tension there, a weight of consideration that seemed to reach beyond any strategy or tactic. It wasn't fear, nor even the alertness of a soldier on edge, but rather a quiet intensity, as though Marius were piecing together something that defied his usual logic. Lucius felt a flash of impatience in the face of his commander's calm, yet he held his composure, schooling his face into the same impassive mask that he wore on the battlefield. He had never doubted Marius, never questioned the judgment that had seen them both through battles few men survived, and he wasn't about to start now.

"Enter," Marius' voice broke the heavy quiet, low and even, yet imbued with the iron authority that Lucius had always respected. Stepping forward, Lucius moved with deliberate silence, the soft scrape of his sandals against the stone floor punctuating the stillness. He halted just a pace from the table, his posture rigid, every line of his bearing a testament to the discipline forged through years of loyalty and service.

Lucius inclined his head slightly, offering the respectful nod of a soldier before he began his report. "The punishment was carried out without incident, sir," his voice controlled and precise. "The dissident provided the example we intended. The assembly of individuals dispersed no one dared to linger." Beneath his formal tone, a trace of satisfaction lingered, though he kept it well-hidden. Rome's justice, swift and uncompromising, was the only kind of order Lucius respected. In the presence of such power, the people had learned well enough to bow or break.

"Rome's reach is well understood by them now," he added, allowing the faintest edge of pride to enter his words. The sight

of the dissident collapsing under the lash, the terrified faces of those in the crowd—these were the moments Lucius believed mattered. Order had a way of growing from such moments, from the realization that defiance brought only pain.

Marius nodded slowly, his gaze still distant. His fingers tapped the surface, drumming a slow, rhythmic beat as though measuring something in his mind. Lucius watched, sensing that Marius' mind was elsewhere, turning over some unspoken thought. Lucius felt his patience prickly, but he held his silence. He knew better than to interrupt Marius' deliberations, even if they seemed out of place.

Finally, Marius looked up, his gaze sharper, fixing on Lucius with that unerring focus that had commanded armies and quelled men with a glance. "And the crowd?" Marius asked, his voice thoughtful, his tone suggesting that he was after more than a simple report. "Anything unusual?"

Lucius hesitated briefly, caught off guard by the question's unexpected turn. He'd expected Marius to approve the mission's success and move on to the next order, not to linger on the crowd's reaction. Collecting himself, Lucius answered carefully, his words measured. "They were tense, mostly afraid," he replied, his tone level. "But there was a... a sort of tension, something more than just fear." The words hung in the currents, as Lucius held Marius' gaze, trying to assess if he was striking the right tone. "Passover always brings crowds. With it, sir, comes a dangerous restlessness."

Marius leaned back, his face taking on an almost meditative look as he considered Lucius' words. Lucius wondered what it was that drew Marius to focus on the crowd. He had always trusted his commander's instincts, respected the insight that had carried them through even the direst conflicts, but tonight, there was something more, a depth of thought that felt foreign. Lucius waited, feeling a brief flicker of impatience rise within him, though he suppressed it with practiced ease.

"A city full of rebels simmering beneath the surface," Marius murmured, his voice barely more than a whisper, as if speaking more to himself than to Lucius. "Even the meek find courage in numbers." There was a weight in his tone,

something contemplative, yet edged with an unease that Lucius wasn't used to hearing from him.

Straightening, Lucius' expression darkened. "If there's a spark, we'll snuff it out before it catches flame," he said firmly, his tone laced with the cold certainty of a man accustomed to enforcing Rome's will. For him, there was no need to dwell on the mood of the crowd or the ebb and flow of beliefs—Rome's power was absolute, and any threat could be crushed with swift, unyielding force.

But Marius kept his gaze fixed on Lucius, thoughtful and quiet, as if weighing the conviction behind his words. It was a look that lingered, and for a fleeting moment, Lucius felt a flicker of uncertainty, as though his commander saw something more—something just beyond his grasp. The feeling stirred a faint frustration within him. To Lucius, the answer was clear: Rome's strength met defiance with cold, decisive action. Yet tonight, Marius seemed preoccupied with a path more circuitous and nuanced than Lucius deemed necessary.

Leaning forward slightly, Marius stilled the rhythmic drumming of his fingers against the worn tabletop. His gaze sharpened as he broke the silence hanging between them. "There's more at work in this city than the usual unrest, Lucius. Something deeper flows beneath the surface—a belief, not in rebellion or vengeance, but in something..." He paused, as though searching for the right word. "Something different."

Lucius stiffened, unable to mask his irritation entirely. Marius' insight, his attention to the subtleties of crowds and emotions, was something Lucius respected deeply. But to him, this felt different—a distraction from Rome's strength, a dalliance in murky philosophies. "With all respect, sir, unrest always grows thick as Passover approaches," he replied, his tone neutral but edged with a restrained impatience. "Jerusalem is full of strangers, each bringing their own beliefs and superstitions. A dangerous mix, but one we know well enough to contain."

Marius' gaze remained steady as he studied Lucius, his mouth pressed into a contemplative line. "I am not concerned with the usual mix of hopeful souls and hardened rebels. Tell me, Lucius," Marius began, his voice deliberate, as though

carefully gauging the significance of his next words, “have you heard of this... Jesus of Nazareth?”

Lucius felt tension ripple through his features, surprised to hear the name spoken here, in the barracks, by his commander. He had heard the rumors circulating among soldiers, servants, and even merchants in the streets—a prophet from Nazareth who spoke of strange things, of a kingdom beyond Rome’s reach. Lucius had dismissed it all as the idle fancies of desperate men seeking comfort in fanciful ideas. Yet, to hear Marius speak this name, to hear it given weight in this place, stirred a mixture of irritation and unease in him.

“Yes, sir,” Lucius replied, keeping his tone as even as possible. “A man from Nazareth who draws the poor and desperate, filling their minds with promises of peace as though words could shield them from Roman spears.” He allowed himself a faint smirk, a hint of his disdain seeping through. “They speak of him as if he were something more than flesh.”

Marius’ mouth quirked in a barely perceptible smile, though his gaze remained serious, contemplative. “Indeed. They say he speaks of a kingdom beyond this world, a kingdom without walls, without swords... And yet, his followers gather, not just by tens, but by hundreds. Perhaps thousands.” His eyes flicked back to Lucius. “And they whisper of miracles.”

Lucius felt a familiar bitterness coil within him at the mention of miracles, his smirk fading into a hard line. “Miracles are the indulgences of the weak,” he replied, his voice taking on a steely edge. “Rome’s strength does not waver at the mention of miracles, sir.”

Marius’ gaze sharpened, and Lucius noticed a faint glint of reproach in his eyes, as though his commander found his skepticism... lacking. Marius leaned back in his chair, folding his arms across his chest as he continued to study Lucius. “And yet, it is often those very ‘indulgences’ that ignite the fiercest conviction in men’s hearts, Lucius. Conviction that builds empires—or destroys them. It’s conviction, not iron, that gives men courage to act beyond reason, to stand when others would bow.”

Lucius resisted the urge to roll his eyes, forcing himself to hold his commander's gaze with disciplined stillness. He respected Marius, deeply so, but this talk of prophets and the power of faith felt like an unwelcome distraction from the real threats they faced daily. "With all respect, sir, the people will tire of him soon enough," Lucius replied, his tone tightly controlled. "A prophet's words fade quickly when they come up against the might of Rome."

Marius' fingers resumed their tapping, a slow, deliberate rhythm that struck, echoing through the room. "It is often those who dismiss a threat, Lucius, that find themselves caught unawares," Marius replied quietly, his words carrying a weight that Lucius found hard to ignore. "Faith, especially when it comes without fear, can be more powerful than any legion."

Lucius' mouth tightened, a barely contained frustration simmering beneath his composed exterior. He felt his irritation flare at the thought that his commander—a man of unyielding authority, a man he had looked up to for years—could give such weight to a prophet's empty words. "Words are hollow without strength to back them, sir," he replied, his tone sharpening. "Whatever 'kingdom' this man imagines will crumble as soon as it meets Rome's power. We've seen the courage of zealots falter before."

Marius held his gaze steadily, his face unreadable, though his voice softened to a near murmur. "Perhaps. But it is not the zealots who concern me, Lucius." He leaned forward slightly, his eyes taking on a contemplative gleam. "It is those who follow not out of fear, nor even out of hatred, but out of belief—belief in something greater than themselves."

Lucius felt his frustration rise, pressing against his discipline, but he kept his composure intact. Marius' words rang with an unfamiliar caution, almost a reverence he could not name. Yet, despite his irritation, he sensed that Marius spoke from a place of knowledge that went beyond his own, a conviction that was as unsettling as it was firm.

Lucius took a steadying breath, his gaze drifting momentarily to the torches on the walls as he absorbed his commander's words. This—this discussion of prophets and miracles—felt

almost... misplaced. It stirred in him a memory he would rather have left buried, a bitter reminder of what he had learned about faith in his darkest hour.

In that instant, he remembered his pregnant wife, the way she had grown weaker with each passing day. He had paid a fortune in silver to priests and healers, traveled to temples on the advice of strangers, grasping at any promise of hope for her recovery. Each healer had sworn to summon the gods, had promised miracles. But the days grew longer, and her breathing grew weaker, until she and his unborn baby slipped from his grasp entirely. The gods had remained silent. All their promises, all their rites—they had meant nothing.

The gods had taken everything from him, left him hollow and raw, with nothing but memories and the emptiness their so-called “miracles” had failed to fill. In the years that followed, he had closed himself to faith, rejecting the gods as illusions meant to pacify weak minds. Rome was all that remained real to him, Rome and the iron strength that could impose order in a world of disorder and meaningless dreams.

And now, Marius spoke of this Jesus as if he were something worth examining, something that demanded consideration beyond the realm of faith and fantasy. The thought stung Lucius, gnawed at him as he forced himself to focus, suppressing the bitterness that the memory stirred. He knew better than to let such thoughts rise to the surface. But in this moment, his resolve felt strained, stretched thin by the force of Marius’ words.

“Sir, faith alone doesn’t make a man strong,” he said finally, his voice barely more than a murmur, tinged with bitterness he could not quite mask. “I’ve seen what faith does to men who seek miracles. It makes them desperate, empty... even weaker than they were before.”

Marius tilted his head slightly, his gaze unreadable, as if he sensed more than Lucius would ever say. “Sometimes, Lucius, it is desperation that lights the fiercest fires.”

Lucius set his jaw, swallowing the response that rose in him. To him, the strength of Rome, the discipline and order it

imposed, was all that remained reliable. And he would not entertain fantasies about prophets or faith. Marius continued to hold Lucius' gaze, as if weighing his next words carefully.

After a long silence, he leaned forward, his tone calm yet deliberate. "We will observe this Jesus tomorrow, Lucius. At dawn." His voice was steady, carrying an unspoken command Lucius recognized well. "I want to see him with my own eyes. I want to understand what power, if any, he holds over these people."

Lucius fought back the irritation that flared within him. The thought of standing in the presence of some wandering prophet who spoke of peace felt absurd, almost insulting. His place was among soldiers, dealing with real matters—threats that demanded vigilance and strength—not indulging in the illusions of a man spinning tales for the desperate.

Yet he nodded, his arms tight at his sides. "As you command, sir," he replied, his tone respectful, masking the resentment simmering beneath his surface. "We'll observe, assess his following, and determine the risk."

Marius watched him closely, as though sensing the battle Lucius fought to keep his thoughts contained. "Good," Marius said, a faint glint of approval in his eyes. "But remember, Lucius, this is not about mere words. Sometimes, those who follow a cause beyond reason are more dangerous than those who take up arms."

Lucius bit back a retort, forcing himself to remain silent. He would do as commanded—observe this Jesus, measure his influence. But he would do it with the detached focus he brought to every mission, reminding himself that Rome's might could not be shaken by a man who spoke only in words.

Marius paused, letting the gravity of his command sink in before continuing. "There's one more matter, Commander," he added, almost as if it were an afterthought. "After our morning observation, you'll take a squad and secure the convoy arriving at midday. It's critical, and we cannot risk any disruptions." His voice sharpened, his tone brooking no

argument. “Meet them a mile outside the city and ensure their safe passage.”

Lucius felt a surge of relief at the familiar assignment. Here was something concrete, a duty rooted in purpose that required no ambiguity, no distractions of faith or fancy. “Understood, sir,” he replied, inclining his head. “I’ll see to it that our men are ready.”

A small, satisfied smile tugged at Marius’ lips, though his gaze held its contemplative edge. “Good. I want every detail in place. And Lucius—” He leaned forward slightly, his voice softening but carrying an unspoken authority. “Approach this observation with a sharp eye. Underestimating what we don’t understand has led to the fall of greater men than us.”

Lucius nodded, though his mind was already turning to the convoy, sorting through the logistics and details that would demand his full attention. He could still sense the intensity of Marius’ gaze, an unspoken command to stay vigilant. Yet in his heart, Lucius knew his duty to Rome was as steadfast as the iron sword at his side.

“Very well, sir,” he replied, his voice calm, his gaze steady. “We’ll make the observation at dawn and be ready to meet the convoy by midday.”

Satisfied with his resolve, Lucius allowed himself a fleeting moment of pride in the clarity of his task, letting it overshadow the distraction he felt regarding Jesus. For now, his loyalty and duty to Rome’s authority were the only things that mattered.

Lucius turned to leave, his composure held firm, though a quiet frustration simmered beneath his disciplined mask. The thought of spending his morning in the presence of a prophet, a man whose followers spoke of miracles, grated against everything he valued as a soldier of Rome. He forced himself to push aside the memory of his wife, of the priests and so-called healers who had taken his silver and delivered only false hope. But tonight, that old bitterness was hard to ignore.

As he reached the doorway, Lucius paused, glancing back over his shoulder. Marius had already turned to his work, his

attention fixed on the scattered parchments spread across the table. The lines etched deep into his commander's face told the story of years spent imposing Rome's will across distant lands. Seeing a man like Marius—hardened by war and shaped by unyielding discipline—giving thought to the power of a prophet unsettled Lucius in ways he could not fully articulate.

But he reminded himself that this was simply another assignment, a task like any other, requiring his attention and his discipline. Whatever his doubts, he would approach the morning's assignment with the same resolve that had carried him through battlefields and sieges. He would watch, measure, and, if necessary, report anything of concern. But he would not be swayed by talk of kingdoms without walls, nor by the illusions of desperate men.

As Lucius stepped outside, the cool night air brushed against his face, a stark contrast to the dim, torch-lit confines of the barracks. He paused, drawing in a steadying breath as the weight of the coming day pressed upon him. Tomorrow, he would confront this Jesus—the man rumored to wield a power beyond Rome's grasp. Afterward, his duty would demand his unwavering focus on securing the convoy.

Yet within him, a quiet and unshakable resolve remained. Whatever visions Marius harbored of prophets and their kingdoms, Lucius would not be swayed by faith or miracles. Rome was his foundation, and he would uphold its order with steadfast loyalty.

Standing just beyond the barracks steps, Lucius gazed out over Jerusalem, his eyes tracing the darkened landscape that stretched toward the city's ancient walls. Even at this hour, life stirred in the streets, faint lights flickering in the distance, voices carrying on the night wind. Jerusalem, a city unlike any he'd known, a place filled with faith as fervent as it was volatile. He took in the sprawling view, feeling the tension of its thousands of inhabitants even from this distance.

In the dark sky above, stars glittered in cold indifference, silent witnesses to a city teetering on something vast, something that pulsed just beyond his understanding. Lucius allowed himself

a final, deep breath, letting the night air fill his lungs, calming the unease that lingered from his conversation with Marius. Rome's rule was unbreakable, and in his heart, he knew that tomorrow would be no more than an inconvenience.

He steeled himself, silently renewing his commitment to Rome, to the order it brought to lands of chaos. Tightening his resolve, his thoughts shifted once more to the convoy, the task that felt like solid ground beneath him. At dawn, he would stand by Marius' side, observe Jesus' followers, and then carry out his real duty—to ensure the safe arrival of Rome's supplies.

And if this Jesus dared pose even the slightest threat, if his words truly held the power to sway hearts against Rome, Lucius knew what would be required. He would act without hesitation, without mercy, as Rome demanded. But for now, he would simply watch, measure, and prepare.

A grim satisfaction settled over him as he turned back toward the barracks, ready to prepare his men. In the morning, he would face the prophet, and he would see for himself whether this man's power was real—or merely a flicker of false hope in a city teeming with the dreams of desperate men.

Act 1 - 08

Simon

As the evening began to lengthen its shadows, Simon set his focus, his purpose as straightforward as the leather coin pouch strapped tightly to his belt. He was here not only to complete his sacred pilgrimage, but also to procure gifts for his family—a task he knew would ease the anxious worry his wife likely felt in his absence. He thought of her now, of her words as he'd left: "Go with God, Simon, but don't linger where there's talk of trouble. Jerusalem can hold its secrets but keep your distance from them." Her gaze had been heavy, her voice cautious, a sentiment he'd carried with him into the city.

With each step he took deeper into the marketplace, Simon felt the calm of the Temple giving way to the marketplace's restless energy. The sheer variety of goods on display dazzled him—textiles in every shade imaginable, fresh fruits piled high, and the glint of hammered metal glistening from one vendor's table. A part of him wanted to pause and absorb the scene, to appreciate how everything hummed in perfect chaos, but he knew he had a purpose.

The voices of vendors pulled him from his thoughts. "Silks from Damascus! Perfect for a royal garment or a feast-day robe!" one vendor bellowed, his voice loud enough to command the attention of passersby. A few steps away, another called, "Wool from the hills, soft as lamb's breath and strong enough to last a lifetime!" Simon allowed himself a small smile, charmed by the vendors' enthusiasm, the way they seemed to treat each passerby as a long-lost friend. It was a ritual, this

calling out, a sacred dance between buyer and seller that had gone on since the city's stones were first laid.

He approached a stall overflowing with bolts of fabric. The colors were as vibrant as a painter's palette—deep indigo, fiery reds, and soft earthen tones that reminded him of his home. Simon ran his fingers over a length of blue wool, admiring the way it caught the light. Practicality guided his hand as he inspected the weave, and his merchant's eye saw both its beauty and its value. Yes, this fabric would suit his family, would bring home a piece of Jerusalem's heart.

"Good eye, my friend," the merchant greeted him warmly, a stout man with a neatly combed beard and a smile as wide as the Nile. He leaned forward over the table, folding his hands together with an air of expectancy. "That blue is one of my best pieces, woven from the finest wool and dyed with indigo from the coast. A worthy addition to any household."

Simon nodded, his hand still resting on the fabric. He could feel the pull of his family, his sons and newborn daughter awaiting him, and his heart swelled with the thought of sharing this moment with them. The merchant's cheerful voice broke through his reverie. "Shall we say three denarii for it? A fair price, given the quality. You won't find anything finer this side of the Jordan."

Simon gave a short laugh, raising his eyebrows in mock surprise. "Three denarii? I could buy half a flock of sheep for that price!" he replied, his voice light but carrying the seasoned edge of a trader's instincts. "Surely you could part with it for two. Jerusalem may be a holy city, but my coin isn't blessed to multiply."

The merchant chuckled, rubbing his hands together with a grin that said he enjoyed the game of bargaining as much as Simon did. "Ah, two denarii, is it? You wound me, my friend. I have mouths to feed and a stall to maintain! But for a pilgrim of such discerning taste... two and a half denarii. And that's only because I like you." He winked, his tone conspiratorial.

The back-and-forth haggling felt like slipping into an old, well-worn cloak. For a moment, Simon could almost forget the

tensions simmering in the city, the murmurs of prophets and the shadow of Rome. Here, beneath the sun and amidst the shouts of the marketplace, he felt the simple joy of connection, of trading with another man's goodwill.

As he considered his response, a surge of voices rose nearby, pulling Simon's attention away. His hand stilled on the fabric as he turned, catching sight of an assemblage gathering, faces turned toward a lone figure at the center. A palpable shift in the atmosphere accompanied the sight, as if the very air had drawn in a breath. Simon felt his heart quicken, his curiosity stirring as he heard the name murmured among the gathering: Jesus.

Simon shifted his attention to the merchant, who still had that spark of expectation in his eye, a gleam that told Simon he wouldn't easily let the sale slip away. In the few short minutes of their bargaining, they had entered the ancient dance of seller and buyer, one that called for a balance of pride and compromise.

He gestured toward the fabric, a practiced, skeptical look crossing his face. "Two denarii and not a coin more," he declared, his tone firm yet amiable. "A pilgrim's purse is not meant to line a merchant's pockets. Or are you trying to send me home to my family empty-handed?"

The merchant clapped his hands in mock despair, throwing a glance heavenward as if asking for divine intervention. "The things I do for the faithful!" he exclaimed, smiling broadly. "But fine—two denarii. And may it bless you and your family."

Simon handed over the coins, feeling a small triumph in his heart, though he knew the merchant had likely gained his profit in other ways. With the purchase secured, Simon tucked the fabric carefully into his satchel, feeling a surge of satisfaction as he envisioned his family's joy at this gift from the holy city.

The marketplace seemed to swell with life around him, every stall bursting with its own story, each vendor's call blending into a chaotic but mesmerizing melody. Jerusalem felt alive in a way that resonated with his soul, each passerby a reminder of the resilience of his people. The sun now cast a warm glow

over the crowd, illuminating faces weathered and youthful alike, each one drawn by purpose, devotion, or need. In the middle of this vibrant sea of humanity, Simon felt grounded, connected to a tradition that stretched back to his ancestors.

Just then, the commotion near another stall drew his attention once more. Murmurs grew louder, blending into exclamations that rose and fell like the waves of the nearby sea. “Jesus of Nazareth!” he heard someone say, their voice thick with awe. “He is here!”

Simon felt an inexplicable pull, an urge that went beyond curiosity. This was the man whose name had spread through the city like wildfire, whispered on the lips of pilgrims and citizens alike. The stories of healings, parables, and miracles had woven through the streets of Jerusalem, stirring hearts and sparking conversations in homes and markets alike. Could it be true? Could a simple teacher from Nazareth carry such power?

Without a second thought, he turned toward the gathering, leaving the marketplace’s calls and haggling behind him. In that moment, the purchase of cloth seemed a trivial thing compared to the mystery unfolding nearby.

Simon threaded his way through the crowd, stepping carefully around baskets of goods and sidestepping a pair of children chasing each other through the stalls. His heart pounded as he approached the gathering, close enough now to see the figure at the center—a man, standing simply among the people, with no banner, no symbols of status or authority. And yet, his presence alone commanded the crowd.

It was Jesus.

The teacher stood quietly, his gaze calm yet penetrating, as though he saw each person in that crowd individually, as though he could sense their burdens, their longings, and even their hidden fears. Simon found himself standing in silent awe, his earlier sense of purpose momentarily forgotten. There was something different about this man, something that went beyond the stories he’d heard.

A voice rose from the people congregated, breaking the stillness. “Rabbi, tell us—how do we find hope? The Romans press down on us like a storm cloud, leaving no path to freedom.”

Simon’s breath caught as Jesus stepped closer to the edge of the crowd, his eyes alight with conviction. “I am the good shepherd,” Jesus declared, his voice carrying effortlessly over the restless murmurs. “The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.”

The crowd stilled; their attention riveted. Simon felt his heart race as Jesus continued. “The hired hand runs when the wolf comes because he does not care for the sheep. But I, I know my sheep, and my sheep know me—just as the Father knows me, and I know the Father.”

For a moment, their eyes met. Simon froze, caught by a sense of being fully known yet wholly accepted. The tension of the crowd dissipated, the words hanging heavy yet hopeful in the air.

The people murmured softly, as if absorbing a truth too deep for words. Simon felt a stirring within him, a small, fragile flicker of hope he had not felt since he was young. Jesus’ words cut through the anxieties of the marketplace, the burdens he carried for his family, and the oppressive shadow of Roman rule. For the first time, he saw a vision of strength rooted not in power but in something quieter, something unbreakable.

As he listened, Simon found himself drawn in, his skepticism yielding to an emotion he could scarcely name. He had come to Jerusalem for renewal, and here, unexpectedly, he felt a new beginning taking root in his heart. The message was simple, but it carried a resonance that went beyond mere words.

And in that moment, he understood why so many had been drawn to this teacher. Jesus’ presence felt like a soothing touch to a wound Simon hadn’t realized he carried, a reminder that faith was more than ritual or custom. It was a force that could kindle courage, even in the face of insurmountable odds.

As Simon lingered near the crowd, captivated by Jesus' words, he felt a nudge at his shoulder. It was the merchant, who had noticed Simon's distraction and followed him to the gathering. "It seems you've already forgotten about my fine fabrics!" the merchant teased lightly, though his eyes glinted with curiosity as they settled on Jesus. "Are you here to buy faith now too?"

Simon chuckled softly, breaking from his reverie. "Perhaps I am," he replied, his tone half-jesting. But there was a seriousness beneath his words that the merchant seemed to sense.

The merchant shook his head, his voice dropping to a quieter tone. "People flock to him like birds to seed. They say he speaks of a new kingdom, a world where Rome's shadow does not reach. But we've heard such promises before, haven't we?"

Simon glanced at the man, torn between the hope he'd felt moments before and the merchant's sober warning. "I don't know," he admitted. "But there is something different about him. I can feel it, can't you? His words... they're not like the others. They carry a weight." He paused, looking back at Jesus as he spoke to the crowd. "Perhaps he truly is the one who can lead us out from under the yoke of oppression."

The merchant's face softened, a faint trace of empathy flickering in his expression. "Hope is a powerful thing," he murmured. "But be careful with it. Hope can carry you to safety—or it can lead you straight into ruin." He nodded toward the Roman guards stationed around the marketplace, their presence an unspoken reminder of the dangers of believing too boldly. "Rome does not forgive those who try to light a new fire."

Simon felt the impact of the merchant's words sink deep within him, and his gaze shifted to the guards, their stern faces sweeping the assembled with practiced vigilance. A part of him understood the risk, the precarious balance they all maintained between faith and survival. Yet, the hope kindled by Jesus' words persisted, unwavering, refusing to be extinguished.

He looked back at the merchant, offering a small, resolute smile. “Hope may be dangerous, but so is despair. Perhaps it’s worth the risk.”

The merchant nodded, a quiet respect in his eyes. “Well said. But remember, Jerusalem has swallowed many hopes before.” With a final nod, the merchant turned back toward his stall, leaving Simon alone among the gathering once more.

Returning to his task, Simon moved on from the fabric stall, weaving through the maze of market stalls as he gathered provisions for the Passover Seder. His mind was still filled with the echoes of Jesus’ words, but he focused on the familiar routine of trading, haggling over prices for food that would sustain his family and friends.

At a stall laden with dried fruits and nuts, he carefully selected a small pouch of dates, the merchant’s quick fingers deftly counting them out. Further down the way, he purchased lentils, envisioning the comforting meal they would make that evening, shared with those closest to him. Each item felt like a piece of home, a link to the life he had left behind for this trip, a reminder of his family’s simple joys and the bonds that held them together.

As he completed each purchase, he couldn’t help but overhear fragments of conversation from those around him, snippets of thoughts that mirrored his own questions and doubts. A vendor nearby, a weathered man with lines of wisdom and worry etched into his face, was speaking to a fellow trader about Jesus. “They say he healed a child, brought her from the brink of death,” the vendor whispered, his voice thick with awe. “And just this morning, a blind beggar—he touched his eyes, and the man saw the sun for the first time in his life.”

Simon felt a shiver run through him. Miracles were spoken of with wonder, but also with a touch of fear, as though the words themselves might call forth something beyond their understanding. Could such acts truly be the work of God, as Jesus’ followers claimed? Or were these just stories, mere wisps of hope conjured by the weary and desperate?

A woman's voice pierced his thoughts, laced with skepticism. "Healing, perhaps," she said, her words sharp and measured, "but what use is healing when Rome presses harder with each day? Miracles won't save us from their cruelty. Rome's wrath is a fire that consumes even the righteous, leaving ash in its wake."

Simon understood her words, felt their sting as they took root in his mind. Yet, something within him resisted—an instinct, a quiet voice suggesting that perhaps this time, things could be different. Hope was dangerous, yes, but without it, what else was there? He thought of his family, of his two sons and newborn daughter, and felt the pull of his own longing for a world where they could grow up unshackled by fear.

With a small sigh, he pocketed his purchases, his steps heavy but purposeful as he continued through the marketplace. The stories he'd heard today, the voices of those who had seen Jesus or heard him speak, lingered like an echo. They were fragments, pieces of a puzzle he was not yet able to assemble, but they filled him with a yearning he couldn't dismiss.

Just as Simon was about to leave the marketplace, arms heavy with his day's purchases, he caught sight of Jesus again, the cluster around him having shifted to allow a clearer view. The teacher stood quietly, as if in deep thought, while people pressed close, their faces eager, desperate, hopeful. From this distance, Simon could see the gentleness in Jesus' face, an expression that was calm yet full of strength, a look that held both conviction and compassion.

Simon felt the inexplicable pull to approach him, to draw nearer to this man who had stirred something deep within him. A part of him longed to speak to Jesus, to ask him questions he barely knew how to articulate. Could he, a simple man from Cyrene, find guidance in the words of this prophet? Or was he merely indulging in a fantasy, caught up in the fervor among the masses?

But even as he felt himself drawn closer, he could feel his caution holding him back. The reality of his responsibilities, his family waiting at home, the warnings in the merchant's voice—all of it pressed against him, reminding him that he could not

afford to risk everything for a fleeting encounter. There was too much at stake.

With a sigh, he turned away, his heart heavy. But he could not deny that something had changed within him, a small shift he did not yet understand. It was as though Jesus' words had planted a seed, fragile yet resilient, that might one day bloom if he allowed it.

As he walked away, the voices surrounded by the onlookers faded behind him, replaced once more by the familiar cacophony of the market. Yet in his heart, Jesus' words lingered, a quiet reminder of hope in a world that seemed increasingly devoid of it. And though he tried to push the thoughts aside, he knew they would return to him, would haunt him, until he understood what they truly meant.

As he made his way through the dwindling marketplace, Simon felt a profound stillness settle over him, a quiet sense of wonder intertwined with a lingering uncertainty. The sun had begun its slow descent, casting a warm, golden light over the stalls, softening the edges of the bustling scene and lending a sense of calm to the chaos. Each step he took seemed to draw him further from the company that surrounded Jesus, yet he felt as if a part of him had remained there, caught up in that strange, magnetic presence.

Simon had left home filled with a sense of duty, a simple desire to fulfill his pilgrimage and to return with provisions for his family. But now, he realized, he carried something more—a new burden of questions, of hopes both fragile and dangerous.

Would they understand? Could he explain it to them, this sensation of hope that had filled him despite the darkness that loomed over their lives? He imagined Alexander, his eldest, with his endless questions, his curiosity matched only by his impatience. And Rufus, the quieter one, whose thoughtful gaze could often see into the heart of things with wisdom beyond his years. Perhaps, he mused, they would understand better than he did.

Simon smiled faintly as he pictured their eager faces, the way they would lean in close, waiting for every detail. It was for

them, and for the life he hoped they might one day lead, that he clung to the hope stirred by Jesus' words. Perhaps, in a world so often ruled by fear, a spark of faith could be the shield they needed.

Simon stopped at the marketplace, letting his gaze drift back toward the multitude that still gathered around Jesus, their voices fading softly into the distance.

Was he a fool, he wondered, for entertaining the hope that one man's words could change the course of his people's future? The merchant's words echoed in his mind, cautioning him to remember the wrath of Rome, the price that hope could exact from those who dared to believe in something greater. Yet, in the face of Jesus' message, that caution felt like a whisper compared to the roar of possibility that had stirred within him.

The road back to Cyrene would be long, filled with the familiar tasks of trade and travel, but it would also be marked now by something new—a journey not just of distance, but of faith. He knew that the man he had been when he arrived in Jerusalem was not the same man who would return. Somewhere in the echoes of Jesus' words, he felt his faith take root, small and vulnerable, yet resilient in a way he could not deny.

As he lingered, torn between leaving and turning back to Jesus, a young woman passed by, her face alight with a fervor that mirrored his own. "He is the one," she murmured to those around her, her voice filled with quiet conviction. "I know it in my soul. He is the one we have waited for."

Simon watched her disappear into the crowd, her words lingering like a whisper of fate. He wondered if, someday, he too might find that same certainty.

Act 1 - 09

Dismas

As the others busied themselves, Dismas found himself drifting to the edges of the cave, seeking a quiet corner where he could escape the charged atmosphere. The air was thick with the eager chatter of men sharpening their blades, discussing their roles, and trading words of bravado meant to hide the flicker of fear in their eyes. But for Dismas, there was no solace in their excitement. Instead, he felt an unease gnawing at him, an emptiness that all their fervor couldn't fill.

He closed his eyes, letting the muted sounds wash over him, trying to drown out the sense of dread that had taken root in his mind. It wasn't fear of the battle—he had known that fear long ago and learned to bury it deep. It was something else, something that felt like betrayal, though he couldn't say who he felt betrayed by: Rome, Barabbas, or perhaps even himself.

The memory of the prophet's calm face surfaced unbidden, the man's words still resonating within him, though he wished they didn't. Dismas tried to shake it off, to push away the voice that whispered of another path, one that didn't lead to bloodshed and the cold grip of steel. But the whisper wouldn't be silenced, as persistent as the beat of his own heart.

He glanced around, watching his fellow men as they laughed and shared tales of past raids, their voices filled with the thrill of tomorrow's battle. Yosef caught his eye, a question in the young man's gaze. Dismas wanted to speak, to voice the doubt that weighed on him like a stone. But he held his tongue,

knowing that no one here would understand—perhaps not even himself.

Barabbas strode to the center of the cavern, his sharp eyes scanning the group. He waited, letting the silence deepen, his mere presence commanding attention until every murmur and rustle faded into stillness. His gaze burned with intensity, and his tone was resolute as he began to speak.

“Remember, we strike not just for ourselves but for all who have suffered beneath Rome’s crushing grip,” he declared, his voice carrying both conviction and defiance. “We fight for our families, for our land, for every man, woman, and child whose lives have been trampled by an empire that sees us as nothing more than tools for its ambition.”

A murmur of agreement rippled through the group, and the firelight cast Barabbas’ face in stark relief, his features hard, almost unforgiving. “Rome believes itself invincible,” he continued, his voice rising. “But tomorrow, we show them that we are not broken, that we are not afraid. We are the thorn in their side, the fire they cannot extinguish.”

He paused, letting his words sink in, watching as the faces around him hardened with determination. Yosef’s eyes gleamed with something close to reverence, his face a blend of awe and trepidation as he hung on every word.

“They will remember us,” Barabbas said, his tone almost reverent. “We will make them see that they cannot break our spirit. Let them know that we are here, and we will not fade away like dust.” He looked around, meeting each man’s gaze, his own eyes fierce with conviction. “Rest tonight, my brothers. For tomorrow, we make them pay.”

A roar of approval echoed through the cave; the sound filled with the raw intensity of men who had nothing left to lose. Dismas forced himself to join in, though the shout tasted bitter in his mouth, a hollow echo of the fervor he’d once felt.

As the cave began to settle, men drifting to find places to rest, Dismas felt a tug at his sleeve. He turned to find Yosef beside him, the young man’s face a mix of excitement and

uncertainty. His eyes held a question, one he seemed hesitant to voice.

“Dismas,” Yosef began, his voice barely above a whisper, “do you really think... do you really think this raid will change anything? That Rome will notice us?”

Dismas looked at him, studying the boy’s face—the fierce determination mixed with a flicker of fear. He could see himself in Yosef, a younger version of the man he’d once been, filled with dreams of rebellion, of a life where freedom wasn’t just a distant hope but a reality. He felt a pang of regret, though he couldn’t name its source.

“Rome will notice, Yosef,” he spoke, his tone steady, though a trace of doubt edged his words. “Maybe not in the way we hope, but they’ll know we were here. Sometimes... sometimes that has to be enough.”

Yosef’s gaze dropped; his face clouded with doubt. “But Barabbas... he says we can win. That we can make them fear us.”

Dismas placed a hand on Yosef’s shoulder, his grip firm but gentle. “Barabbas is strong, and he believes in what he’s saying. And that’s good—it’s what we need. But sometimes... victory isn’t what we think it is. Sometimes it’s just about surviving another day.”

The young man’s face tightened, his expression one of reluctant understanding. “So, we’re fighting just to keep fighting?”

Dismas nodded slowly, his voice barely more than a murmur. “Sometimes, yes. Sometimes, that’s all there is. But don’t let it harden you, Yosef. There’s a difference between fighting for freedom and being consumed by it.”

Yosef looked away, his jaw set, a mixture of anger and sadness flickering in his gaze. He didn’t respond, but Dismas could see the conflict brewing within him, the battle between hope and disillusionment, a battle he himself knew all too well.

As Yosef moved to join the others, Dismas felt a pang of sorrow, a strange feeling of loss, as though he were watching a flame flicker and fade. He knew that tomorrow would test them all, and he feared what would be left in the wake of the fight.

As the men settled in, some resting their heads against their packs, others speaking in hushed tones of quiet prayers, Dismas found he couldn't join them in sleep. The tension that had been building within him all day seemed to press harder now, weighing on his chest like the stone walls of the cave itself. He slipped out toward the entrance, needing air, needing space. The night air was cool and clear, with only the faint sounds of distant animals breaking the silence. Leaning against the rough stone of the cave, Dismas let his thoughts drift. The face of Jesus came unbidden, a steady, quiet presence that unsettled him. He hadn't expected a man like that to meet their gaze without fear or anger, without the hardened resolve of a soldier. No, the prophet's eyes had been calm, piercing through the bitterness Dismas had worn like armor for years.

The words of Jesus surfaced in his mind, gentle yet unshakable: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest". He hadn't grasped their meaning then, but now they gnawed at him. Was there truly rest to be found? Dismas felt the weight of his life pressing in, the hollow ache of a freedom that always seemed just out of reach.

Perhaps Barabbas was right—freedom was worth any cost. But in the stillness of the night, the shadows seemed to whisper otherwise. Were they fighting for freedom, or simply running from the chains that had already bound their hearts?

Just as Dismas turned to go back inside, he heard footsteps behind him. It was Yosef, his face drawn and pale, eyes wide with a look that held both fear and something more. He stopped a few paces away, watching Dismas in silence, as if he weren't sure whether to approach or retreat.

"Can't sleep either?" Dismas asked softly, his voice barely more than a whisper. He knew Yosef was young, and even seasoned fighters struggled with the tension that came before

a raid. But the look in Yosef's eyes hinted at something more, something that went beyond the usual apprehension.

Yosef took a hesitant step forward. "Dismas," he began, his voice shaky, "when I joined Barabbas, I thought... I thought I knew what I was fighting for. But now..." He trailed off, his gaze shifting toward the hills. "What if it's not enough? What if we're just throwing our lives away?"

Dismas felt a pang of sympathy, recognizing the conflict in the boy's voice. He had felt that same doubt, long ago. "Only you can answer that, Yosef," he said thoughtfully. "Barabbas has his fire, and we follow him because we believe in it, or maybe because we want to believe. But at the end of the day, you have to decide what's worth fighting for. And sometimes... sometimes that means seeing past the blood and anger."

Yosef nodded, his face thoughtful, as though Dismas' words had given him something to hold onto in the darkness. "Thank you," he murmured. "I needed to hear that."

Dismas watched him return to the cave, his heart heavy. As the battle loomed, he wondered what would be left of them once the sun rose again. He felt an ache of dread, knowing that for some, there would be no coming back from this.

Dismas returned to the cave and lay down on his bedroll, yet sleep eluded him. The cave was quiet now, the men finally settled into uneasy rest, the soft rise and fall of their breathing filling the space. Barabbas slept near the front, his hand resting on his blade, even in sleep still clinging to his weapon. Gestas lay a few feet away, a faint smirk still visible on his face even in the dim torchlight.

Dismas closed his eyes, the burden of it all pressing heavily on him. The quiet resolve in Yosef's voice lingered, a faint echo of the hope Dismas himself had once carried. He wondered what awaited them when they returned to the valley, to the road chosen for the ambush. Would Yosef survive this, or would Dismas be forced to witness yet another young life claimed by the relentless struggle?

The torchlight flickered, and Dismas finally surrendered to sleep, knowing that when he awoke, he would face whatever the day demanded. In the dim stillness, he murmured a silent prayer—though he no longer knew to whom he prayed. Perhaps it was to whatever force had given Jesus the courage he had seen in the man's eyes, or perhaps it was to the earth itself, to hold him steady through the battles yet to come.

But for tonight, he allowed himself the small grace of rest, letting go of the questions and doubts that plagued him, and slipping into a dreamless sleep.

Act 1 - 10

Simon

The path from the marketplace to the inn felt longer with each step, Simon's arms laden with bundles of fabric and provisions, each one a heavy reminder of the day's burdens. As he neared the inn, its familiar stone walls rising against the dimming sky, he felt a small, quiet relief. The inn's doorway loomed like a sanctuary, the dim light from within a promise of warmth and refuge.

He pushed open the door, stepping into the glow of flickering oil lamps clinging desperately to the low beams overhead. Shadows danced over the rough-hewn wooden walls, casting familiar shapes and twisting into memories of countless travelers who had taken shelter here before him. The air was thick with the rich aroma of stew, its warmth coiling around him like a long-lost friend, offering him a moment's peace from the troubles outside.

The common room hummed with life, every table filled with patrons sharing food and stories under the warm but worn wood of the inn's ceiling. The mismatched tables and chairs, some scarred with scratches and gouges, seemed to pull everyone closer together, uniting strangers and friends alike in this modest refuge. Simon could feel the weight of the day lifting slightly, the warmth of the room easing his weariness, if only for a while.

Scanning the room, his gaze fell on Eli, sitting by the hearth. The sight of his familiar face, illuminated by the fire's glow, stirred a warmth within Simon's chest. He approached, the

day's troubles momentarily forgotten, and raised his voice just enough to call over the hum of voices around him.

"Eli!" Simon greeted, his own voice carrying a note of relief. "What mischief have you stirred today?"

Eli looked up, his eyes lighting up at the sight of Simon. He grinned, a familiar glimmer of humor in his gaze. "Simon! By the heavens! The market's still the mad circus it's always been. And you—have you survived its chaos?"

With a weary grin, Simon lowered himself into the seat across from him, placing his burdens beside the table. "Survived, yes. But today..." He paused, his smile fading as the memories of the day's events resurfaced, heavy and unrelenting. "I saw things that chilled my heart, Eli."

Eli's smile faded as well, replaced with a look of quiet understanding. He leaned forward, his tone softening. "Tell me, my friend. Did those merchants give you more trouble than usual?"

Simon shook his head, the shadows of the day's memories darkening his expression. "It wasn't the merchants," he spoke, his tone subdued. "Today, I saw a man—one of our own—beaten senseless by Roman soldiers, right there in the street. They showed no mercy. It felt like a dagger to the heart, Eli, a reminder of their grip over us."

Eli's face grew solemn, his brow furrowing as he took in Simon's words. "Ah," he murmured, a sigh escaping him. "The Romans... they never show mercy, do they? But to witness it firsthand like that—yes, I imagine it stays with you. A sight like that lingers."

Simon nodded slowly, a shiver running through him as he remembered the brutality, the cruel satisfaction in the soldiers' faces. "How can we celebrate our deliverance when such violence surrounds us, Eli? How can we lift our spirits with this kind of oppression bearing down on us?"

Eli's face grew sadder still, his hand reaching across the table to rest on Simon's arm. "This time of year, is meant to remind

us of freedom, to bring hope to our hearts. But when the very air is thick with fear... yes, I understand. It is difficult to find hope."

Simon and Eli sat in silence for a moment, the unspoken tension of their exchanged words settling between them. The hum of the common room—the clinking of dishes, the occasional burst of laughter from nearby tables—felt distant, like an echo of a joy that no longer belonged to this troubled time. Simon's eyes settled on the fire, its flickering light casting restless shadows on the walls, mirroring the unease stirring in his heart.

Eli cleared his throat, his voice breaking the quiet like the first crack of thunder. "Simon, why do you keep coming here, year after year? Is it just tradition, or is there something more?"

Simon smiled faintly, glancing at his friend. "A bit of both, I suppose. The pilgrimage is something I do for my family, to keep the faith alive, to honor what has been passed down to us. But this year..." He paused, his expression darkening. "Eli, the city feels heavier. The air, the stones—it's as if Jerusalem itself knows something's coming."

Eli nodded; his gaze distant. "I feel it too. But it wasn't just the heaviness, Simon. You saw him, didn't you? In the procession. That man—Jesus. There was something about him."

Simon's eyes met Eli's, his tone quiet but resolute. "Yes, I saw him. And I've heard him speak to a group before I arrived here. The crowds call him a prophet, a healer. Some even say he's the Messiah."

Eli's face lit up briefly, but there was a sobering edge to his tone. "I've never seen anything like it, Simon. The way the people shouted his name, laid their cloaks before him—it was as if they already believed he was the one they'd been waiting for. Did you see his face? The way he looked at the crowd, as though he carried all their burdens and yet still stood tall?"

Simon's brow furrowed, and he leaned forward. "I saw it. But, Eli, you know how this goes. Rome doesn't tolerate hope like that—not for long. We've seen prophets rise before. They

make promises of freedom, and then they fall. What makes Jesus any different?"

Eli's voice sharpened, his conviction cutting through Simon's doubt. "Because he *is* different. He doesn't just talk about a kingdom—he *shows* it. Simon, we saw it in their eyes, the way people lit up just being near him. It's not just miracles or words. It's him. He carries something—something no one else has."

Simon hesitated, his fingers tightening on the table. "But hope, Eli, is a dangerous thing. Rome crushes those who dare to carry it. You know that as well as I do."

Eli's expression softened but remained resolute. "I do, Simon. But I also know that this hope isn't fragile. It's not the kind that crumbles when pressed. This is a fire. And Jesus isn't afraid of letting it burn."

Simon sighed, shaking his head, his shoulders sagging under the strain of his thoughts. "I want to believe, Eli. But what good is a kingdom within us when Rome's soldiers stand at our gates? How can words and miracles shield us from their swords?"

Eli's voice softened, but his conviction only grew. "And maybe that's what we need, Simon. To let it consume the fear, the chains we've carried for so long. Rome has taken so much from us—our land, our dignity, our hope. But Jesus... he's giving something back. And I don't think we can ignore that."

Simon fell silent, his mind churning with questions he couldn't yet answer. He looked at Eli, searching his friend's face for something—certainty, maybe, or courage. All he found was a reflection of his own yearning. And for the first time, he wondered if that was enough.

Simon met Eli's gaze, his expression a mixture of resistance and longing. "I don't know, Eli. I want to believe that. But I don't think it's that simple."

The two men sat in silence, the heaviness of their conversation hanging in the atmosphere. For Simon, doubt was a chain, anchoring him to the ground. For Eli, hope burned like a torch,

casting light on the path ahead. Between them, the fragile possibility of something greater wavered like a flame in a storm—unsteady yet unwilling to be snuffed out.

Their shared silence was interrupted by a sharp voice from behind. “Hope, is it?” Simon and Eli turned to see Miriam, a widow with a fierce spirit and a piercing gaze, approaching their table. Her arms were crossed, her expression unreadable as she stepped into their conversation. “Hope is a fine thing, but it can cut as deeply as any sword.”

Eli’s brows furrowed, his tone turning firm. “Hope isn’t a weapon, Miriam. It’s what keeps us alive. Without it, we’re just waiting for Rome to break us completely.”

Miriam’s gaze flickered to Eli, “I’ve heard the whispers too. This Jesus, this so-called prophet—maybe he is different. Or maybe he’s another dreamer doomed to fail. I’ve buried too many friends who dared to hope. Families left behind to scrape by, abandoned to carry the cost of freedom. You call it hope; I call it blindness.”

Simon shifted, her words hitting deeper than he wanted to admit. He met her gaze evenly. “I know the risks, Miriam. We all do. But if this man offers even a chance—a real chance—at freedom from Rome, how can we not take it? What else are we supposed to do?”

Miriam’s sharpness softened, though her eyes held a shadow of pain. “You ask if it’s worth the risk, but is it worth the cost, Simon? If he stirs Rome’s wrath, it won’t be the zealots who pay—it will be the rest of us. Hope doesn’t carry swords, but it leaves us vulnerable to those who do.”

Eli leaned forward, his voice calm but resolute. “Miriam, we’ve all seen the cost of defiance. But don’t dismiss what’s happening here. This Jesus—he’s more than words. He’s already changing people, healing them. I’ve seen men weeping at the mention of his name. That’s not just hope; that’s transformation.”

Miriam glanced away, her voice turning softer. “I want to believe he’s the one, Eli. Truly, I do. But if he isn’t... if he leads

us into the jaws of Rome... hope won't save us from the consequences."

Simon nodded slowly, the fervor in his heart tempered by her caution. "I hear you, Miriam. But something in me says I have to know for myself. I can't turn away from this—not when everything inside me says there's more to him than we can see."

Miriam studied him, then gave a small nod. "Then seek him, Simon. But do it with open eyes. Don't let hope blind you to the danger."

As the silence lingered, a booming laugh shattered the moment. Yitzhak, the stout cloth merchant with a voice as large as his frame, clapped Eli on the shoulder, sending the mugs on the table rattling. Dressed in a vibrant blue robe that stretched across his belly, his round face gleamed with humor and warmth as he pulled up a chair without invitation.

"Well, well! Talking about hope, are we?" Yitzhak bellowed; his grin infectious. "Now there's a subject you can debate until the sun comes back up. So, you're all chattering about this Jesus fellow, eh? The one making the zealots' heads spin?"

Simon nodded; his tone thoughtful. "You've heard of him, then?"

Yitzhak chuckled, leaning back with an ease that belied the tension of the night. "Who hasn't? He's all they talk about. The zealots are practically ready to crown him king, you know. They're convinced he'll march on the Antonia Fortress, drive out every Roman, and free the city by sunrise."

Miriam's skepticism flared as she leaned forward. "And you don't think he will?"

Yitzhak shrugged, his grin softening into something more contemplative. "The zealots would follow anyone who promises to spill Roman blood. But this Jesus... he doesn't seem like the kind of man to take up a sword. He speaks of peace, doesn't he? Of something... different."

Eli tilted his head, a quiet challenge in his voice. “So, what do you think, Yitzhak? Is he the one we’ve been waiting for?”

The merchant’s humor faded, his expression growing serious. “I’ve seen too many ‘Messiahs’ come and go. They start with fire in their eyes, but Rome knows how to snuff flames before they spread. If this Jesus is the real thing, he’d better be prepared for a fight like nothing he’s ever faced. If he’s not... well, we all know how that ends.”

Simon’s voice cut through the growing solemnity. “And what if he offers a different path? Not one paved with swords and blood, but with something greater?”

Yitzhak studied Simon, the younger man’s earnestness reflected in his own softened gaze. “Then maybe he’s worth listening to, Simon. But let’s not hang everything on one man. Too many dreams have died that way already.”

The words lingered in the air as each turned inward, reflecting on what they had heard and what they believed. Eli’s confidence stood firm, Miriam’s caution persisted, and Simon’s uncertainty sharpened—yet so too did his desire to see more of this Jesus for himself. As their conversation faded into silence, the tension of hope and danger settled over them, a stark reminder that in Jerusalem, nothing came without a cost.

The flickering firelight cast restless shadows across their faces as they sat in contemplation. Simon broke the silence, his voice carrying a note of resolve that drew the attention of his friends. “I can’t sit idly by and hope from afar,” he said, the conviction in his tone surprising even himself. “If there’s a chance that Jesus is who they say he is, then I want to hear him speak more. I want to know if his promises hold the kind of strength that can shatter the yoke we live under.”

Eli looked at him, admiration mingled with caution in his gaze. “Then you must be prepared, Simon. The path of hope, of any kind of change, is not without danger.”

Yitzhak clapped Simon on the back with a hearty laugh. “Braver men have sought less, my friend. But you’re right. If he

truly speaks of deliverance, then maybe it's worth hearing his words straight from the source."

Miriam, however, regarded Simon with a softer, more wary look. "Simon, remember hope can be as treacherous as it is inspiring. This Jesus may bring us something, yes, but don't place your faith in him blindly. The Romans... they won't sit by if he stirs the people too strongly."

Simon nodded, absorbing the caution in her words. "I know, Miriam. But something within me stirs whenever I think of him. I've carried this weight for so long—this desire to see our people free, to feel that all of this suffering has a purpose. If he's not the one, then so be it. But I have to find out for myself."

Eli's expression softened, and he gave Simon a small nod. "Then may the path lead you to the truth, Simon, whatever it may be."

With that, the conversation slowed, each of them left to their own thoughts. The question of hope lingered in the space around them, fragile but unyielding, like a flame against the dark night. In that moment, Simon felt his purpose solidify, his desire to see Jesus and understand his message now a promise he made to himself and to the people he loved.

The evening wore on, and the crowd began to thin as patrons retired to their rooms or made their way into the night. The warmth of the stew in Simon's belly and the glow of camaraderie left him feeling content, if only for a moment. He finished his meal, nodding to his friends as he rose to make his way to the small room he'd rented for the night.

The innkeeper led him down a narrow hall, the floorboards creaking underfoot. The room was modest but sufficient—a simple cot, a small table, and a single candle whose faint glow cast a soft light over the walls. As he entered, Simon set down his bundles, each one a reminder of his purpose here and the family awaiting him back home.

The room was quiet, a welcome contrast to the bustling marketplace and the intense conversations of the evening.

Simon lowered himself onto the cot, feeling the weariness of the day settle over him like a blanket. Yet despite his exhaustion, his mind whirled with the words he had heard—Jesus’ message of hope, his friends’ caution, and his own growing desire to understand this man who was stirring such a reaction in the city.

Sighing, he extinguished the candle, letting the room fall into darkness. The soft sounds of the inn around him—the creak of floorboards, the murmur of distant voices—lulled him, and as he lay down, his last conscious thoughts were of the dawn, of the hope that maybe, just maybe, Jesus could be the one to change everything.

The inn grew quiet, save for the occasional murmur from the common room or the distant clinking of dishes. Simon lay in his cot, staring up at the ceiling in the dim light. As he drifted on to sleep, his mind replayed the events of the day—the brutal sight of the man beaten in the streets, the whispers of Jesus’ miracles, the conversations with his friends.

Closing his eyes, he offered a silent prayer. “God of our fathers, guide me. Show me the path, grant me the strength to see it through. Let me be a light for my family, for those I love.”

In the quiet of his room, Simon felt a flicker of peace settle over him, a small, fragile comfort against the uncertainty that loomed ahead. He knew that finding Jesus might lead him down a road of even greater doubt and fear, but it was a journey he felt called to take.

The night deepened, and Simon finally surrendered to sleep, his thoughts fading like embers. Whatever lay ahead, he would face it with courage, driven by a hope that felt as powerful and unyielding as the walls around him.

Act 2

Act 2 - 01

Lucius

The pale light of dawn stretched its fingers across the landscape, casting long, soft shadows over the dew-kissed earth. The air was cool, yet heavy with the promise of the day's heat, and a faint mist clung stubbornly to the ground, swirling gently as Lucius led his column of soldiers along the road. Their armor, dulled by the early light, caught occasional glints from the rising sun, muted reflections that still managed to draw wary eyes from those gathered ahead. The rhythmic march of sandaled feet against the packed dirt was steady and precise, each step echoing like a drumbeat that announced their approach with unyielding authority.

Jerusalem sprawled in the distance, its towering walls standing as both protector and oppressor of the lives contained within. Marius trailed behind Lucius, his movements measured and deliberate. Where Lucius radiated sharp energy—a readiness to strike if needed—Marius carried himself with quiet strength, his silence commanding respect. Yet his eyes betrayed a thoughtful distance, as if weighed by the unseen burdens of the journey.

The road ahead curved gently, revealing a congregation of people that seemed to shift and writhe like a living thing. Pilgrims and villagers had gathered in numbers too great to count, the vibrant colors of their robes clashing with the muted tones of the arid landscape. The voices of men, women, and children wove together, rising in an uneven chorus of

anticipation. Their faces reflected a spectrum of emotion: awe, hope, doubt, and fear.

Lucius felt his expression harden as he scanned the attendees. He was no stranger to crowds—riotous mobs in faraway provinces or sullen gatherings in subdued territories—but this was different. This was not the wary submission of the conquered nor the chaotic anger of the oppressed. These people moved with purpose, their heads turning as one toward the epicenter of their collective focus: a lone figure standing a short distance beyond the crowd's edge.

“They follow him like sheep chasing a shepherd,” Lucius observed in a whisper, his tone quiet, more observational than disdainful.

“They flock because they hope,” Marius replied, his gaze fixed ahead. His tone was neutral, neither rebuking nor agreeing, but the words carried weight.

Lucius glanced back at him, arching a brow. “Optimism is a fragile thing,” he said coldly. “Easily broken. Easily exploited.”

Marius said nothing. His eyes remained steady on the figure ahead, but his expression was unreadable—a mask honed through years of military service and careful observation.

As they drew closer, the details among the congregation became clearer. Families clung together, parents shielding children as if their proximity to the soldiers might provoke punishment. Others stood with tense shoulders and hardened gazes, defiance flickering in their eyes even as they avoided direct confrontation. It was a tension that Lucius had felt a hundred times before, the taut line between compliance and rebellion. One wrong move, one spark, and it would ignite.

The figure at the center of it all stood motionless, his simple garments a stark contrast to the soldiers' finery and the gaudy robes of the wealthier onlookers. His presence was magnetic, not because he imposed himself upon the scene but because he seemed utterly at ease within it. The man's hands hung loosely at his sides, his posture unguarded, yet his gaze swept

over the assembly with the quiet authority of one who saw beyond the surface.

Lucius could not suppress a sneer. “This is the man they whisper about? The prophet who dares speak of kingdoms and defiance? He looks like a beggar.”

“And yet they listen,” Marius said softly.

Lucius’ eyes narrowed. “And what of you, Marius? Will you listen too? Or, like them, do you think that this man holds the power to change anything?”

The words hung in the space around them, and for a moment, Marius said nothing. Then he spoke, his voice calm but firm. “I am here to observe, Lucius. To listen, if there is something worth hearing.”

Lucius scoffed, but his irritation was tempered by something he could not name. There was a stillness to Marius—a restraint that was as alien to Lucius as the language of these Judean villagers. It unsettled him, though he would never admit it.

As they approached the crowd, the people parted reluctantly, their murmurs growing softer as the soldiers stepped into their midst. Some bowed their heads, unwilling to meet the piercing gaze of Rome’s enforcers, while others whispered prayers beneath their breath. Lucius caught snatches of their words—pleas for deliverance, invocations of a God whose presence he could not feel. He dismissed them as the ramblings of the desperate.

But Marius watched with quiet intensity. His eyes lingered on a young mother clutching an infant to her chest, her face lined with exhaustion and fear. They moved to an elderly man kneeling on the ground, his lips moving soundlessly in prayer. Each face told a story, and though Marius did not speak, he absorbed them all, as if filing them away for some unknown purpose.

At last, they came to a halt near the front amidst the assembly. The man at the center turned slightly, his gaze meeting Lucius’

for the briefest of moments. Lucius felt a jolt of something—irritation, perhaps, or unease—as if the man’s eyes saw through him, peeling back the layers of duty and ambition to find the raw humanity beneath. It was an unsettling sensation, and he quickly averted his gaze, his sneer deepening.

Marius stepped forward, his movements slow and deliberate, and the tension in the crowd seemed to ripple outward like a wave. All eyes turned toward him now, the Roman centurion whose presence seemed both an intrusion and a challenge.

The man at the center, encircled by the crowd, did not move, but his eyes shifted to meet Marius’; the noise from the surrounding onlookers faded into silence.

Lucius adjusted the strap of his armor as he moved forward, each step sending small puffs of dust into the air. They citizens parted instinctively before him, the murmurs of their voices fading into uneasy silence. His presence carried weight, a silent proclamation of authority embodied in his rigid stance and the deliberate precision of his movements. Even without a word, the power of Rome loomed larger through him, and none dared meet his gaze.

Marius hung back slightly, arms crossed over his chest, his eyes sharp as they observed the exchange from a short distance. He had no need to intervene. This was Lucius’ task—a chance for the younger soldier to prove his command in a situation more nuanced than an open battlefield.

Lucius’ gaze scanned the crowd, sharp and unrelenting, searching for someone who seemed closely tied to the prophet. The people avoided his eyes, their gazes cast downward, hands clutching the shoulders of children or gripping the arms of loved ones. Then his focus settled on a man near the center, simply dressed yet carrying a quiet presence that marked him as one of the prophet’s close companions.

“You,” Lucius said, his voice breaking the oppressive silence with calm authority. He pointed at the man, his tone steady and heavy with expectation. “Step forward.”

The man hesitated, his fingers briefly brushing another's shoulder as if drawing strength, before he moved. There was no fear in his movements, only a deliberate caution, as though he were carefully weighing the gravity of the moment. He stopped a few steps from Lucius, inclining his head slightly, his demeanor calm yet watchful.

Lucius studied him, noting the roughness of his hands and the lines etched into his face. This was no warrior, no threat to Roman authority, but there was something in his demeanor—a quiet strength that grated against Lucius' patience.

"The Centurion requests an audience with your prophet," Lucius said. His tone was formal, clipped, each word delivered like a command. There was no room for refusal, no suggestion of negotiation.

The man's eyes flicked to Marius, then back to Lucius, and his expression softened. He nodded once, his movements deliberate but without subservience. "I will inform him," he said simply. His voice was calm, with none of the deference Lucius had expected—or demanded.

Lucius' gaze sharpened, his tone hardening. "See that you do," he said, his voice dropping slightly, a threat curling around his words.

The man did not respond. Instead, he turned and began making his way back through the crowd, his movements smooth and unhurried. The people shifted to allow him passage, their eyes darting between him and Lucius.

From his vantage point, Marius caught the faintest shift in Lucius' expression—a flicker of something beneath the surface. It wasn't anger, though that was present, but an unease, a frustration born not from defiance but from the absence of fear.

"He acts as if we're equals," Lucius said as he returned to Marius' side

“Perhaps he sees no reason to believe otherwise,” Marius replied, his tone neutral but carrying a weight that drew a sharp glance from Lucius.

Lucius said nothing, his attention fixed on the movement ahead. The disciple approached the prophet, who stood unmoving at the heart of the assembly. Lucius observed intently as the two exchanged quiet words, though he could not make out what was said. He caught the faintest inclination of the prophet’s head, a silent acknowledgment that sent the disciple moving once more, this time toward the perimeter of the gathering.

Lucius turned to Marius, his frustration evident in the tension tightening his features. “They think they’re untouchable,” he said, his tone sharp and clipped. Marius’ gaze lingered on the prophet, who now looked directly at them, his expression calm but unyielding. “Perhaps they believe they answer to someone else,” Marius said softly, almost to himself.

Lucius scoffed, his fingers brushing the pommel of his sword as if to remind himself of the power that hung at his side. But his grip did not tighten. The prophet’s gaze, steady and piercing, rested on them for a moment longer before turning toward the crowd, leaving Lucius with the uncomfortable sensation of being dismissed.

The multitude grew restless as Marius stepped forward, his deliberate, armored strides stirring the dust that hung thick in the surroundings. The circle of onlookers tightened, pressing closer together, their hushed voices rippling outward like the whispers of a storm. The prophet stood at the center, calm and unmoving, as though he had been waiting for this moment.

Lucius, standing a few paces back, observed the scene with sharp, calculating eyes. This was his plan—a preemptive strike to address the whispers rippling through the city about this so-called prophet. The rumors of miracles, the talk of a new kingdom, the swelling crowds—these were the sparks of rebellion, and Lucius had resolved to uncover the man’s intentions. He expected Marius to approach with the full weight

of Roman authority, his questions slicing through any illusion of divinity.

And yet, something about the scene set Lucius on edge. Marius' usual aggressive strides, the commanding dominance he wielded with soldiers and unruly crowds alike, were absent. Instead, there was a measured stillness to him now, an almost meditative calm that felt alien. Lucius frowned, his fingers tapping rhythmically against the pommel of his sword.

The prophet's gaze never wavered from Marius as the centurion came to a stop a few paces away. The mob seemed to hold its collective breath, their anticipation almost tangible in the stillness. Lucius noticed how some clutched their hands together in silent prayer, their expressions filled with reverence as if this moment carried a weight far greater than it should. The sight gnawed at him, an uneasy sensation creeping into the back of his mind.

To Lucius, it was simple: Marius was here to question this man, to strip away the mystique and reveal the mortal beneath the stories. That was why Lucius had arranged this meeting—to remind the crowd, and perhaps the prophet himself, that Rome watched, and Rome judged.

As Marius halted before the prophet, the two men stood in stark contrast. Marius' polished armor gleamed with the sunlight, a symbol of Roman discipline and power. The prophet's simple robes, dusty from the road, spoke of humility and something Lucius could not quite name—something that grated against his instincts.

"What are you doing, Marius?" he grumbled softly, his irritation growing. "Get to the point."

Marius regarded the man for a long moment, his silence unnerving even Lucius. Finally, he spoke, his tone quiet but steady. "Lord," he said, the title falling from his lips with an unexpected weight, "my servant lies at home, stricken and near death."

The words struck like a sudden gust of wind through a quiet room, unsettling the stillness and drawing every eye. Even

Lucius blinked, his mind struggling to grasp what he had just heard. This was no interrogation. This was a plea.

The prophet met Marius' gaze with quiet intensity, his expression unchanging. Then, in a voice calm and resolute, he replied, "I will come and heal him."

A murmur swept through the crowd, faint and electric. The simplicity of the words carried a certainty that silenced even the most skeptical whispers. Lucius' expression grew taut, his mind racing to process what was unfolding.

Marius inclined his head slightly in acknowledgment, his face revealing nothing. The crowd shifted, their whispers swelling once more as the moment stretched. Behind him, Lucius stood motionless, watching with a mixture of confusion and irritation.

The murmurs amid the gathering hung like an echo, their astonishment palpable. "I will come and heal him." The simplicity of the prophet's words unsettled Lucius more than any threat or defiance might have. There was no posturing, no grand declaration of authority—just an assurance spoken with a quiet certainty that carried through the air like a blade cutting through fog.

Marius shifted slightly, his posture changing as he lowered his gaze. When he spoke, his voice was softer, carrying the gravity of the moment in its measured tone. "No, Lord," he said, raising a hand as though to stop Jesus' approach. "I am not worthy to have you come under my roof."

This Roman centurion—this symbol of imperial might and control—had just confessed unworthiness. The words hung in the air like an unexpected rush, unsettling and carrying whispers of disbelief through the onlookers. Lucius, standing rigid at the scene, felt his confusion harden into irritation. This was not the commander he knew, the man who had always stood firm against gods and kings alike.

Marius' voice grew stronger, though it remained laced with humility. "But only say the word, and my servant will be healed."

Gasps rippled through the crowd, the raw faith in the centurion's voice shattering any pretense of detachment among the people. Even Lucius felt the hair on his arms rise as he watched his commander, his mind struggling to grasp what he was witnessing. This wasn't strategy. This wasn't Rome. This was something else entirely—something foreign and intangible.

Marius straightened slightly, his tone steady and deliberate as he continued. "For I, too, am a man under authority, with soldiers under me. I say to one, 'Go,' and he goes; to another, 'Come,' and he comes. I understand the force of commands and the power of obedience." He paused, his gaze locking with the prophet's, his voice firm yet reverent. "If you only say the word, it will be done."

Jesus' gaze softened as he listened, his hands remaining loose at his sides. A faint smile touched his lips, not of amusement, but of recognition—of understanding something that no one else in the crowd seemed to grasp. He turned, looking out over the gathered faces, his voice carrying easily over the murmurs.

"Truly, I tell you," Jesus said, his tone calm but ringing with authority, "I have not found such faith in all of Israel."

The crowd erupted into a flurry of whispers and gasps, their reactions a swirling mixture of awe and bewilderment. Some cast glances at Marius, their eyes alight with newfound respect, while others exchanged uneasy looks, their disbelief etched into furrowed brows. A Roman—one of their oppressors—had been praised for his faith by the very prophet they revered.

Lucius' arms tensed at his sides, tension spreading through his frame as a wave of unease rippled through him. He could feel the weight of the crowd's stares shifting toward him, their gazes probing for meaning in his presence, in his connection to the man now commended. Every instinct urged him to dismiss it, to draw his sword and reassert his authority, to remind them of their place beneath Rome's heel. Yet the moment unfolding before him felt vast, slipping beyond his grasp, and it gnawed at him with an unease he could not

define.

Jesus turned back to Marius, his expression calm but resolute. "Go," he said, his voice steady and commanding. "Let it be done for you as you have believed."

Marius inclined his head, his movements deliberate. He looked at Jesus for a moment longer, his eyes carrying something that Lucius had never seen in him before—gratitude, unburdened by pride. Then, without another word, he stepped back, the masses parting once more to let him pass.

Lucius stood motionless as Marius approached, his mind spinning. This was not how this was supposed to go. The meeting was meant to test the prophet, to draw out his intentions and measure his threat to Rome. Instead, Marius had emerged changed, and Lucius was left standing on a moment he could neither explain nor control.

When Marius reached him, Lucius stepped forward, his voice sharp and low. "What was that?" he demanded, his irritation barely concealed.

Marius paused, his face betraying no hint of emotion. It seemed as though he might brush the question aside. But when he spoke, his voice was calm and firm.

"Faith, Lucius," he said simply. "That is all."

Lucius stared at him, his frustration mounting as Marius turned away, moving toward their waiting contingent. The group began to speak as one, their voices rising in excited murmurs, but Lucius remained rooted where he stood, his mind churning.

Faith. The word left a bitter taste in his mouth, yet it lingered in his thoughts long after the moment had passed.

As Marius stepped away, the gathering surged with movement and noise, breaking the fragile silence that had held them captive. Whispers gave way to a rising murmur, a chaotic symphony of awe, disbelief, and raw emotion. Some pointed after the Centurion, their faces etched with wonder, while

others turned to one another, grasping for meaning in what they had just witnessed.

“Did you hear him? A Roman soldier, calling him ‘Lord.’”

“And the prophet praised him—praised his faith!”

“A Roman... of all people. What does it mean?”

A small knot of men near the gathering argued fiercely, their voices low but intense. “How can this be?” one of them hissed, his brow furrowed in disbelief. “He’s one of them—an oppressor. How could his faith be greater than ours?”

An older man beside him shook his head, his weathered face thoughtful. “It isn’t for us to question. Did you not see the prophet’s face? He knew. He saw something in that man we could not.”

A young woman clutched the hand of her child, her eyes wide with tears. “If he can heal the servant of a Roman,” she whispered, her voice trembling, “perhaps there is hope for all of us.”

But not all were so moved. A gruff merchant standing nearby spat on the ground, his expression dark with anger. “Hope?” he scoffed. “That Roman kneels to no one. This is a game, a trick. He’ll return to his soldiers and laugh at us all.”

Others murmured in agreement, but their voices were faint beneath the rising tide of awe and reverence that swept through the crowd like a flood. Those who had come to hear the prophet speak now found themselves caught in the gravity of something larger than words—a moment that appeared to transcend their understanding.

Lucius remained rooted to his spot, his arms crossed tightly over his chest. His dark eyes swept over the assemblage, noting every shift in posture, every flicker of emotion on their faces. It was chaos, raw and unfiltered, and it unnerved him. Rome thrived on order, on control, and this moment was anything but.

The whispers reached his ears, stinging him like nettles.

“Did you see the way the prophet looked at him? As if he already knew.”

“A Roman! Of all people—a Roman!”

Lucius’ irritation mounted as he scanned the faces, his teeth pressing together in frustration with every word. He wanted to shout, to remind them who they were and where they stood beneath Rome’s iron gaze. But the prophet’s words echoed in his mind, unbidden and unwelcome: “I have not found such faith in all of Israel.”

He caught sight of a young boy clinging to his father’s robe, his wide eyes fixed on the path Marius had taken. “Papa,” the boy whispered, tugging at the fabric, “does this mean he is the one? The messiah?”

The father hesitated, his face lined with doubt and hope in equal measure. “I... I don’t know,” he said finally, his voice faltering. “But if even the Romans believe...”

Lucius turned away abruptly, his fists clenching at his sides. The rising tide of their hope pressed against him, heavy and suffocating, threatening to engulf him. He despised it—hated the way they looked at Marius, as if he had just stepped into something far greater than himself. As though he had crossed an unseen boundary, leaving Lucius isolated and alone on the other side.

At the center of the dispersing crowd, Jesus remained still, his gaze sweeping over the faces around him. His expression was calm, yet there was a gravity to it—a knowing that seemed to quiet even the harshest whispers. The people around him began to press closer once more, their questions bubbling to the surface.

“Master, what did you see in him?”

“Why would you help a Roman?”

“What did he mean about your authority?”

Jesus did not answer immediately. His eyes lingered on the horizon, where the figure of Marius was disappearing into the distance. When he finally spoke, his words were quiet but carried with them the same weight as his earlier proclamation. "The kingdom of heaven is open to all who believe."

The crowd fell silent at his words, their faces a tapestry of emotions—wonder, confusion, and a flicker of something deeper. Hope.

For many, the moment marked a shift in their understanding of the prophet. He was not merely a healer or a teacher, but something more—a bridge between the power they had hoped for and the faith they struggled to find. Yet for others, the moment sowed seeds of doubt. How could their messiah extend grace to their oppressors? What kind of kingdom did he claim to bring?

Lucius, however, had no patience for their pondering. His irritation boiled over, and he turned on his heel, striding back toward their contingent. The murmurs within the assembly followed him, their voices a maddening hum in his ears.

"Faith," he croaked quietly, the word cutting into him like a blade. His arms grew rigid as he walked, his hands flexing with tension, his mind churning with thoughts he could not control. For the first time in years, Lucius felt the faint stirrings of something unfamiliar, something he refused to name.

Behind him, they began to disperse, their voices rising in a mixture of awe and debate. Yet the image of Marius standing before the prophet lingered in their minds, as indelible as a mark burned into stone. Whatever the Centurion had seen, whatever had compelled him to speak with such faith, it had left its mark—not just on the people, but on the very fabric of the moment itself.

The sun burned high overhead, its heat pressing down relentlessly as the last murmurs of the onlookers faded into the dry midday air. The road beyond the gathering stretched wide and empty, a reminder of the task that still lay ahead. Marius stood at the dispersing host; his gaze fixed toward the horizon.

Lucius approached swiftly, his armor clinking softly with each step. His expression was sharp, his movements brisk. "The convoy," he said without preamble, his tone clipped. "We're late."

Marius turned slightly, his face calm but purposeful. "Yes," he said evenly. "Take ten men and go now. They'll be nearing the city gates."

Lucius didn't hesitate. "Understood." He turned, motioning to the nearest group of soldiers. "Let's go," he barked, pointing to the men who snapped to attention at his command. "Form up. We're moving."

The soldiers quickly fell into step, their movements precise and practiced. Lucius glanced back at Marius, his face revealing no trace of his thoughts. "And you?" he asked, though the question was more procedural than personal.

"I'll remain here a while longer," Marius replied, his tone steady. "The crowd has dispersed. There's no risk."

Lucius gave a curt nod, his attention already refocusing on the task at hand. He motioned to his detachment, his voice ringing with authority. "Move out!"

As the soldiers began their march, the synchronized rhythm of their movements filled the air, a steady reminder of Roman discipline. Lucius kept his gaze fixed forward, his posture rigid. The thought of the convoy—its predictable route, the familiar precision of an escort—offered a strange solace, a brief reprieve from the storm of thoughts that had haunted him since the encounter with the prophet.

Each step away felt like a step back into order, into control. Yet even as he marched, the words spoken just hours before lingered in his mind, unshakable: "I have not found such faith in all of Israel." Lucius forced his thoughts back to the task at hand, tension rippling through his features.

Marius watched the detachment until they vanished into the shimmering heat of the horizon, their figures swallowed by the distance. He stood motionless for a moment longer, his hands

resting loosely at his sides, before shifting his gaze toward the hills. The road ahead was still and quiet, yet the gravity of the moment lingered, pressing heavily upon him.

Lucius tightened his expression, trying to shove the memory aside. He wanted to dismiss the moment as theatrics, a clever manipulation meant to sway the listeners. And yet, the sincerity in Marius' voice, the calm certainty in the prophet's gaze—these things lingered, defying his attempts to bury them.

Lucius didn't look back. "Keep the pace steady," he ordered, his voice sharper than he intended. The soldiers fell silent, their obedience automatic, and Lucius forced his focus onto the road ahead.

The convoy. That was all that mattered now. Protecting the shipment, maintaining the order Rome required—these were tasks he understood, tasks that did not demand he wrestle with questions of faith or meaning. If he could just reach the gates, oversee the convoy's safe arrival, everything would return to its proper place.

But even as he quickened his stride, a shadow of unease clung to him, lingering like a second skin. Lucius couldn't shake the feeling that something had shifted, that the encounter with the prophet had left a mark deeper than he was willing to acknowledge. For now, he forced the thought aside, burying it beneath the demands of duty.

Ahead, the gates of Jerusalem loomed, and the promise of familiar routine beckoned. Lucius straightened his shoulders and tightened his grip on his sword. Whatever ghosts lingered in his mind, he vowed they would not follow him here.

Act 2 - 02

Dismas

The morning was cruel, the kind of day that began with the sun already high and merciless in the sky, beating down on the jagged path like a hammer. The rocks, pale and weathered, shimmered in the heat, their sharp edges slicing through shadows that clung to the ground like wounded animals. Dust hung thick in the still air, stifling the lungs and turning every breath into an effort. Even the birds had fallen silent, their songs smothered by the tension that gripped the land.

Hidden among the rocks and scrub, Barabbas crouched low, his body coiled like a predator waiting to strike. Sweat dripped down his temple, tracing a line along the hardened planes of his face before disappearing into the grime on his skin. His hand rested on the hilt of his dagger, the fingers curling and uncurling as if testing its readiness. He exhaled through his nose, his sharp gaze fixed on the road below, where the faintest rise of dust in the distance signaled the coming of their prey.

This was his domain, this space between silence and violence, where time seemed to slow and every detail burned with clarity. The promise of blood sharpened his senses, his purpose honed to a singular edge. For Barabbas, moments like this were life itself—a defiant reminder that he was not just a shadow under Rome's heel but a force to be reckoned with.

"Positions," he hissed, his voice slicing through the heavy silence with the precision of the blade he carried.

The men around him stirred, shifting into place with practiced precision. Each one was a weathered emblem of rebellion, their faces carved by hunger and loss, their bodies hardened by years of relentless struggle. They melded seamlessly into the rugged terrain, their movements so subtle they seemed to vanish into the scrub and stone. To any traveler on the road below, the hills would appear barren, untouched by human presence.

Nearby, Dismas pressed his chest to the earth, his breathing shallow. The sun scorched his back, but a cold knot coiled deep within him. He tightened his grip on the blade in his hand, yet the act brought no solace. Unease had taken root inside him, creeping like a shadow. He could still see the prophet's face, the calm gaze that had pierced through the clamor of the gathering days before. The memory lingered, haunting and unrelenting, like the echo of a dream he couldn't shake.

He glanced toward Barabbas, whose intensity radiated like a flame that refused to be extinguished. The men around them seemed drawn to it, their loyalty born of desperation and shared suffering. Barabbas spoke of vengeance and justice, of a world without Rome's iron grip, and they followed him because his words gave shape to their rage. But for Dismas, that rage had begun to waver. The prophet's words about peace and freedom lingered, a quiet whisper that made the blade in his hand feel heavier than it should.

A few paces away, Gestas crouched low, his face split by a sly grin. His fingers brushed the hilt of his blade in an almost loving gesture, as though the weapon were an extension of himself. Unlike Dismas, there was no hesitation in him, no whisper of doubt. He lived for moments like these, where chaos reigned, and blood ran freely.

Gestas leaned in, his grin curling with dark amusement. "You've got that look again," he murmured, his tone sharp and needling. "Like you're somewhere else. Not here. Not with us."

Dismas shot him a sidelong glare, tension evident in his expression. "I'm here, aren't I?"

"Your body is," Gestas said, his voice lowering as his grin faded into something colder. "But what about the rest of you? Do you even know why we fight? Or are you just following along, hoping the blood won't stain your hands too much?"

Dismas' gaze hardened, his voice sharp. "Don't question me, Gestas. I've bled for this cause as much as you have."

Gestas chuckled darkly, his hand brushing the hilt of his blade. "Then act like it, brother. We're not here to hesitate—we're here to take back what's ours. And Rome won't hand it over without a fight."

Dismas turned away, tension tightening his features as he forced the doubt to the back of his mind. He scanned the rocks and brush around him, the terrain so familiar it felt like an extension of himself. The ambush site was perfect—a narrow stretch of road flanked by steep hills, offering the rebels the advantage of height and cover. They had scouted this spot endlessly, memorizing every stone and shadow. And yet, as the dust cloud in the distance grew larger, Dismas couldn't shake the feeling that the path ahead led not to victory but ruin.

Barabbas crouched behind a boulder, his eyes narrowing as he caught sight of the convoy's approach. The faint clinking of armor and the murmur of voices drifted to them, carried on the wind. A muscle in his jaw twitched, his hand rising slowly to signal the men to prepare. The movement was precise, deliberate, a command as clear as if it had been shouted.

Dismas pressed himself lower to the ground, his pulse quickening. He pushed away the unease gnawing at him and focused on the task ahead. He was a blade now, a weapon in the hand of rebellion, and there was no room for doubt.

The sound of the approaching convoy grew louder, the rhythmic clinking of armor like an ominous drumbeat carried on the hot wind. Barabbas raised a hand, his fingers splayed wide, a silent command that sent the rebels into absolute stillness. Even the faint rustling of grass seemed to pause, nature itself holding its breath.

The men crouched low behind rocks and in the shadows of scrubby bushes, their weapons drawn and ready. Barabbas shifted slightly, his sharp eyes scanning the road below. The narrow pass was perfect for an ambush, and his heart beat steadily, each pulse matching the deliberate rhythm of his preparation. Every detail had been rehearsed, every role assigned. Barabbas was not a man who left anything to chance.

He glanced to his left, catching sight of Dismas pressed flat against the ground, his face half-buried in the dirt. There was tension in the younger man's posture, a stiffness that betrayed his unease. Barabbas' lip curled slightly. He didn't need to hear Dismas' doubts to know they lingered—he could see them in the way Dismas gripped his blade, fingers flexing as though testing its weight.

Dismas wasn't the only one. The silence stretched taut around them, and Barabbas could feel the nerves creeping in, the slow creep of doubt that came in moments like this.

It was the silence that did it, he knew. The waiting. Men could grow hard, endure hunger, and fight like demons when the moment came, but the waiting tested them in ways they rarely understood.

He turned his head slightly, his voice low but firm. "Steady," he murmured, his tone a steel thread that cut through the quiet. "We've done this before. You all know what to do. Trust your training. Trust me."

The men around him shifted slightly, their movements almost imperceptible, but the tension hovering around them seemed to ease. Barabbas' presence alone was enough to anchor them. He wasn't just their leader—he was their symbol, the living embodiment of their resistance. To the men hiding among the rocks, Barabbas was more than flesh and blood. He was vengeance given form.

To Barabbas, it was just another raid. Another strike in a long, unending war.

A few feet away, Gestas crouched with the ease of a man completely at home in the stillness. He ran his fingers over the blade strapped to his side, his touch almost affectionate, like a hunter stroking his bow before a kill. He caught Dismas glancing his way and flashed a toothy grin.

“What’s the matter, Dismas? Regretting your choices already?”

Dismas shot him a glare, tension flashing across his face. “I’m fine,” he replied curtly.

“Fine?” Gestas sneered, leaning slightly closer. “You look like you’re about to faint. Maybe we should leave you here, let you pray for our souls while the rest of us do the work.”

“Shut up, Gestas,” Dismas hissed, though his voice lacked the sharpness of conviction. He turned his attention to the road, willing himself to ignore the gnawing unease in his chest.

Barabbas’ voice lashed through their murmurs, sharp and stinging. “If you’ve got breath to waste on this nonsense, you’re not fit to fight,” he snapped, his gaze like a drawn blade.

Both men fell silent immediately, their gazes lowering in unspoken acknowledgment of the rebuke. Barabbas’ authority was absolute, forged through years of leading men into battles that should have killed them all. He didn’t tolerate weakness, and he had no patience for distractions.

“Eyes on the road,” Barabbas said, his voice softer now but no less commanding. “Focus.”

The rebels obeyed, their gazes homing in on the road below. The convoy was growing closer now, the shapes of the soldiers visible in the shimmering heat. Five men marched in formation around a single wagon, their spears held at perfect angles, their armor gleaming in the harsh sun. The wagon creaked with each turn of its wheels, the sound grating in the stillness.

Barabbas studied the soldiers with a practiced eye, his mind already calculating the best approach. The Romans were

disciplined, their movements precise, but they weren't prepared for an ambush. Not here. Not now.

"They don't even know we're here," Gestas whispered, his grin returning. He tapped the hilt of his blade against his knee, anticipation radiating from him like heat. "Five soldiers. Hardly seems fair."

Dismas didn't reply. His eyes were fixed on the soldiers below, but his thoughts lingered elsewhere. He couldn't stop thinking about the man he'd seen in the crowd days ago—the prophet with the calm eyes and words that gave the impression of piercing the chaos of the world. A man who spoke of peace and freedom, not as a distant dream, but as something real. Something possible.

And yet here Dismas was, lying in the dirt with a blade in his hand, waiting to spill blood. The contrast felt like a stone in his chest, cold and heavy.

Barabbas raised his hand again, signaling the men to ready themselves. The soldiers' voices drifted up from the road, fragments of words carried on the wind. The rebels tensed, each one sinking lower behind their cover, their breaths shallow and controlled.

"Stay low," Barabbas murmured, his voice barely audible. "Wait for my signal."

The wagon creaked again, the noise grating against the tense silence. Dismas tightened his grip on his blade, his knuckles white. Gestas leaned forward slightly, his grin widening, his body taut with anticipation. Barabbas' hand remained steady in the space around them, a signal to hold, to wait, to watch.

Barabbas' hand dropped sharply, and the rebels erupted from their hiding places like shadows bursting into the light. The silence that had gripped the pass shattered, replaced by the fierce cry of men lunging toward their prey. Stones scattered underfoot, and blades flashed in the searing sunlight as the rebels descended upon the convoy.

The Roman soldiers reacted with startled shouts, their disciplined formation thrown into chaos. A spear clattered to the ground as the nearest guard was struck down before he could raise his shield. Barabbas moved like a force of nature, his dagger plunging into the soldier's throat in one brutal, fluid motion. Blood splattered across his face, but he didn't flinch. His roar of triumph carried above the melee, rallying his men as they fell upon their opponents.

"Strike hard! No mercy!" Barabbas bellowed, his voice piercing the din.

The rebels moved with fierce precision, each man a sharpened blade of desperation and rage. Gestas fought with wild abandon, a feral grin stretched across his face as he lunged at the nearest soldier. His blade found the gap between the Roman's breastplate and arm, and the man crumpled to the ground with a strangled cry.

"Is this the best Rome has to offer?" Gestas sneered, wrenching his blade free and pivoting toward his next target.

Dismas moved more cautiously, his chest heaving as he ducked beneath a swinging spear. The air buzzed with the clash of steel, the grunts of exertion, and the cries of the dying. He sidestepped another attack, his blade slashing across a soldier's leg, sending the man staggering backward. The Roman's helmet tilted, and for a fleeting moment, Dismas caught the man's eyes—wide, frightened, human. The connection froze him in place, his grip on his blade faltering.

"Dismas!" Barabbas' voice cut through his hesitation like a whip.

Around him, the battle surged. The wagon creaked violently as one of the soldiers climbed onto it, shouting commands to the others. "Form up! Shields—now!" His voice carried with the authority of discipline, and the remaining Romans moved to regroup. Shields rose, locking together in a defensive line as they struggled to hold their position.

Barabbas saw the movement and charged forward, his dagger flashing in the sunlight. "Break their line!" he roared, driving his

blade into the nearest shield bearer's shoulder. The man cried out, his shield dropping, and the rebels surged through the breach like water pouring through a cracked dam.

Gestas cackled, his blade darting forward to pierce another soldier's neck. "Fodder for the crows!" he howled, blood streaking his face.

Dismas gritted his teeth, his movements mechanical as he parried a spear thrust and slashed at the exposed arm of his opponent. The Roman cried out, stumbling, and Dismas struck again, his blade finding flesh. The soldier fell, clutching his side, and Dismas stepped back, his breath coming in short, shallow gasps. The fight was brutal, relentless, and yet he couldn't shake the feeling that it was all wrong—like a play performed too many times, each act bleeding into the next.

The Romans fought with desperate precision, their disciplined training evident in every calculated motion. But their numbers dwindled as the relentless ferocity of the rebels overwhelmed their defenses. The line broke, soldiers falling one by one, their blood darkening the dusty road.

Barabbas lunged at the last standing guard, his dagger catching the sunlight as it struck. The Roman staggered, crimson spreading across his chest, before collapsing to the ground. Barabbas stood over the body, his chest rising and falling in labored breaths, his face streaked with sweat and blood.

A heavy silence descended over the narrow pass, punctuated only by the groans of the wounded and the ragged breathing of the rebels. For a moment, no one moved, their weapons hanging limply at their sides as the aftermath of the fight settled over them.

"It's done," Barabbas growled, his voice rough with exertion. He wiped his blade on the soldier's tunic, then straightened, his eyes sweeping over the bloodied bodies scattered along the road. "The road is ours."

Around him, the rebels began to stir. Gestas let out a triumphant laugh, his blade raised high in the expanse. "Rome

will feel this," he crowed, his voice echoing off the rocky hills. "They'll remember us now."

Some of the men echoed his cry, their voices tinged with relief and exhilaration. Others leaned heavily against the rocks, their faces pale and weary. Blood streaked their clothes and pooled in the dirt at their feet.

Dismas stood apart, his blade still in hand, though it hung loosely at his side. His gaze drifted over the fallen soldiers, their lifeless faces frozen in shock and pain. He felt a chill creep over him, dulling the heat of the midday sun. Victory had never felt heavier.

The dust from the ambush settled slowly, hanging in the still, hot air. Barabbas stood in the center of the road, his blade resting at the ready, his chest rising and falling with measured breaths. Around him, the rebels moved cautiously, their adrenaline beginning to fade, leaving behind exhaustion and the bruises of a hard-fought battle. The wagon lay tilted on one side, its wheels half-buried in the blood-streaked dirt.

"We did it," one of the younger men murmured, clutching at a gash on his arm as he leaned heavily against a rock. His voice was tinged with disbelief. "Rome won't forget this day."

"Rome never forgets," Gestas replied with a sneer, crouched over a fallen soldier. He was rummaging through the man's belt, pulling free a pouch of coins. "That's the point. Let them remember who we are." He tossed the pouch into the wagon, then glanced toward Dismas, a cruel grin spreading across his face. "What about you, Dismas? Still thinking about saving their souls?"

Dismas stood apart from the others, his blade hanging loosely from his fingers. His gaze swept over the fallen soldiers, blood pooling around their lifeless forms. The memory of flesh yielding beneath his blade lingered, a sensation that refused to fade. The faces of the dead seemed to stare back at him, their expressions etched with pain and confusion, as though silently questioning the lives that had ended so abruptly.

The rebels around them worked quickly, gathering supplies from the wagon and the fallen guards. Coins, grain sacks, and tools were pulled free and thrown into a pile. It wasn't much, but it was enough to keep them moving for a little while longer.

Barabbas crouched beside the wagon, inspecting the contents with a critical eye. His mind was already moving beyond this moment, calculating their next strike, their next chance to drive their message deeper into the heart of Rome's oppression. He didn't have the luxury of doubt, not now. Not ever.

"We'll take what we can carry," Barabbas said, rising to his full height. "The rest stays. Move fast. We're not staying here long."

The men nodded, their movements hurried but methodical. Despite the brief flashes of triumph, the reality of their situation weighed heavily on them. The road was quiet now, but none of them believed it would stay that way. Rome was never far behind.

Dismas lingered near the road, his back to the others. His hand tightened around the hilt of his blade as he stared down at the horizon. He thought of leaving: Just turning and walking away, disappearing into the hills and leaving this life behind. The memory of the prophet's calm gaze tugged at him, a quiet voice in the back of his mind whispering that there was another way.

But where would he go? What would he do?

He was a soldier of rebellion, bound to this fight, even if it no longer felt like his own. He let out a slow breath, forcing the thoughts aside. There was no room for doubt here. Not now.

The sound reached them before the sight. A low, rhythmic pounding that grew louder with each passing moment. Barabbas stiffened, his head snapping toward the horizon. The other men paused, their movements faltering as the noise became distinct: the steady cadence of marching feet on dry earth.

"No," Dismas whispered, his stomach sinking.

Over the rise came the glint of sunlight on polished armor. A Roman cohort, ten strong, marched in perfect formation, their shields raised and their spears upright. At their head was Lucius, his expression cold and furious. His sword gleamed in his hand as he signaled the advance.

"Positions!" he barked, his voice sharp and commanding. "Form up!"

Barabbas cursed, his hand tightening around his dagger.

The rebels scrambled, their earlier confidence dissolving as the disciplined Roman soldiers advanced with relentless precision. The ground seemed to quake with the force of their march, each step a harbinger of destruction.

Lucius raised his sword, his voice ringing out over the pass. "Take them down!"

The soldiers surged forward, their shields locked in a near-impenetrable wall of steel. Barabbas turned to his men, his voice rising above the chaos. "Hold the line!" he roared. "We fight to the last breath!"

Dismas felt his grip tighten on his blade as the Romans bore down on them. The moment of triumph was gone, replaced by the cold, hard reality of survival.

The Roman soldiers advanced with relentless precision, their shields raised in a tight formation that gleamed under the midday sun. Dust swirled in faint clouds around their steady march, the rhythm of their movements echoing like a heartbeat. At their head, Lucius moved like a blade slicing through the air, his expression cold and unyielding. The ambush site lay before him, a grim scene of bloodied bodies and scattered supplies, and his fury simmered just below the surface.

"Shields up," he commanded, his voice like steel. His men obeyed without hesitation, their movements precise, trained for moments like this. They formed a wall of iron and leather, spears angled forward, their disciplined advance making the rebels' ragged positions seem laughable in comparison.

Barabbas stood at the center of his men, his dagger gripped tightly in his hand. He watched the Romans approach with narrowed eyes, his jaw set in determination. This was no convoy, no small band of unsuspecting guards. This was Rome as he knew it—disciplined, efficient, and deadly.

“We hold them here!” Barabbas barked, his voice breaking through the tension. “They want to crush us, to send a message. But we’ll send one of our own. Fight like dogs if you have to! Fight to the last breath!”

The rebels formed a loose line, their weapons raised, but the exhaustion from the earlier fight was evident. Shoulders sagged, and breaths came in short, uneven gasps. Still, they obeyed Barabbas’ command, their loyalty to him stronger than their fear.

Dismas stood to the side, his blade trembling slightly in his grip. The gravity of the moment bore down on him, his thoughts spiraling out of control. The sight of the advancing Romans, their unyielding formation, made the earlier victory feel like nothing more than a fleeting illusion.

“This is madness,” he whispered faintly, but the sound of Gestas’ voice cut through his doubt

“Are you giving up already, Dismas?” Gestas sneered, his grin sharp and mocking. “They’re just men like us. Bleed them, and they fall.”

Dismas didn’t reply. His grip tightened on his blade as the Romans closed the gap, their formation steady, their spears like an iron forest.

Lucius raised his sword, the signal to charge. “For Rome!” he roared, his voice echoing off the rocks.

The Roman line surged forward as one, shields locking together, spears thrusting forward with brutal precision. The impact was immediate and devastating.

The rebels clashed against the Roman wall like waves breaking on a cliff. Barabbas lunged forward, his dagger

darting in and out, striking at gaps in the soldiers' armor. He fought with the ferocity of a man possessed, his movements swift and deadly. A Roman spear grazed his side, drawing blood, but he didn't falter.

"Push them back!" Barabbas shouted, his voice hoarse. "Hold the line!"

The rebels fought valiantly, but the discipline and sheer force of the Romans quickly began to overwhelm them. A spear struck one of the younger men in the chest, and he crumpled to the ground with a strangled cry. Another rebel fell moments later, his head snapping back as a Roman blade found its mark.

Gestas fought like a cornered animal, his wild strikes forcing the soldiers back momentarily. His laughter, sharp and unsettling, carried over the chaos. "Come on!" he shouted, his voice half-mad. "Let's see what you're made of!"

But even Gestas' savage energy began to falter as the Romans pressed forward, their shields battering the rebels' weapons aside with ruthless efficiency.

Dismas parried a thrusting spear, his arms straining under the impact. He ducked low, slashing at a soldier's leg, but the man barely staggered before another thrust forced Dismas to retreat. The unity of the Romans was unbreakable, their formation moving like a single entity.

Barabbas slashed at a soldier's exposed neck, his dagger finding its mark. The man fell, but Barabbas' victory was short-lived as another soldier took his place, the Roman line pushing closer. Blood streaked Barabbas' face, his breath coming in ragged gasps, but he refused to yield.

"Keep fighting!" he roared, his voice raw with desperation.

Lucius cut through the chaos like a storm, his blade flashing as he drove into the rebel line. His expression was cold, methodical, his every movement precise. He locked eyes with Barabbas for a brief moment, and something in his gaze made Barabbas' blood boil.

The tide of battle turned swiftly. One by one, the rebels began to fall, their cries of pain mixing with the clang of steel. Gestas staggered back, a deep cut running down his arm. Dismas found himself forced into retreat, his breath coming in panicked bursts as the Romans pressed closer.

“Barabbas!” one of the rebels cried, his voice trembling. “We can’t hold them!”

Barabbas gritted his teeth, his gaze darting across the battlefield. He could see the bodies of his men scattered among the rocks; the once-defiant line now reduced to a desperate struggle for survival.

“Fall back!” he shouted, his voice hoarse but resolute. “Scatter to the hills!”

The rebels broke formation, their retreat a chaotic scramble as they fled into the rocky terrain. Barabbas stayed behind for a heartbeat longer, his dagger raised, his eyes blazing with fury. Then, with a final glare at Lucius, he turned and disappeared into the shadows of the hills.

Lucius lowered his sword, his breath steady despite the battle’s chaos. Around him, the Romans began to regroup, their discipline holding firm even in the aftermath of violence. He looked out over the battlefield, his expression hardening as his gaze fell on the bodies of the fallen soldiers.

“Secure the area,” Lucius ordered, his voice cold. “Find the survivors. They won’t get far.”

The Romans moved to obey, their formation breaking as they began their search. Lucius remained where he stood, his grip on his sword tightening. The rebellion had drawn blood today but so had Rome. And the score was far from settled.

The rebels fled into the hills, their steps uneven as exhaustion and fear weighed heavily on them. The sharp rocks tore at their feet, and the heat of the midday sun burned mercilessly against their backs. Every breath felt like a struggle, the air thick with the lingering stench of blood and dust.

Dismas stumbled over a loose stone, barely catching himself before he fell. He paused, clutching his knees as he gasped for air. Behind him, the faint clamor of the Romans echoed through the hills, their disciplined search closing in like the jaws of a trap.

"Move!" Barabbas hissed, grabbing Dismas by the arm and yanking him upright. His face was streaked with blood and dirt, his expression hard and unrelenting. "You stop, you die. Keep moving!"

Dismas nodded mutely, his legs trembling as he forced himself forward. Ahead of them, Gestas was sprinting with a reckless fervor, his bloodied blade still clutched in his hand. His wild laughter had vanished, replaced by a grim determination that bordered on desperation.

"This isn't over, Barabbas!" Gestas shouted over his shoulder, his voice hoarse. "We'll regroup. We'll hit them again!"

Barabbas didn't respond immediately. His sharp eyes scanned the rocky terrain, searching for any path that might lead them to safety. Every direction seemed the same—harsh, unyielding, and perilous.

"Keep heading for the ridge," Barabbas finally said, his tone quiet but resolute. "We can lose them in the caves."

Behind them, the fourth surviving rebel—a young man whose name Barabbas couldn't recall in the chaos—staggered as he climbed the incline, his face pale and streaked with sweat. He clutched at a wound on his side, his breaths shallow and pained.

"I can't..." the young man whispered, collapsing against a boulder. "I can't—"

"You can," Barabbas snapped, his tone brooking no argument. "Get up!"

But the young rebel shook his head, his body trembling. "They're coming," he murmured, his eyes wide with fear. "I can hear them. We're finished..."

The sound of approaching footsteps grew louder, echoing off the rocks like a drumbeat. Barabbas cursed under his breath, his dagger gleaming in his hand as he turned sharply toward the source of the noise.

“Go!” he barked at Dismas and Gestas, his voice filled with urgency. “Get to the ridge. I’ll hold them off!”

Gestas hesitated for only a moment before nodding sharply. “Don’t die, Barabbas,” he said, a sly grin flickering across his face. “We need someone to yell at us.”

Barabbas smirked faintly, though his eyes were hard. “Go!”

Dismas lingered, his brow furrowing. “Barabbas...”

“Get out of here, Dismas,” Barabbas growled, his tone leaving no room for argument.

Reluctantly, Dismas turned and followed Gestas, his steps unsteady as they climbed toward the ridge. The sounds of the Romans grew fainter as the terrain steepened, the jagged rocks providing a temporary shield against pursuit.

Barabbas stood his ground, his dagger held tightly in his grip. The young rebel lay slumped behind him, his breaths coming in shallow gasps. Barabbas glanced down at him briefly, his expression hardening.

“If you can’t run,” Barabbas said quietly, “then fight.”

The young man looked up at him, his fear flickering into something closer to resolve. With a trembling hand, he reached for his blade, pulling it free from his belt.

The first Roman appeared over the ridge, his shield raised and his spear angled forward. Barabbas lunged before the soldier could strike, his dagger finding the gap in the man’s armor. The Roman staggered, a strangled cry escaping his lips before he crumpled to the ground.

Another soldier followed, and then another. Barabbas moved with brutal efficiency, each strike of his blade swift and

calculated. The young rebel fought beside him, his movements clumsy but desperate. Together, they held the line for a few precious moments, their defiance burning like a dying flame.

But it wasn't enough.

The young rebel fell first, a Roman spear piercing his side and silencing him with a sharp gasp. Barabbas roared in fury, driving his blade into the soldier's throat. But as more Romans poured over the ridge, he knew the fight was over.

Barabbas turned and ran, his breath coming in ragged gasps as he sprinted toward the ridge. The Romans shouted behind him, their voices rising in a chorus of commands. He didn't look back.

Farther ahead, Dismas and Gestas reached the caves, their steps faltering as they ducked into the shadows. The air inside was cool and damp, a stark contrast to the blazing sun outside. Gestas leaned against the rough stone, his chest heaving as he wiped a hand across his face.

"Well," his voice dripping with bitter humor, "that could have gone better."

Dismas didn't respond. He leaned against the wall, his eyes fixed on the cave's entrance. His mind churned with thoughts he couldn't untangle, images of the fallen rebels and the unrelenting Romans flashing before him.

Barabbas stumbled into the cave moments later, his face pale but resolute. Blood streaked his arm, but he didn't seem to notice.

"We're alive," Barabbas said, his voice rough but steady. "That's all that matters."

"Barely," Gestas said in a low tone, though he didn't press the issue further.

Dismas sank to the ground, his blade slipping from his grasp as he stared blankly at the rocky floor. The strain of the day overwhelmed him, more crushing than any wound. His

thoughts drifted to the prophet, to the words he had spoken to the crowd. "*Blessed are the peacemakers.*" The memory felt distant now, like a fragment of a fading dream.

Barabbas moved toward the entrance, his silhouette stark against the fading light outside. "This isn't over," his voice was low but resolute. "They'll hunt us. But we'll be ready. This is far from over."

Act 2 - 03

Lucius

The sun beat down unrelentingly, its searing heat baking the earth and turning the road into a shimmering expanse of dust and jagged rocks. Lucius pressed forward, his steps steady despite the growing frustration simmering in his chest. Behind him, his soldiers followed in disciplined formation, their armor gleaming and their shields slung low on their backs. The air was thick with the tension of the morning, but it paled in comparison to the pressure of failure gnawing at his thoughts.

Precious time had been lost to Marius' indulgence—a diversion to humor a prophet and his empty proclamations. Lucius' expression grew taut as he replayed the exchange, Marius' calm deference to a wandering preacher contrasting with the chaos that surely awaited them now.

Then, faintly at first, the sounds began to drift toward them—the unmistakable clash of steel on steel, the cries of men locked in mortal struggle. Lucius froze for half a heartbeat, his ears straining to confirm what he already knew.

Battle.

“Double time!” he barked, the sharpness of his command piercing the stillness. His hand instinctively went to his sword as he surged forward, his soldiers falling into step with the practiced precision of years drilled into them. The steady rhythm of their march intensified, the sound rising like a drumbeat as the urgency spread through the rank

Lucius' mind raced as he ran, his heart pounding in rhythm with the echoes of combat growing nearer. He had failed to reach the convoy in time, failed to prevent the bloodshed he had known was coming. Shame burned in his chest, a bitter reminder of the toll of his command. This was his responsibility, his duty, and already it was slipping through his grasp.

The road curved sharply ahead, the rocky terrain rising into steep embankments on either side. As Lucius rounded the bend, the full weight of the scene crashed down upon him.

It was chaos.

The bodies of Roman soldiers lay scattered across the ground, their crimson tunics darkened further by blood soaking into the dust. Some sprawled motionless, their lifeless eyes staring at the unfeeling sky. Others writhed in pain, clutching at wounds as their cries cut through the air like jagged shards of glass.

Amid the carnage moved a ragged band of men—rebels, unmistakable in their mismatched clothing and crude weapons. The remnants of the convoy's defenders stood little chance, their disciplined lines broken and scattered.

Lucius' eyes locked onto the figure at the center of the chaos, a man whose presence seemed to command the battlefield.

Lucius' grip tightened on the hilt of his sword, his knuckles white. A dark resolve settled over him as he took in the scene. He had read reports of Barabbas' exploits, the raids, the ambushes, the relentless defiance that had made him a thorn in Rome's side. But to see him here, standing amid the wreckage of Roman authority, was something else entirely.

"Barabbas!" Lucius shouted, his voice cleaving through the din of battle like a blade.

The rebel leader turned, his eyes narrowing as they met Lucius' gaze. For a split second, the chaos seemed to pause, the battlefield shrinking until only the two of them existed. A slow sneer spread across Barabbas' bloodstained face, his expression equal parts challenge and disdain.

“Rome’s dog arrives,” Barabbas spat, his voice carrying easily across the distance. “A pity you’re too late to save them.”

Lucius’ fury surged, hot and unyielding. He raised his sword, the motion swift and deliberate, as he barked a command to his men, the signal to charge.

“For Rome!” he roared, his voice echoing off the rocks.

His soldiers moved like clockwork, shields snapping into place as they formed a disciplined wall. The contrast between their precision and the rebels’ ragged ferocity was stark, a clear line drawn between order and chaos.

Lucius strode forward at the head of his men, his steps measured and deliberate. His gaze remained fixed on Barabbas, the hatred in his chest burning brighter with each step. This man was no mere rebel. He was an insult to Rome, a living defiance that demanded to be silenced.

Barabbas’ sneer widened as he gestured to his men, his voice sharp and commanding. “Kill them! Every last one!”

The rebels surged forward, their chaotic energy crashing against the advancing Roman line like a storm against a stone wall. Lucius raised his sword, his focus narrowing as the first clash erupted in a whirlwind of steel and blood.

Lucius’ soldiers met the onrushing rebels with the force of a collapsing gate, their shields locking into a solid wall of iron and wood. The first wave of attackers slammed into the line, their weapons scraping and splintering against the disciplined formation.

“Hold steady!” Lucius shouted, his voice ringing out above the cacophony of clashing steel. He strode behind the line, his presence an anchor of authority for his men as they braced against the chaos.

The rebels fought like cornered wolves, their strikes wild and unrelenting, driven by desperation rather than precision. Their weapons were crude—daggers, rusted swords, even wooden

clubs—but they wielded them with the fury of men who had nothing left to lose.

Lucius' blade flashed as he stepped forward, cutting down the first rebel to break through the line. The man fell with a strangled cry, blood spraying across the dry earth. Another followed, his eyes wide with fury as he lunged at Lucius, but the soldier sidestepped the attack, driving his sword into the man's exposed side.

"Push them back!" Lucius roared, his words accompanied by the sound of shields slamming forward, forcing the rebels to retreat a step. "Hold the line!"

To his left, a younger soldier faltered, his shield dipping as a rebel's attack crashed against it. Lucius reacted instinctively, his sword slicing through the rebel's arm in a swift, decisive motion before turning to meet another assailant. The young soldier steadied himself, a look of gratitude flashing across his face as he raised his shield again, prepared to fight on.

"Stay focused!" Lucius snapped, his voice sharp as a blade.

The battlefield was a storm of motion, the air thick with the cries of the wounded and the clash of weapons. Lucius' gaze swept over the chaos, taking in the tide of battle. The rebels were relentless, but their numbers were dwindling, their ferocity no match for the disciplined precision of Roman soldiers.

Barabbas' voice cut through the din, sharp and commanding. "Keep fighting! Make them bleed!"

The rebel leader moved like a force of nature, his dagger flashing as he darted between Roman soldiers. He struck with brutal efficiency, each motion quick and deliberate. Lucius' eyes narrowed as he watched Barabbas take down another soldier, the man crumpling to the ground in a heap.

"Barabbas!" Lucius barked, his voice rising above the clash of battle.

The rebel leader turned, his eyes locking on Lucius once more. His sneer deepened, and he gestured for the rebels around him to fall back slightly, creating a pocket of space between the two forces. It was an invitation, a challenge, and Lucius felt the weight of it settle heavily in his chest.

“Coward!” Barabbas shouted, his voice dripping with disdain. “You send your men to die while you hide behind their shields?”

Lucius strode forward, his sword raised. “Your rebellion ends here,” he said, his voice cold and steady.

Barabbas laughed, a harsh, guttural sound. “Rome has been saying that for years,” he replied, his dagger spinning deftly in his hand. “But I’m still standing.”

Lucius advanced, his soldiers holding the line behind him as the rebels regrouped. The clash was narrowing, the chaos folding in on itself as the two leaders moved toward one another.

Around them, the battle raged on. Dismas fought nearby, his strikes precise but hesitant, as though he were holding something back.

Gestas, on the other hand, reveled in the chaos. His laughter rang out like a broken echo as he swung his blade with reckless abandon, his strikes wild but effective.

“Is this all you’ve got?” Gestas shouted, his grin widening as he ducked beneath a Roman spear and drove his blade into the soldier’s stomach. “Rome, the great empire—brought to its knees by a few starving men?”

The clash of battle tightened around Lucius as he approached Barabbas. The rebel leader stood his ground, his dagger held low, his stance loose but ready. The hatred in his eyes burned like a brand, and Lucius felt his own resolve harden in response.

“Come, Commander,” Barabbas taunted, his voice low and dangerous. “Show me what Rome is made of.”

Lucius lunged, his sword slicing through the air toward Barabbas. The rebel leader moved quickly, deflecting the strike with his dagger and countering with a swift jab aimed at Lucius' side. He twisted away, their blades clashing in a spray of sparks.

The fight was brutal and immediate, each strike an unspoken declaration of their opposing wills. Lucius fought with precision and discipline, every motion deliberate and practiced. Barabbas, by contrast, fought with raw ferocity, his movements unpredictable but deadly.

The sounds of the battlefield seemed to fade around them, the chaos narrowing into the space between their blades. It was as though the rest of the world had fallen away, leaving only the two of them, locked in a battle not just of bodies but of ideals.

"You fight well," Barabbas said, his voice a harsh rasp. "But you fight for nothing."

"I fight for Rome," Lucius replied, his words cold as steel.

Barabbas' sneer deepened. "Then you fight for chains."

The sun blazed overhead, casting harsh shadows across the battlefield as Lucius and Barabbas circled each other, blades poised. Around them, the fight continued, rebels and Roman soldiers locked in a deadly dance of chaos and precision, but the space between the two leaders seemed to exist on a plane of its own.

Barabbas' expression was sharp, almost feral, his bloodied dagger glinting in the sunlight. He lunged first, his movements wild yet calculated, testing Lucius' reflexes. Lucius sidestepped, his sword deflecting the blow with a loud clang.

"You've spent too long barking orders from behind a wall of shields," Barabbas sneered, circling again. "Let's see if you can fight like a man."

Lucius' expression remained unchanged, his sword steady in his grip. "I fight with discipline," he replied, his tone icy and controlled. "Not desperation."

Their blades met in a flurry of strikes and counters, the clang of steel ringing out over the battlefield. Barabbas' attacks were relentless, his strikes unpredictable and fueled by fury. Lucius matched each one with practiced precision, his movements fluid and controlled, his breathing even despite the heat and exertion.

As they fought, their words cut as deeply as their blades.

"You kill for shackles," Barabbas spat, his dagger slicing through the air toward Lucius' shoulder. "You fight for an empire that crushes your people like dust beneath its heel."

Lucius deflected the strike, his counterattack forcing Barabbas back a step. "And you kill for chaos," he shot back. "You offer nothing but ruin in place of order."

Barabbas grinned, though his breath came in short gasps. "Better ruin than the life Rome offers—scraping and bowing to men like you. Better to die free."

Lucius' grip tightened on his sword as he stepped forward, his strikes growing sharper, more aggressive. "Your rebellion has never been about freedom," his tone laced with disdain. "It's about vengeance, and vengeance destroys everything it touches."

Barabbas' grin faded, replaced by a flicker of something darker—something raw and unyielding. "You don't know what Rome has taken," he said, his tone quiet but laced with fury. "You wouldn't understand."

Their blades clashed again, the force of the impact sending a tremor through Lucius' arm. The two men locked eyes, their hatred as palpable as the heat radiating from the sunbaked earth.

The battle pressed on around them, a cacophony of shouts and cries. Lucius caught glimpses of his soldiers holding their ground, shields raised as they fended off the rebels' frenzied attacks. Near the melee, Dismas hesitated, his blade faltering as he faced one of Lucius' men. For a brief moment, his gaze

met Lucius', a flicker of something uncertain passing between them before he turned away.

Lucius pushed the thought aside, focusing on the fight at hand. Barabbas lunged again, his dagger slicing through the air toward Lucius' chest. Lucius twisted to the side, countering with a powerful strike that forced Barabbas to stagger back.

The rebel leader's expression darkened, his grin now replaced by a grim determination. "You'll bleed today, Roman," he growled, his voice rough with exertion.

Lucius' expression hardened, his focus sharpening. "You'll fall with your rebellion," he replied, his sword arcing downward in a swift, calculated strike.

Barabbas blocked the blow, their blades locking for a tense moment. Their faces were inches apart, their breaths heavy, their expressions mirrors of one another's unyielding resolve.

"Your empire won't last forever," Barabbas hissed through gritted teeth. "Even Rome can't hold back the tide forever."

Lucius shoved him back, breaking the lock. "Perhaps," he said, leveling his sword. "But you won't live to see its end."

Barabbas roared, lunging forward with a series of ferocious strikes. Lucius deflected them all, his movements precise but tiring. Each swing of his blade felt heavier, the strain of the fight beginning to wear on him. He could see it in Barabbas as well—the slight falter in his steps, the labored rise and fall of his chest.

This wasn't just a clash of weapons. It was a battle of wills, of conviction. Lucius fought with the whole of Rome behind him, the expectation of order and discipline driving every strike. Barabbas fought with the fire of rebellion, each attack fueled by years of rage and suffering.

As the fight raged on, Lucius found his thoughts wandering, despite himself. Barabbas' words echoed in his mind—accusations of chains, of oppression. He questioned whether

the rebel's defiance came from something deeper than anger. Could there be truth in his hatred?

But the thought was fleeting, chased away by the next strike of Barabbas' dagger. Lucius parried, twisting his blade to force Barabbas' weapon aside.

Lucius drove Barabbas back with a fierce strike, their blades clashing in a spray of sparks. The rebel leader staggered but recovered quickly, his dagger raised, his breath heavy. Lucius didn't pursue immediately; instead, he turned his head briefly, taking in the state of the battlefield around him.

The clash had devolved into a brutal, grinding melee. His soldiers, trained and disciplined, held their line with grim resolve, their shields locked as they pressed against the rebels. The rebels, though fewer in number, fought with a ferocity born of desperation. The cries of the wounded and the sharp clang of steel filled the air, a cacophony that reverberated off the rocky hillsides.

Lucius' gaze fell on Dismas, not far from the battle. The rebel was locked in combat with one of his soldiers, their blades meeting in a rapid exchange of strikes and counters. But there was something hesitant in his movements, a reluctance that set him apart from the others. Dismas swung his blade. The strike was deflected, and Lucius turned away, his focus heading toward the broader conflict.

Nearby, Gestas fought with savage glee, his laughter rising above the din of battle like the cry of a scavenging hawk. His wild strikes seemed almost careless, yet they found their marks with deadly precision. Lucius felt a surge of contempt rise in his chest as he watched the wiry rebel revel in the chaos.

"Is this the best Rome can muster?" Gestas sneered, his voice dripping with scorn as he slashed at a Roman soldier's shield, forcing the man back. "You're nothing but dogs!"

Lucius gestured sharply to one of his men. "Silence him," he ordered, his tone cold.

The soldier nodded, advancing toward Gestas with his shield raised. Lucius didn't linger to watch; his attention was drawn to a section of the line where the rebels were beginning to falter.

"Push forward!" Lucius barked, his voice cutting through the chaos. "Break their line!"

His soldiers obeyed, their shields slamming forward with a unified roar. The rebels scrambled to hold their ground, their earlier ferocity waning as exhaustion set in. Lucius felt a grim satisfaction as he watched his men press the advantage, their discipline overpowering the rebels' wild aggression.

Barabbas' voice rang out above the fray, sharp and commanding. "Hold your ground! Fight like men!"

Lucius turned back toward the rebel leader, tension evident in his expression as he watched Barabbas rally his men. Despite the odds, the rebel's presence seemed to fortify their resolve, giving them the strength to keep fighting even as their numbers dwindled.

The rebel leader turned his gaze toward Lucius, and their eyes met once more. Lucius saw something in Barabbas' expression—something more than defiance. It was a challenge, yes, but also a recognition of the battle's stakes, a silent acknowledgment that this fight was as much about ideals as it was about survival.

Lucius felt a flicker of respect, unbidden and unwelcome. He pushed it aside, his grip tightening on his sword as he strode toward Barabbas once more.

The battlefield seemed to shrink as the two men closed the distance between them, their weapons raised, their movements mirroring one another in their determination.

Lucius lunged, his blade slicing toward Barabbas' side. The rebel leader parried, countering with a swift jab of his dagger. Lucius twisted away, their blades clashing again in a flurry of strikes and counters.

"You're losing," Lucius said, his tone firm despite the strain of the fight.

Barabbas smirked, his movements unrelenting. "Am I? Or am I just making you bleed?"

The words stung more than Lucius cared to admit. His soldiers were winning the day, but the cost was clear. The bodies of his men littered the ground alongside the rebels, their blood soaking into the dry earth. For every rebel that fell, it seemed two more stepped forward, their ferocity undiminished even in the face of overwhelming odds.

Lucius pressed the attack, his strikes growing more aggressive as he sought to overwhelm Barabbas. But the rebel leader fought with a raw, untamed energy that made him impossible to predict. Every time Lucius thought he had an opening, Barabbas countered, forcing him back on the defensive.

"You fight for slave masters," Barabbas growled, his dagger slicing toward Lucius' chest. "You fight for men who would crush you as easily as they crush us."

Lucius blocked the strike, his sword twisting to deflect the dagger. "I fight for order," he replied, his tone sharp. "Without it, there's nothing but chaos."

Barabbas laughed, a harsh, guttural sound. "Then perhaps chaos is what we need," he spoke, his eyes blazing.

Their blades locked again, the tension between them crackling like a live wire. Around them, the battle raged on, the cries of the dying a grim reminder of the stakes.

Lucius broke the lock, stepping back as he prepared for another strike. But before he could move, his attention was drawn to the horizon. A dust cloud was rising in the distance—the rest of the Roman convoy.

Barabbas noticed it too. His expression darkened, his sneer fading as he took in the sight of reinforcements approaching. For a moment, the two men stood frozen, their weapons lowered as the realization settled over them.

“Fall back!” Barabbas roared, his command rising above the chaos as he gestured urgently to his men. “Retreat!”

The rebels began to scatter, their movements chaotic as they fled toward the hills. Lucius’ soldiers surged forward, eager to pursue, but he raised his hand sharply.

“Hold the line!” he shouted, his voice rising above the chaos. Turning to his second-in-command, he added firmly, “Dispatch a team to pursue them. Barabbas is to be captured alive if possible.”

The officer nodded, signaling a group of soldiers who broke away to pursue the retreating rebels. The rest of the men began to regroup, their shields raised as they watched the hills for signs of lingering resistance.

Lucius’ gaze lingered on the fleeing figures, his mind racing with thoughts of the day’s events. Barabbas had escaped, but his forces were fractured, his rebellion weakened. Lucius turned back toward the battlefield, where the bodies of both Romans and rebels littered the ground.

“Secure the area,” he ordered, his tone cold. “Tend to the wounded. And prepare a report. Rome will want to hear about this.”

Act 2 - 04

Simon

The air in the market was thick with the scents of spices, bread, and sweat, a pungent cocktail that clung to the narrow streets of Jerusalem. Simon of Cyrene moved purposefully through the throng, his sharp eyes scanning the stalls laden with goods. His companion, Eli, walked beside him, their strides in sync as they wove through the chaos of the city

“It seems busier than last year,” Simon remarked, his tone edged with irritation as he avoided a vendor thrusting a basket of dates into his path. “Perhaps more pilgrims, or perhaps fewer merchants with anything to sell.”

Eli chuckled, his weathered face breaking into a wry smile. “More taxes, more greed. Every trader bleeds a little more into Rome’s coffers, and every year we pay the price.”

Simon shook his head, “Wool is dearer than ever. Bread, salt, oil—it’s all the same. Soon, even a man’s faith will carry a tax.”

“Ah, but look around you.” Eli gestured to the bustling street, where families jostled for position near the best stalls, their faces alight with a strange mixture of determination and hope. “Still, they come. They trade their coins, offer their sacrifices. Rome cannot tax faith—at least, not yet.”

Simon followed Eli’s gaze, taking in the restless crowds. Children clung to their parents, traders shouted over the din, and weary travelers leaned against the stone walls of the

street. Everywhere, the hum of human desperation blended with a stubborn sense of purpose.

“Faith runs deeper than hardship,” Simon murmured, his voice quieter now. “Perhaps that’s what Rome can never fully grasp.”

Eli’s smile faded, his expression hardening. “Faith, yes,” he said, his tone heavy with cynicism. “But how much faith is real, and how much is bought and sold? The prophets in these streets offer hope as easily as bread, but where is the deliverance they speak of?”

Simon shrugged, glancing at the clusters of people around him. “Deliverance is a word they cling to because it is all they have left.” His voice grew sharper, tinged with a skepticism that surprised even himself. “Have you heard the latest? Jesus of Nazareth, they call him. A teacher. Some say he heals the sick, even performs miracles.”

“And what do you say?” Eli asked, his brow raised.

Simon scoffed. “Hope is cheap in this place. The poorer a man is, the more he clings to it. A healer, a teacher, a prophet—it changes nothing when Rome’s boot presses on all of our necks.”

Eli tilted his head thoughtfully, his voice quieter now. “Perhaps. But the stories—they are strange, Simon. If there is truth in that...” He trailed off, his eyes narrowing as though considering a dangerous possibility.

“If there is truth,” Simon repeated, his tone dry, “then perhaps this Jesus is not defying Rome, but something greater.”

The two men continued in silence, their conversation drifting into the background noise among the onlookers. They passed a butcher shouting his wares, the gleam of his cleaver flashing as he split a bone clean in two. Farther ahead, a spice merchant displayed his goods with a flourish, colorful powders spilling over the edges of carefully arranged jars.

Simon glanced at Eli, his brow furrowed. "It's strange, isn't it? Here we are, talking of prophets and healers as if they were the price of bread."

Eli chuckled, though the sound carried little true amusement. "Perhaps saviors are as common as thieves in this city. Every man with a cause proclaims himself chosen."

Simon raised a brow but said nothing. He had heard the edge in Eli's voice, the subtle weariness that came from witnessing too much of the world's promises and too little of its fulfillment.

Their conversation turned lighter as they moved further into the market, weaving between fading stalls and the remnants of the day's activity. Eli shared news of his daughter's upcoming marriage, his voice warming as he described the preparations. In return, Simon told a tale of a goat back home in Cyrene—a stubborn beast that had escaped its pen three times before Simon had outwitted it. The memory brought a faint smile to his lips, though it faded quickly as the marketplace dimmed around him.

At last, Eli reached his destination, a quiet courtyard flanked by low stone walls. He paused and turned to Simon, his expression softening.

"I'll see you this evening?" Eli said, his tone lighter now, though his eyes lingered on Simon as if searching for something unspoken.

Simon nodded, a faint smile touching his lips. "Perhaps. We must see where God leads us."

Eli stepped into the courtyard; his figure swallowed by the shadows of the evening. Simon stood where he was, watching his friend disappear, his thoughts heavy with the strange pull of the day.

Then he felt it—a subtle shift, a presence too close for comfort. Simon's eyes snapped open, his body tensing as he turned his head slightly. In the corner of his vision, he caught a figure moving toward him, the silhouette blending with the shadows of the alleyway.

Act 2 - 05

Dismas

The late afternoon sun hung high over Jerusalem, its light harsh and unyielding as it baked the city in golden heat. The streets were alive with movement—a cacophony of merchants shouting over the clinking of coins, the bleating of goats, and the shuffling of thousands of sandaled feet. Pilgrims pressed shoulder to shoulder in the narrow alleyways, their faces worn from long journeys, their hands clutching offerings meant for Passover. The constant presence of Roman soldiers, stationed at every corner, added a sharp edge to the bustling chaos.

Dismas moved through the throng with practiced ease, his steps careful and deliberate. Dust clung to his cloak, which hung loose around his shoulders, and his face was set in a hard, unreadable mask. Beside him, Gestas strode with a swagger, his crooked smile flashing beneath the shadows of his hood.

“Too many people,” Dismas uttered, his voice low. His eyes scanned the area, his tension evident in the tight set of his jaw. “A marketplace at this hour? This is foolish.”

“Relax,” Gestas replied, his voice dripping with mockery. “Look around you, Dismas. Do you think anyone’s watching us? These sheep are too busy chasing blessings to see the wolves in their midst.”

Dismas shot him a sharp look but said nothing. He pulled his cloak tighter around him, his fingers brushing the worn fabric as if seeking some anchor in the shifting sea of bodies. His

mind was already running through escape routes, his instincts bristling with the knowledge that Roman patrols lurked everywhere.

As dusk settled over the bustling streets, Dismas and Gestas slinked through the fading crowds like shadows. The last of the day's light cast long, distorted shapes on the dusty ground beneath them, while nearby pilgrims and vendors unwittingly passed by, oblivious to the two men watching from the alley's edge.

Dismas kept his gaze low, his cloak wrapped tight around him as he scanned the street. "We're pushing our luck here," he spoke barely audibly, his voice barely above a whisper. "The Romans are everywhere, and these people have little enough to spare."

"Luck?" Gestas scoffed, casting Dismas an amused glance. "Look around you. Passover has flooded this city with more coins than any Roman vault could hold." His eyes glittered with a kind of reckless confidence. "Easy pickings, if you ask me. They're so busy clinging to their promises of salvation, they wouldn't notice if you took the robes off their backs."

Dismas frowned, his gaze fixed on the crowd as he weighed Gestas' words. His mind drifted, revisiting the earlier procession, to the figure on the donkey, and to the strange, unyielding pull that lingered even now. Part of him wanted to believe there was more than survival—something beyond the constant grip of hunger and fear.

"This prophet of theirs," Dismas commented in a subdued voice, almost to himself. "They look at him like he's more than a man."

Gestas rolled his eyes. "He's a distraction," he said, shrugging off the thought. "Hope is for men who can afford it. Us? We survive. That's all." He nudged Dismas, nodding toward the scattered pilgrims who had yet to return home. "Come on, think about it—there's no easier crowd to work than one distracted by dreams."

Dismas didn't respond immediately, his eyes lingering on a few stragglers making their way along the street. He could see it in their faces—their reverence, the hope mingled with desperation, each one carrying something they couldn't name. He wanted to turn away, to leave them to their faith, yet the ache of hunger gnawed at him, relentless and unavoidable.

"You're losing your edge, Dismas," Gestas sneered, his voice laced with mockery. "Thinking about what these people deserve? Or have you been spending too much time listening to these holy men?"

Dismas shot him a sharp look, but the words rang hollow. He knew they couldn't afford hesitation, not here. Not now. "Fine," he said finally, his tone resigned. "But we do this carefully. No risks, no show. We find someone who won't put up a fight."

Gestas grinned, scanning the crowd with a predator's eye. His gaze settled on a lone figure lingering by a fruit stall near the market's edge. The man was plainly dressed, his clothes travel-worn, his steps cautious. Clearly an outsider, alone and likely carrying what little money he had.

"There," Gestas murmured, his voice gleeful. "Perfect. A foreigner, probably weighed down with whatever he's got left from his journey."

Dismas felt a pang of guilt as he observed the man. There was something about him—an air of quiet that suggested he was not a hardened city dweller but a traveler, weary from the road. But Dismas' empty stomach forced him to silence his doubts, nodding curtly. "Quick and clean," he said. "In and out, no one's the wiser."

The two of them slipped through, inching closer to their target with the stealth of men who had long made shadows their allies. Gestas nudged Dismas, signaling that he'd take the lead. With a practiced step, he brushed against the man as if by accident, his hand reaching toward the small pouch at the man's belt.

But just as his fingers grazed the pouch, the man's hand clamped down on his wrist, iron-strong. The stranger's head

whipped around, his eyes narrowing as he stared directly into Gestas' startled face.

"What do you think you're doing?" The man's voice was low but firm, ringing out.

Gestas jerked back, his mask of confidence slipping into a flash of anger as he tried to pull away. Dismas grabbed his arm, his eyes looking around, noting the heads turning toward the disturbance. Panic flared in his chest as he saw the glint of Roman armor, the soldiers moving closer, drawn by the commotion.

"Run!" he hissed, tugging Gestas with him as they tried to slip back into the alleyway. But it was too late—the soldiers had already spotted them, their voices barking out commands as they closed in.

Rough hands grabbed Dismas and Gestas, dragging them to the ground as their protests were smothered beneath the unyielding force of Roman armor. The stranger stepped back, raising his hands in a gesture of innocence, but a soldier seized him as well, his face cold and devoid of mercy.

"I don't know these men!" the man protested, his voice tight with frustration. "I was the one they tried to rob!"

"Stand down!" barked the lead soldier, his voice slicing through the murmurs of the gathered.

The foreigner stood nearby, his hands raised in a defensive posture. "I have nothing to do with them!" he protested, his voice rising with frustration. "I was the one they tried to rob!"

But the soldiers' attention was already elsewhere. One of them pulled the foreigner toward the group, his grip firm despite the man's protests. "You'll explain yourself to the commander," the soldier said coldly, his expression betraying no sympathy.

Dismas clenched his teeth, his pulse racing as the soldiers hauled him to his feet. The crowd had pulled back now, their faces wary and curious, but none dared to interfere. He could

feel their eyes on him—condemning, pitying, or simply indifferent—as he and Gestas were dragged away.

The foreigner's voice reached his ears, tight with a blend of anger and helplessness. "I told you, I'm innocent! They tried to take from me!"

Dismas felt the words stab at his chest. For all their desperation, they had managed to drag someone else into their mess, someone who had nothing to do with their plight. Guilt swirled in him, though he tried to bury it under the familiar weight of resignation.

"Quiet," snapped one of the soldiers, his patience clearly worn.

Dismas said nothing, his gaze fixed on the ground as they were marched through the streets. The Roman barracks loomed ahead, its stone walls stark and unyielding against the darkening sky.

The barracks were dimly lit, the flickering torchlight reflecting off the cold stone walls and casting restless shadows. The three prisoners stood before Lucius, their shackled wrists clinking as they were shoved forward by the guards. Lucius' sharp eyes swept over them, his posture rigid, his face a mask of grim authority.

"You," Lucius said, his voice curt as he gestured to the foreigner. "Step forward."

The man hesitated but complied, his steps slow and deliberate. A soldier nudged him with the butt of a spear, urging him closer. Though his shoulders were squared, a flicker of unease showed in the tension of his expression.

Lucius studied him for a long moment, his eyes narrowing. "I recognize you," his voice calm but edged with suspicion. "You were in the market earlier today."

The man inclined his head, his tone measured but cautious. "Yes."

Lucius' gaze remained fixed on him. "And what are you doing here, then? Who are you?"

The man straightened slightly, his voice firm but restrained. "I am a pilgrim, here for the Passover."

Lucius' expression didn't shift, but there was a brief flicker of recognition in his eyes. "Your name?"

"Simon," the man replied, meeting Lucius' gaze steadily.

"And where are you from?" Lucius pressed.

"Cyrene," Simon answered, his tone unwavering.

Lucius' eyes lingered on him, weighing his words, before he gave a sharp nod to the guards. "Take him to the hallway. I'll deal with him later."

Simon's face tightened with protest, but he bit back his words. The guards grabbed him by the arms, leading him toward the door. He cast a glance at the two remaining prisoners, his face giving nothing away, before disappearing into the corridor.

Lucius' gaze locked onto Dismas and Gestas, his posture rigid as he stepped forward. The air in the room seemed to grow heavier, his presence bearing down on the two thieves with palpable intensity.

He halted in front of them, his expression hardening, his voice low and cutting. "You," he spoke, his tone laced with barely contained fury. "I know who you are. Barabbas' men."

Dismas stiffened, his shoulders instinctively pulling back, though his eyes stayed fixed on the ground. Gestas, in stark contrast, smirked, the crooked grin on his face radiating defiance.

Lucius stepped closer, his movements slow and deliberate, each step radiating his controlled anger. "The ambush outside the city," he hissed, his words cold and sharp. "You butchered my men like cattle. Loyal soldiers of Rome, slaughtered because of your treachery." His voice rose slightly, biting with

accusation. "Do you even remember their faces? Do you care about the lives you destroyed?"

Dismas shifted uncomfortably but stayed silent. Gestas laughed bitterly under his breath, the sound grating against the tense air.

"Barabbas is the one who matters," Gestas said, his tone mocking. "Why waste your breath on us?"

Lucius slammed a fist onto the table, his voice erupting like a thunderclap. "Because I want him!" he roared. "Barabbas led that slaughter, but he didn't swing every blade. You did. And you will tell me where he is."

Gestas' smirk widened. "And if we don't?"

Lucius' eyes burned with fury as he leaned closer, his voice dropping to a dangerous whisper. "If you don't, you'll die for the blood you spilled. But if you give me Barabbas, I might let you live long enough to regret your choices."

The words hung heavy in the open air. Gestas' grin faltered for the briefest moment, but he quickly masked it with a scoff. "Barabbas would gut us himself if we gave him up. You're wasting your time, Roman."

Lucius' gaze shifted to Dismas, his tone softening, though his intensity remained. "And you? Will you waste your life for a man who would abandon you in a heartbeat?"

Dismas hesitated. He could feel Gestas' eyes on him, the unspoken expectation to stay silent hanging like a noose. But Lucius' words gnawed at him, the offer lingering like a sliver of hope in the darkness.

"Barabbas doesn't care about you," Lucius continued, his voice quieter now, almost coaxing. "He didn't stop that ambush to save your life, and he won't spare a thought for you when you're gone. Is that the kind of man you want to die for?"

The silence stretched, suffocating in its weight. Dismas lowered his head, his shoulders sagging as he finally spoke,

his voice rough and low. "The eastern quarter," he grunted in a low voice. "Near the tannery."

Lucius straightened, his mouth twisting into a grim smile. He nodded to the guards. "Take them to the cells. Keep them under watch."

The soldiers moved to seize the two men. Dismas kept his gaze lowered, his shame evident in the defeated set of his posture, while Gestas' expression twisted into open contempt.

"Coward," Gestas spat, his voice dripping with venom as they were dragged away.

Lucius stood in silence, his satisfaction muted by the shadow of his losses. Turning toward the doorway, he caught sight of Simon lingering just beyond the corridor. Without a word, he strode purposefully into the hallway, the stillness of the barracks amplifying the soft scrape of his boots against the stone floor.

Inside the holding cell, the atmosphere was tense, the silence heavy. Dismas sat on a rough wooden bench, his hands resting loosely in his lap, his gaze distant. Gestas, unable to sit still, paced back and forth, the faint scrape of his movements against the stone floor breaking the oppressive quiet.

In the hallway just outside, Simon stood with his back against the wall. His hands hung loosely at his sides, but his shoulders were tight, his unease evident in the way his eyes flicked toward every sound. The soldiers who had escorted him earlier stood nearby, their postures relaxed but their watchful gazes sharp.

Inside the cell, Gestas let out a sharp, bitter laugh, breaking the stillness. "This is what it comes to, eh?" he said, spinning on his heel to face Dismas. "Locked up like dogs while Barabbas hides in some hole."

Dismas didn't reply, his focus still on the ground.

"I'm talking to you," Gestas snapped, his voice rising. "Don't pretend you're above this, Dismas. You've been running with me long enough to know exactly what we are."

"And what's that?" Dismas asked quietly, his tone flat.

"Survivors," Gestas said, spreading his arms as if proclaiming something grand. "We take what we need, we fight when we must, and we don't look back."

Dismas' lips pressed into a thin line. "Survivors, huh? Then why does it feel like we're dying by inches?"

Gestas laughed again, though there was no humor in it. "Because you're soft. You've been soft ever since that rabbi stared you down. You think his words are going to save you? You think anything will?"

Dismas looked up at Gestas, his expression calm but firm. "I think there's more to this than what we've been doing."

Gestas' eyes narrowed. "And what does that mean?"

Dismas didn't answer. Instead, he turned his gaze toward the cell door, his thoughts far away.

In the hallway, Simon shifted uncomfortably, the muffled sound of Gestas' rant carrying through the heavy wooden door. He glanced toward the guards, who remained impassive, their faces like stone. Simon let out a slow breath, leaning his head back against the cool wall.

The events of the day replayed in his mind—the commotion in the marketplace, the moment he'd caught Gestas' hand reaching for his belt, the swift and brutal arrival of the Roman soldiers. He'd come to Jerusalem seeking connection, seeking meaning. Instead, he'd been dragged into a chaos that was entirely unfamiliar.

The door to the holding cell opened suddenly, and a soldier stepped into the hallway, his eyes locking onto Simon.

"You," the soldier barked. "The commander wants you again."

Simon hesitated but nodded, his movements deliberate as he straightened and followed the soldier down the corridor. The sound of his footsteps echoed faintly against the stone, and though he kept his face calm, a knot of unease tightened in his chest.

Inside the cell, Gestas and Dismas fell silent, their gazes flicking toward the door as it clanged shut behind Simon.

The hallway was dimly lit, the torches casting unsteady light against the cool stone walls. Simon walked silently behind the soldier who had summoned him, his steps echoing faintly in the still air. His heart beat heavily in his chest, though his face betrayed little of the unease twisting within him.

They stopped at the doorway to a small chamber. The soldier opened it with a sharp motion, stepping aside to allow Simon through. Inside, Lucius stood by a wide wooden table, his hands braced against its surface. His expression was hard, his piercing gaze locking onto Simon the moment he entered.

Simon hesitated in the doorway, his eyes flicking briefly to the torches lining the walls before returning to Lucius.

“Step forward,” Lucius commanded, his voice sharp and precise.

Simon complied, moving carefully into the room. He stood a few paces from the table, his posture straight but unassuming.

Lucius’ gaze locked on him, a faint flicker of recognition crossing his face. “Simon of Cyrene,” he remarked, his tone calm but laced with pointed curiosity.

“You find yourself in the company of thieves and rebels,” he said coldly. “Not the most fitting place for a pilgrim seeking God, is it?”

Simon felt the sting of the words but kept his tone even. “I had no part in their actions,” he replied firmly. “I was in the market, going about my business, when they tried to rob me. That is all.”

Lucius tilted his head slightly, his expression thoughtful but no less stern. “Perhaps,” he stated in a near whisper, his voice low.

“But in this city, even being in the wrong place at the wrong time can carry consequences. You know what these men are accused of?”

Simon hesitated, then nodded. “Theft.”

“More than that,” Lucius said sharply. “The men you were with are not mere pickpockets. They’re followers of Barabbas, criminals responsible for the deaths of Roman soldiers. Murderers. And yet you expect me to believe you’re innocent, that your only crime was poor timing?”

“I am innocent,” Simon said firmly, meeting Lucius’ gaze without flinching. “I had nothing to do with their actions.”

Lucius held his gaze, the tension in the room thick enough to cut. Then, with a sharp exhale, Lucius stepped back, gesturing toward the door.

“Perhaps you are,” he remarked, his tone clipped. “For now, you will remain here. But know this, Simon of Cyrene—Jerusalem is not kind to those who cannot navigate its dangers. If you find yourself in the company of criminals again, your excuses may not save you.”

Simon inclined his head slightly, his expression neutral though his chest tightened with frustration.

Lucius turned to the soldier at the door. “Take him back to the hallway. He stays under watch until I have no further need of him.”

The soldier nodded, signaling Simon to follow. As he left the room, Simon’s steps remained steady, though his mind churned with the gravity of Lucius’ words.

Behind him, Lucius remained at the table, his expression tense as he turned his thoughts to Dismas and Gestas.

Act 2 - 06

Lucius

The streets of Jerusalem lay cloaked in shadows, the quiet of the night settling like a heavy shroud over the city. Moonlight glinted off the uneven cobblestones, lending a pale glow to the narrow alleys and arched doorways that wound through the eastern quarter. From somewhere in the distance came the faint murmur of voices and the occasional bark of a dog, but the streets themselves were deserted, the hustle of the day replaced by an uneasy stillness.

Lucius moved with purpose, his steps striking the stone in measured, deliberate steps. Behind him, a small detachment of Roman soldiers followed, their armor muted beneath dark cloaks, their weapons held close. The air smelled of dust and the faint acrid tang of tannery runoff, a scent that lingered like an unwelcome guest.

At his side, Marcellus, his second-in-command, kept pace, his hand resting lightly on the pommel of his sword. "The eastern quarter is quiet tonight," Marcellus murmured, his tone subdued, just loud enough for Lucius to hear.

"Too quiet," Lucius replied, his eyes scanning the shadows. "Barabbas likes to think he owns these streets, but every hiding place has its end."

They turned a corner, entering a narrower alley where the buildings loomed close, their darkened windows watching like hollow eyes. Lucius' memory of the city was sharp, each twist

and turn of its labyrinthine paths burned into his mind by years of patrols and raids.

Marcellus edged closer, his tone heavy with caution. "They say Barabbas has been moving between safehouses for weeks. Always one step ahead. This could be another trap."

Lucius' mouth tightened, the faintest twitch of a grim smile tugging at the corner of his lips. "Let him try. It won't save him."

Marcellus nodded but hesitated before speaking again. "He's slippery, that one. He's made fools of Rome before."

Lucius stopped and turned his head slightly, his expression cold and unwavering. "Not tonight."

His words lingered in the air, a quiet promise of the outcome he was determined to bring about. Lucius' thoughts wandered, unbidden, to the ambush the day before—his men sprawled lifeless in the dirt, their blood staining the earth. The images remained vivid, raw, like an unhealed wound, stoking the fire burning within him.

Barabbas. The name was more than a man now; it was a symbol, a thorn driven deep into the side of Rome's authority. His defiance had emboldened others, his rebellion sparking whispers of resistance in places Lucius had worked tirelessly to keep under control. But Lucius knew rebellion was like rot—if left unchecked, it would spread, undermining everything. Tonight, he would cut it out.

The detachment reached a small plaza, the open space bordered by low stone buildings. A single torch burned in a sconce by one of the doors, its light flickering weakly in the breeze. Lucius raised a hand, signaling a halt.

"Set the perimeter," he said quietly to Marcellus. The second-in-command nodded, motioning to the soldiers, who began moving with practiced precision, disappearing into the shadows to secure the exits.

Lucius' hand rested on the hilt of his gladius, his grip firm but steady. His eyes scanned the dimly lit surroundings, the lines of his face set with grim resolve.

"Barabbas' games end tonight," Lucius murmured to himself, his voice a low growl.

The tannery loomed ahead, a squat, unassuming building nestled in the heart of the eastern quarter. Its walls were streaked with grime and soot, the faint stench of treated hides clinging to the air like a warning. The narrow street leading to its entrance was lined with abandoned crates and barrels, their contents long since scavenged.

Lucius advanced slowly, his steps careful and deliberate, his hand never straying far from his weapon. Behind him, Marcellus and two other soldiers followed, their movements silent as they approached the darkened doorway. The faint glow of a lamp inside flickered through the cracks in the shutters, casting thin slivers of light into the gloom.

"This is the place," Marcellus whispered, his voice tight with anticipation.

Lucius didn't reply. He moved closer, his eyes narrowing as he studied the tannery. The silence around it was unnatural, a vacuum that pressed against his ears. He glanced over his shoulder, giving Marcellus a brief nod.

The soldiers moved into position, their shields held ready, their expressions grim. Lucius approached the door, his fingers curling around the handle. He pushed it open with deliberate force, the wooden hinges groaning in protest.

Inside, the room was dimly lit, the weak flame of an oil lamp casting long, uneven shadows along the walls. The smell of treated leather was stronger here, mingling with the metallic tang of sweat and steel.

Barabbas sat at a rough wooden table, hunched over a map spread out before him. His face was lit by the lamp's flickering glow, the shadows dancing across his sharp features. Two

men stood nearby, their hands resting on the hilts of their weapons, their postures tense.

Lucius stepped into the room, his presence commanding despite the confined space. Behind him, the soldiers fanned out, their movements slow and deliberate.

Barabbas looked up, his expression calm but sharp, his eyes glinting with something close to amusement. A faint smile tugged at his lips as he leaned back in his chair, spreading his arms in mock welcome.

“Well,” he drawled, his voice thick with disdain. “The wolf finds his way to the henhouse. To what do I owe the honor, Roman?”

Lucius didn’t reply immediately, his cold gaze sweeping over the room. His hand remained steady on his gladius, his expression hardening as his focus locked onto Barabbas.

“You’ve used this city long enough as your hiding ground,” Lucius said at last, his tone steady and resolute. “It’s done with you.”

Barabbas chuckled softly, the sound dark and humorless. “Is that what you tell yourself to sleep at night?”

Lucius stepped forward, his presence filling the room. “We’ll see how much sleep you get when this is over,” he said, his voice carrying a dangerous edge.

The room grew still, the tension coiling tight as both men stared each other down, their words a prelude to the inevitable clash.

Barabbas rose slowly from his seat, the scraping of the wooden chair against the stone floor a jarring sound in the tense stillness. His posture was relaxed, almost casual, but there was a sharpness in his gaze, a readiness coiled beneath the surface like a spring wound too tight.

"You Romans always talk like you own the world," Barabbas said, his voice dripping with mockery. "But let me ask you, Lucius, what good is an empire when its people are starving?"

Lucius didn't flinch. He held his ground, his gladius resting lightly in its scabbard. "You think starving them further with your rebellion will fix that?" he asked, his voice cold. "Rome brings order, Barabbas. Your chaos only breeds suffering."

Barabbas laughed, low and bitter, the sound breaking through the dim room like a blade. "Order? Is that what you call the heel grinding us into the dust? The taxes bleeding our families dry? Don't preach to me about order, Roman."

Lucius' expression remained steady, though tension flickered briefly across his features. "Rome has given this city more than it could ever repay. Roads. Laws. Stability. You rebel not for the people, but for your pride."

Barabbas leaned forward, his eyes flashing with fire. "Pride?" he snarled. "Is that what you think this is about? Look around you, Lucius. Do you see the lines of hungry men? The children without fathers? I've fought for every one of them while you've sat in your barracks tallying your conquests and calling it peace."

Lucius took a step closer, his tone quiet and unwavering, but the steel beneath it unmistakable. "What you've done," he said, "is spill blood that can't be washed away. You speak of freedom as if it's a cure, but what you've brought is chaos—and it will die here with you."

Barabbas shook his head, a faint, humorless smile crossing his lips. "You don't understand loyalty, Roman. These people don't fight for me because I force them. They fight because they see a life worth dying for. Can you say the same for your men?"

Lucius' gladius was out in an instant, the blade catching the lamplight with a cold gleam. His voice, low and edged with steel, cut through the rising chaos. "This ends now."

Barabbas didn't hesitate. His hand went to his belt, drawing a short blade, its edge nicked and worn but no less dangerous. The two men stood still for a heartbeat, the room crackling with tension, before Barabbas lunged.

Their blades met with a metallic ring, the force of the clash reverberating through the small space. Lucius moved with precision, his strikes calculated and deliberate, while Barabbas fought like a man possessed, each swing wild but driven by a fierce determination.

Around them, the soldiers clashed with Barabbas' men, the room erupting into chaos. The narrow confines of the tannery became a whirlwind of bodies and steel, grunts of exertion mingling with the sharp cries of pain as blades found their marks.

Lucius forced Barabbas back step by step, his movements controlled, his training evident in every thrust and parry. But Barabbas was relentless, his strikes fueled by sheer will.

With a sudden twist, Lucius forced Barabbas' blade aside, driving him back against the wall. Barabbas' chest heaved, but his defiance burned as brightly as ever.

Lucius pressed forward, his gladius poised. "This is the end, Barabbas," he declared, his tone cold and unyielding. "Yield, and I may grant you a quick death."

Barabbas laughed through ragged breaths, the sound more a growl than a chuckle. "I die on my feet, not in chains," he snarled.

The soldiers, their fight with Barabbas' men now ending in a decisive Roman victory, circled closer. Two of Barabbas' men lay dead, their blood pooling on the stone floor. A third groaned softly, clutching a deep wound in his side.

Barabbas' blade trembled slightly in his grip, his strength waning but his resolve unbroken. He lunged again, his movements slower now but no less fierce. Lucius sidestepped the attack, bringing the hilt of his gladius down hard against Barabbas' wrist. The rebel's blade clattered to the floor.

In a heartbeat, two soldiers seized Barabbas, forcing him to his knees. He struggled briefly, but the fight had gone out of him, his shoulders slumping as he was pinned in place.

Lucius stepped closer, his shadow falling over Barabbas. "Your rebellion is through," he stated, his voice cold and unyielding.

Barabbas lifted his head, his lips twisting into a faint smile. "The rebellion," he rasped, "is just beginning."

Lucius motioned to the soldiers. "Bind him. Take him to the barracks. Let's see if he's still so bold under a Roman lash."

The soldiers obeyed, tightening the ropes around Barabbas' wrists and hauling him to his feet. His defiance didn't waver, though his face twisted briefly in pain as the bonds bit into his skin.

The streets of Jerusalem were silent as Lucius and his soldiers marched Barabbas through the narrow alleys. The faint glow of the moon lit their path, the shadows stretching long behind them.

Barabbas' men who survived the skirmish were left behind, bound and awaiting the Roman patrols to collect them. The responsibility of victory pressed on Lucius' shoulders, but his expression remained stoic as they continued on their way.

Marcellus walked at his side, his voice low. "Do you think this will make a difference?"

Lucius didn't answer immediately. His eyes remained fixed ahead, his thoughts churning. "It's not for us to question," he said at last. "Rome doesn't tolerate rebellion. What happens next is for the people to decide."

Barabbas chuckled softly, his voice hoarse but cutting. "The people have already decided, Commander. You just don't see it yet."

Lucius' expression grew thoughtful, but he didn't respond. The procession continued, the quiet of the night broken only by the sound of their footsteps echoing off the stone.

As they neared the barracks, the gates rose before them, their iron bars glinting softly under the pale moonlight. Lucius felt the heaviness of the night pressing down on him, Barabbas' words lingering in his thoughts like an unwelcome echo that refused to fade.

"Lock him up," Lucius ordered as they entered. "Double the guard. No one speaks to him without my permission."

The soldiers led Barabbas away, his defiant gaze lingering on Lucius until he disappeared into the dim corridors of the prison.

Lucius stood for a moment in the courtyard, his gladius still at his side. He closed his eyes briefly, the memory of Barabbas' mocking smile flashing behind his lids. The rebellion had been stopped tonight, but for how long?

Act 2 - 07

Simon

The corridor stretched before Simon like an endless void, cold and unyielding. The rough stone walls seemed to press inward, their chill seeping into his bones despite the torchlight flickering faintly overhead. Shadows wavered on the uneven surfaces, creating a shifting tapestry of jagged lines and indistinct shapes, as though the walls themselves conspired to deepen his sense of unease.

He leaned back against the unforgiving surface, his head resting lightly on the stone, his eyes fixed on the ground. How had it come to this? When he set out for Jerusalem, his heart had been light, his purpose clear. He had traveled for the Passover to affirm his faith and connect him to something greater. Yet now, that sense of connection felt frayed, tangled in the harsh reality of a city straining under the weight of too many bodies, too many hopes, and too many whispered fears.

Simon sighed, his breath visible in the cool air of the corridor. He thought of Cyrene, of the familiar rhythms of life there: the soft hum of the market in the mornings, the golden light that bathed the fields, and the comforting laughter of his children playing outside their small home. In Cyrene, his faith was a constant—a quiet but steady force that carried him through the mundane trials of life.

Here in Jerusalem, though, faith felt like a fragile thing, tested and strained at every turn. The streets that should have been welcoming were choked with tensions he could neither see nor understand. The city buzzed with voices—some joyous, some

angry, and some carrying the unmistakable edge of desperation.

The day had been chaotic, a blur of faces, sounds, and moments that Simon couldn't fully piece together. He had only tried to find his way through the market, to gather what he needed for his stay, and yet somehow he had ended up here, tangled in Roman authority and thrown into a world of violence and lawlessness that was entirely foreign to him.

His fingers brushed the stone bench beneath him, rough and cold, grounding him as his thoughts threatened to spiral. How could something as simple as a pilgrimage turn so wrong? Simon was a man of order, of routine, yet Jerusalem seemed to defy both, pulling him into its chaos.

The silence around him grew heavier, settling over the corridor like a thick fog. He closed his eyes, trying to steady himself, to draw comfort from the faith that had always been his anchor. But even that felt distant now, dulled by the cold stone and the oppressive weight of his situation. For the first time since he had arrived, Simon felt utterly alone.

The oppressive silence shattered, replaced by the sharp clanking of metal against stone. Simon's eyes flew open, his head snapping up as the sounds grew louder—a heavy, deliberate rhythm that echoed through the corridor.

He straightened, his body instinctively tense as the voices of soldiers drifted toward him, harsh and clipped. Their words were indistinct, but the tone was unmistakable—commands barked with the authority of men accustomed to being obeyed.

And then he saw them.

A group of soldiers emerged from the far end of the corridor, their armor catching the faint light of the torches, their movements measured and purposeful. At their center was a man—bound, bloodied, and unmistakably dangerous.

Barabbas.

Simon had heard his name whispered in the streets, carried like a shadow that lurked in every corner of the city. The rebel leader. The man who defied Rome with a ferocity that seemed almost mythic. He had been a figure of stories to Simon, a distant symbol of the chaos that simmered beneath Jerusalem's surface. But now, seeing him in flesh and blood, Simon felt a chill creep up his spine.

Barabbas was tall and broad-shouldered, his frame diminished but not broken by the chains that bound him. His clothes were torn and filthy, streaked with grime and dried blood. A bruise darkened one side of his face, and a cut above his brow left a faint trail of crimson that had dried into a jagged line. Yet despite his battered appearance, his presence was undeniable.

There was a wildness to him, a raw energy that radiated outward, filling the corridor with a suffocating weight. His steps were uneven, his movements forced by the soldiers' rough shoves, but his head remained high, his gaze fixed straight ahead.

Simon watched, unable to look away, as the soldiers dragged Barabbas closer. The man's face was a mask of fury and resolve, his eyes dark and unyielding. There was no fear in those eyes, only defiance—a burning fire that refused to be extinguished, even in chains.

As Barabbas stumbled, one of the soldiers shoved him hard, nearly driving him to his knees. A low growl escaped his throat, but he did not fall. Instead, he straightened, the iron cuffs biting into his wrists as he turned his head slightly, his lips curling into a sneer.

And then, as if drawn by some unseen force, Barabbas' gaze locked onto Simon.

Simon felt his chest tighten, as if the air had been drawn out of the corridor. Barabbas' eyes, dark and piercing, bore into him with an intensity that hit like a physical blow. It wasn't mere anger—though anger simmered beneath the surface—it was something deeper. It carried the impact of a thousand battles fought and lost, the mark of a life forged in unyielding defiance.

The moment stretched, each heartbeat loud in Simon's ears. He felt naked under that gaze, his own thoughts and fears laid bare in a way that made him want to recoil. Barabbas didn't blink, didn't flinch. His stare was unyielding, unrelenting, as though daring Simon to look away first.

Simon's fingers dug into the bench as he fought to steady himself. He felt like a child caught in a storm, overwhelmed and powerless, yet unable to flee. Barabbas' eyes held him in place, a silent command that he couldn't disobey.

And then, as quickly as it began, the moment was over.

The soldiers dragged Barabbas past, his chains rattling as he stumbled forward. His gaze broke away from Simon's, redirecting to the path ahead, and the spell was broken. But the impression remained, a scar burned into Simon's mind.

And yet, beneath the fury and defiance, there had been something else, something Simon couldn't name. A burden, perhaps, or a pain too deep to be hidden behind Barabbas' sneer. It unsettled Simon, the realization that even a man like Barabbas—so hardened, so wild—might carry a weight he couldn't set down.

He let out a slow breath, his mind flickering to memories of his life in Cyrene. There, everything had been simpler. The struggles of daily life, though real, were manageable. He had been surrounded by family, friends, and the quiet rhythms of a life lived in peace.

Here, in Jerusalem, that peace felt impossibly far away. This city, with its crowded streets and constant tensions, had thrust him into a world he didn't understand—a world of rebellion and violence, of men like Barabbas who seemed to thrive in chaos.

The memory of Barabbas' eyes stirred something strange in Simon. It wasn't sympathy, exactly, nor was it anger. It was an unease that settled deep in his chest, a feeling he couldn't quite name but couldn't shake.

The corridor seemed quieter now, though the echoes of Barabbas' chains lingered overhead. Simon let out a shaky

breath, his hands trembling slightly as he rubbed them together. He felt as though he'd been standing on a precipice, staring into a chasm that threatened to swallow him whole.

Barabbas. The name had been a whisper in the marketplace, a shadow that loomed over the city. Simon had dismissed it, thinking of the rebel leader as nothing more than a common criminal, a troublemaker stirring unrest for reasons Simon didn't care to understand.

But seeing him now, Simon realized how wrong he'd been.

Barabbas was no mere criminal. He was a force, a presence that demanded attention. Even bound and bloodied, he carried himself with an authority that appeared to defy the chains that held him. Simon had seen proud men before, men who carried themselves with confidence, but Barabbas was something else entirely.

There was a fire in him, a raw and uncontrollable energy that filled the corridor even after he was gone. It wasn't just defiance—it was conviction, the unshakable belief in something larger than himself.

Simon's thoughts churned, each more unsettling than the last. What kind of man chose such a path? What had Barabbas seen, endured, to become who he was? And what gave him the strength to defy Rome, to hold his head high even while bound in iron?

Simon felt a strange mixture of fear and fascination. He wanted to reject Barabbas, to condemn the violence and chaos he represented. But a part of him couldn't help but wonder if there was something noble in that defiance, a strength Simon couldn't comprehend.

The corridor was still now, save for the faint flicker of torchlight casting restless shadows on the walls. But Simon's thoughts churned, restless and unresolved. He sat with his elbows on his knees, his head in his hands, trying to process the strange, heavy feelings that Barabbas' presence had stirred in him.

He thought of the life he had left behind—a life of peace, simplicity, and untested faith. In Cyrene, Simon had known who he was: a husband, a father, a man of quiet labor and quiet devotion. That world had been small but steady, untouched by the storms that seemed as though they raged endlessly in Jerusalem.

Here, everything felt precarious. The streets were thick with tension, the air heavy with murmurs of rebellion and unrest. Faith, once a steadfast foundation, now seemed like a fragile thread, stretched to its breaking point by the strain of all he had witnessed.

And then there was Barabbas.

Simon hated the way Barabbas had made him feel—small, powerless, as though his entire life had been insignificant. Yet he couldn't dismiss the strength in the man, the unyielding defiance that stood unbroken even subjected to Rome's crushing power.

For the first time, Simon wondered if his own life had been too small, too safe. Had he been content to live without questioning the greater forces at work, sheltering in the shadow of something larger? And if so, was that wrong?

The thought unsettled him. He didn't want Barabbas' life—didn't want to carry the darkness and fury that seemed to drive the man. But he couldn't ignore the feeling that something within him was shifting, as if the life he had known was slipping away, leaving him on the brink of something he didn't yet understand.

He sat in silence, the gravity of the moment pressing down on him. The corridor was cold, the torchlight dim, but Simon barely noticed. His mind was far away, caught between the comforting certainty of the past and the chaotic unknown of what lay ahead.

And as he sat there, Simon knew one thing with certainty: no matter what happened next, there was no going back.

The sound of measured footsteps echoed in the corridor, jolting Simon from his thoughts. He looked up to see a group of soldiers returning, their faces grim and their movements brisk. At the center of the group was Lucius, his expression as sharp and unreadable as ever.

Simon stiffened instinctively as Lucius' gaze swept the corridor, pausing briefly on him before moving on. The Roman commander carried himself with an air of authority that made the air in the hallway feel heavier, and Simon felt the heaviness of it settle over him.

Lucius exchanged brief words with one of the guards, his tone low but firm. Simon couldn't make out the words, but the soldier nodded and stepped aside, giving Lucius a clear path to the cell where Barabbas had been taken.

The commander's presence seemed to command silence, the corridor growing quieter as even the soldiers lowered their voices. Simon watched as Lucius disappeared into the shadows, his steps purposeful and unhurried.

Simon's heart pounded in his chest, though he didn't understand why. He had no connection to Barabbas, no stake in the rebellion that had brought him here. Yet he couldn't shake the feeling that something important was happening, something that would ripple far beyond the confines of this cold, stone hallway.

The sound of Lucius' voice carried faintly through the corridor, though the words were too muffled to make out. Simon strained to hear, but the stone walls absorbed most of the sound, leaving only the occasional sharp note.

He leaned back against the wall, his mind racing. Barabbas had been captured, his rebellion struck a heavy blow. But Simon couldn't escape the sense that this wasn't the end. Men like Barabbas didn't fade quietly into the shadows—they left marks, scars that lingered long after they were gone.

The minutes stretched into an eternity, the stillness in the corridor growing heavier with each passing moment. Simon sat

in silence, his thoughts churning, as the burden of the day settled over him.

Barabbas was behind bars, but his presence still filled the air. Simon could feel it pressing against him, a reminder of the forces at play in this city—forces he didn't understand and wasn't sure he wanted to.

Simon pictured his wife's face, her warm smile as she tended to their children. He imagined the sound of the sea, the way the waves lapped gently against the shore, bringing a rhythm to life that felt timeless and unshakable.

But even as he clung to those memories, they felt distant, like a dream fading in the harsh light of day. Here in Jerusalem, nothing felt timeless or unshakable. The city was a storm, a swirling chaos of voices and tensions that seemed ready to explode at any moment.

What was his place in all of this? He was a pilgrim, a man of peace, and yet he had been drawn into the orbit of men like Barabbas, men who carried the load of rebellion and defiance like a banner.

Simon opened his eyes, his gaze fixed on the torches flickering along the corridor. He didn't know what tomorrow would bring, but he felt a stirring deep within him—a sense that the path ahead would not lead him back to the life he had known.

Act 2 - 08

Simon

Simon sat slumped on the rough stone bench, his back pressed against the cold wall of the dim hallway. The torches sputtered in their iron brackets, casting flickering shadows that seemed to creep along the walls like silent spectators to his discomfort. His wrists were red and raw from the coarse rope that had bound him, his muscles stiff from a night spent on the unyielding surface. The faint murmurs of Roman soldiers echoed through the barracks—orders barked, the rhythmic clink of armor—reminding him that he was still very much in their grip.

This was not the Jerusalem he had envisioned when he began his pilgrimage. He had dreamed of peace, a sacred stillness where faith might feel tangible and unshakable. Instead, he had walked into a storm—a city on edge, its streets brimming with unease. The air felt oppressive, not with holiness, but with fear and fury, as though the stones themselves carried the encumbrance of a thousand unsaid prayers. Even free of his bonds, Simon could not escape the deeper confinement—the feeling that he was caught in something far greater than himself, something he could neither understand nor control.

The sound of approaching footsteps pulled him from his thoughts. He looked up to see a young Roman soldier striding down the corridor toward him. The man's expression was impassive, his steps sharp and precise. He carried himself with the kind of rigid authority that Simon had come to expect from the occupiers.

The soldier stopped before him, his tone curt. "On your feet. You're free to go."

Simon didn't move, unsure if he had heard correctly. Free? The word loomed like a fragile thing, its promise almost too

good to trust. Slowly, he rose, his legs protesting the motion after hours of stillness. He stretched cautiously, the ache in his shoulders a dull reminder of the previous day's humiliations.

The soldier gave him a once-over, his gaze hard and indifferent. "Stay out of trouble," he offered in a hushed tone, his voice carrying a warning that left no room for interpretation.

Simon nodded, murmuring a soft, "Thank you," though he doubted the man cared for gratitude.

The soldier turned on his heel and began to walk away, motioning for Simon to follow. They moved through the labyrinthine corridors of the barracks, the cold stone walls and narrow passageways amplifying every sound. Simon's footsteps echoed dully, his sandals scuffing against the floor as he tried to shake off the lingering unease of captivity.

When they reached the main entrance, the soldier paused and glanced at Simon, his face betraying no emotion. Then, with a grunt, he pulled open the heavy wooden door. A sharp flood of sunlight spilled into the space, momentarily blinding Simon as his eyes adjusted to the sudden brightness.

Simon stepped outside, his breath catching as the cool morning air touched his skin. He simply stood there, letting the light and the sounds of the city wash over him. He closed his eyes, inhaling deeply, hoping the crisp air would carry away the heaviness of the past day.

But the relief he sought did not come.

Jerusalem was alive, but not in the way he had imagined. The streets buzzed with an energy that felt more volatile than festive. Pilgrims and merchants moved through the narrow alleys, their voices weaving a tapestry of languages and dialects, yet there was an edge to their movements, an urgency that set his nerves on edge. The Passover crowds, meant to celebrate liberation, instead seemed burdened by something darker, something unspoken that lingered like a storm cloud over the city.

As Simon descended the steps of the barracks, he heard snippets of conversations that prickled at the edges of his awareness.

"They've taken him to Pilate," one man said, his voice heavy with trepidation.

"Who?" came another, curious but wary.

"Jesus. The Nazarene. The prophet who heals."

Simon's steps slowed, his ears straining to catch more.

"They say he called himself the Son of God," murmured a woman nearby, her tone hushed as though afraid the very words might bring judgment upon her. "The priests have brought him to be judged."

Simon's heart quickened, though he didn't fully understand why. Just the day before, he had stood among the crowds, watching this man—Jesus—as he taught. His words had been unlike any Simon had heard before, cutting through the noise of the market with a clarity that left him unsettled.

Tales of miracles, of healings, of a preacher who spoke with authority, had followed Simon on his journey to Jerusalem, whispered in hushed tones by travelers and pilgrims. Those stories had felt distant, like fragments of legend. Yet now, hearing his name spoken in the midst of this chaos, the man felt startlingly real, his presence heavy with a gravity Simon couldn't shake.

The city around him seemed to press closer, the noise rising as he moved deeper into the streets. Pilgrims gathered in clusters, their faces a mix of fear, awe, and confusion.

"My cousin saw him heal a blind man," a voice said behind him.

"Blasphemy," someone else hissed. "He calls himself the Messiah. He forgives sins! Only God can forgive sins!"

Simon's steps faltered as the overwhelming sense of their words sank in. He wanted to leave, to escape the thickening tension, but his feet refused to carry him away. Instead, he found himself drifting toward the current of people heading in one direction, their faces turned toward the looming walls of The Palace of Pilate.

Above the crowd, he caught sight of the governor's palace—a structure that radiated power and authority, its stone walls stark against the pale morning sky. Simon's stomach tightened as he realized where his steps were leading him. He didn't belong here, didn't want to be swept into whatever judgment was unfolding within those walls. And yet, something pulled at him, a strange, unnamable force that kept him moving forward.

"Stay out of trouble," the soldier had said. The words echoed in his mind, but they felt distant now, almost irrelevant in the face of the growing tension that loomed.

Simon paused at the crowd, his heart pounding. He had come to Jerusalem seeking clarity, a renewal of faith. Instead, he found himself drawn into the swirling chaos of a city on the brink, caught between whispers of miracles and the roar of condemnation.

And somewhere, at the heart of it all, was the man they called Jesus.

The streets narrowed as Simon pushed deeper into the city, the press of bodies growing denser with each step. Voices rose and fell in waves, creating a cacophony that reverberated off the stone walls. Merchants shouted halfheartedly to sell their wares, but their usual vigor was tempered by the palpable tension in the atmosphere. The city felt on edge, like a bowstring pulled taut, ready to snap.

Simon kept his head low, weaving through clusters of pilgrims who clung together, their conversations hushed and heavy. The word "Jesus" hung in the air, carried on murmurs that passed from one person to the next like the ripple of a stone cast into still water.

“He’s before Pilate now,” a woman whispered to her companion, her voice trembling. “The priests want him condemned.”

Another man, his face lined with age and weariness, shook his head. “I heard he healed a man’s withered hand,” he said quietly. “And cast out demons. What kind of threat is he to Rome?”

Simon paused, his ears straining to catch the exchange as the two moved past him.

“The priests say he blasphemed,” the woman countered. “Claimed he could destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days. Can you imagine? Such arrogance.”

Simon frowned, his brow furrowing as he absorbed their words. The temple—a symbol of faith, of unity, of identity for an entire people. The very idea of its destruction was unthinkable. Yet, as unsettling as the claim was, it didn’t align with the stories of compassion and healing that had surrounded the name Jesus.

The gathering surged again, pulling Simon along its currents. He glanced up, catching glimpses of the towering palace of Pontius Pilate ahead. The sprawling structure loomed over the gathered masses, its imposing walls casting long shadows that swallowed the crowd whole. Roman soldiers stood at attention along the parapets, their silhouettes sharp against the morning sky. Below, the courtyard teemed with people—pilgrims, merchants, Pharisees, and others whose faces were alight with a mix of anticipation and dread.

Simon found himself drawn toward the edges of the onlookers, where the conversations grew sharper, more pointed.

“This Jesus claims to be the King of the Jews,” a young man said, his voice tinged with scorn. “Doesn’t he understand what happens to those who challenge Rome?”

“And yet,” an older woman said, her expression grave, “he carries no sword. He speaks of peace, of turning the other cheek. Is that the way of a king?”

A man with a trader's pouch slung over his shoulder snorted. "A king who rides into Jerusalem on a donkey. He's no king. He's a fool—or worse, a liar."

Simon pressed his lips together, his unease deepening as the conflicting voices surrounded him. He had no desire to linger, no interest in being caught up in the fervor, yet his feet remained rooted to the ground. He couldn't ignore the tension that rippled through the way the people seemed to oscillate between hope and fury.

Ahead, the murmur of voices grew louder as the Pharisees moved through the throng like dark specters. Their robes, ornate and pristine, stood in stark contrast to the dusty, travel-worn garments of the pilgrims. They moved with purpose, their expressions grim, their eyes scanning the crowd as though searching for dissenters.

"Blasphemer," one Pharisee intoned, his voice carrying over the din. "He dares to call himself the Son of God, to forgive sins as if he were the Almighty Himself."

They responded with a mixture of gasps and murmurs. Some nodded in agreement, their faces hardening with indignation. Others looked troubled, their expressions flickering with doubt or sorrow.

Simon clenched his fists, his heart pounding as he watched the Pharisees sway the masses with their words. He thought of the stories he'd heard—of blind men receiving sight, of lepers healed, of the hungry fed. Could the man capable of such acts truly be guilty of the crimes they accused him of? Or was he being condemned for something far more elusive, something that challenged the fragile power of those who now sought to destroy him?

As the crowd surged forward, Simon was caught in the tide. He stumbled slightly, his sandals scraping against the stone as the masses pushed him closer to the courtyard. He wanted to turn away, to flee, to the quiet streets where he could find some semblance of peace, but he couldn't. Something held him there, tethered to this moment, to this man he had never met yet couldn't escape.

Above the spectators, the banners of Rome fluttered in the breeze, a stark reminder of the power that loomed over Jerusalem. And yet, as Simon looked around, he realized that the true power here was not the soldiers or the Pharisees or even Pilate himself. It was the masses—their voices, their anger, their collective will. And that power terrified him.

Simon found himself drawn closer to the base of the stairs leading to the courtyard wall, where Pontius Pilate stood. The Roman governor, clad in the finery of imperial authority, had taken his place on a raised platform above the crowd. His face bore the weary look of a man who had seen too much of this city's chaos, his features etched with disdain for the people beneath him.

Yet, despite his imposing presence, there was an unease in Pilate's posture. He shifted in his chair, his gaze flickering between the priests gathered to his right and the restless mob below. His hands gripped the arms of his chair as though holding himself in place, resisting the push and pull of forces that sought to move him.

Simon watched as the high priests stepped forward, their robes billowing like storm clouds as they approached Pilate. Caiaphas, the high priest, was at their head, his expression sharp with purpose. He gestured toward the bound figure of Jesus, who stood slightly to Pilate's left, his hands tied, his face calm and resolute despite the storm raging around him.

"This man," Caiaphas began, his voice rising over the din within the masses, "has claimed to be the Son of God. He has stirred the people with his false teachings, sowing dissent against Rome and against our laws. He is a blasphemer and a threat to order."

The crowd murmured, their voices swelling like waves. Simon craned his neck, catching sight of Jesus. His face, though marred by exhaustion and the beginnings of bruises, held a strange serenity. His eyes, steady and unflinching, seemed to pierce through the noise, locking onto something beyond the chaos.

Pilate raised a hand, silencing them as he turned his attention to the priests. His voice, though calm, carried an edge of impatience. “You bring this man to me, accusing him of crimes against your laws. Yet you also claim he threatens Rome. Which is it?”

The question loomed, a challenge that momentarily unsettled Caiaphas. But the high priest recovered quickly, his voice unwavering. “He claims to be a king,” he said. “If that is not a threat to Caesar, I do not know what is.”

A ripple of murmurs ran through the crowd. Simon caught snippets of their conversations, the words “king” and “treason” rising and falling like the tides.

Pilate leaned forward slightly, his eyes narrowing as he studied Jesus. “Is this true?” he asked, his tone skeptical. “Do you claim to be the king of the Jews?”

Jesus lifted his gaze, meeting Pilate’s eyes without hesitation. His voice, when he spoke, was calm and steady, carrying an authority that seemed out of place for a man in chains. “You say that I am a king,” he said. “For this purpose I was born, and for this purpose I have come into the world—to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice.”

Simon felt a chill run down his spine. The words seemed to hang suspended, defying the noise among the bystanders, the tension of the soldiers, even the heaviness of Pilate’s authority.

Pilate frowned, leaning back in his chair as though retreating from the force of Jesus’ presence. “What is truth?” he whispered softly, almost to himself. His words lacked conviction, as though he had already abandoned the question before it had fully formed.

The crowd, impatient and agitated, began to stir once more. Voices rose, hurling accusations and demands, their collective anger teetering on the edge of chaos. Pilate raised his hand again, though the tension in his expression betrayed his mounting frustration.

"I find no fault in this man," Pilate declared, his voice breaking through the clamor with measured authority.

The words rippled through the crowd like a jolt. The priests bristled, their anger flashing in their eyes as they pressed forward again.

"He incites the people," Caiaphas countered sharply. "From Galilee to Jerusalem, he has stirred them against the established order. He is a threat—to Rome and to us alike."

Pilate's expression shifted, a flicker of relief crossing his face. "Galilee, you say?" he asked. "Then he falls under Herod's jurisdiction." He rose from his seat, gesturing to the soldiers. "Take him to Herod. Let him decide this matter."

The crowd erupted in confusion, their voices blending into a chaotic roar. Some shouted in protest, others in support, but all of it felt like noise to Simon. He watched as the soldiers moved to escort Jesus away, their hands rough as they pushed him forward.

Simon's heart ached as he saw Jesus' calm demeanor, the quiet strength that seemed unbroken despite the indignities heaped upon him. He wanted to turn away, to flee from the tension and anger that surrounded him, but something held him in place. He couldn't shake the feeling that he was witnessing something far greater than himself, something that would leave a mark on the city—and on him.

As the soldiers led Jesus out of sight, Pilate turned his attention shifting to the priests, his frustration evident. "This is your doing," he said, his tone steady but edged with irritation. "You bring this man to me, demanding judgment, yet offer nothing but contradictions. If Herod finds him guilty, it will be on your heads."

Caiaphas' expression darkened, but he said nothing. The priests turned, retreating into the crowd as Pilate waved a hand, dismissing them.

Simon felt the gravity of the moment settle over him like a heavy cloak. The air was thick with tension, the crowd

teetering on chaos. He glanced around, his gaze lingering on the faces of those around him—some filled with anger, others with sorrow, but all marked by the same restless energy.

For the first time, Simon realized the depth of the division within the crowd. This wasn't just about Jesus or the priests or even Rome. It was about something far deeper—something that touched the very soul of the city itself.

Act 2 - 09

Lucius

Lucius strode through the wide stone hall of the Roman barracks, each step deliberate, the rhythmic sound of his movement echoing faintly off the high walls. The light of dawn had just begun to creep through the narrow windows, painting the gray stone with thin streaks of pale gold. The barracks felt colder than usual, the morning chill clinging to the air—or perhaps it was the oppression of the night that lingered, a heaviness that even Lucius' disciplined mind could not completely dispel.

He had not slept. Instead, the hours before dawn had been consumed by the aftermath of Barabbas' capture, the interrogations, and the tense energy that hung over the city like a storm cloud. Jerusalem was restless, seething beneath the surface with an unease that Lucius could feel looming.

Ahead of him, Marius stood near a narrow window, his back to the room. The commander's figure was still, his posture as rigid and unyielding as the marble statues that lined the halls of Rome's great temples. Through the window, the faint sounds of soldiers in the courtyard drifted in—shouted commands, the clash of training swords, the steady rhythm of disciplined movement. It was a sound Lucius had heard a thousand times before, one that should have comforted him with its familiarity. But today, it felt hollow.

Lucius stopped a few paces away and saluted, his right fist thumping against his breastplate in a gesture that was as much muscle memory as it was respect.

"Sir," he uttered, his voice low but steady.

Marius did not turn immediately. He remained motionless, his hands clasped behind his back, his gaze fixed on the courtyard below. The silence lingered, filling the hall with a tension that looked like it grew heavier with each passing second.

Finally, Marius spoke, his voice deep and contemplative. "Jerusalem," he murmured, the word carrying an almost bitter weight. "This city... it is like a sea before a storm."

Lucius shifted slightly, his brow furrowing at the cryptic remark. He wasn't sure how to respond, so he remained silent, waiting for Marius to elaborate.

Marius turned his head just enough for Lucius to see his profile, the sharp lines of his face cast in shadow by the slanting light. "Do you feel it, Lucius?" he asked, his tone almost accusatory. "The tension in the air? The way the streets hum with it, as if the city itself is holding its breath?"

Lucius nodded stiffly. "The city has been restless for days, sir," he said. "But the men are prepared."

"Prepared," Marius echoed, the word carrying a faint note of skepticism. He turned fully now, his dark eyes locking onto Lucius with an intensity that made the younger man instinctively straighten. "Tell me, Lucius—what does it mean to be 'prepared' for chaos? For rebellion? For the collapse of order?"

Lucius' tone steadied. "It means we hold the line, sir. We enforce the law. We maintain control."

Marius studied him for a long moment, his gaze sharp and penetrating. "And do you believe that will be enough?" he asked quietly.

Lucius hesitated. The question loomed like a blade poised to strike. "It will have to be enough," Lucius said at last, his voice firm despite the flicker of uncertainty that gnawed at the edges of his mind.

Marius' expression didn't change, but there was something in his eyes—a flicker of doubt, or perhaps pity. "Jerusalem is not

like other cities, Lucius," he said, his tone softer now. "Its people do not bow as easily as others. They hold to something we cannot touch, something that does not break under the force of swords or taxes. And that makes them dangerous."

Lucius inclined his head, acknowledging the point without fully agreeing. "Dangerous, yes," he said. "But not invincible. Barabbas will hang for his crimes, and this... Nazarene will face judgment like any other man."

Marius' lips curved into a faint, humorless smile. "You speak as though you believe judgment is in our hands," he said.

Lucius frowned, unsure how to respond.

Marius returned to the window, his gaze sweeping over the courtyard once more. Below, the soldiers continued their drills, their movements precise and practiced, yet there was an undercurrent of tension even among them. Lucius could see it in the stiffness of their shoulders, the way they gripped their weapons just a little tighter than usual.

"The mob outside grows by the hour," Marius said, his tone quiet but laced with steel. "They call for blood but what matters is the release it brings. The illusion of control."

Lucius stepped closer, his hands clasped behind his back as he followed Marius' gaze. "The crowds will disperse when their thirst is sated," he said. "They always do."

Marius raised an eyebrow, his expression faintly amused. "Do they? Tell me, Lucius, have you ever seen a sea calm itself after a storm has begun?"

Lucius frowned. "Order will be maintained."

"Order," Marius repeated, the word laced with skepticism. "And how do you impose order on a city that no longer believes in it?" He turned to face Lucius again, his expression grim. "Barabbas is a fire, Lucius. He burns bright, consuming everything around him. The mob sees him as a symbol of their anger, their defiance. And then there is this Jesus..."

Marius' voice trailed off, and his gaze grew distant, as though he were looking at something Lucius couldn't see.

"What of him?" Lucius asked, his tone sharper than he intended.

Marius' eyes refocused, locking onto Lucius with a piercing intensity. "He is unlike any man I have ever encountered," he said. "Barabbas stirs their rage. But Jesus... he stirs their hope. And hope, Lucius, is far more dangerous than anger."

Lucius opened his mouth to respond, but Marius held up a hand, silencing him. "Barabbas carries a sword. Jesus carries an idea. Tell me, Lucius—which is more difficult to kill?"

The question struck Lucius like a blow. He thought of Barabbas' wild defiance, the raw fury that had driven him to challenge Rome itself. And then he thought of Jesus—the quiet authority in his gaze, the unshakable calm that had unnerved even the soldiers who arrested him.

"I don't know," Lucius admitted at last, his voice low. "I don't know which is worse."

Marius nodded slowly, his face revealing no hint of his thoughts. "Perhaps that is your answer."

Marius stood at the window, the faint hum of voices outside growing louder, a steady current of tension rippling through the city like the distant rumble of an approaching storm. His gaze was fixed beyond the walls, but his thoughts were elsewhere.

"They cry for the Nazarene now," Marius said, his tone thoughtful. "They call him King, yet no crown sits upon his head, no legions march in his name. And still, they gather, drawn to him like moths to a flame."

Lucius frowned, stepping closer, his frustration evident. "I don't understand it. A man like him, with no army, no throne... and yet they call him King. You saw him, Marius. He didn't even raise his voice. And still..." Lucius trailed off, his brow furrowing.

“And still, my servant lived,” Marius finished quietly, his voice low. He turned to Lucius, his expression inscrutable. “We both saw it. You know as well as I do that there was no time. No hope.”

Lucius’ gaze dropped briefly, the memory flickering in his mind. The boy’s labored breaths, the pale sweat on his brow, the hollow look in his eyes. “And yet he walked,” Lucius admitted grudgingly. “He walked as if nothing had ever been wrong.”

Marius nodded, his tone careful, as though measuring each word. “This Jesus spoke, and it was done. No gesture, no medicine. Just words.” He turned back to the window, his voice hardening. “And now they call him King.”

Lucius scoffed, some of his tension bleeding into derision. “A King? No army, no banners, no throne—and yet they cling to him as if he could free them. It’s absurd. Rome deals with men of power, not dreamers.”

Marius’ gaze didn’t waver. “Power comes in many forms, Lucius. A sword cuts flesh, but a word can cut deeper. A miracle? That lingers.”

Lucius spoke, his frustration spilling over. “He stirs their hearts with parables and riddles. Miracles or not, this man offers them nothing real—no laws, no strength, no structure. And yet they call out for him as if he were a god.”

Marius turned slowly; his eyes sharp. “And to them, he is. To the poor, the broken, the oppressed, he represents something more than this world. A kingdom that Rome cannot touch.”

Lucius shook his head, his skepticism clear. “A kingdom not of this world? Madness. These people live and die in this world. What good is a kingdom they cannot see or hold?”

Marius’ voice dropped, quieter now but heavy with meaning. “What good is Rome’s order, Lucius, if they do not believe in it? Belief is what holds empires together, not walls or armies.” He hesitated, his tone shifting to something softer, almost reluctant. “And this man... there is more to him than we can grasp. You felt it too.”

Lucius' jaw tightened again; his discomfort clear. "I felt... something. But I can't explain it. It doesn't matter. His words are poison to peace. He threatens the order we've built."

Marius studied him for a moment before nodding, turning to the window. "Peace is a fragile thing, Lucius. This Jesus offers them something Rome cannot—hope. And hope, Lucius, is far more dangerous than anger."

Lucius hesitated, his unease growing. "Dangerous to whom?"

"To all of us," Marius replied, his tone grave. "The priests brought him to Pilate because they see the danger. They want him silenced. But even they must know—ideas do not die so easily."

Lucius moved to the window; his hands clasped tightly behind his back as he followed Marius' gaze. The courtyard below was alive with movement—Roman soldiers drilling with precision, their discipline a sharp contrast to the chaos rising beyond the barracks walls.

"The crowd outside the Palace grows louder," Marius said, breaking the silence. "Every hour, more gather. They cry out for the Nazarene—some in reverence, others in fear, and still more in anger. They do not know what they want, Lucius. They only know they need."

Lucius frowned, his voice low. "They want him dead. They may call him King, but kings do not bow before governors. Kings do not allow themselves to be taken in chains."

Marius glanced at him, his expression grave. "And yet, here he is, bound and silent, and they still cry his name. Do you not see it, Lucius? He is no king in the way we understand, but to them, he is more. A shepherd, a savior."

Lucius shook his head, his frustration mounting. "A savior who will lead them to ruin. Pilate must see this—he must act before the crowd turns violent. If they believe him to be their king, then let them see how Rome deals with false kings."

"Pilate hesitates," Marius said, his voice sharp. "Not because he doubts the law, but because he doubts himself. This man, this Jesus, is not like the others who have stood before him. He does not plead. He does not beg. He stands, silent, as if the judgment is his to give, not Pilate's."

Lucius stiffened, his hands clenching at his sides. "And that silence unnerves him?"

"It unnerves us all," Marius said quietly. He turned to Lucius, his expression heavy with meaning. "This is not about the Nazarene alone, Lucius. It is about what he represents. To the priests, he is blasphemy. To the people, he is hope. And to Pilate... he is a question."

Lucius frowned, his unease deepening. "A question?"

"Yes," Marius said, his voice almost a whisper. "Of power. Of truth. Pilate must decide who he fears more—the priests who brought this man before him, or the crowd that gathers outside."

Lucius exhaled sharply, his frustration boiling over. "Then let him decide. Let him condemn this Nazarene and be done with it. Rome cannot afford hesitation, not in a city like this."

Marius' gaze lingered on him, a flicker of something unreadable in his eyes. "Perhaps. But Rome's power is not only in its strength, Lucius. It is in its ability to outlast. To see beyond the moment. Pilate may condemn him, but if we are not careful, his name will live longer than any judgment we give."

A heavy silence settled over the room, the gravity of Marius' words pressing down like the air before a storm. Lucius shifted, his unease gnawing at him. Beyond the barracks walls, the city murmured and stirred, the crowd's cries growing louder with each passing moment.

Marius turned away from the window, his steps measured as he crossed the room. The flickering torchlight cast long shadows over his face, sharpening the lines of his expression. He stopped before Lucius, his tone steady and resolute.

“You speak of condemnation as though it is simple, Lucius. As though Pilate need only raise his hand, and this matter will be resolved.”

Lucius' brows furrowed. “Is it not? The priests demand his death. The crowd gathers, restless. Pilate's path is clear.”

Marius' eyes darkened, a flicker of frustration breaking through his calm. “The path is anything but clear. Do you think Pilate does not feel the strain of what is before him? If he condemns the Nazarene, he risks turning him into a martyr—fuel for the fire that already smolders in this city. And if he spares him...” He paused, “Then he risks the wrath of the priests and the people's faith in Rome's authority.”

Lucius frowned, his thoughts racing. “Then what choice does he have? A ruler cannot hesitate in the face of unrest. It is better to strike decisively than to let doubt fester.”

Marius' expression hardened. “You speak as a soldier, Lucius, and that is your strength. But Pilate must think as a governor—a man balancing on a blade. He must consider not only this moment but what comes after. The priests brought the Nazarene to him, yes. But the mob outside does not yet clamor for his death. If they turn against Pilate...”

Lucius bristled at the implication. “Then let the soldiers handle it. We have faced mobs before. This is no different.”

Marius studied him, his gaze piercing. “And how many men will you sacrifice to hold this city together, Lucius? How many will you cut down in the streets before the blood spilled outweighs the order you claim to protect?”

Lucius opened his mouth to respond, but the words died on his lips. The two men stood in tense silence, the tension of the conversation settling over them like a heavy shroud.

At last, Marius spoke again, his voice softer but no less resolute. “The Nazarene's fate is not in your hands or mine. It rests with Pilate. And Pilate is not a man who acts without weighing every consequence.”

Lucius' tone cooled, his frustration simmering beneath the surface. "Then what would you have me do, sir? Stand by while this city tears itself apart?"

Marius placed a firm hand on Lucius' shoulder, his gaze steady. "I would have you remain vigilant. Pilate may hesitate, but we cannot. They are a storm waiting to break, and when it does, we must be ready."

Lucius nodded reluctantly, the gravitas of Marius' words settling heavily on his shoulders. He glanced toward the window, where the faint echoes among the multitude carried on the wind. "The mob grows louder. They will not wait forever

"They will not," Marius agreed. He released Lucius' shoulder and stepped back; his expression thoughtful. "But remember this, Lucius: Rome's strength is not only in its force but in its patience. Let Pilate play his hand. Our role is to ensure that, whatever his decision, order is maintained."

Lucius inclined his head, his tone resigned but resolute. "Understood, sir. The men will be ready."

Marius nodded, his gaze lingering on Lucius for a moment longer. "Good. Now, go. See to the preparations."

Lucius saluted and turned to leave, his steps brisk and purposeful. But as he exited the room, the echoes of Marius' words followed him, a quiet reminder of the storm that loomed over them all.

Act 3

Act 3 - 01

All

The corridor stretched long and shadowed, its stone walls absorbing the muffled roar of the growing mob outside. The sound seeped through cracks in the high, thick walls—a restless murmur, like waves crashing against unseen cliffs. Dim shafts of light slanted through narrow, grated windows near the ceiling, cutting across the gloom to illuminate specks of dust swirling in the air.

The metallic clink echoed down the passage, uneven and rhythmic. Three prisoners shuffled forward under the sharp eyes of their Roman escort. Lucius marched ahead, his steps firm and measured, his silhouette stark against the dim light filtering through the far door.

Barabbas walked with an air of defiance, the iron shackles on his wrists shifting with each bold step. His shoulders remained square, his chin held high, as if captivity were merely a pause, not the prelude to judgment. His gaze swept the corridor, sharp and calculating, noting every guard, every shadow, as though laying the groundwork for something yet to come.

Behind him, Dismas shuffled along, his head slightly bowed. His wrists ached from the iron shackles, his breathing shallow. He dared not meet anyone's eyes—not Lucius', not Barabbas'. He kept his focus on the ground beneath him, but his mind churned, every thought louder than the rising murmur of the unseen crowd.

At the back, Gestas trailed with slow, deliberate steps, his face set in a permanent sneer. His lips moved occasionally in grumbled curses, but his words were too low to carry.

The air grew heavier as the corridor stretched on, the light dimming as they neared the great door that led to Pilate's Hall.

Barabbas broke the silence, his voice sharp and unrelenting. "Tell me, Commander," he demanded, his tone carrying an edge of mockery. "Is this what Rome calls justice? Shoving men like cattle to be butchered while the mob howls outside?"

Lucius didn't answer immediately. He continued walking, his posture rigid, his gladius bouncing lightly against his side with each step.

Finally, he replied, his voice cold and firm. "Justice is the law. What the mob howls is noise."

Barabbas' grin widened, but his tone grew darker. "Noise? That noise is their voice, Commander. Their will. And whether you listen or not, it'll crush you like a wave if you stand against it."

Lucius' steps didn't falter, but his jaw tightened. "You overestimate their power, Barabbas. The mob has no will—only hunger. They follow the loudest voice and forget it by nightfall."

Barabbas laughed then, the sound low and rough, like the first rumble of distant thunder. His chains clattered softly with the motion, a rhythm that underscored his defiance. "Then let them feast on my words, Commander," he said, his eyes gleaming with dark fire. "Let them see my face, hear my voice. Let them remember the one who stood unbroken against Rome."

Lucius halted abruptly, turning with the weight of command. The shadows seemed to deepen as his cold gaze locked onto Barabbas. The other prisoners stilled, their breath caught in the charged air.

"You are no tempest, Barabbas," Lucius said, his voice quiet but cutting, each word as deliberate as the swing of a sword.

"You are a spark, fleeting and weak, easily stamped out before it sets anything alight."

Barabbas met his gaze without flinching, his grin sharp and unrepentant. "A spark," he said softly, his words carrying the promise of something greater, "becomes a blaze when the wind takes it."

Behind him, Dismas shifted uncomfortably, the exhaustion of their exchange pressing into him like a leaden hand. He kept his gaze down but couldn't stop his thoughts from racing. Each step brought them closer to Pilate, closer to judgment. He had cooperated, even given them Barabbas, and yet here he was, still bound, still walking the same path toward whatever fate awaited them all.

He glanced briefly at Lucius, his heart pounding.
"Commander," he said hesitantly, his voice quiet but strained.

Lucius turned his head slightly, his cold gaze flicking toward Dismas without stopping his stride.

"You said... you said I'd only be charged for theft," Dismas continued, the words tumbling out before he lost his nerve.

Lucius didn't slow, his expression impassive. "Did you think Rome gives guarantees?"

The words hit Dismas like a blow. His throat tightened, his pulse racing. "I gave you Barabbas," he replied, his voice cracking with desperation. "I told you everything you wanted to know."

Lucius stopped again, turning fully to face him this time. His expression remained cold, his tone sharp as steel. "And now you walk to judgment with him. Perhaps Pilate will spare you, or perhaps not. You should have thought of that before you picked up the blade."

Barabbas laughed, the sound echoing off the walls like a hammer striking iron. "You hear that, Dismas?" he remarked, his voice thick with scorn. "Rome doesn't care about your

bargains or your pleas. "They'll tie you to the same cross as me, and you'll die just as nameless."

Dismas flinched at the words, his fists clenching in frustration. The crushing feeling of the chains, the echo of Barabbas' laughter, the muffled roar emanating from the congregation beyond the walls—it was all too much.

Lucius raised a hand, silencing them all. "Enough," he said, his tone quiet but authoritative. "You'll keep your mouths shut from here forward, or I'll silence them myself."

Barabbas smirked but said nothing more.

The group continued forward, the light ahead growing brighter as they approached the door to the hall. The guards moved ahead, unbolting the heavy wood with precise efficiency.

Lucius paused, glancing back at the prisoners one last time. "When you step through those doors," he replied, his voice firm and deliberate, "you will remember who holds your fate in his hands. Keep your heads down, speak only when asked, and perhaps Pilate will be merciful. But test his patience, and you'll beg for the judgment Rome gives," he responded, his gaze cold and unwavering.

"Do not think for a moment that mercy is guaranteed," he spoke, his tone a warning. "Rome's justice is swift and final," he stated, his eyes scanning each prisoner. "Your lives hang by a thread," he uttered, the words like a cold wind. "It would be wise to remember that," he asserted, his presence imposing. "Pilate's temper is not something you want to provoke," he declared, his voice carrying the weight of authority. "

Barabbas met his gaze, his grin returning. "Let them see me," he said quietly, almost to himself. "Let them see what Rome fears."

Lucius didn't respond. He turned back toward the door, gesturing for the guards to swing it open. The wood groaned loudly as the light spilled into the corridor, illuminating their faces.

Beyond the threshold lay the governor's hall, its shadowed interior filled with an oppressive silence. The muffled roar among the masses lingered just beyond the walls, a constant reminder of the chaos waiting outside.

Lucius stepped through, his back straight, his hand on his gladius as he led the prisoners into Pilate's presence. The doors closed behind them with a resounding thud, sealing them into the chamber of judgment.

Dismas shuffled forward, the iron bindings on his wrists dragging softly against the polished stone floor. The noise from outside seeped through the thick walls—muted but unyielding, a tide of voices rising and falling with the city's unrest. He kept his gaze fixed on the ground, the rhythmic slap of his sandals the only sound he could cling to in the suffocating silence of the chamber.

Ahead of him strode Barabbas, his shoulders squared, his movements confident despite the iron shackles around his wrists. Dismas couldn't decide if the man was defiant or delusional. Barabbas carried himself as though he were walking into a battlefield rather than a place of judgment. Behind him, Gestas trailed with a sneer etched into his features, his gaze flicking disdainfully at the guards flanking them.

The chamber itself was vast, its cold, shadowed walls rising high into an arched ceiling that swallowed the light streaming in from narrow windows above. Torches lined the walls, their flickering flames casting uneven shadows across the room, adding to the sense of foreboding that hung heavily in the atmosphere.

Near the far side of the hall stood Pilate, his robes immaculate but his face betraying a weariness that no amount of Roman pomp could conceal. Beside him, standing a pace behind, was Marius, his posture rigid and his hand resting lightly on the hilt of his gladius. A cluster of priests and Pharisees stood a short distance away, their whispers carrying an edge of self-righteous satisfaction.

But it was the figure standing to Pilate's right that caught Dismas' attention.

Jesus.

Even bound, even stripped of the dignity his followers had ascribed to him, he stood out like a flame in the dim room. His expression was calm, his eyes steady, as though the chains and accusations meant nothing. It unsettled Dismas. Beside Barabbas' raw energy and Gestas' simmering anger, Jesus seemed almost otherworldly—a man untouched by the reality of his own fate.

Dismas' gaze darted toward Barabbas, who had stopped short and was staring at Pilate with a predator's focus. "That's Pilate?" he muttered under his breath, the hint of a smirk tugging at his lips.

Lucius, who had been walking alongside them, snapped, "Quiet." The edge in his voice silenced Barabbas, though it did little to dim the zealot's grin.

Pilate, sensing their arrival, turned his head slowly. His gaze swept over the three prisoners, lingering on each one as though appraising their worth—or lack thereof. His expression was inscrutable, but his brow furrowed slightly when his eyes met Barabbas'.

"You've brought the insurgents," Pilate said, his voice carrying the gravity of command.

"Yes, Governor," Lucius replied, stepping forward with a crisp salute. "The charges are insurrection, murder, theft, and conspiracy against Rome."

Pilate's eyes narrowed at Barabbas, who met his gaze without a hint of deference. "So," Pilate said, his tone almost casual, "you're the one they call Barabbas."

Barabbas tilted his head, the iron restraints shifting subtly as he took a deliberate step forward. "That's right, Governor," he replied, his voice smooth, laced with defiance. "And you're the one they say holds Caesar's leash in this forsaken city."

Lucius stiffened, but Pilate held up a hand, his expression hardening. "You would do well to hold your tongue," he said coldly. "Rome's patience is not infinite."

Barabbas chuckled low in his throat, the sound echoing faintly in the chamber. "And neither is the people's, Governor. That's why you're here, isn't it? To keep the peace, to quell the fires before they burn too bright."

Dismas flinched at the boldness of Barabbas' words, his pulse quickening as he glanced nervously between the rebel and the governor. Gestas spoke in muffled words, too low for Dismas to catch, but his tone was sour and laced with scorn.

Pilate's gaze shifted to Lucius, who stood firm and composed, the quiet weight of Roman authority resting on his shoulders. There was a stillness to him, the kind that spoke of years spent commanding without question. "He's a talkative one," Pilate remarked dryly, his voice touched with a note of weary disdain as his eyes flicked to Barabbas.

Lucius dipped his head slightly in acknowledgment. "He believes himself untouchable, Governor," he said. "The leader of their cause, in his own eyes."

Pilate's lips pressed into a thin line before his focus turned to the other two prisoners. His sharp eyes swept over Dismas, who faltered under the scrutiny, and Gestas, who held Pilate's gaze with thinly veiled disdain.

"And what of these two?" Pilate asked, his tone brusque.

"Companions of Barabbas," Lucius reported evenly. "Charged with murder, theft, and insurrection." He hesitated for a moment before adding, "Dismas, however, sought leniency. He offered information about Barabbas' whereabouts in exchange for a reduced sentence."

Dismas' breath caught in his throat, the challenging reality of Lucius' words pressing down on him. He had known this would come to light, but hearing it laid bare before Pilate felt like a blade twisting in his gut. He opened his mouth to defend

himself, to explain, but Pilate's eyes snapped to him before he could muster a word.

"Is that so?" Pilate murmured, his tone calm and deliberate. His piercing gaze bore into Dismas, as though dissecting the man before him. Dismas thought Pilate might speak further, but instead, the governor's gaze shifted to Gestas, who met him with a sneer.

Pilate exhaled, his irritation breaking through as he gestured toward Jesus. "And him," he said sharply. "Returned to me from Herod with nothing decided, though the priests cry louder than ever for his death. They call him King, but what kind of king says nothing in his own defense?"

Marius stepped forward from his position near the wall, his calm tone cutting through the tension. "Governor," he began, his voice unwavering, "there is a tradition at Passover." Pilate turned to him, his brow furrowing slightly.

Marius continued, his words deliberate. "The people may request the release of one prisoner—an act of leniency to honor their festival. It is customary, though it has not always been welcomed by the crowds." His gaze flicked briefly to the window, where faint murmurs from the gathering outside could still be heard. "Perhaps it might be... useful, under the circumstances."

Pilate's expression shifted, his annoyance giving way to consideration. His gaze lingered on Barabbas, then moved to Jesus, who stood silent and unmoving. The tension in the room deepened as the idea seemed to take root in Pilate's mind.

"The people may choose," Pilate said slowly, almost to himself. "A rebel or a prophet. A murderer or a king." His voice turned colder, addressing Marius directly. "And which do you think they'll favor?"

Marius' expression remained neutral, his tone cautious. "The crowd is unpredictable, Governor. But offering them the choice may quell some of the unrest."

Pilate's eyes flicked toward Jesus once more, his frustration evident. "A king without a crown," he grumbled softly. "And a rebel who taunts me in my own hall."

The tension in the room was palpable, every word hanging heavily in the atmosphere. Pilate studied Barabbas for a long moment, his face giving nothing away, before finally turning his attention to Jesus.

"And you," he replied, his tone shifting slightly, as though addressing someone entirely different. "They call you the King of the Jews. They say you claim to be a ruler, a prophet."

Jesus said nothing, his gaze steady and unyielding. The silence stretched, thick and heavy, until Pilate's irritation broke through.

"Do you have nothing to say for yourself?" he demanded, his voice rising.

Still, Jesus remained silent, and the contrast between him and Barabbas could not have been more stark. Dismas felt the emotional toll of it, the strange, almost magnetic pull of the Nazarene's presence. He couldn't look away, even as his own fate loomed closer with every passing moment.

Simon lingered near the platform where Pilate had earlier sent Jesus to Herod, reflecting on the tense moments that had just unfolded. The governor had dispatched Jesus with an air of irritation, and the crowd, unwilling to leave, continued to grow. Their voices swelled with speculation and impatience as they awaited what would come next.

He recalled the moment Herod's soldiers had marched Jesus back through the streets earlier that morning. His breath had hitched at the sight of Jesus then, his appearance marred by the marks of mistreatment and a crude crown of thorns pressing into his skin. The memory lingered vividly, a cruel testament to the events leading to this moment.

The memory of Jesus' torn robes, streaked face, and the mockery of the thorny crown haunted Simon. It was an image of suffering that seemed to echo the crowd's unrest.

Herod's soldiers smirked and laughed, their expressions brimming with disdain as they shoved Jesus forward. Pilate's jaw tightened, his irritation with the entire ordeal etched clearly on his face.

"Herod sends him back to me," Pilate declared, his voice breaking through the murmurs in the court with clipped authority. "He finds no fault in this man. And neither do I."

The crowd exploded with cries of disbelief and fury. Simon flinched as the noise swelled around him, the collective anger of the people pressing in like a tangible weight.

"You hear it, Governor!" one of the priests called, his voice rising above the din. "The people demand justice! You cannot let this man go unpunished."

Simon's heart raced as he witnessed the frenzy spread. He noticed the priests weaving through the gathering, their quiet words and subtle gestures adding fuel to the fire. It was clear they would stop at nothing to achieve their goal.

Pilate turned back toward his soldiers, his frustration boiling over. "Bring out Barabbas," he commanded, his tone steady but sharp.

The gravity of the courtyard seemed to deepen as Pilate turned from the murmuring crowd below to the prisoners before him. The mix of defiance and calm among these men was a stark reflection of the chaos raging outside. Barabbas stood tall, his bound hands almost incidental to his fiery demeanor, while Jesus, calm and composed, radiated an unsettling stillness that gnawed at Pilate's sense of authority.

Pilate stared at the two, his mind racing through the twisted puzzle laid before him. The crowd's cries for blood and mercy roared faintly in the distance, yet their decision would ultimately hinge on what he presented to them.

Barabbas broke the silence, his voice a cutting edge. “Why delay, Governor?” His grin was sharp, his tone defiant. “The people cry for their king. Let them have him, or do you fear what they’ll say when you deny them?”

Pilate’s jaw clenched, but he did not immediately reply. His eyes shifted to Jesus, whose silence only deepened the growing irritation simmering within him.

Pilate’s thoughts turned inward, a storm of frustration and calculation.

Pilate glanced briefly at the Pharisees gathered at the courtyard. Their smug expressions only added to his growing ire. They had brought this man to him with claims of rebellion, of blasphemy, of undermining Caesar himself. Yet Pilate could see none of it in the figure before him.

Barabbas, though—that man was exactly what he appeared to be: dangerous, unrepentant, and loud. A man whose existence stoked the flames of unrest in the city. But to put him and Jesus side by side? It felt absurd. One was a firebrand; the other seemed almost ethereal, a man who carried no weapon and made no demands.

“Rome must be slipping if its governor needs this long to act,” Barabbas said, his grin widening. “The people already know who I am. They’ll call my name.”

Pilate’s gaze snapped to him, his irritation breaking through. “And what does that earn you, Barabbas?” he asked, his tone cold. “A momentary cheer? The same voices that call for you will spit your name when the streets run red with the consequences of your rebellion.”

Barabbas merely shrugged, his grin never faltering. “Better to die with fire in their memory than to fade in silence.”

Pilate’s lip curled in distaste, but he didn’t answer. Instead, his thoughts turned to the dilemma at hand.

“Governor,” one of the Pharisees interjected, stepping forward. His voice carried the kind of oily confidence that set Pilate’s

teeth on edge. “The man before you—this Jesus—claims to be a king. Is that not treason against Caesar?”

Pilate turned sharply, his patience thin. “I see no rebellion in him. Your charges are whispers dressed in pomp. If he is a king, he holds no throne, no army, no sword.”

“He stirs the people,” another Pharisee argued, his tone urgent. “Even without weapons, his words turn them against us. Against you.”

Pilate raised a hand, silencing him. His eyes flicked between the Pharisees, Barabbas, and Jesus, each representing a piece of the puzzle. And then he knew—the solution was not his to give.

Pilate’s gaze hardened as the plan began to form. The crowd below had already begun to seethe with anticipation. If they wanted blood or mercy, let them decide. If their loyalty to this Jesus was so great, they would cry for him. If their hatred outweighed their love, Barabbas would walk free. Either way, Pilate’s hands would remain untied.

“Bring them both forward,” Pilate commanded, his tone firm and unwavering.

Dismas’ breath hitched as he processed Pilate’s command. His earlier flicker of hope reignited as he tried to make sense of it. “Both,” Pilate had said. Barabbas and Jesus. Could it be that the people’s choice would extend to all of them?

He turned to Gestas, who remained grim-faced, and then to Barabbas, who exuded a smug confidence that both irritated and unsettled him.

“If they cry for Barabbas,” Dismas thought, his heart racing, “surely, they’ll cry for us too. They’ll have to.”

But as his gaze shifted to Jesus, that fragile hope faltered. The man’s presence seemed to draw every eye, every whisper among the gathering below. Would they truly choose a rebel over a prophet? And if they didn’t—what would become of him?

The soldiers began to move, pulling Barabbas and Jesus forward. Dismas' chains rattled as he was forced to follow, his pulse pounding in his ears.

The crowd waited.

And the weight of their judgment pressed down on them all.

The crowd murmured in confusion and anticipation as the order was carried out. Simon shifted uneasily, sensing that the scene was building toward something he could not yet understand.

Moments later, the Zealots were dragged into the courtyard, as the soldiers forced them forward. Simon watched as Barabbas was brought to stand opposite Jesus, the contrast between the two men stark and undeniable. One was a figure of quiet strength, his presence steady despite the mockery and abuse he had endured. The other was a force of raw anger, his every movement charged with rebellion and violence.

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All

Pilate stepped between the prisoners, his posture rigid, his presence commanding as he faced the gathered crowd below. The platform, though shielded by its height, seemed barely enough to hold back the force of the people's collective fury and fervor.

"It is custom during the Passover," Pilate began, his voice measured yet resonating over the chaotic din of the courtyard, "to release one prisoner to you." His gaze shifted across the sea of faces, each one alight with anticipation, anger, or judgment. "A gesture of mercy, a reminder of Rome's magnanimity."

The words carried an edge, one aimed at the religious leaders at the forefront of the assembly. Their stern faces betrayed nothing, but Pilate could feel the tension radiating from them—a silent demand for him to proceed.

His arm swept to the side, pointing toward Barabbas. "This man," he declared, his voice hardening, "Barabbas—a murderer, a rebel who has brought death to your streets, chaos to your city. A man whose hands are stained with the blood of your own people."

The crowd buzzed with murmurs, a ripple of unease working with a furious energy. Barabbas, unbowed, stood defiantly, his lips curling into a faint smirk. He surveyed the masses below as though weighing their worth, his eyes glinting with the same fire that had fueled his insurrection.

Pilate allowed the moment to linger before gesturing toward Jesus, who stood silent and calm at his other side. "And this man," Pilate continued, his tone shifting to one of curiosity, as if even he couldn't quite grasp the absurdity of the situation. "Jesus of Nazareth. Accused of blasphemy. Of claiming to be your king."

A sneer crept onto his lips as he turned toward the priests gathered near the front. "Your king," he repeated mockingly, his voice dripping with disdain.

The energy shifted, the murmurs turning into a chorus of clashing cries. Pilate stepped back, allowing their voices to rise into a chaotic wave.

Barabbas turned his head slightly, glancing at Jesus with an expression caught between disdain and disbelief. "So," he grumbled quietly, loud enough for the nearby guards and the prisoners to hear, "this is the man they want to crown." His laughter was low, humorless. "A king who does nothing while they bind his hands."

Dismas, standing several steps behind, felt his pulse quicken. The tension was heavy, charged like the moments before a lightning strike. He scanned the sea of faces, searching for clues to their mood and intentions. He clung to the fragile hope that they would choose Barabbas—that the zealot leader's infamy might tip the scales, granting him a chance at freedom.

Pilate raised a hand, commanding silence from the restless crowd. The noise subsided to a murmur, but the tension in the air remained, taut and unyielding, stretching between the platform and the masses below.

"Whom shall I release to you?" Pilate demanded, his voice breaking the stifling silence with authority. He turned to face the assembly, arms spread wide in a gesture that seemed to offer them control over the decision. "Barabbas, the Zealot? Or Jesus, the one you accuse of blasphemy?"

The crowd erupted once more, a cacophony of voices clashing in a storm of demands. Defiant cries for Barabbas rang out, fueled by the fervor of rebellion, while others shouted for

Jesus, their tones a mix of reverence, desperation, and derision. The sound surged and crashed like waves against the courtyard walls, a raw torrent of human emotion spilling over in chaotic force.

Barabbas tilted his head back slightly, a faint grin playing on his lips. He shifted his weight, appearing almost relaxed amidst the chaos. He turned to Lucius, his voice cutting. "You hear them, Commander?" his tone dripping with confidence. "They know my name. They remember what I've done for them."

Lucius' jaw tightened as he cast a sharp glance at Barabbas. "They remember the blood you've spilled," he retorted, his voice icy. "Don't mistake their cries for loyalty, zealot. The mob's favor changes with the wind."

Barabbas shrugged, his grin widening. "Perhaps. But today's wind seems to favor me."

Dismas, standing farther back, felt the burden of his chains as acutely as the gravity of the moment. His eyes flicked between Barabbas and Jesus, then out to the crowd, which surged and roared like a living thing.

"Do they really want him?" Dismas murmured, almost to himself, his voice barely audible amidst the cacophony. He felt a spark of hope—a dangerous, fragile thing—as he considered the possibility. Barabbas' reputation was infamous, his deeds spoken of in hushed tones even among the desperate. Would the crowd truly choose a murderer over a man rumored to heal with a touch?

At the platform, Pilate turned toward Jesus, his expression a mixture of weariness and irritation. "Well?" he asked, his voice low enough to escape the ears within the congregation. "Do you hear them? They're ready to decide your fate, yet you remain silent. Do you have nothing to say for yourself?"

Jesus' eyes met Pilate's, calm and unwavering. He didn't speak, his silence heavy with meaning.

Barabbas scoffed, the sound sharp in the tense air. "He won't speak because he's nothing," he said, addressing no one in

particular. “No king, no warrior—just a man too weak to defend himself.”

The square outside Pilate’s court was thick with a restlessness that felt alive, humming through the air as if every voice, every heartbeat, was somehow in sync.

Simon of Cyrene had been swept into the gathering crowd, a mere pilgrim in Jerusalem for Passover, now caught up in a spectacle he could scarcely understand but could not resist. He watched as people pressed forward, craning to see over one another’s heads, their faces taut with anticipation.

Two figures stood at the forefront, chained and flanked by Roman guards. Simon’s eyes were drawn to the one on the left first—a man he quickly recognized.

Even to a foreigner, Barabbas’ reputation had traveled, an infamous zealot with fire in his eyes and rebellion in his bones. His stance was bold and fierce, his face twisted with a kind of wild satisfaction, as if he thrived in the chaos, even bound and waiting for judgment.

Barabbas didn’t cower or flinch; instead, he seemed to revel in the attention, as though the iron biting into his wrists were a badge of pride.

Next to him, however, stood another man entirely, a figure shrouded in an aura of serenity so profound that it seemed almost out of place.

Dressed in a worn purple robe, a color twisted into mockery, the man’s calm presence seemed to radiate, a soft light in contrast to the thunderous energy among the spectators. Jesus of Nazareth.

Simon had seen him speak, heard tales of healings and miracles, of words that reached beyond this world. And now here he stood, still and silent, his gaze unfocused, as if he were seeing something far beyond the faces of the people crying for his judgment.

Simon's attention wavered, drifting toward two other men who had robbed him standing slightly behind Barabbas and Jesus.

Chained and silent, they bore the unmistakable air of those who had gambled recklessly, heedless of the cost, and now faced the crushing weight of justice. Simon didn't know their names, but he didn't need to; he recognized their type. They were men who had left trails of misery in their wake and seeing them here stirred in him a grim sense of satisfaction. Justice, at last, had caught up to them.

Yet as his gaze returned to the two central figures—Barabbas with his fierce, unyielding stare and Jesus with his unnerving calm—an unfamiliar unease began to creep in. There was something disquieting in the stark contrast between the two, a tension that tugged at the edges of Simon's thoughts, elusive and unnamable.

Around him, the crowd grew increasingly restless, their voices swelling into a chorus of curiosity and anger. Simon caught snatches of conversation—a heated grumble here, a biting whisper there—as the undercurrent of emotion rippled through the throng, growing stronger with every passing moment. “That's Barabbas, the zealot,” a man beside him spoke in hushed tones, his voice a mix of disdain and admiration. “They say he'd tear down Rome with his own hands if given the chance. He's a fire we need in times like these.”

Simon nodded thoughtfully, eyeing Barabbas with a mix of curiosity and unease. “A fire that could just as easily burn us all,” he replied, his voice quiet. His gaze moved back to Jesus, lingering on the strange peace that emanated from him. “And this other one... what of him? They say he's stirred up the priests and the elders.”

The man beside Simon scoffed, his expression skeptical. “They call him king, some say. King of a kingdom no one's ever seen.” His lips twisted in a sneer. “If you ask me, he's just another dreamer speaking of peace where none can be found. The priests have had their fill of him.”

Simon frowned, his curiosity deepening. He had heard stories of this man, Jesus—tales that painted him as something beyond the usual prophet, a healer, a man whose words

seemed to command the unseen. Yet here he stood, as vulnerable as any other prisoner, bound and awaiting the people's judgment.

The murmurs around him grew louder, a low rumble spreading like the ominous roll of distant thunder. Then, rising above the noise, a voice rang out, sharp and deliberate, cutting through the air and breaking the tension like a blade.

"Give us Barabbas!" the voice demanded, strong and unyielding, its force rippling through the assembly like a spark igniting dry tinder.

Simon's gaze snapped toward the source of the cry, spotting the speaker—a man in the robes of a priest, his eyes blazing with intensity, his expression carved from stone. There was venom in his tone that startled Simon, making it clear this was no ordinary bystander. This was a leader, one of the very men who had orchestrated Jesus' trial and brought him here to be judged.

"Yes! Release Barabbas!" came another shout, louder this time, emboldened by the priest's cry. The call spread, catching like fire on parched grass, voices rising in a swelling chorus until the air itself seemed to vibrate with the demand.

"Free Barabbas! Let him go free!"

Simon felt the energy around him shift and gather, as though the crowd had become a single entity, pulsing with a shared will. His gaze returned to Jesus, questioning how this man of peace—a figure of quiet words and humble acts—could inspire such hostility, such fervent emotion.

As he watched, he noticed more priests weaving through the throng, their low, urgent whispers fanning the flames of discontent into a roaring inferno.

"Barabbas fights for you!" a priest's voice rang out, breaking through the murmurs like a clarion call. "He stands against Rome! He would see you free from your chains!"

A hum of agreement rippled outward, the crowd responding to the priest's words like a gathering storm.

"But this Jesus?" the priest continued, his tone now laced with scorn. "He speaks of kingdoms that exist only in dreams, of peace that grants no power. Is that the leader you would follow?"

A new voice rose above the crowd, resolute and insistent. "Yes! Give us Barabbas! He fights for us!"

Simon's stomach churned as he took in the scene. The fervor in the square swelled with each cry, each whispered word of persuasion.

Pilate, his face betraying irritation and fatigue raised his hands, he called for silence, though a flicker of impatience flashed in his eyes.

"As is tradition, I present two before you," Pilate announced, his voice steady and commanding. "One shall be released to you as a gesture of goodwill for the Passover."

He gestured to the prisoners before him. "Will it be Jesus, called the King of the Jews, who has committed no violence? Or Barabbas, a man known for rebellion?"

The response was immediate, voices uniting in a deafening roar: "Barabbas! Give us Barabbas!"

"Barabbas! Release Barabbas!"

Simon's heart pounded, shaken by the intensity of their fervor, the way their voices merged into a single, unrelenting roar. His gaze darted to Pilate, hoping against hope that the governor might see reason, might find a way to appeal to their conscience. Yet the priests moved deftly among the gathered masses, their whispers sharp and insistent, fueling the anger, driving the people to demand Barabbas' release.

“Give us Barabbas!” The cry rose again, louder this time, a tidal surge of voices that drowned out any hint of dissent.

Pilate raised his hands for silence, his voice carrying an edge of disbelief as he addressed the sea of faces. “And what shall I do, then, with this man, Jesus, whom you call the King of the Jews?”

For a fleeting moment, there was silence—a charged stillness, as though the very air braced itself. Then, slowly, a darker chant began to emerge, spreading like wildfire through the gathering, its weight pressing down with terrible finality.

“Crucify him! “

“Crucify him!”

Simon felt the words strike him like a physical blow, the sheer cruelty of them cutting through him. He had come to Jerusalem seeking peace, renewal, and spiritual reflection during the Passover. Instead, he found himself surrounded by a relentless throng demanding death, calling for the blood of a man who had committed no crime.

The chant swelled, rising like a storm, its pounding rhythm shaking the very ground beneath them, a tempest of human fury unleashed.

“Crucify him!”

“Crucify him!”

Simon’s gaze drifted back to Jesus, who stood silent and still, his face untroubled despite the venomous cries that surrounded him. It was as though he stood apart from it all, untouched by the fury that swirled around him.

Simon felt a pang of sorrow, a strange, unexplainable grief that seeped into his bones. He could not understand why this man, who bore himself with such calm, should be the target of such rage.

And yet the cries continued, a crescendo of anger that showed no sign of abating.

The chief priests moved among the people, their voices hissing and whispering, sowing seeds of doubt, of mistrust. Simon heard their words drift past him, snippets of sentences laced with scorn.

“He claims to be king, but what king lets himself be captured?”

“He would have you believe in a kingdom beyond this earth, but where is the strength in that?”

“This Jesus will bring us nothing but weakness.”

Each word added fuel to the fire, feeding the crowd’s anger, their resentment. And as the chant reached a fever pitch, Simon felt the quiet oppression of their judgment pressing down upon him, a shadow that seemed to settle.

The heaviness of his chains had not lessened, but for the first time in what felt like days, Dismas allowed himself a flicker of hope. The chant of “Barabbas” still rang in his ears, the crowd’s fervent cries like a strange melody that threatened to drown out his own thoughts. He shifted on his feet, glancing toward the guards who stood impassive, their faces as rigid as the walls of the courtyard.

Barabbas had been freed. Dismas held on to that fact like a lifeline, repeating it in his mind as though sheer repetition could make it true for himself as well. Rome might be ruthless, but surely even they would not crucify petty thieves alongside zealots and rebels. He shot a glance at Gestas, whose stony expression betrayed none of the storm Dismas was sure raged within him.

“They’ll let us go,” Dismas muttered, his voice trembling slightly. “They have to.”

Gestas turned his head slightly, a sneer twisting his lips. "Do they?" he asked, his tone sharp enough to cut. "Or do they just save the sharpest nails for traitors like you?"

Dismas flinched, the accusation striking deeper than he cared to admit. He looked away, fixing his gaze on the far wall of the courtyard where the sun cast long shadows. Gestas didn't understand. He couldn't. Dismas had done what he had to do, had given the Romans what they wanted. Surely that counted for something.

But even as he tried to reassure himself, doubts crept in, curling like dark tendrils around his thoughts.

Barabbas, standing some distance away, soaked in the energy like a man basking in the sun. His arms were free now, the chains that had bound him lying discarded at his feet. Dismas watched as the zealot raised his hands, his posture bold and triumphant, feeding off the assembly's adoration.

Barabbas turned his head, and their eyes met. The smirk that spread across Barabbas' face made Dismas' stomach twist. The zealot strode toward him, his movements deliberate, his gaze never wavering.

"Well, well," Barabbas said, his tone quiet and mocking. "Look at you. Still shackled, still hoping." He leaned in closer, his breath hot against Dismas' ear. "Did you think they'd reward a rat? That Rome would pat you on the head and let you scurry free after you sold us out?"

Dismas swallowed hard, his throat dry. "I... I did what I had to," his voice barely above a whisper. "I thought—"

"You thought wrong," Barabbas cut in, his words laced with venom. He stepped back, his laughter harsh and grating. "Good luck, Dismas," he uttered, his smirk widening. "You'll need it."

As Barabbas turned away, striding toward the courtyard where the guards waited, Dismas' fragile hope wavered. The zealot's words echoed in his mind, each syllable a reminder of the precariousness of his position.

No, he thought, shaking his head slightly. Barabbas was wrong. He had to be. Dismas had cooperated and had given Rome what it wanted. That had to mean something.

The faint scrape of iron bindings drew his attention to the guards as they approached. Their faces were stoic, their steps precise and deliberate. Dismas' heart quickened, his pulse pounding in his ears as they closed the distance.

Would this be the moment they told him he was free?

The chains clinked softly as Dismas adjusted his stance, his wrists sore from the constant chafing of iron against skin. Despite the ache in his limbs and the pressure of the guard's unflinching gaze, Dismas allowed himself a glimmer of optimism. Barabbas had been freed, released to the cries of the mob. Surely this meant mercy was not beyond reach for the rest of them.

His eyes darted to Gestas, standing rigid and silent. The man's face was a mask, his lips pressed into a hard line, but Dismas knew him well enough to sense the tension simmering beneath the surface. Gestas might not voice it, but he felt it too—the faint chance that they could escape the cross.

"They let him go," Dismas murmured under his breath, his voice barely audible over the shuffling of soldiers nearby. "Barabbas walked free."

Gestas turned his head slightly, his face devoid of emotion. "You think that means something for us?" he asked, his tone flat, almost mocking.

Dismas hesitated, then nodded. "It has to. He's the leader, the one they hate the most. If they spared him..."

"They didn't spare him," Gestas interrupted, his voice cutting through Dismas' words like a knife. "The people chose him. They don't care about us, Dismas. To them, we're just shadows trailing behind the zealot."

Dismas frowned, his fragile hope dimming slightly. "But we're not like him," he argued, though the conviction in his voice wavered. "I gave them information. I helped them."

Gestas let out a dry, humorless laugh. "You think Rome cares about your help? About your deals?" His eyes narrowed, his voice dropping to a sharp whisper. "They want blood. Whether it's yours or mine, they'll spill it just the same."

The words hit harder than Dismas cared to admit, but he refused to let them snuff out the faint flicker of belief he still clung to. "Barabbas said they'd pick him," Dismas said quietly, almost to himself. "And they did. He was right."

Gestas shook his head, his expression darkening. "Barabbas thinks he's some chosen savior, a warrior for God. That's why they wanted him—the priests made sure of it. But us? We mean nothing to them."

Dismas glanced away, his gaze drifting toward the far side of the hall where the soldiers were preparing to move them. His thoughts swirled, heavy and chaotic. Gestas' words held truth, but so did the memory of Barabbas' release. If the crowd had the power to free a zealot and a murderer, perhaps there was a chance for him too.

One of the guards approached, his face stony and impassive. "Move," he ordered, gesturing toward the main chamber where Pilate awaited.

Dismas shuffled forward, the chains around his ankles biting with each step. His heart thudded heavily in his chest as they passed through the archway, entering the judgment hall. The light was dimmer here, the air cooler, but the burden of what lay ahead bore down on him like a physical force.

His eyes caught on the figure standing beside Pilate—Jesus, silent and serene, his hands bound but his posture unbowed. The sight of the Nazarene sent a strange ripple through Dismas, a mixture of unease and something he couldn't quite name. He had heard the stories, the whispered tales of miracles and proclamations of peace. Yet here he stood, just as chained as the rest of them, awaiting the same fate.

Gestas followed Dismas' gaze, his sneer deepening. "Look at him," he said almost inaudibly, his voice dripping with disdain. "The so-called King of the Jews. What good is a king who can't even save himself?"

Dismas said nothing, his focus lingering on Jesus. There was something different about him, something that unsettled and intrigued him in equal measure. The man's calm was unnatural, a stillness that defied the chaos surrounding them.

The guards halted them before the platform, where Pilate stood with his arms crossed, his face betraying no emotion. Dismas felt the governor's gaze sweep over them, assessing, calculating. His stomach churned as he waited for Pilate's words, the uncertainty gnawing at him like a rat in the dark.

Behind him, Gestas shifted restlessly, his chains jangling softly. "Hope you're ready, Dismas," he breathed in a low tone laced with bitter sarcasm. "Looks like they're saving the best for last."

Dismas pressed his lips together, willing himself to ignore the comment, to hold onto the fragile thread of hope that still lingered in his mind. He had done what he could, played the hand he was dealt. Surely, it had to count for something.

But as Pilate's cold eyes met his, Dismas couldn't shake the creeping doubt that perhaps it hadn't.

Act 3 - 03

Dismas

The clanking of chains filled the quiet tension as the guards arranged Dismas, Gestas, and Jesus before the platform. Pilate, standing at the center with his robes draped in the regal authority of Rome, regarded the group with a mixture of disdain and fatigue. Lucius stood at his side, stoic and unyielding, while Marius lingered near the edges of the scene, his sharp eyes scanning the prisoners and the guards alike.

Dismas felt the gravity of Pilate's gaze land on him and shifted uncomfortably, his chains scraping against the stone. The hall was quieter here, away from the roar along the outskirts, but the oppressive stillness only intensified the moment. Beside him, Gestas maintained his hard glare, his defiance simmering just beneath the surface.

Pilate's voice broke the silence, low and sharp. "Three men stand accused," he said, his words deliberate, as if savoring each syllable. "Blasphemers, thieves, zealots, murderers. Each of you are accused of breaking the law of Rome." His eyes moved over the prisoners, pausing briefly on each man. "And yet, by custom, one among you may walk free."

Dismas felt his breath hitch, his mind racing. The words hung in the air, heavy with implication. This was it—the moment he had clung to since Barabbas' release. The possibility of freedom felt almost tangible, just out of reach.

Pilate's gaze turned to Lucius, his expression hardening. "Commander, report."

Lucius stepped forward, his posture rigid as he spoke. "Barabbas has already been released by the will of the people," he stated, his tone crisp and precise. "These three remain." He gestured to Dismas and Gestas first. "Dismas and Gestas, companions of Barabbas. Charged with theft and insurrection. Both have confessed to their crimes."

Dismas flinched at Lucius' words. Confessed? Was cooperation the same as guilt in Rome's eyes? He wanted to protest, to argue that he had been trying to save himself, not admit to rebellion. But the words froze in his throat, fear tightening its grip on his chest.

Pilate's gaze lingered on Jesus, his brow furrowing slightly. The Nazarene stood silent, his bound hands resting calmly at his sides, his posture unbroken. Pilate's lips pressed into a thin line as though he were weighing something unseen.

He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, gazing over the platform as though it carried the heavy mantle of all Rome. His eyes lingered on the crowd far below, the murmuring masses awaiting his verdict. When he turned to the prisoners, his movements were deliberate, calculated. His gaze fell first upon Jesus, whose bound hands rested at his sides, his head lifted in quiet stillness.

Pilate spoke, his tone sharp but weary. "You, Jesus of Nazareth. They call you a king, though I see no crown, no army, no kingdom. What say you to their accusations?"

Pilate's brow furrowed. "Nothing? Not even to save yourself?" His voice rose slightly, not with anger but frustration. The governor sighed heavily, glancing toward the priests lingering nearby, their faces alight with triumph.

"Gestas," Pilate began, his tone flat. "Thief. Zealot. A man who murders and steals from his own and claims it in the name of rebellion."

Gestas smirked, his words dripping with mockery. “And yet here I am, Governor, sharing the same air as kings and saviors.”

Pilate’s expression hardened. “And you would share their fate, too, if not for the mercy I now consider.” He studied Gestas’ face for a reaction, but the thief offered only a dry laugh.

“Mercy,” Gestas said, shaking his head. “An odd word for a Roman.”

Pilate stepped back with a look of disdain before turning to the last prisoner. Dismas.

Pilate’s expression softened, as though he were weighing something unseen. “Dismas,” he said, the name hanging in the air. “Thief, but not a zealot. I am told you cooperated with Rome.”

At these words, a spark flickered in Dismas’ chest—a fragile hope that flared despite his efforts to temper it. He straightened slightly, daring to meet Pilate’s gaze.

“I did,” Dismas said, his voice cracking with tension. “I gave them Barabbas.”

“You thought that your betrayal of one man would spare you from the law of Rome?” Pilate’s voice grew harder, his gaze piercing. “I see no regret in you, only desperation.”

Dismas’ chest tightened. The fragile hope he had nurtured began to crumble under Pilate’s words.

Pilate’s gaze swept over the three prisoners; his jaw set as though bracing himself for the uproar to come. At last, he turned to the crowd, raising his hands to still their murmuring.

“The people have spoken,” Pilate said, his voice deliberate. “Barabbas is free.”

Barabbas’ chains lay discarded where he had stood moments before. The memory of his mocking smirk still hung heavy

overhead, though he had vanished into the chaotic streets of Jerusalem.

He turned first to Jesus, who stood calm and silent, his posture unbowed despite the shadow of the gathering's verdict.

"Jesus of Nazareth," Pilate began, his tone taking on a faint note of bitterness. "Accused of blasphemy and insurrection, condemned by your own priests, and now rejected by the people." He paused, the irony not lost on him. "I find no guilt in you deserving of this sentence, yet I am no longer the arbiter of your fate."

Pilate gestured toward the guards. "By the will of the people, you shall be crucified."

Jesus remained still, his gaze steady and calm, fixed on a point beyond Pilate, beyond the soldiers, beyond the crowd. His silence unnerved the governor, who lingered for a moment before moving on.

Pilate turned to Gestas, whose sneer had returned in full force. The thief stood with his shoulders squared, defiance burning in his eyes as though the governor's judgment meant nothing to him.

"Gestas," Pilate intoned, his voice cold. "For your crimes of murder, rebellion, and theft, the sentence is death by crucifixion."

Gestas laughed bitterly, his lips curling into a cruel smile. "So, this is Rome's justice," he spat. "A dog's death for daring to bite back."

Pilate's expression remained impassive. "Rome's justice is for those who threaten its peace," he said, turning from Gestas without another word.

Finally, his gaze fell upon Dismas, who had been standing in rigid silence, his hands trembling slightly as the weight of his chains pressed into his skin. Pilate studied him, as though trying to decide if this man was worthy of the same fate.

“Dismas,” Pilate said at last, his tone measured. “A thief. An accomplice to rebellion. Yet you cooperated with Rome, betraying your companions to lessen your burden.”

Dismas’ chest tightened, his breath catching as Pilate spoke. He dared to hope that his cooperation would mean something, that his betrayal might yet save him from the same punishment as Gestas.

“Because of your cooperation,” Pilate continued, “the charge of rebellion has been dismissed.”

A murmur rippled through those gathered, swiftly stifled by the weight of what was left unsaid.

“But theft,” Pilate said, his voice hardening, “remains a crime against Rome.

And the sentence is death by crucifixion.”

The words struck Dismas like a hammer. His knees nearly buckled, but the chains held him upright. “No,” he whispered, his voice trembling. “No, I... I helped you! I told you—”

“You chose your path,” Pilate interrupted, his tone cold and unyielding. “And Rome does not bargain with thieves.”

Dismas’ head dropped, his hope crumbling into despair. He felt the sting of Gestas’ mocking laughter beside him, a bitter sound that cut deeper than any blade.

Pilate raised his hand, signaling the guards to step forward. “Take them,” he ordered. “Prepare them for execution.”

The soldiers moved swiftly, their hands rough as they tightened the chains on Dismas and Gestas, pulling them forward. Dismas stumbled, his legs weak beneath him, his mind reeling. He cast one last desperate glance at Pilate, but the governor had already turned away, his attention shifting to the crowd outside.

Act 3 - 04

All

Voices echoed through the narrow alleys, bouncing off the worn stone walls and converging in a cacophony of jeers, shouts, and murmured fascination. Here, in this city of Passover pilgrims, the spectacle of a Roman crucifixion was no mere execution—it was theater.

Lucius walked at the forefront of the grim procession, his armor gleaming dully reflecting the harsh sunlight. The streets were choked with bodies, a mix of locals and travelers, their faces etched with disdain, pity, or cruel delight. The commander's gaze was cold and calculating as he surveyed the path ahead. He had walked this route countless times, but never with such a high-profile prisoner.

Behind him trailed the condemned: three men bound by fate and by iron. At the rear of the line, Jesus of Nazareth staggered beneath the crushing weight of his crossbeam. His robe hung in tatters, the fabric clinging to his skin where fresh blood seeped from the lash marks. His steps were slow, deliberate, but unsteady, as though each motion drew from some hidden well of resolve.

Lucius' eyes flicked briefly to Jesus before shifting forward again. There was something about the man's silence that gnawed at him. Most condemned screamed, raged, or cursed their captors. Jesus, though beaten to death, bore his burden with an unsettling calm.

Ahead of Jesus, the thieves Dismas and Gestas stumbled, the weight of their own crossbeams. Dismas' face was pale, streaked with sweat and dirt, his movements tense and faltering. Gestas, on the other hand, moved with bitter defiance, his breath ragged but punctuated by growled curses at the crowd. Each stumble brought jeers from the onlookers, their voices rising in cruel amusement.

The sunlight bore down, unrelenting, baking the packed earth of the street and reflecting off the stone buildings. Dust swirled in the dry air, catching in throats and making the heat all the more oppressive. Lucius felt the familiar tightness in his chest, not from the march, but from the volatile energy of the crowd pressing close.

Simon stood near the road, pressed into the throng of bodies. He was an outsider, a Cyrenean pilgrim who had come to Jerusalem to observe Passover. Yet now, against his will, he found himself swept into the tide of the city's darkest spectacle.

He had seen the man they called Jesus on the day of his arrival in Jerusalem, when the streets had filled with cries of "Hosanna!" and palm fronds had lined the path. The figure he saw now, hunched beneath a splintered beam, bore little resemblance to that triumphant entry.

Simon froze, his breath catching as he watched Jesus falter. The man's face was drawn, streaked with blood and sweat, yet there was something in his eyes that Simon couldn't name—something unbroken.

Ahead of them, Lucius barked an order, his voice cutting through the clamor like the strike of a blade. "Keep moving!"

The soldiers flanking Jesus prodded him forward, their expressions betraying a mixture of impatience and disdain. One guard jabbed at him with the butt of a spear, and Jesus stumbled, nearly falling to his knees.

Lucius' expression hardened as he turned briefly, his piercing gaze sweeping over the scene. He couldn't afford delays. This

was more than a mere execution—it was a message, a warning to the restless city that Rome’s grip was unyielding.

“Move faster!” Lucius barked again, his frustration mounting as the procession slowed. He scanned the crowd, his gaze sharp and searching, as though looking for a solution.

Simon felt a chill run through him as Lucius’ eyes passed over him, lingering for a moment before shifting away. He let out a slow breath, his hands trembling slightly as he adjusted the pack slung over his shoulder.

The crowd pressed tighter, their taunts growing louder as the procession trudged forward. Lucius strode at the head, his posture rigid, his presence a clear reminder of Rome’s authority. He would not allow this display to falter, even if it meant dragging the condemned forward himself.

The procession drew closer to Simon, the oppressive heat and chaotic noise bearing down on him. He edged toward the side of the street, hoping to avoid being swept up in the tide of bodies pressing in around him. The air felt heavy with dust and the mingled stench of sweat and blood.

Simon’s gaze locked on the condemned men as they passed. First came two thieves, their faces contorted with pain and bitterness, their steps faltering, the crushing strain of the beams digging into their shoulders. But it was the figure trailing behind them that drew Simon’s full attention.

Jesus had seemed like a man borne by the joy of the people’s adoration, a quiet power in his words and presence. Now, that same figure was nearly unrecognizable—his body broken, his face bloodied, his steps labored.

Simon froze as Jesus stumbled. The beam on his back shifted with the jarring motion, throwing him forward onto his knees. The crowd jeered, some laughing cruelly, others murmuring uneasily at the sight of his collapse.

Lucius, marching ahead of the procession, stopped abruptly and turned at the sound of the fall. His sharp eyes swept over the scene, irritation flickering across his face as he saw Jesus

struggling to rise. He barked a terse command to the soldiers flanking the Nazarene.

“Get him up!”

The soldiers moved, grabbing at Jesus, but his body was failing him. He barely lifted his head before collapsing again under the unrelenting pressure of the beam. Lucius’ expression tensed, his patience wearing thin.

Simon shifted uneasily, shrinking back into the crowd. But it was too late. Lucius’ sharp gaze caught him.

“You!” Lucius’ voice cut through the din like a whip.

Simon stiffened, his heart leaping into his throat as the command bore down on him. He hesitated, glancing to either side, but the crowd had already pulled back slightly, leaving him exposed.

“Yes, you!” Lucius barked, stepping toward him. “Get over here, now!”

The force of authority in Lucius’ voice left no room for argument. Simon moved forward hesitantly, his hands raised slightly in deference, his steps deliberate.

“I... I don’t know this man,” Simon stammered as he neared the Roman commander.

Lucius’ hard gaze silenced him. He gestured sharply toward Jesus, who lay sprawled on the ground, the beam angled awkwardly across his back. “You will take up his cross.”

Simon’s stomach churned, and he shook his head instinctively. “I... I cannot. This is not my—”

“Silence!” Lucius cut him off, his tone brooking no resistance. “Take it, or I’ll see you bear worse than a beam today.”

The threat was enough. Simon hesitated only a moment longer before moving toward Jesus. He bent down, his hands

trembling as he gripped the rough wood of the beam, its splinters biting into his palms.

Jesus looked up at him, his face a mask of pain but his gaze steady. Simon thought he saw something in those eyes—a wordless acknowledgment, a shared understanding. Then he lifted the beam fully, feeling its weight press down on his shoulders.

Lucius nodded curtly. “Good. Now move!”

The procession resumed, the soldiers prodding the thieves forward as Simon fell into step beside Jesus. The beam was heavier than he had imagined, its rough edges digging into his skin with every step. The heat of the day and the oppressive cries of the agitators bore down on him, but he gritted his teeth and kept moving.

Simon adjusted his grip on the beam, his muscles screaming in protest as the splintered wood bit into his shoulders. Each step seemed to stretch the road ahead, the path narrowing to a blur of dust and jeering faces. He’d thought the weight unbearable at first, but now it was settling into his bones, a relentless ache that promised to linger long after this nightmare ended.

The shouts from the crowd were a ceaseless torrent, a mixture of scorn and grim satisfaction. Some hurled insults at the condemned, their faces twisted with contempt. Others whispered amongst themselves, their expressions ranging from pity to muted horror. But Simon barely registered them. His focus remained on the man ahead of him.

Jesus stumbled again, his pace agonizingly slow, his body swaying as though the mere act of walking demanded every ounce of strength he had left. Simon marveled at how the man remained upright at all.

How does he endure this? Simon wondered, his breath hitching.

The heaviness of the beam dragged Simon’s gaze downward, but each time he looked up, his eyes found Jesus. Blood ran in

rivulets down his back, soaking the fabric of his torn robe. The crown of thorns pressed cruelly into his brow, and yet his face remained calm—pain-wracked, yes, but strangely composed.

Simon's thoughts turned again to the day when Jesus had entered Jerusalem, seated on a donkey, the crowd welcomed him with palm branches and cries of "Hosanna!" He had been there, watching from the edges, caught up in the energy of the moment. Back then, Jesus had seemed larger than life, a man whose presence could shift the very air. But now, he looked so human, so fragile. And yet... there was something in his demeanor that unsettled Simon.

It wasn't defiance. Nor was it resignation. It was as though Jesus carried the burden of more than just the cross.

Simon stumbled slightly, his foot catching on an uneven stone. The movement abruptly brought him to the present, the beam shifting on his shoulders. He adjusted it quickly, grimacing. "Keep moving!" Lucius' voice boomed, clear and authoritative, rising above the chaos.

Simon flinched but obeyed, his pace quickening to match the commander's order. He glanced briefly at Lucius, whose face remained a mask of cold efficiency. The Roman commander's eyes, however, flicked repeatedly toward Jesus, a flash of something unreadable in their depths.

The road sloped upward, and Simon's legs burned with the effort of climbing. He tried to focus on the rhythm of his steps, the act of putting one foot in front of the other, but the sight of Jesus faltering ahead of him pulled his attention again and again.

"Why don't they stop this?" Simon remarked in a hushed voice, though he didn't know who he was addressing. The soldiers, the crowd, Rome itself—it didn't matter. The entire scene felt senseless, a grim theater of cruelty.

He caught a glimpse of Dismas ahead, the thief's back hunched beneath his own crossbeam. Simon had noticed Dismas earlier, his expression one of simmering desperation. Now, though, the man barely looked back as the procession

slowed. Gestas, the other thief, moved with bitter determination, his shoulders rigid as if he carried his hatred as much as the wood.

Simon's gaze returned to Jesus. The man staggered but didn't fall, his breath labored but steady. It was as though he were drawing strength from some unseen source.

"What kind of man is this?" Simon whispered to himself.

He remembered the stories he had heard. A healer. A teacher. A man who spoke of peace and forgiveness. Yet here he was, condemned to die like a criminal. Simon couldn't reconcile the tales with the reality before him.

The crowd pressed closer as they neared a bend in the road, their jeers growing louder. A woman's voice rose above the din, sharp with sorrow. Simon turned his head, catching sight of her as she reached out, her face streaked with tears. A soldier stepped between her and Jesus, his spear barring her path.

"Move back!" the soldier barked.

The woman recoiled but didn't retreat far. Her anguished cries followed the procession as it continued forward.

Simon's chest tightened. The woman's pain, the weight of the beam, the relentless noise of the curious—it all pressed on him, suffocating. He wanted to drop the wood, to disappear into the mass of people and pretend this day had never happened. But he couldn't. Lucius' sharp gaze remained fixed on him, a silent warning that Rome's patience was thin.

And then there was Jesus.

Simon couldn't shake the feeling that this man, beaten and bloodied as he was, carried something greater than his own suffering. It made no sense, but Simon couldn't deny it. Each step brought him closer to Golgotha, but it also drew him deeper into questions he didn't want to ask.

Why had this man been condemned? Why did the crowd hate him so much? And why, in the midst of all this chaos, did Jesus seem so... steady?

Simon adjusted his grip on the beam again, gritting his teeth as the procession climbed higher. Whatever answers awaited him at the end of this road, he wasn't sure he wanted to know.

Lucius walked at the forefront of the procession, his gaze fixed on the narrow, uneven path ahead. The noise of the watchers rose and fell around them, a chaotic sea of taunts, coarse laughter, and whispered condemnation. It was the sound of a city desensitized to blood and death yet endlessly captivated by its spectacle. He had marched condemned men to their deaths more times than he cared to count, yet...something about this journey made his chest tighten—a sensation he quickly dismissed as weariness.

The condemned moved in a line behind him, their steps faltering under the crushing weight of their crossbeams. Gestas was ahead, shoulders hunched as he growled softly, the beam grinding into his raw, blistered skin. Behind him, Dismas stumbled with visible effort, his lips tight as he struggled to keep his footing. And at the very back, Simon bore the strain meant for Jesus, his movements uneven but steady enough to keep the pace.

Lucius' eyes flicked to the man in the rear—the Nazarene, bruised, bloodied, yet inexplicably composed. Jesus' silence pressed against the chaos, a calm that Lucius couldn't ignore. It was maddening, even unsettling, how this man carried himself. Others spat or hurled curses at their tormentors, but Jesus did neither. Instead, he endured the beatings, the taunts, and the crushing weight of his suffering with a resolve that seemed to transcend the brutality engulfing him.

Lucius glanced at Simon, noting the tension in his shoulders, the grim set of his face as he shifted beneath the crossbeam. Simon had not resisted when pressed into service, but Lucius could see the smoldering resentment in his expression—the fury of a man dragged into something he did not choose.

“Keep moving,” Lucius barked at the soldiers nearest the rear, his voice cutting through the din. He could feel the procession lagging. Simon adjusted his grip on the beam, his face twisted in discomfort, and Lucius caught the quick glance Simon cast toward Jesus—half pity, half confusion.

Simon wasn't the first to carry a burden he didn't choose, Lucius thought grimly. And yet, watching Simon toil with his burden, Lucius felt an unbidden sense of relief. This change of pace might finally push them toward Golgotha without further delay.

Ahead, Gestas stumbled, nearly collapsing beneath his burden, but recovered with a guttural growl. Lucius' gaze sharpened as he studied the man. Gestas carried his bitterness like armor, each step a defiance of Rome, though his strength waned with every passing moment.

Dismas, on the other hand, carried his crossbeam like a man resigned to the gallows. Lucius watched him carefully, noting how his eyes darted toward the crowd, his expression clouded with something close to desperation. When Dismas turned slightly, looking toward Simon, Lucius caught the flicker of recognition in his face—the faint stirrings of a man realizing how easily a life could unravel.

That realization seemed to hit Lucius as well. He glanced at Simon again, now trudging steadily. He had been nothing more than an onlooker, a man swept into the drama of the moment, yet here he was—part of the pageant, burdened by a cross that wasn't his. Lucius exhaled sharply. Rome demanded more than death; it demanded a message. And Simon's presence sent one as clear as the beams on the condemned men's backs: no one was beyond Rome's grasp.

They neared the final bend in the road, the terrain growing steeper, the rocks loose and sharp beneath their feet. Lucius slowed his steps, listening to the voices of the observers grow louder, angrier. Faces blurred together in a mass of hatred and fascination. It was always this way—Rome's spectacles drew not just the hungry and the restless, but the enraged, the frightened, and the eager. The execution would remind them of their place.

Lucius' grip tightened on his sword hilt as he scanned the faces pressing against the path. Children clutched their mothers' skirts; merchants leaned against carts, their eyes narrowed in morbid fascination; priests whispered among themselves, their gazes fixed on Jesus. The Nazarene had stirred this city to its core—king, prophet, blasphemer, they called him. Whatever he was, he had challenged something greater than himself, and Rome had crushed him for it.

Lucius turned his focus back to the road. He glanced again at Simon, moving with measured steps beneath the crossbeam. There was strength in him, reluctant though it was. Lucius had seen weaker men falter beneath lesser burdens, yet Simon endured. He would make it to Golgotha—of that Lucius was certain.

The hill loomed ahead now, stark and jagged against the sky. Lucius felt the moment pressing on him, a heavy sense of inevitability. This was where it always ended—beneath the unrelenting sun, where the condemned faced their judgment, and the crowd gorged themselves on the theater of pain.

Lucius' eyes fell on Jesus once more. He stumbled again, his body sagging as Simon pressed forward. Lucius opened his mouth, ready to command the soldiers to steady him, but something in the man's resolve stilled the words in his throat. This was no ordinary prisoner, no mere rebel.

They reached the base of the hill, where the narrow road widened into a barren expanse. The soldiers moved ahead, preparing the ground for the final act, their movements precise and unhurried. Lucius halted the procession, his gaze sweeping over the condemned.

Simon stumbled to a stop, the crossbeam still weighing on his shoulders, his breath ragged. Dismas shifted uncomfortably, his gaze darting toward Gestas, who muttered something too low for Lucius to hear. Behind them, Jesus stood silent, his face calm but inscrutable.

Lucius took a steadying breath. Golgotha awaited, as it always did—a place of death and endings. Yet as he watched the condemned prepare for their final steps, he couldn't shake the

sense that this day would linger far beyond the bloodshed, a shadow that would stretch across his life long after the sun set over the hill.

The path grew steeper as they neared the gates, the incline biting into Dismas' legs with every step. His breaths came shallow and ragged, the weight of the crossbeam pulling at his shoulders like a relentless tide. The crowd surged alongside them, voices rising and falling like waves against the cliffs.

Ahead, the dark arch of the city gates loomed, casting a shadow that swallowed the road beneath it. Beyond the threshold lay Golgotha, the place of the skull, a name that bore the shadow of countless stories whispered in fear.

Dismas felt his stomach twist as the hill came into view, its barren face stark against the pale sky. He had heard of this place—heard the tales of those who had died here, their bodies left as warnings, their agony a testament to Rome's iron will. But hearing was one thing. Seeing it, knowing it waited for him, was another.

He shifted under the burden of the beam he carried, his hands trembling as splinters bit into his palms. The ache in his shoulders and back had become a constant thrum, a pain so deep it blurred into numbness. And yet, he couldn't stop. The soldiers saw to that, their voices sharp as whips, driving the condemned forward with threats and curses.

Gestas stumbled beside him, his curses muffled by the strain in his voice. "Keep moving," a soldier barked, shoving him forward with the blunt end of a spear. Gestas spat a bitter laugh, his hatred spilling out in words barely audible over the noise. "What's the hurry? It's not like we're going anywhere after this."

Dismas winced at the sound, his own thoughts dark and swirling. He had walked many roads in his life—some paved with greed, others with desperation—but none had led to a place like this. The hill loomed closer with every step, its jagged silhouette a grim reminder that there was no escape, no reprieve.

Jesus walked behind him, his footsteps uneven yet steady. Dismas dared a glance over his shoulder, his breath catching at the sight. The man staggered beneath his wounds, his body swaying as though every step might be his last. And yet, there was no fight in him, no defiance. Only silence, heavy and impenetrable, as though he carried more than his own pain.

A soldier stepped forward, prodding Jesus with the butt of his spear. "Move," the man growled, his impatience clear.

Jesus stumbled, his knees buckling beneath him, but he steadied himself before falling. His gaze remained fixed ahead, resolute, as though the taunts of the onlookers were insignificant compared to the weight of what awaited him.

Dismas turned away, his chest tightening. He didn't understand the man, didn't understand how anyone could walk to their death with such calm. He had spent his life running, fighting, doing whatever it took to survive. And now here he was, dragged to his end by the choices he'd made, while Jesus—this strange, silent man—seemed to accept his fate as though it had been written long before this day.

The gates were closer now, their shadow stretching long over the path. The crowd pressed tighter, their voices a discordant roar that echoed off the stone walls. Dismas felt their hatred like a physical force, their eyes boring into him, stripping him bare. They wanted a spectacle, and he was part of it—a man reduced to a body, a sinner reduced to a sentence.

As they passed beneath the arch, the air seemed to grow heavier, colder. The noise of the followers softened, muffled by the stone overhead, but it returned in a roar as they emerged on the other side. The hill rose before them, its barren slopes scarred by the memories of countless deaths.

Dismas' legs trembled as they began the final ascent, his breaths shallow and labored. The ground beneath him was dry and cracked, the earth hardened by the press of countless feet that had trod this path before.

Ahead, the soldiers barked orders, their movements efficient and practiced. They knew this road, knew its end, and their

faces betrayed no emotion as they herded the condemned forward.

Golgotha rose higher with every step, its bleak form casting an oppressive shadow over them. The beams on their shoulders felt heavier with each labored stride, the oppressive weight of their own deaths bearing down as they neared the summit.

The shadow of the gates fell behind them as the road climbed sharply toward the barren rise of the Place of the Skull. Dismas staggered, his legs threatening to buckle beneath him, the strain of the beam more than his battered body could bear. He stumbled once, catching himself with a jolt of pain that shot up his arms, but the second time, his knees gave way entirely, and he crashed to the ground.

The beam fell hard across his back, forcing a cry from his lips. The crowd roared at his failure, pointing, their laughter cutting deeper than the blows of the soldiers. Dismas clawed at the dirt, trying to push himself up, but his strength had abandoned him.

From behind, he heard the steady footsteps falter. The sound of the procession slowed, and he turned his head just enough to see Jesus approaching. The man did not look at him, his gaze fixed ahead, his expression as calm as it was agonized.

Dismas lay helpless, watching as Jesus moved past him. The soldiers barked commands, driving him forward, and for a moment, the condemned man's presence eclipsed everything else.

As Jesus passed, he came between Dismas and Gestas, the three of them forming a grim procession with Jesus now in the center. Dismas let his head fall to the ground, the cool dirt against his face offering a fleeting relief as the realization struck him: he would now follow this man, even to the place of death.

The soldiers grabbed Dismas, hauling him to his feet with brutal efficiency. They shoved the beam back onto his shoulders, and he stumbled forward, forced into motion again.

Jesus walked ahead now, his steady, deliberate steps leading the way toward the place where they would all meet their fate.

Dismas turned his gaze to the ground, his breaths coming in ragged gasps. The shadow of the hill loomed before them, its barren crown stark against the merciless sky. The road narrowed, and as they climbed, he could feel the end drawing closer with every painful step.

Act 3 - 05

All - The Cross

The hill of Golgotha rose stark and desolate, silhouetted against a sky bruising with the deep hues of approaching dusk. The air was heavy with the sound of labored breaths, the creak of wood, and the mocking cries of the throng as the condemned were driven toward their final judgment.

The soldiers moved with practiced precision, their faces set like stone as they barked commands and drove the prisoners forward. Each man bore his suffering in his own way: Gestas with a defiant snarl, his curses spat at anyone who dared to look at him; Dismas with a quiet dread, his steps halting and uneven as though the shadow of the hill itself pressed upon his shoulders. And then there was Jesus, the Nazarene, who moved with a battered dignity that set him apart, even now.

Simon of Cyrene, his face slick with sweat and his shoulders bowed beneath the heaviness of the crossbeam, stumbled to a halt as they reached the crest of the hill. His task was done. A soldier stepped forward, shoving him aside without ceremony, and Simon staggered back into the crowd, his eyes lingering on Jesus for a moment longer before the sea of onlookers swallowed him whole.

Lucius surveyed the scene with a critical eye. Everything had to proceed according to protocol; there could be no room for error. This was not just a punishment—it was a spectacle, a performance of power meant to instill fear in all who watched. Golgotha was not merely a place of death; it was a stage upon which the might of Rome played out its cruel drama.

“Strip them,” Lucius ordered, his voice breaking through the murmurs of the crowd with cold authority.

The soldiers moved quickly, yanking the tunics from the condemned men with rough hands. Gestas struggled, lashing out at the nearest soldier, only to be met with a swift blow to the stomach that left him doubled over, gasping for air. Dismas did not resist, though his body flinched involuntarily as the rough fabric was torn from his skin, leaving him exposed to the leering eyes of the spectators. Jesus stood silent, his gaze fixed on some distant point beyond the rabble, beyond the soldiers, beyond the cross itself.

The crowd's jeers rose to a fever pitch as the condemned were stripped bare. They shouted insults, spat at the prisoners, and hurled stones that the soldiers occasionally swatted away with impatient gestures. To the onlookers, this was more than punishment—it was entertainment, a grim festival of humiliation and death.

Among the crowd, whispers spread like wildfire, fueled by the sight of the Nazarene. “Is this the one they called the King of the Jews?” one man sneered, his voice dripping with scorn. “Some king,” another replied, his laughter cutting through the tension like a blade.

Above it all, Lucius' gaze remained steady, his mind ticking through the steps of the execution like a well-worn checklist. Each man would be nailed to his crossbeam first, then the beams would be hoisted onto the upright stakes waiting in the hard-packed earth. The process was efficient, methodical—a testament to the discipline of Rome.

“Bring the first one,” Lucius commanded, his eyes flicking toward Gestas.

Two soldiers stepped forward, dragging Gestas toward the waiting crossbeam. He struggled against them, his curses turning into incoherent roars of rage as they forced him down onto the wood. The crowd surged closer, eager for the spectacle, their voices rising in a chaotic symphony of hatred and bloodlust.

Lucius watched with dispassion as the soldiers pinned Gestas' arms to the beam. One soldier knelt, holding the man's wrist steady, while another raised a hammer high above his head. The first blow fell, a sickening thud followed by Gestas' scream—a sound that cut through the crowd's noise like a jagged edge.

As the hammer rose and fell again, Dismas turned his head away, his face pale. He knew his turn would come soon, and though he had long tried to steel himself for this moment, the reality of it was more than he could bear. His hands trembled at his sides, his breath coming in shallow gasps as he tried to push down the rising tide of panic.

Lucius' gaze shifted to Jesus, who stood motionless beside his own crossbeam, his body battered and bloodied but his face serene, revealing nothing. There was no fear in his eyes, no trace of the desperation that gripped the others. It was as if he were already somewhere else, beyond the reach of this place, this moment.

The commander felt a flicker of unease but quickly buried it. This was just another execution. He had seen men face their deaths in every way imaginable: with rage, with tears, with silence. Whatever the Nazarene's calm meant, it would not change the outcome.

"Next," Lucius commanded, his tone sharp and controlled.

The people pressed closer as the soldiers turned their focus to Jesus. Their shouts grew louder, a discordant mix of taunts and insults that clung to the stifling air.

"Where are your miracles now, Nazarene?" a voice sneered, slicing through the din.

Lucius gestured sharply, and the soldiers responded with the efficiency of seasoned practice. They seized Jesus by the arms, forcing him onto the waiting crossbeam. Despite their rough handling, the Nazarene made no sound, no protest. His battered body sagged beneath their grip, yet his face remained calm, almost otherworldly, his gaze distant, fixed on something beyond the hill and the chaos surrounding him.

The soldiers hesitated briefly, their movements faltering as his silence unsettled them. Lucius noticed and stepped forward, his presence a cold reminder of Rome's dominance.

"Do your duty," he barked, his tone as unyielding as the nails they held.

The first soldier pinned Jesus' wrist to the beam, his hands steady despite the unease rippling through the onlookers. The second raised the hammer, its surface catching the faint, muted light of the sun now obscured by thickening clouds.

The first blow landed, a metallic crack ringing out over Golgotha like a grim tolling bell. For a moment, the noise silenced the onlookers, leaving only a tense, breathless pause. Then came the second strike, each one deliberate, resonant, and irrevocable. Blood welled from the wounds, dark against the wood, but still, Jesus uttered no cry.

From his place on his own crossbeam, Gestas let out a harsh, bitter laugh. "What kind of king doesn't fight back?" he rasped, his voice strained with pain and scorn.

Jesus did not respond. His head turned slightly, his gaze resting on the faces of those who hurled ridicule and venom. His lips moved faintly, forming words too soft for the soldiers or the onlookers to hear.

Lucius frowned, stepping closer. "What is he saying?"

One of the soldiers leaned in, his expression turning to confusion. "He's... praying," he said, his voice uncertain.

"Praying?" Lucius repeated, his skepticism evident in his tone.

The soldier nodded. "He said, 'Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do.'"

The words lingered, heavy and unsettling, breaking through the noise of the process. Lucius felt a flicker of something unnamable—a tightening in his chest, a faint unease he quickly forced aside.

“Enough,” he barked. “Raise the beam.”

The soldiers moved to obey, hoisting the crossbeam onto the upright stake already embedded in the ground. Jesus’ body sagged against the weight, his hands stretched taut by the nails. The wood groaned under the strain as the beam locked into place with a dull thud.

The crowd erupted again, their taunts mingling with coarse laughter and venomous curses. Some hurled stones, while others spat at the foot of the cross.

Lucius stood apart, his gaze fixed on the scene before him. The air around him felt heavy, oppressive, as though the gravity of what was happening pressed down on the hill itself. The sun, still hidden behind the thickening clouds, cast a strange pall over the landscape, muting the colors, turning everything to shades of gray.

“Dismas,” Lucius barked, turning his attention to the second thief. “Bring him forward.”

The soldiers moved toward Dismas, who stood trembling, his gaze darting between the crowd and the darkened sky. The execution was far from over, and Golgotha demanded its due.

Dismas was dragged forward by the soldiers, his legs unsteady beneath him, his breath coming in ragged gasps. The derision within the multitude rang in his ears, sharp and cutting, each word a reminder of his failures, his crimes.

“Thief!” someone shouted, their voice rising above the din. “You deserve worse than this!”

Dismas flinched as the soldiers forced him to the ground beside his crossbeam. His heart pounded as he stared at the rough wood, the grain darkened by the blood of countless others who had met the same fate.

“On your back,” barked one of the soldiers, his tone leaving no room for defiance.

Dismas hesitated, his body trembling. He turned his head, his gaze landing on Gestas, who was already affixed to his cross. The other thief smirked despite his pain, his expression twisted with bitter defiance.

"Get it over with, Dismas," Gestas called out, his voice ragged. "Or do you think you're too good for this?"

A wave of anger surged through Dismas, hot and sudden, but it faded just as quickly, leaving only fear in its wake. He lowered himself onto the beam, his back scraping against the rough wood, splinters biting into his flesh.

The soldiers moved quickly, their hands practiced and efficient. They stretched his arms out across the beam, pinning his wrists in place.

"Hold still," one of them muttered, his grip tightening as Dismas began to shake.

The first strike of the hammer was a shock, a flash of white-hot pain that tore through him. Dismas cried out, his voice raw and desperate, but the soldiers paid him no mind.

The second nail followed each blow driving the iron deep into his flesh, anchoring him to the cross. The pain was overwhelming, consuming, a fire that burned through every nerve in his body.

Tears streamed down his face as the soldiers lifted the beam, securing it to the upright stake. Dismas felt his body sag against the nails, his weight pulling at his wounds, the agony redoubling as he was hoisted into place.

The crowd erupted once more, their voices a chorus of scorn and mockery.

"Another one for the hill!" someone shouted, their tone dripping with venom.

"Where's your rebellion now, thief?"

Dismas tried to shut out their voices, but they were relentless, a storm of hatred that battered him from all sides. He clenched his teeth, his breaths coming in shallow, uneven gasps as the pain wracked his body.

His gaze drifted to Jesus, now raised high on his own cross. Despite the blood, despite the bruises and wounds that marred his body, there was a calmness in the man's face, a peace that seemed to defy the horror of the moment.

Dismas swallowed hard, his throat dry as sand. His own suffering seemed to pale in comparison to the weight he saw in Jesus' eyes—a weight not of pain, but of purpose.

“What kind of man are you?” Dismas murmured, his voice barely audible over the crowd.

For the first time in his life, he felt truly alone—cut off from everything he had ever known, everything he had ever been. But as his gaze fell on Jesus once more, a strange thought stirred within him, a spark of something he could not name.

Hope.

It was faint, fragile, and utterly foolish. But it was there, flickering like a candle in the dark.

The soldiers worked quickly, their movements precise, their faces impassive. Gestas' curses echoed across the hill as he was lifted into place, his defiance as sharp as the nails that bound him.

And then, at last, the soldiers stepped back, their work done. The three crosses stood in stark relief against the darkening sky, a grim tableau that cast a shadow over the world itself.

Dismas closed his eyes, the weight of the moment pressing down on him like the cross at his back. He did not know what awaited him, but as the first drops of rain began to fall, he felt a flicker of something strange, something unexpected.

The Darkening Sky

The day seemed to falter as the sun wavered in the sky, its light dimming unnaturally. A restless unease swept through the crowd, their taunts growing softer, their voices hesitant, as though they, too, felt the change in the atmosphere.

Dismas opened his eyes, his vision blurred by pain and exhaustion, and glanced at the horizon. The light that had once burned so fiercely now seemed muted, the shadows lengthening unnaturally across the barren ground. A chill crept through the air, sharp and biting, though the day had been warm.

“What’s happening?” someone in the crowd murmured, their voice tinged with fear.

The priests, who had stood so proudly moments before, exchanged uneasy glances. Their triumph seemed muted now, their voices quiet as they huddled together, casting nervous glances toward the sky.

Simon lingered in the crowd, his breath still heavy, the burn in his shoulders and palms an unwelcome reminder of his burden. The crossbeam was no longer his to carry—he had laid it down. The soldiers had not looked his way since; his task was done.

And yet, he stayed.

He told himself it was to catch his breath, to find his bearings before disappearing into the city. But the truth tugged at him like an anchor, pulling him closer to the grim scene unfolding on the hill. His feet would not obey the instinct to leave.

The crowd shifted, surging forward as the soldiers reached the center of the hill. The voices rose, mocking mixed with laughter, as though the assembly found in this moment both justice and cruel entertainment. Simon winced as the crossbeam was thrown down with a crack, the sound jolting him like a whip.

His gaze fixed on Jesus. his body pressed down by the weight of the soldiers and the rough wood Simon had carried. A tightness gripped Simon's chest as he watched them stretch Jesus' arms across the beam. He wanted to look away, but his eyes refused to obey.

"I should leave. There's nothing more for me here," he thought.

Yet his feet remained rooted to the ground, the air around him heavy with an intangible weight that pressed on him from all sides.

The Messiah. That was what they had called him. Simon had witnessed it himself—the palms laid before him, the cries of "Hosanna!" echoing through the streets. He had stood by the roadside, watching as Jesus entered Jerusalem like a king. But now, that same man knelt before a jeering crowd, treated no better than the lowest of criminals, stripped of dignity and shrouded in mockery.

"How can this be the same man?"

The crack of the hammer drove the question from his mind. Simon flinched as the sound carried, followed by a sharp intake of breath from the man on the cross. Jesus did not cry out, though his body jerked with each strike. The restraint only deepened Simon's unease, his sense that this was unlike anything he had ever witnessed.

Simon's throat tightened as he watched the soldiers lift the cross. The wood groaned under its weight, and Jesus' body sagged, the nails holding him fast. The crowd erupted in mocking cheers, their voices a storm of taunts.

Simon clenched his fists, anger bubbling beneath his skin. These people had cheered for him days ago, had hailed him as the Messiah. And now? Now they spat venom at him, as though their earlier adoration had been some cruel jest.

He wanted to shout at them, to tell them to stop. But what could he say? He barely understood what had compelled him to stay, what had drawn him into this moment.

And then Jesus' head lifted, his eyes finding Simon's through the crowd. The noise seemed to fade, the ridicule and laughter distant, as though the world held its breath. Simon's anger faltered, his knees threatening to buckle under the gravity of that gaze.

Jesus' face was pale, streaked with blood and dirt, yet his eyes held something that Simon could not name. Strength, perhaps, or peace—something that should not exist here, in this place of death.

Simon's chest ached, his breath catching as he dropped his gaze, unable to meet those eyes any longer. He had come to Jerusalem as a pilgrim, seeking the peace of the Temple, the sanctity of Passover. He had not come to stand here, at this terrible moment, watching a man die.

"But I can't leave."

The thought settled over him, heavy and unyielding. He stayed because he had to see it through, though he did not understand why. He stayed because this man's presence pulled at something deep within him, something he had not known was there.

The crowd pressed closer, their cries filling the air as the sun beat down on the hill. But Simon stood apart, his heart heavy, his mind reeling.

And though he could not yet name it, he knew he would never forget this moment, nor the man who had captured his heart with a silent gaze.

Simon remained near the crowd, unable to pull himself away, though every instinct screamed at him to leave this place of suffering and shame: Gestas, the bitter one, snarling even now as though his words could somehow defy the death waiting for him.

To Jesus' right, Dismas hung silent, his face drawn in pain. Yet Simon saw something shift in his expression—a flicker of recognition, a depth that startled him. Dismas, the man

branded a thief and condemned to die, looked upon Jesus with an emotion Simon could only describe as reverence.

The air around them thickened, the sun burning hot overhead, the heat oppressive as Simon struggled to reconcile the scene before him. The one they called the Messiah hung between two criminals, his body broken yet his presence undeniable.

The man they called the Messiah was dying, and yet his words carried life, carried hope. Simon felt it stir within him, unbidden, a fragile thing he did not yet dare to name.

He wanted to turn away, to flee from the grotesque spectacle of suffering, yet something in him refused to move. The Messiah—this man who had entered Jerusalem to shouts of Glory—now hung as a criminal, his body broken, his crown of thorns mocking the title they had once believed. How could this be? How could salvation come through such humiliation?

Simon's gaze drifted to the Roman soldiers standing just beyond the crosses. Lucius, the commander who had pressed him into service, stood with his arms crossed, his face unreadable. Marius loomed nearby, his stern expression betraying a flicker of unease. Simon's heart clenched. These men were cogs in Rome's brutal machine, yet even they seemed unsettled by what they witnessed.

The sun burned high, casting sharp shadows that stretched long and jagged across the rocky hill. Sweat dripped down Simon's back as he shifted uncomfortably, his sandals grinding into the dusty ground. He could leave now, couldn't he? His task was done. The soldiers had released him. Yet his feet remained stubbornly planted.

A sudden cry from the crowd jolted him from his thoughts. "He asks why God has forsaken him." Isn't he the son of God?" The taunts began anew, louder this time, fueled by malice and disbelief.

Simon flinched at the venom in their voices, at the way they twisted the title of Messiah into a weapon. And yet, Jesus did not answer them. He bore it all—every insult, every sneer—

with the same unyielding silence that had marked him along the road.

Simon's mind churned. He remembered that road, the weight of the crossbeam biting into his shoulders, the oppressive heat, the way Jesus had stumbled beside him, bruised yet resolute. What had it meant? Why had he been chosen to carry that burden, if only for a time?

He glanced toward Jesus again, his heart pounding with unspoken questions that refused to take shape. Blood streaked the man's face, his body trembling under the weight of agony, yet his eyes remained steady, almost detached, as though focused on something far beyond the horrors of Golgotha.

And then, without warning, the thought struck Simon like a thunderclap: "This was just the beginning."

The realization stole his breath. The cross was an ending—undeniably so—but it was the symbol of something new being birthed before their very eyes. He couldn't fathom how he knew this, yet the certainty burned fiercely within him, cutting through the thick fog of confusion and sorrow with a light he could not ignore.

Simon's gaze shifted back to Lucius. He wondered if they felt it too—that heavy, intangible presence pressing down on them. Lucius' expression remained stoic, yet his eyes lingered on Jesus longer than they did on the others condemned. Nearby, Marius barked orders to the soldiers, his jaw tight, but his movements lacked the sharp precision that came with his command.

Something was shifting here, Simon realized. Something vast and unnamed, yet undeniable.

The sky darkened suddenly, the sun obscured by thick clouds that seemed to roll in from nowhere. The crowd stilled, their voices tapering off into uneasy murmurs. Simon felt a chill run down his spine as the air grew heavy, oppressive, as though the earth itself held its breath.

He looked at Jesus again, his chest tightening at the sight. The man who had entered his life so briefly yet so profoundly now hung on the brink of death. And yet, even in his suffering, there was something unshakable about him—something... victorious.

Simon clasped his hands before him, a silent prayer rising unbidden from his heart. He did not know what he prayed for—peace, understanding, forgiveness? Perhaps all of these things, and more.

And as the shadows deepened and the murmurs faded into stillness, Simon knew one thing with utter clarity: he could not leave. He had to see this through to the end.

For the Messiah was not done. Not yet.

The world seemed to hold its breath as Lucius stood at the base of the hill, his eyes locked on the crosses silhouetted against the darkening sky. The sandaled feet of his men shifted uneasily against the rocky ground, their discipline holding firm but their faces betraying unease. The unnatural gloom had swept across the heavens without warning, a darkness that was neither cloud nor storm but something far heavier, far stranger.

Lucius could feel the pressure in his chest, a suffocating presence that pressed down like armor worn too tight. He had stood on this hill many times, overseen countless crucifixions, but this was different. This felt as though the earth itself rebelled against the act unfolding here.

To his left, Marius stood with his arms crossed tightly over his chest. His eyes darted from the crosses to the horizon and back again, his lips pressed into a thin line, betraying unspoken thoughts. Lucius knew that look—knew the uncertainty it masked, the doubt that crept in despite their training.

"This isn't right," Marius murmured faintly, though the words were not meant for anyone's ears.

Lucius ignored him, his attention drawn to the crowd that had begun to shift restlessly. The sneers had quieted; the mocking voices stilled as the eerie twilight settled over them. Even the most hardened among them seemed unnerved, their shouts dying in their throats as they gazed upward at the man they had condemned.

Jesus.

Lucius' gaze lingered on the man hanging on the middle cross. The Nazarene's head was bowed, his body slumped in exhaustion. Blood streaked his face and chest, the cruel marks of the scourge visible even from where Lucius stood. Yet there was something in his stillness, something in the way he bore the agony, that unnerved the Roman commander.

Simon of Cyrene stood nearby, his face pale, his hands trembling as he clutched his robe. The man had not left after being dismissed from carrying the cross. Instead, he lingered, his eyes fixed on Jesus as though drawn by an invisible force.

"You should go," Lucius said to him, his voice firm.

Simon turned toward him, his expression a mix of fear and defiance. "I can't," he said, his voice barely above a whisper. "I have to see..." He trailed off, unable to find the words to explain what had anchored him here.

Lucius frowned but remained silent, his gaze fixed on the crosses. His grip on the hilt of his sword tightened as the silence grew heavy, almost suffocating.

From the left cross, Gestas began to stir, his hoarse voice breaking the oppressive stillness. "You call yourself the Messiah," he sneered, his words laced with venom despite his agony. "Prove it! Save yourself—and save us while you're at it!"

Lucius' features tightened. Even in the face of death, some men clung to their hatred as if it were armor.

On the right cross, Dismas raised his head weakly, his voice barely audible yet filled with a raw, quiet strength. "Do you not

fear God,” he rasped, his words trembling with both pain and conviction, “since you are under the same sentence?”

Lucius felt a pang at the words, though he could not say why. He watched as Dismas turned toward Jesus, his voice cracking with emotion. “We are punished justly,” he continued, “for we are getting what our deeds deserve. But this man... this man has done nothing wrong.”

The crowd stirred uneasily, the murmurs spreading like wind rustling through dry leaves. Lucius found himself holding his breath as Dismas spoke again, his words a broken plea.

“Jesus,” he said, his voice a whisper carried by the strange stillness, “remember me when you come into your kingdom.”

Jesus lifted his head slowly, his bloodied face turning toward the thief. Despite the anguish etched into his features, there was a calm in his eyes that Lucius could not understand.

“Truly, I tell you,” Jesus said, his voice unwavering and imbued with an authority that transcended the frailty of his body, “today you will be with me in paradise.”

The crowd’s scorn faltered, confusion rippling through their ranks. To Simon, it was as if time itself had bent, the gravity of eternity pressing into the moment.

Lucius exhaled sharply, a chill running down his spine. He glanced at Marius, whose face had gone pale. The older officer opened his mouth as though to speak but said nothing, his words caught somewhere between doubt and disbelief.

Simon took a step forward, his eyes wide, his hands clenched at his sides. He looked at Lucius, his voice trembling as he asked, “Do you hear him? How can he—”

Lucius raised a hand to silence him, his own questions pressing in too heavily to focus on Simon’s. The atmosphere around them thickened, and in the distance, a faint rumble of thunder echoed from deep within the earth, as if the very ground itself was responding.

“This is madness,” Marius said in a low tone, his voice barely audible. “I’ve seen hundreds die on this hill, but never... never like this.”

Lucius said nothing, his gaze fixed on Jesus. The man hung there, his body broken yet unbowed, his presence filling the hill with something Lucius could not name. It was not power, not defiance, but something quieter, deeper—a strength that made even the hardened Roman commander feel small in its presence.

And then, Jesus spoke again, his voice rising above the murmurs, above the rumble of distant thunder.

“Father,” he cried, his words tearing through the silence, “into your hands I commit my spirit.”

The ground beneath Lucius’ feet seemed to shift, a tremor running through the hill as if the earth itself responded to the cry. He staggered slightly, his hand going to the hilt of his sword as a reflex, though there was nothing to fight.

The sky grew darker still, the twilight deepening into a shadow that blotted out even the faintest trace of sunlight. The crowd murmured in confusion and fear, some falling to their knees, others turning to flee.

Lucius stood rooted in place, his eyes fixed on Jesus as the man’s head fell forward, his body going still. A hush fell over Golgotha, broken only by the faint whisper of the wind.

Lucius’ voice was barely audible, the words escaping him before he realized he had spoken them. He looked to Marius, who stood as pale and shaken as he felt.

As he gazed at the lifeless figure on the cross, “Surely, this was the Son of God.”

Epilogue

Lucius

The room was stark, its only adornments the shifting shadows cast by a lone oil lamp, its flame dancing over the rough wooden table. Outside, Jerusalem settled into the cool embrace of evening, the hum of the Sabbath's end carried on the wind—a quiet blend of murmured prayers and shuffling footsteps. But inside, the air hung heavy, laden with the lingering weight of unspoken thoughts.

Marius sat across from Lucius, his elbows resting on his knees, his hands clasped tightly, as though the tension in his fingers might yield some understanding. The lamp on the nearby table burned steadily, its glow highlighting the furrow in Marius' brow and the taut lines around his mouth. Lucius leaned back in his chair, arms crossed, the weight of the day etched deeply into his face.

For a long while, neither man spoke. The silence between them wasn't one of companionship but a heavy stillness, thick with unspoken thoughts and the remnants of what they had witnessed. Finally, Lucius broke it, his voice low and measured.

"The hill was like no other I've seen." He paused, letting the words find their gravity. "I've seen death many times, Marius. But nothing like that."

Marius didn't respond immediately. His gaze shifted to the small window, where the horizon had long since surrendered to night. When he spoke at last, his voice was rough, as though dragged from a place he didn't want to confront. "We've carried out hundreds of crucifixions. They're always brutal, always full of rage or regret. Why was he different?"

Lucius leaned forward, resting his hands on the table, his dark eyes unflinching. "You tell me" he said. "You've seen men beg, scream, curse their gods. But him? He didn't fight. He didn't curse us."

Marius' expression tightened, the memory of the Nazarene's calm, unyielding presence surfacing unbidden. The way Jesus had spoken forgiveness while nailed to the cross lingered in his mind, gnawing at him. He shifted in his seat, visibly uncomfortable.

Lucius pressed on, his tone softening but no less insistent. "When I said he was the Son of God, I meant it."

Marius' head snapped up, his voice sharp with unease. "And what does that mean, Lucius? Are you saying he was divine? A god walking among men?"

Lucius shrugged, his expression troubled, as though the words themselves eluded him. "I don't know what I believe, Marius. But if ever there was a moment that felt... beyond us, it was there on that hill." He exhaled, rubbing a hand over his face as though trying to ease the tension of unspoken thoughts. "It wasn't just another execution. It was as if everything—every word, every act—had been planned for that moment. And we were part of it."

Marius glanced toward the lamp, his voice quieter now, weighted with something unspoken. "He said nothing to us. And yet, it feels as though he said everything."

Lucius didn't reply. He let the words hang in the air, their weight pressing on both men. The steady light of the lamp cast long shadows across the room, their movement slow and deliberate, as if the walls themselves bore witness to the gravity of their thoughts.

Marius broke the silence, his voice taut with suppressed emotion. "When I asked him to heal my servant, I thought it was desperation—a last resort." He stared at the table as the memory played vividly in his mind. "But the way he looked at me... it wasn't just confidence. It was certainty. He didn't need to come to my home. He just spoke, and it was done."

Lucius leaned back, his expression contemplative. "What do you think it means?"

Marius rubbed his temples, the shadow of the question bearing down on him. “I don’t know. Watching him on that cross—it was as though he held more power in his suffering than we do in our swords. He should have been angry. He should have hated us.”

“But he didn’t,” Lucius finished quietly. “Instead, he forgave us.”

“Yes,” Marius said, shaking his head as if trying to rid himself of the thought. “A man stripped bare, humiliated—and still he forgives. It’s... maddening.”

Lucius’ voice dropped, almost to a whisper. “I can’t stop thinking about it. His words, his gaze—it felt like he wasn’t just a man. It felt like... more.”

Marius looked up, the furrow in his brow deepening. “And now what? What do we do with this, Lucius? With him?”

Lucius was silent for a moment before answering. “I don’t know. But I know I can’t forget it. Yesterday, something in me shifted. For the first time, I questioned everything.”

Marius leaned back, hearing the chair creak with his weight. “We’ve always been soldiers, Lucius. Men of duty. Of order. What does this change?”

Lucius stood, walking to the window. The streets of Jerusalem stretched before him, quiet now in the wake of the Sabbath. “Maybe it changes everything,” he said softly. “What if we’ve been living wrong? Fighting for power that means nothing?”

Marius watched him, a mixture of frustration and resignation in his eyes. “You think he was here to change the world?”

Lucius turned, his gaze steady. “I think he’s already changed it. And us.”

Marius didn’t answer immediately. Instead, he looked at his hands, his voice distant. “He spoke of a kingdom. Not of kings or thrones, but something... deeper. Something I don’t understand.”

“Neither do I,” Lucius admitted. “But I can’t ignore it.”

Marius sighed, his features softening as if surrendering to the pervasive sorrow of it all. “Perhaps understanding isn’t for us. Not yet.”

Lucius nodded, his mind still wrestling with the memory of Jesus on the cross. “Maybe not. But whatever he was, Marius, I don’t think we’ve seen the end of it.”

Together, they stood in the stillness, their choices hanging heavily, the Nazarene’s final words echoing like distant thunder. The city had moved on, but they hadn’t. And in the quiet of that room, beneath the flickering light of an oil lamp, two soldiers began to confront the possibility that their lives—and the world—might never be the same.

Simon

The sun had sunk beneath the horizon, and the streets of Jerusalem had quieted to a murmur, the chaos of the previous day a fading memory. The Passover crowds had dispersed, the feasts and prayers a distant hum against the backdrop of the city’s ever-present tension.

Simon lingered at a quiet courtyard near the gates, his body aching from the strain of the crossbeam, while his soul carried an even heavier mental load. He had taken a seat on a worn stone bench, his fingers tracing the grooves of the rock, as though they might guide him to some clarity, some understanding. His thoughts had returned to the events of the previous day—Jesus, the crucifixion, the crowd, the mockery—and he found himself still struggling with the enormity of it all.

He had walked away from the hill, following the soldiers’ orders to keep his distance, yet his heart had stayed behind. It was as though a part of him had been nailed to that place of suffering, bound to that man on the cross by something invisible, something stronger than his will to resist.

Simon had no intention of getting involved. He had only come to Jerusalem to fulfill a simple pilgrimage, to pay his respects, and to offer his prayers. He had never asked for any of this.

But now, standing in the city, he was left to reconcile the man he had helped carry with the image of a king. A king, yes, but one who died like a criminal.

"Simon, there you are!" The familiar voice of Ruben, his childhood friend, broke through his reverie like a sudden breeze. Ruben was a fellow pilgrim, a man Simon had known since his youth in Cyrene. He was a broad-shouldered man, his face rough from years in the fields, but his eyes still carried a light that suggested an enduring hope.

Simon looked up and managed a faint smile, though the lines of sorrow remained etched deep in his face. "Ruben," he replied, his voice heavy. "I didn't expect to see you here so late."

Ruben sat down beside him with a grunt, glancing around at the quiet courtyard. "I came to see if you had heard about what happened. You've been out all day, haven't you? Some of the men were talking—about the man they nailed to the cross. I heard things, Simon. Strange things."

Simon's hands clenched tighter around the stone, feeling its coolness seep into his skin. He wasn't sure he was ready for this conversation. "I've heard enough for today," he said quietly, his eyes focused on the ground. "I helped carry his cross yesterday. I did what they told me, Ruben. That's all. I don't know much about the rest."

Ruben turned to him, his expression softening as he studied his friend. "But you must have witnessed everything, Simon. The crowd's jeers, the scorn, the mockery. How could you—how could anyone—stand and watch such cruelty unfold?"

Simon's voice faltered as he spoke. "I don't know... there was something about him. Something different. Even as they beat him, even as they cursed him, he never once fought back. Not with his fists or with words. I don't understand it."

Ruben let out a breath, his gaze far away. "That's what the men were talking about. They say he was a prophet. That he could heal the sick, make the blind see. But he didn't use any of that power to save himself. He didn't even resist. Why,

Simon? Why would anyone do that? A king, a man with power—and he lets himself die like a lamb led to slaughter?”

Simon's heart pounded in his chest. Ruben's words mirrored the confusion that had taken root deep inside him. How could he explain it? How could he reconcile the quiet strength he had seen in Jesus with the brutal end that awaited him?

“I don't know,” Simon murmured, his voice tinged with weariness as he shook his head slowly. “I don't know what I saw. But there was something about him, Ruben. Something in the way he looked at me when I helped him with the cross. He wasn't angry. He wasn't scared. He just... He looked at me like he knew me. Like he knew everything about me and still, he didn't judge me.”

Ruben fell silent, his hands resting in his lap. He didn't speak for a long while, as if he, too, was trying to process the same weight that Simon carried. The flickering light from the oil lamps nearby seemed to draw the shadows long, filling the space between them with quiet tension.

Finally, Ruben spoke, his voice barely above a whisper. “Some of the men say he was the Messiah. The Anointed One. The King of the Jews. But if that's true, why didn't he save himself?”

Simon's heart clenched, his mind turning over the questions that had been growing ever since he helped Jesus carry the cross. He had come to Jerusalem seeking peace, seeking God. And yet, nothing felt peaceful anymore. The world seemed upside down, turned on its head by the events of the last day.

“I don't know, Ruben,” Simon said finally, his voice tight with the sense of unease gripping him. “I don't know if he was the Messiah. But I know this—there was something in his eyes. Something that made me think there was more to him than what they said. More than just a king, or a criminal.”

Ruben raised an eyebrow, his gaze searching Simon's face. “What are you saying, Simon?”

Simon stood up, his legs stiff from the lingering effect of the crossbeam still etched into his muscles, but the decision had already been made in his heart. "I don't know. But I can't forget him. What he did, what he said. It's like... he changed something inside me. And I can't explain it."

Simon gazed into the stillness of the streets, his eyes following the last of the pilgrims as they made their way back to their homes. The city was settling back into its usual rhythm, but Simon felt as though something had shifted. Something deep inside him had been changed, and the path ahead no longer felt certain. What did it mean to carry a burden for someone else? To witness a man's death and wonder if he had seen a glimpse of divinity?

"Maybe we're meant to learn, Ruben," Simon whispered, his voice distant, "but I don't know if I'll ever understand."

The modest room, lit only by the flicker of an oil lamp, felt heavy with the quiet weight of Simon's words. His friends sat around him, their expressions a mix of reverence and disbelief as he spoke. Outside, the city murmured softly, the hum of life continuing as though nothing extraordinary had happened. But Simon's heart was anything but calm.

"I thought I knew the Messiah," Simon began, his tone quiet and halting. "We all did. A king, a conqueror, one who would drive out Rome and restore Israel's glory. I thought... I thought I was ready for him."

One of his friends leaned forward, his brow furrowed. "And now? Do you think he was...?"

Simon shook his head, not in denial but in wonder. "I carried his cross. I saw him—" His voice caught, and he steadied himself. "I saw him bleed, saw him stumble under the weight. And I thought, 'This cannot be the one.' But then, as I walked beside him, something stirred in me—something I cannot explain."

He looked up, his eyes searching theirs. "You know Isaiah's words, don't you? 'He was pierced for our transgressions, crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him.' Those words came to me as I watched him, as I heard the soldiers mock him and the crowd taunt. It felt as though the prophet himself had whispered them in my ear."

One of the men gasped softly, his hand clutching at his chest. "You think that was him? The Suffering Servant?"

Simon nodded slowly. "I don't know how to make sense of it. But I remember the words, and I saw him—the way he bore it. Not with anger, not with curses, but with something else. As if he knew it was meant to be."

Another friend spoke, his voice laced with skepticism. "But the Messiah is to reign, Simon. To bring victory, not—"

"I know!" Simon interrupted, his voice rising with emotion. "I thought the same! But then, as he hung there, I heard him cry out. 'My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?' And I remembered David's psalm, the one we've sung since we were boys. It speaks of hands and feet being pierced, of garments divided. I... I saw those things, with my own eyes. It was happening before me!"

The room fell silent, the gravity of his words settling over them like a heavy mantle. The men exchanged glances, their doubt tempered by Simon's conviction.

One of them broke the silence. "But how can the Messiah suffer? It makes no sense, Simon."

Simon's gaze dropped to the floor, his voice soft and weighted. "That's what I thought, too," he murmured. "Until I saw his eyes. He turned to the crowd—those who mocked him, who spat on him—and he said, 'Father, forgive them.' Forgive them! Who can speak such words in the face of hatred like that?"

His voice broke, and he wiped his face with a trembling hand. "And then it struck me—Zechariah's words. 'They will look on

me, the one they have pierced.' I cannot explain it, my friends, but in that moment, I knew. He wasn't there to save himself. He was there for... for us."

One of the men stood abruptly, pacing the room. "If you're right, Simon... if you're right, what does it mean? For us? For Israel?"

Simon looked up, his eyes brimming with tears. "I don't know," he admitted, his voice heavy with emotion. "But I know this: I cannot go back to my life as it was. I came to Jerusalem for Passover, to worship and return home. But now... now I feel as though I've seen the Passover lamb itself. Not in the Temple, but on that hill."

The words hung in the air, and for a moment, the room felt sacred, as though something larger than themselves lingered there. One by one, Simon's friends bowed their heads, their hearts grappling with the enormity of what they had heard.

Simon exhaled slowly, the weight of his experience pressing down on him.

"He said he would rise again" he whispered, more to himself than to them.

"Three days. If that is true... everything will change."